

IELTS Speaking question bank

Sample answers · review copy for sir

Part 1: 62 topics × 5 questions (310) · Part 2: 200 cue cards with a sample talk and 2 rounding-off questions · Part 3: 60 topics × 8 questions (480) · 1911 vocabulary entries (separate PDF).

What we changed

- Part 1: your 100 questions are grouped into 62 exam-style topics of 5 questions each (the examiner asks 4–5 on one topic). Your questions and answers are unchanged; the 210 new ones are marked NEW.
- Part 2: your talks (about 160 words, roughly 1 minute 15 seconds) are extended to 240–290 words so they last close to 2 minutes, every bullet is covered in order, and each card has 2 rounding-off questions and its linked Part 3 topics.
- Part 3: answers are unchanged except for the vocabulary marks (plain words such as health, both, shift replaced by real Band 8 words or whole idioms, exactly 3 per answer) and a few softened factual claims ("studies show" → "many argue").
- All answers follow one speaker: a young man from Sirajganj working at an education consultancy, BBA graduate; father recently retired, mother at home, younger sister studying, elder sister married in Dhaka, grandparents in the village. Contradictions between the files were fixed to match this.

How to read this: **bold underlined** = vocabulary word (tap-to-open in the app) · **green background** = text added by us · ~~red struck through~~ = your text we removed or replaced. Anything without a mark is your original wording.

Part 1 · Short questions

Work

Personal & Background · sp1_work · intro topic

1. Do you work or are you a student? (your no. 4)

I'm working at the moment, at an education consultancy, where I **predominantly** help students with their applications abroad. It keeps me busy, but seeing someone reach a goal they worked towards is genuinely rewarding, so the effort feels worthwhile.

2. Why did you choose that job? (NEW)

Mainly because I went through the application process myself as a student and realised how confusing it can be. I wanted to help people **navigate** that uncertainty, and this role lets me do exactly that.

3. What do you like most about your job? (NEW)

Honestly, it's the people. Every student comes with their own hopes and worries, so no two days are identical, and guiding someone through such a **daunting** process gives me a real sense of purpose.

4. Is there anything you dislike about your work? (NEW)

The deadlines can be quite stressful, particularly during the main admission seasons when everything seems to arrive at once. There's a lot of paperwork too, and I'll admit the administrative side can get rather **tedious**.

5. Would you like to change your job in the future? (NEW)

Not entirely, but I'd like to grow within the field. Ideally, I'll study abroad myself one day and then come back to a more senior role. For now, though, I'm happy **honing my skills** where I am.

Studies

Personal & Background · sp1_studies · intro topic

1. What subject did you study? (your no. 5)

I studied business administration at university, with a focus on management. It gave me a broad understanding of how organisations actually run, which has proved surprisingly **invaluable** in the work I do now.

2. Why did you choose that subject? (NEW)

Partly because of my father, to be honest. Growing up around his small business, I saw how much planning goes into keeping things running, and I suppose that **sparked my interest** in management quite early on.

3. Did you enjoy your time at university? (NEW)

Very much, on the whole. The coursework was demanding at times, but I made some lifelong friends and took part in a few debating events. Those years really helped me become more **self-assured** and independent.

4. What was the most useful thing you learned? (NEW)

Probably how to communicate clearly in a professional setting. We did a lot of group presentations, which I dreaded at first, but they gradually made me far more **articulate**, and I rely on that every day at work.

5. Would you like to study something else in the future? (NEW)

Yes, I'd love to do a master's abroad, possibly in international education or management. I feel it would deepen my understanding of the field and **open doors** that aren't really available to me here.

Hometown

Personal & Background · sp1_hometown · intro topic

1. Where is your hometown? (your no. 1)

I'm from Sirajganj, a modest town in the north of Bangladesh, right beside the Jamuna river. It's about four hours from Dhaka by road, and I've lived there most of my life, so it has a certain **tranquillity** that feels like home.

2. What do you like most about your hometown? (NEW)

Without doubt, the river. In the evenings I often walk along the Jamuna embankment, and watching the sun set over the water is incredibly **soothing**. The people are warm and welcoming too, which gives it a real sense of community.

3. Is your hometown a good place for visitors? (NEW)

It's not a major tourist destination, but it has its charms. Sirajganj is known for its handloom weaving, and visitors can take a boat trip on the Jamuna. It suits anyone who enjoys a slower, more **laid-back** pace.

4. Has your hometown changed much in recent years? (your no. 11)

Quite a lot, actually. There are more shops, better roads and far more traffic than when I was younger. Some of it is welcome progress, but part of me misses how quiet and **unspoilt** it used to feel.

5. Do you prefer living in a city or the countryside? (your no. 12)

That's a tough one. I enjoy the energy of a city, but I genuinely appreciate the calm of the countryside. Honestly, the **ideal** for me would be a quieter town that isn't too far from a city.

Home

Personal & Background · sp1_home · intro topic

1. Do you live in a house or a flat? (your no. 2)

I live in a flat, on the third floor of a building in a quiet residential area. It's a three-bedroom place I share with my family. It suits us well, though I do **occasionally** wish we had a bit more open space around us.

2. How long have you lived there? (NEW)

Well over a decade now, since I was a teenager. Before that we rented a smaller place nearby, so moving there felt like a real step up, and the flat is full of **fond memories** for all of us.

3. Which room do you spend the most time in? (your no. 13)

Definitely my bedroom, which doubles as my study, so I'm in there for most of the day when I'm home. I've arranged it to be quiet and comfortable, which makes it easy to **concentrate**.

4. Is there anything you'd like to change about your home? (NEW)

I'd love a bigger balcony, to be honest. Ours is quite narrow, so there isn't much room for plants or a chair. A bit more outdoor space would make it far more **inviting** on pleasant evenings.

5. What kind of home would you like to live in in the future? (NEW)

Ideally, a small house with a garden, somewhere peaceful but still within reach of the town. I'd like to grow a few vegetables and have space for bookshelves. Nothing grand, just somewhere that feels like a genuine **sanctuary**.

Family

Personal & Background · sp1_family

1. Can you tell me about your family? (your no. 3)

It's a fairly typical family. There are ~~four~~ five of us: my parents, my ~~younger-sister~~ two sisters and me, although my elder sister is married now and lives in Dhaka with her husband and children. My father ~~was~~ ran a small business until he retired recently, and my mother looks after the home. We're quite close-knit, and ~~we~~ those of us at home usually have dinner together every night.

2. Do you spend much time with your family? (NEW)

Quite a lot, especially in the evenings. Once work is done, we tend to gather in the living room over tea and chat about our day. Those relaxed moments help me wind down after a long day.

3. Who are you closest to in your family? (NEW)

Probably my younger sister. She's a student and incredibly hard-working, so we often talk about her studies and plans. I feel quite protective of her, and she's usually the first person I share news with.

4. What do you like to do together as a family? (NEW)

We love visiting my grandparents in our ancestral village, which isn't far from Sirajganj. The whole family gathers there, especially during Eid, and those visits have an unhurried warmth that I really treasure.

5. Has your family changed much in recent years? (NEW)

Quite a bit, actually. My elder sister got married and moved to Dhaka, and my father has recently retired, so he's at home far more. It was a big adjustment at first, but it's brought us even closer.

Your name

Personal & Background · sp1_name

1. Does your name have any special meaning? (your no. 6)

Yes, it does actually. My name carries a meaning connected to guidance and light, which is fairly common in our culture. I quite like it, because names here are usually chosen with real deliberation behind them.

2. Who chose your name? (NEW)

My grandfather did, actually. In our family it's customary for the eldest relative to suggest a name, and my parents were happy to go along with it. I think that's quite a touching tradition.

3. Do you have a nickname? (NEW)

Yes, like most people in Bangladesh, I have a short nickname that my family and close friends use. My formal name is really only for official documents, so the nickname feels far more affectionate and personal.

4. What names are popular in your country? (NEW)

Names with religious or poetic meanings are very popular here, particularly Arabic and Bengali ones. Recently, though, I've noticed parents choosing shorter, more modern names, which reflects a broader generational change in taste.

5. Would you ever change your name? (NEW)

No, I can't imagine doing that. My name connects me to my grandfather and to my family's traditions, so changing it would feel like losing part of my heritage.

Daily routine

Personal & Background · sp1_routine

1. What is your typical daily routine? (your no. 7)

It's fairly structured on weekdays. I get up around seven, have a quick breakfast, and I'm at work by nine. After work I usually study for a couple of hours, then **unwind** before bed. Weekends are far more relaxed.

2. Do you usually get up early? (your no. 30)

Yes, on weekdays I'm up by seven. I've found I think much more clearly in the mornings, so I make the most of that quiet, **uninterrupted** time. On weekends, though, I happily allow myself a lie-in.

3. Which part of the day do you like most? (your no. 16)

The early morning, surprisingly. It's quiet, the day hasn't got hectic yet, and I feel clear-headed. A calm start with a cup of tea genuinely sets a **productive** tone for everything that follows.

4. Do you prefer having a routine or variety? (your no. 39)

A bit of both, ideally. A steady routine keeps me productive, but I'd get bored without some variety. So I like structure on weekdays and something a little more **spontaneous** at the weekend.

5. Has your routine changed much since you were a student? (NEW)

Quite significantly. At university my days were far more flexible, and I'd often stay up late and sleep in. Now that I work full-time, I've had to become much more **disciplined**, which has honestly been good for me.

Neighbours

Personal & Background · sp1_neighbours

1. Do you know your neighbours well? (your no. 8)

Reasonably well, yes. In our building people are fairly friendly, so we greet each other and occasionally chat. I wouldn't say we're close, but there's a warm, **cordial** relationship, which matters when you live so near people.

2. How often do you see your neighbours? (NEW)

Almost every day, just in passing, on the stairs or near the entrance, and we usually exchange a quick greeting. During Eid, though, we visit each other properly and share food, which is a **heartwarming** custom.

3. Do you ever help your neighbours? (NEW)

Now and then, yes. There's an elderly man on our floor, so I sometimes carry his shopping upstairs or help with small errands. It's only a small gesture, but I think these acts of **goodwill** matter in a community.

4. What do you think makes a good neighbour? (NEW)

Someone who's respectful and considerate, really. A good neighbour keeps the noise down, says hello and is willing to lend a hand in an emergency, but also respects your privacy and doesn't **pry**.

5. Do you think people are as close to their neighbours as they used to be? (NEW)

Not really, especially in bigger cities. When I was younger, neighbours would drop in unannounced for tea. Nowadays people are busier and more private, so those bonds have **eroded** somewhat.

Friends

Personal & Background · sp1_friends

1. Do you have many friends? (your no. 9)

I wouldn't say many, but I have a small circle I really trust. I've always preferred a few close friendships over a wide range of **acquaintances**. Those are the people I can be completely myself around.

2. How did you meet your closest friends? (NEW)

Most of them are from school and university, so we've known each other for years and share a lot of history. A couple are former colleagues too, which shows that friendships can **blossom** in unexpected places.

3. Can you describe your best friend? (your no. 20)

Sure. He's easygoing, genuinely kind and a great listener, which is probably why we've stayed close for so long. He has this **reassuring** way of putting things in perspective whenever I'm stressed.

4. What do you usually do with your friends? (NEW)

Nothing too elaborate. We usually meet at a local tea stall and chat for hours, or watch a cricket match together. Sometimes we take a walk by the river. It's the easy, **unpretentious** company that I value most.

5. Do you think it's easy to make friends as an adult? (NEW)

Not as easy as it was at school. Adults are busy with work and family, so there are fewer chances to connect naturally. Friendships still form, but they take more time and **deliberate** effort.

Childhood

Personal & Background · sp1_childhood

1. Where did you grow up? (NEW)

Mostly in Sirajganj, although I spent many school holidays at my grandparents' home in our village nearby. Both places shaped me, and I still feel a strong sense of **belonging** whenever I go back.

2. What did you enjoy doing as a child? (your no. 10)

I was quite an outdoorsy kid. I'd spend hours playing cricket with the neighbourhood children until it got dark. Looking back, those were some of the most **carefree** times of my life.

3. Did you have any hobbies as a child? (your no. 59)

Plenty. I was always outside playing cricket, and I also loved reading comics and adventure stories. Those simple hobbies kept me endlessly **entertained**, long before phones and screens took over.

4. Did you have much freedom as a child? (NEW)

Quite a lot, compared to children in big cities today. As long as I was home before dark, my parents were fairly relaxed. Our neighbourhood felt safe, so I could **roam** around with friends quite freely.

5. Do you think children today have a better childhood than you had? (NEW)

In some ways, yes. They have access to far more information and opportunities. However, I think they spend too much time indoors on screens and miss out on the kind of **unstructured** outdoor play I enjoyed.

Languages

Personal & Background · sp1_languages

1. What languages do you speak? (your no. 14)

I speak Bengali as my mother tongue, and English fairly fluently. I picked up English mostly through school and a lot of self-study, and I use it daily at work, so it's become almost **instinctive**.

2. Is English widely spoken in your country? (NEW)

It's widely understood in cities, particularly in business, universities and among younger people. In rural areas, though, Bengali is used for almost everything. English is increasingly seen as a **gateway** to better jobs and study opportunities.

3. Would you like to learn another language? (NEW)

I'd love to learn Arabic, mainly so I can understand the Quran more deeply. I've also considered German, since some students I advise are interested in universities there, so it could give me a **competitive edge** at work.

4. Do you find learning languages difficult? (NEW)

It can be, especially as an adult. Grammar and vocabulary take time, but the real challenge is speaking confidently without fear of mistakes. I think consistent practice and **immersion** matter far more than natural talent.

5. Do you think children should learn a foreign language at school? (NEW)

Absolutely. Children pick up languages far more easily than adults, and early exposure builds confidence. In such an **interconnected** world, a second language gives them a real advantage later in life.

Future plans

Personal & Background · sp1_future-plans

1. What are your plans for the future? (your no. 15)

In the short term, I'm focused on strengthening my career and possibly studying abroad. Longer term, I'd like to reach a point where my work has real impact and I have the **stability** to enjoy life a little more.

2. Which country would you most like to study in? (NEW)

Probably the UK or Canada. Both have excellent universities and a strong reputation in business and education. Having helped so many students apply there, I understand the process well, which makes the idea far less **intimidating**.

3. Where would you like to live in the future? (NEW)

I'd happily spend a few years abroad for study, but eventually I'd like to settle back in Bangladesh, perhaps in Dhaka or near my hometown. My family is here, and I feel deeply **rooted** in this place.

4. Do you usually plan things carefully? (NEW)

For important matters, definitely. I like to set clear goals and break them into manageable steps. That said, I've learned that life rarely goes exactly to plan, so staying **adaptable** is just as important.

5. Do you think your life will be very different in ten years? (NEW)

I imagine so. Hopefully I'll have completed further studies and be in a more senior position. I might have a family of my own by then too, so my priorities will probably **evolve** quite a lot.

Weekends

Personal & Background · sp1_weekends

1. What do you usually do at the weekend? (your no. 17)

I try to keep weekends flexible after a busy week. Usually I catch up on sleep, meet a friend or two, and maybe run some errands. If I'm lucky, I'll fit in a book or a film to properly **recharge**.

2. Who do you usually spend your weekends with? (NEW)

Mostly with my family, to be honest. My younger sister and I sometimes go out for snacks, and occasionally we all visit my grandparents in the village. Evenings are usually for friends, so my weekends feel pleasantly **well-rounded**.

3. Do you prefer weekdays or weekends? (your no. 85)

Weekends, without question. Weekdays are productive but tiring, whereas weekends give me space to rest and see people. That balance is what keeps me **going** through the week.

4. Did you do anything special last weekend? (NEW)

Nothing extraordinary. On Friday I went to the mosque for Friday prayers, then spent the afternoon reading. On Saturday I met two old friends for tea, and we ended up chatting for hours, which was **thoroughly** enjoyable.

5. Are your weekends different now from when you were a child? (NEW)

Completely. As a child, weekends meant endless cricket and visits to relatives. Now they're mostly about resting and catching up on things I couldn't do during the week, so they feel less **adventurous** but more precious.

Sleep

Personal & Background · sp1_sleep

1. How many hours do you usually sleep? (NEW)

Usually around seven hours on weeknights, which seems to be enough for me. At weekends I sometimes sleep a little longer to **make up for** the week, although I try not to overdo it.

2. Do you usually sleep well? (your no. 18)

Mostly, yes, though it varies. When my mind is calm I fall asleep quickly, but on stressful days it takes a while to switch off. I've learned that avoiding my phone before bed is **remarkably** effective.

3. Do you take naps during the day? (NEW)

Rarely on workdays, since there simply isn't time. On Fridays, though, I sometimes have a short nap after lunch. Even twenty minutes leaves me feeling **refreshed** and noticeably sharper for the rest of the day.

4. What do you do when you can't fall asleep? (NEW)

I usually get up and read something light for a while rather than lying there frustrated. Sometimes a cup of warm milk helps too. Once my mind settles, I tend to **drift off** fairly quickly.

5. Do you think people get enough sleep nowadays? (NEW)

Not really, particularly young people. Many stay up late on their phones or working, then wake early for work or classes. I think sleep is often treated as a **luxury** rather than a necessity these days.

Time and punctuality

Personal & Background · sp1_time

1. Are you a punctual person? (your no. 19)

I'd like to think so, yes. I genuinely dislike keeping people waiting, so I usually aim to arrive a little early. To me, being on time is a simple way of showing **consideration** for others.

2. How do you feel when other people are late? (NEW)

It depends on the situation. If it's a friend and only a few minutes, I don't mind at all. But if someone is repeatedly late for professional meetings, I find it quite **exasperating**, because it wastes everyone's time.

3. Are you good at managing your time? (your no. 33)

Mostly, yes. I rely a lot on a simple to-do list, which keeps me on track. I'm not perfect, and things occasionally slip, but planning ahead stops me feeling **overwhelmed**.

4. Do you usually wear a watch? (NEW)

Not anymore. I used to wear one my father gave me, but now I just check the time on my phone. I still keep that watch safely in a drawer, though, because it has real **sentimental value**.

5. Do you think people are busier today than in the past? (NEW)

I'd say so. With smartphones, we're always reachable, so work often spills into our personal time. Our parents seemed to have clearer boundaries, whereas now life feels far more **fast-paced** and demanding.

Cooking

Lifestyle & Habits · sp1_cooking

1. Who does most of the cooking in your family? (NEW)

My mother, without a doubt. She's an excellent cook and takes real pride in it. My younger sister and I help occasionally, but honestly, nobody can **replicate** her fish curry, no matter how hard we try.

2. Do you enjoy cooking? (your no. 21)

I do, actually, though I only really cook at the weekend. During the week I'm too busy, but on a lazy Saturday I quite enjoy trying a new recipe. I find the whole process rather **therapeutic** after a hectic week.

3. What dishes can you cook? (NEW)

Nothing too ambitious. I can make a decent chicken curry, khichuri and simple fried fish. Lately I've been trying to **master** a proper biryani, although my first attempts were fairly disappointing, to put it kindly.

4. Do you find cooking relaxing? (your no. 53)

Surprisingly, yes. When I'm not rushed, following a recipe and getting fully **immersed** in it takes my mind off everything else. And of course there's the reward of a good meal at the end.

5. Do you think children should learn to cook? (NEW)

Definitely. Cooking is a basic life skill, and it teaches children about nutrition and independence. If they learn early, they're far less likely to **fall back on** fast food when they eventually live on their own.

Meals and eating out

Lifestyle & Habits · sp1_meals

1. What do you usually have for breakfast? (NEW)

Usually something simple, like paratha with egg or a bit of vegetable curry, along with a cup of tea. It's not elaborate, but it's **wholesome** and keeps me going until lunch.

2. What is your favourite meal of the day? (your no. 22)

Definitely dinner. It's the one meal where the whole family sits down together and actually talks, so it's as much about the company as the food. It's become a small daily **ritual** I really value.

3. Do you prefer eating at home or in restaurants? (your no. 40)

Mostly at home, to be honest. Home-cooked food is healthier and more comforting. That said, I do enjoy dining out now and then, especially when it's a chance to **socialise** with friends over a meal.

4. Is there a traditional dish from your country you'd recommend? (NEW)

I'd definitely recommend hilsa fish, especially cooked in mustard sauce. It's our national fish, and it has a rich, **distinctive** flavour. During Pohela Boishakh, many families eat it with panta bhat.

5. Have your eating habits changed in recent years? (NEW)

Somewhat, yes. I used to eat a lot of fried street food, but now I try to cut back on oily snacks and eat more vegetables. I haven't given them up completely, but I'm certainly more **health-conscious** than before.

Shopping

Lifestyle & Habits · sp1_shopping

1. Where do you usually go shopping? (NEW)

For everyday things, I go to the local market near our home, which is always **bustling**. For larger purchases, I'd rather order online or visit one of the bigger shopping centres, where there's more choice.

2. Do you enjoy shopping? (your no. 23)

It depends what I'm shopping for, honestly. I like buying books or a bit of tech, but clothes shopping **drains** me quickly. These days I do most of it online, which saves me a lot of time.

3. Do you prefer shopping alone or with others? (NEW)

Alone, usually, because I like to get in and out quickly. When I go with my sister, it turns into an afternoon of **browsing** every single shop, which is fun occasionally but exhausting.

4. Do you ever buy things on impulse? (NEW)

Occasionally, especially books. If I see an interesting title, I find it hard to resist, even if I already have a pile waiting to be read. Otherwise, I'm fairly **prudent** with what I spend.

5. Has the way people shop in your country changed? (NEW)

Dramatically. Not long ago almost everyone shopped at markets, but now online shopping and home delivery are extremely common, especially in cities. Still, traditional markets remain **resilient**, because people enjoy bargaining and seeing products in person.

Clothes

Lifestyle & Habits · sp1_clothes

1. What kind of clothes do you like to wear? (your no. 24)

I tend to keep it simple and comfortable, mostly casual shirts and jeans. I'm not one for chasing trends. As long as something is neat and versatile, I'm perfectly happy with it.

2. Do you wear different clothes at work and at home? (NEW)

Yes, quite different. At work I wear formal shirts and trousers, since a polished appearance matters when meeting students and parents. At home, though, I change straight into something loose and comfortable.

3. Do you ever wear traditional clothes? (NEW)

Yes, mostly on special occasions. For Eid and weddings I always wear a panjabi, which is a long traditional shirt. I really enjoy it, because it feels festive and connects me to our cultural roots.

4. Do you spend a lot on clothes? (NEW)

Not really. I buy new clothes mainly before Eid or when something wears out. I'd rather invest in a few good-quality items than lots of cheap ones that quickly lose their shape, as it's more economical in the long run.

5. Have clothing styles in your country changed much? (NEW)

Considerably, especially among young people. Western styles like jeans and T-shirts are now everyday wear in towns and cities. Even so, traditional clothing remains deeply ingrained, particularly during festivals and family celebrations.

Mobile phones

Lifestyle & Habits · sp1_phones

1. When did you get your first mobile phone? (NEW)

I got my first one when I started college, at around sixteen. It was a basic model that could only make calls and send texts, but I was absolutely thrilled with it, even though it seems ancient by today's standards.

2. How often do you use your mobile phone? (your no. 25)

Far too often, if I'm honest. It's become almost indispensable for work and staying in touch, so it's rarely out of my hand. Lately I've been trying to set limits, because it's easy to lose track of time.

3. What do you mainly use your phone for? (NEW)

Mostly for work, to be honest. I reply to students' messages, check emails and join video calls. Outside work, I read the news and keep in touch with my elder sister in Dhaka, so it's become a real lifeline.

4. Do you prefer phone calls or text messages? (your no. 96)

For quick things, texting, since it's fast and doesn't interrupt anyone. But for anything important, I much prefer a call. You can hear the tone of someone's voice, which makes the exchange feel far more genuine.

5. Do you think young children should have smartphones? (NEW)

Not at a very young age. A basic phone for emergencies is sensible, but unrestricted internet access can be harmful. I think parents should introduce smartphones gradually and keep an eye on how they're used.

Technology

Lifestyle & Habits · sp1_technology

1. What technology do you use most often? (NEW)

My laptop, without question. I use it all day at work for applications, emails and research, and in the evenings for studying. My phone is a close second, but the laptop is really the **backbone** of my working day.

2. How does technology help you in your work? (NEW)

Enormously. Almost every application is submitted online now, and I can hold video meetings with universities abroad. Tasks that once took days can be done in hours, which has **streamlined** our work considerably.

3. Do you think you rely too much on technology? (your no. 26)

To some extent, yes. It makes life easier, but I've noticed I reach for my phone out of habit rather than need. I'm trying to be more **mindful**, especially in the evenings when I should be relaxing.

4. Is there any piece of technology you'd like to buy? (NEW)

I'd quite like a good e-reader. I read a lot, and carrying several books around isn't very practical. An e-reader would be lighter and easier on the eyes than my phone, so it seems a **worthwhile** investment.

5. Do older people in your country find technology difficult? (NEW)

Many do, although it's improving. My grandfather, for instance, now makes video calls to my elder sister, but it took a lot of patience to teach him. Once they see the benefits, older people can be surprisingly **receptive**.

Exercise and health

Lifestyle & Habits · sp1_health

1. Do you do any sports or exercise? (your no. 27)

I try to, though not as consistently as I should. I go for a brisk walk most evenings, and occasionally I play badminton. I always feel **rejuvenated** afterwards, so I really ought to do more of it.

2. Did you play any sports at school? (NEW)

Yes, cricket was my main sport, and I played for my school team for a couple of years. I wasn't the most talented player, but I made up for it with **sheer enthusiasm**, and it taught me a lot about teamwork.

3. Do you prefer exercising alone or with other people? (NEW)

It depends. For walking, I prefer being alone, because it gives me time to think. For something like badminton, though, company makes it far more enjoyable and keeps me **accountable**, so I'm less likely to skip it.

4. Do you have a healthy lifestyle? (your no. 28)

Reasonably, I'd say. I eat home-cooked food most of the time and try to stay active, but my sleep could be better. It's an ongoing effort, but I think I'm gradually **cultivating** better habits.

5. Are people in your country becoming more health-conscious? (NEW)

Gradually, yes. You now see many people walking or jogging in parks early in the morning, which was rare before. There's a **heightened awareness** of diet too, although fast food is still hugely popular among young people.

Tea or coffee

Lifestyle & Habits · sp1_tea-coffee

1. Do you prefer tea or coffee? (your no. 29)

Tea, without a doubt. It's a bit of a **ritual** here, and I probably have three or four cups a day. Coffee is fine occasionally, but nothing quite beats a hot cup of tea in the morning.

2. How do you take your tea? (NEW)

I like it strong, with milk and just a little sugar. My mother sometimes adds ginger or cardamom, especially in winter, which gives it a lovely **aromatic** quality. Plain black tea is fine too, but milk tea is my favourite.

3. Do you often drink tea outside the home? (NEW)

Quite often, yes. Roadside tea stalls are everywhere here, and meeting friends at one is a big part of our social life. There's a **convivial** atmosphere at those stalls that you simply can't find in a café.

4. Is coffee becoming more popular in your country? (NEW)

Definitely, especially among young people in cities. New coffee shops keep opening in Dhaka, and they've become **trendy** places to study or meet friends. Tea is still far more common, though, particularly outside the big cities.

5. Do you think you drink too much tea? (NEW)

Possibly, yes. Three or four cups a day may be a bit much, especially in the evening, as it sometimes keeps me awake. I've been trying to **cut back** after dinner, though with mixed results so far.

Housework

Lifestyle & Habits · sp1_housework

1. Do you do much housework? (your no. 31)

A fair amount, yes. I take care of my own room and help out at the weekend. I can't say I enjoy it, but there's a certain satisfaction in a **tidy**, well-organised space.

2. Which household chore do you dislike the most? (NEW)

Washing dishes, without a doubt. After a big family meal there's always a mountain of them, and it seems to take forever. I'd much rather sweep the floor or do the shopping than face that **seemingly endless** pile.

3. Did you help with housework as a child? (NEW)

A little. My mother expected us to make our beds and keep our school things in order. At the time I **grumbled** about it, but looking back, those small responsibilities taught me to look after my own space.

4. Is housework shared equally between men and women in your country? (NEW)

Not yet, honestly. Traditionally, women have done most of it, and that's still common. However, younger couples, especially in cities, are increasingly sharing chores, which I see as a **welcome shift**.

5. Do you think children should do housework? (NEW)

Yes, within reason. Simple chores like tidying their room or setting the table teach responsibility. It also stops them from **taking for granted** how much work goes into running a home.

Money

Lifestyle & Habits · sp1_money

1. Did you get pocket money when you were a child? (NEW)

Yes, a small amount each week from my father. I usually spent it on snacks or comics, but occasionally I'd save up for a new cricket bat. That was probably my first lesson in **delayed gratification**.

2. Are you good at saving money? (your no. 32)

I'm getting better at it. I used to spend fairly carelessly, but now I set aside a fixed amount each month before anything else. Being **frugal** in small ways gives me real peace of mind.

3. What do you spend most of your money on? (NEW)

Apart from contributing to household expenses, mostly books, transport and the occasional meal out with friends. I'm also putting money aside for studying abroad, so I try not to **splash out** on anything unnecessary.

4. Do you prefer paying in cash or by mobile? (NEW)

Mostly by mobile these days. Mobile banking apps are hugely popular in Bangladesh, and they've **revolutionised** everyday payments here. Rickshaw fares and small market purchases are still usually paid in cash, though.

5. Do you think schools should teach children about money? (NEW)

Absolutely. Many young people finish school without knowing how to budget or save properly. Basic financial lessons would help them avoid debt and make **informed decisions** once they start earning.

Habits

Lifestyle & Habits · sp1_habits

1. What good habits do you have? (NEW)

I'd say reading before bed is my best habit. I also keep a to-do list and try to walk most evenings. None of these are dramatic, but together they make my days feel more **purposeful**.

2. Do you have any habits you would like to change? (your no. 34)

One or two, definitely. I spend too long on my phone, and I sometimes **procrastinate**. I'm slowly working on both, though old habits are surprisingly hard to break.

3. How do you usually develop a new habit? (NEW)

I start small and attach it to something I already do. For example, I read ten pages right after my evening tea. Keeping it manageable like that makes a new habit much easier to **sustain**.

4. Did you have any bad habits as a child? (NEW)

Oh yes, I used to bite my nails constantly, especially before exams. My mother tried everything to stop me. Eventually I simply **outgrew** it, although I still catch myself doing it when I'm nervous.

5. Do you think we learn our habits from our family? (NEW)

To a large extent, yes. I got my love of tea and my habit of rising early from my parents. Children **absorb** a great deal simply by watching the adults around them, both good and bad.

Free time

Interests & Hobbies · sp1_free-time

1. What do you usually do in your free time? (your no. 41)

It varies with my mood. Often I'll read or listen to music, and if I have more time I'll meet friends or watch a film. I try to spend it on things that genuinely relax me rather than mindless **scrolling**.

2. Do you prefer spending your free time alone or with others? (NEW)

A mixture, really. After a long day with students, I often need some quiet time alone to recover. But at weekends I actively seek out friends, because I'd feel quite **isolated** without them.

3. How do you relax after a busy day? (your no. 35)

Usually with something simple. I'll read, listen to music, or watch an episode of a show. Anything that lets me properly **decompress** from work does the trick.

4. Do you have enough free time? (your no. 58)

Not really, if I'm honest. Between work and study, my weekdays fill up fast. I **safeguard** my weekends fiercely, but I do wish I had a little more downtime during the week.

5. Do you think people have less free time today than in the past? (NEW)

In a sense, yes. People work longer hours and are constantly connected, so leisure time gets squeezed. Ironically, though, much of our free time is now spent on screens rather than genuinely **fulfilling** activities.

Transport

Daily Life & Opinions · sp1_transport

1. How do you usually travel around? (your no. 83)

Mostly by bus and rickshaw for daily trips, and occasionally a ride-share app when I'm in a hurry. It works well enough, though the traffic can turn even a short journey into a real **ordeal**.

2. Do you often use public transport? (your no. 36)

Quite often, yes, mainly buses and the occasional rickshaw for shorter trips. It's affordable and saves the stress of parking, although it can get **congested** during peak hours, which is the main downside.

3. How do you usually get to work? (NEW)

Usually by rickshaw, since the office is only a short ride from home. On pleasant mornings I sometimes walk instead. It's a fairly **stress-free** commute compared to what my elder sister faces in Dhaka traffic.

4. Is traffic a problem where you live? (your no. 84)

Very much so, especially in the bigger cities. Congestion during rush hour is genuinely frustrating and eats into everyone's day. I think better public transport is really the only **viable** long-term solution.

5. Would you like to own a car one day? (NEW)

Perhaps eventually, mainly for family trips to our village. For now, though, it isn't really necessary, and the running costs are quite high. A motorbike might be a more **sensible compromise** in the meantime.

Walking

Lifestyle & Habits · sp1_walking

1. Do you like walking? (your no. 37)

I do, more than I expected to. A slow evening walk is one of my favourite ways to unwind, and it's good for my health too. It clears my head far more **effectively** than sitting in front of a screen.

2. How often do you go for a walk? (NEW)

Almost every evening, weather permitting. I usually walk for around half an hour after work. During the monsoon it's harder, but I try to keep it up, because skipping it leaves me feeling **restless**.

3. Where do you like to go for a walk? (NEW)

My favourite spot is the embankment along the Jamuna. The breeze off the river is lovely, and the view at sunset is **breathtaking**. It's quite popular too, so I often bump into people I know.

4. Did you walk a lot as a child? (NEW)

Constantly. I walked to school every day with my friends, and we'd often take the long way home just to **dawdle** and chat. Those walks were a highlight of the day rather than a chore.

5. Do you think people walk less nowadays than in the past? (NEW)

Definitely. With rickshaws, motorbikes and ride-share apps so readily available, many people won't even walk short distances. It's a pity, because walking is such a simple way to stay fit and **clear-headed**.

Weather and seasons

Daily Life & Opinions · sp1_weather

1. What's the weather like where you live? (NEW)

Hot and humid for much of the year. We have a long summer, then a heavy monsoon from around June, and a short, pleasant winter. The monsoon rain can be **torrential**, and flooding is common near the river.

2. What kind of weather do you like? (your no. 81)

I'm fondest of mild, sunny weather, the kind you get here in winter. It's warm enough to be comfortable but not stifling, so you can actually enjoy being outside. The intense summer heat I find rather **oppressive**.

3. What is your favourite season? (your no. 82)

Winter, easily. It's short here but lovely, with cool, pleasant days and clear skies. It's the season when I feel most **energetic** and want to be out and about, so I always look forward to it.

4. Does the weather affect your daily plans? (your no. 38)

Quite a bit, actually. The rainy season here can be **relentless**, so I often check the forecast before heading out. On a pleasant, sunny day I'm far more likely to go out and do something active.

5. Has the weather in your country changed in recent years? (NEW)

People certainly feel it has. Summers seem hotter and longer, and the rains are less predictable than they used to be. My grandfather often says the seasons have become far more **erratic** than in his youth.

Reading and books

Interests & Hobbies · sp1_reading

1. Do you like reading? (your no. 42)

Yes, very much. I've been a keen reader since childhood. I mostly read non-fiction these days, especially business or self-improvement, since I enjoy the feeling of **broadening** my knowledge with each book.

2. What kind of books do you enjoy? (your no. 43)

I lean towards non-fiction, particularly psychology and personal growth. Occasionally I'll pick up a good novel to switch off, but generally I prefer something that offers a genuine **insight** or two.

3. Do you prefer printed books or e-books? (NEW)

Printed books, definitely. I love the feel of paper and being able to see my progress through the pages. That said, e-books are handy for travelling, so I can see myself **embracing** both eventually.

4. What did you read as a child? (NEW)

Mostly comics and adventure stories, which I borrowed from friends or bought with my pocket money. I remember being completely **engrossed** in them, often reading late into the night by torchlight.

5. Do you think young people read less than they used to? (NEW)

In terms of books, probably yes, as phones and social media compete for their attention. But they actually read a great deal online. The problem is that it's often **fragmented** content rather than anything in depth.

Music

Interests & Hobbies · sp1_music

1. Do you like listening to music? (your no. 44)

I do, it's part of my daily life really. I listen while I work, travel and relax. My taste is fairly **eclectic**, from mellow acoustic tracks to a bit of classical when I need to concentrate.

2. What kind of music is popular in your country? (NEW)

Traditional folk music is still hugely popular, especially Baul songs and the classics of Tagore and Nazrul. Younger people also love modern Bangla bands and Western pop, so there's a fascinating **fusion** of old and new.

3. Can you play a musical instrument? (your no. 45)

Not properly, unfortunately. I dabbled with the guitar as a teenager but never **persevered**. It's one of those things I'd genuinely love to return to one day, when I finally have the time.

4. Do you like singing? (your no. 73)

I enjoy it, though only in private or among close friends. I wouldn't sing in front of a crowd, but humming along to a favourite song is one of life's simple **pleasures**.

5. Do you think children should learn music at school? (NEW)

I really think they should. Learning an instrument teaches discipline and patience, and it gives children a **creative outlet** that other subjects don't always offer. I sometimes wish I'd had more encouragement myself when I was younger.

Sport

Interests & Hobbies · sp1_sport

1. What sports do you like? (your no. 46)

Cricket, above all, which is almost a national obsession here. I enjoy playing casually, but I love watching it even more. I also play a bit of badminton, which is a fun way to stay **active** with friends.

2. Did you play much sport as a child? (NEW)

All the time. After school, my friends and I would play cricket in any open field we could find, often until it got dark. Those **makeshift** matches, with a taped tennis ball and a wooden bat, are some of my happiest memories.

3. Do you enjoy watching sports? (your no. 47)

Absolutely, especially cricket. There's a real buzz when the national team is playing, and the whole country seems to stop and watch. Even people who aren't usually into sport get **caught up** in the excitement.

4. Is there a sport you would like to try in the future? (NEW)

I'd love to learn to swim properly, which might sound surprising given that I grew up beside a huge river. I can just about stay afloat, but I'd like to improve, partly for fitness and partly because it's such a **vital life skill**.

5. Do you think sport is important for young people? (NEW)

Definitely. Beyond keeping them fit, sport teaches young people how to cope with losing, cooperate with others and stay disciplined. At a time when so many kids are **glued to their screens**, getting them outside matters more than ever.

Photos and memories

Interests & Hobbies · sp1_photos

1. Do you like taking photos? (your no. 48)

I do, casually at least. I mostly take photos on my phone when I travel or see something striking. I'm no expert, but I love the idea of **preserving** a moment so I can look back on it later.

2. What do you usually take photos of? (NEW)

Mostly landscapes and family moments. The Jamuna at sunset is a favourite subject, because the light on the water is just **breathtaking**. I also take lots of pictures of my nephew whenever we visit my sister in Dhaka.

3. Do you like keeping photos of special events? (your no. 76)

Definitely. I love looking back at photos from trips and celebrations, because they bring the feelings of that day rushing back. They're some of my most **treasured** possessions, honestly.

4. Do you prefer printed photos or keeping them on your phone? (NEW)

Practically, I keep almost everything on my phone, but I have a real soft spot for printed photos. My mother still has old albums from her wedding, and flicking through them together has a **nostalgic** charm that scrolling never quite matches.

5. Do you think people take too many photos nowadays? (NEW)

I think so, yes. Because it costs nothing, people snap hundreds of pictures and hardly ever look at them again. Sometimes I feel we're so busy **capturing** a moment that we forget to actually enjoy it.

Art and drawing

Entertainment & Culture · sp1_art

1. Are you interested in art? (your no. 68)

I appreciate it, though from a distance. I enjoy visiting exhibitions and admiring how much emotion an artist can **convey** in a single piece, even if I can't create anything like it myself.

2. What kind of art do you like? (NEW)

I'm most drawn to traditional Bangladeshi art, particularly the colourful rickshaw paintings you see everywhere here. They're bold, cheerful and full of detail, and I love that such **intricate** work decorates something so ordinary.

3. Are you good at drawing or painting? (your no. 49)

Not really, I'll admit. I enjoy looking at art far more than creating it. My drawing skills are fairly **rudimentary**, so I happily leave that to more talented people.

4. Did you do art at school when you were a child? (NEW)

We had art classes in primary school, and I remember enjoying them even though my pictures were fairly clumsy. It was a nice break from memorising facts, and it let us be a bit more **imaginative** than usual.

5. Do you think art is important in education? (NEW)

Absolutely. Art encourages children to think creatively and express feelings they might not have words for yet. Sadly, it's often **sidelined** here in favour of subjects seen as more practical, which I think is a real missed opportunity.

Collecting

Interests & Hobbies · sp1_collecting

1. Do you collect anything? (your no. 50)

Books, if that counts. I find it hard to give any away, so my collection just keeps growing. There's something comforting about a shelf full of books you've read, or still **intend** to read one day.

2. Did you collect anything as a child? (NEW)

Stamps and coins, like lots of children back then. My father would sometimes bring home old coins that customers had given him at the shop, and I kept them in a tin box as if they were **priceless** treasures.

3. What kinds of things do people in your country collect? (NEW)

Stamps and coins used to be the classic choices, though they're less common now. These days younger people are more likely to collect cricket **memorabilia**, like signed bats or team jerseys, which says a lot about how much the sport means here.

4. Why do you think people like collecting things? (NEW)

I think it gives people a sense of purpose and achievement, slowly building something over time. There's also the **thrill of the hunt**, that excitement of finally finding the one missing piece you've been searching for.

5. Would you like to start a new collection in the future? (NEW)

Maybe, if I ever get to study abroad. I'd love to collect something small from every city I visit, nothing expensive, just a modest **memento** that brings the experience back whenever I look at it.

Games

Interests & Hobbies · sp1_games

1. Do you play any video games? (your no. 51)

Occasionally, mostly simple ones on my phone to pass the time. I'm not a serious gamer by any means. For me it's more of a light **distraction** during a break than a proper hobby.

2. What games did you play when you were a child? (NEW)

Mostly outdoor games with the neighbourhood kids, like hide and seek, kabaddi and, of course, cricket. We spent long, **carefree** afternoons outside, and nobody needed a screen to have a good time.

3. Do you enjoy playing board games? (NEW)

I do, especially carrom, which is hugely popular in Bangladesh. My family sometimes plays after dinner, and it gets surprisingly **cut-throat**, particularly between me and my younger sister, who absolutely hates losing.

4. Do adults in your country play games? (NEW)

Quite a lot, actually. Older men often gather at tea stalls to play cards or chess in the evenings, and ludo on mobile phones has become a national **pastime** for people of all ages.

5. Do you think video games are good for children? (NEW)

In moderation, they can be. Some games genuinely improve problem-solving and reaction speed. The real issue is when children play for hours on end, because it can become quite **addictive** and take time away from studying and being outdoors.

Outdoor activities

Interests & Hobbies · sp1_outdoors

1. Do you enjoy outdoor activities? (your no. 52)

Yes, whenever I get the chance. I love being outdoors, whether it's a walk by the river or a short trip somewhere green. Being in nature is easily the best way for me to **rejuvenate**.

2. What outdoor activities are popular in your country? (NEW)

Cricket is the obvious one, played in every field and alley. Apart from that, people enjoy fishing, boating on the rivers and family picnics, which are a **cherished** winter tradition here.

3. Did you spend a lot of time outdoors as a child? (NEW)

Almost constantly. My mother had a hard time getting me inside before dark. I was either playing cricket, climbing trees or wandering along the riverbank, so I was **perpetually** covered in mud when I finally came home.

4. Do you prefer being indoors or outdoors? (NEW)

Given the choice, outdoors, though the weather here decides a lot. In the height of summer the heat can be **sweltering**, so I stay in, but on a cool winter morning nothing beats being outside.

5. Do you think people spend less time outdoors than in the past? (NEW)

Sadly, yes. Cities are more crowded, open spaces are disappearing, and screens keep people indoors. I think we're gradually becoming **disconnected from** nature, which probably affects our mood and health more than we realise.

Gardening

Interests & Hobbies · sp1_gardening

1. Are you interested in gardening? (your no. 54)

A little, yes. We keep a few potted plants at home, and I quite enjoy tending to them. There's something calming about **nurturing** something and watching it grow because of the small effort you put in.

2. What kind of plants do you have at home? (NEW)

Mostly small, **low-maintenance** ones on our balcony, like aloe vera, a money plant and a couple of chilli plants. My mother also grows a few herbs, which she proudly uses in her cooking.

3. Does anyone in your family enjoy gardening? (NEW)

My grandmother, without a doubt. At the village home she grows beans, pumpkins and all sorts of vegetables. Her understanding of soil and seasons is completely **instinctive**, built up over decades rather than learned from books.

4. Did you do any gardening as a child? (NEW)

A little, at my grandparents' house. My grandfather would let me help plant seeds, and I remember checking every morning to see if anything had **sprouted**. That kind of patience didn't come naturally to me back then.

5. Would you like to have a garden of your own one day? (NEW)

I'd love that. Living in a flat, a proper garden isn't really possible, but in the future I'd like a small plot where I could grow vegetables. Eating something you've grown yourself must be incredibly **rewarding**.

Writing

Interests & Hobbies · sp1_writing

1. Do you like writing? (your no. 55)

I do, actually. My work involves a fair bit of writing, and I've grown to enjoy shaping ideas into clear, **coherent** sentences. I sometimes jot down thoughts in a notebook too, just for myself.

2. Did you enjoy writing when you were at school? (NEW)

Not especially, to be honest. Essay writing felt like a chore because we mostly had to memorise model answers. It was only at university that I started to enjoy it, once I could **articulate** my own ideas rather than copying someone else's.

3. Do you often write emails or letters? (your no. 95)

Emails, yes, mostly for work. Handwritten letters have almost disappeared, which is a shame. There's a personal warmth to a letter that a quick email just can't quite **replicate**.

4. Have you ever written a poem or a story? (NEW)

Only a few short poems in Bengali when I was a teenager, mostly about the river and the monsoon. They were fairly **sentimental**, looking back, but I still keep them in an old notebook at home.

5. Do you think handwriting will still be important in the future? (NEW)

Less than before, certainly, since so much is typed now. Still, I think it will always matter to some degree. A handwritten note has a personal touch, and writing by hand helps ideas **sink in** far better than typing does.

Dancing

Interests & Hobbies · sp1_dancing

1. Can you dance? (your no. 56)

Not particularly well. I'll join in at weddings and celebrations, which is impossible to avoid here, but I'd never call myself a dancer. I do it purely for the fun of the moment rather than any real **flair**.

2. Is dancing popular in your country? (NEW)

Very much so, especially at weddings and cultural festivals. Classical and folk dance are also taught formally, and during Pohela Boishakh you often see groups performing in **vibrant** traditional costumes.

3. Did you learn to dance when you were a child? (NEW)

No, dance lessons were more common for girls where I grew up. My younger sister took classical dance classes for a few years, though, and she was genuinely **graceful**, unlike her brother.

4. Do you enjoy watching other people dance? (NEW)

Definitely, especially skilled performers. I once watched a Manipuri dance performance at a cultural event, and the control and precision were **mesmerising**. It's a completely different experience from watching relatives dance at a wedding.

5. Do you think dancing is a good way to keep fit? (NEW)

I'd say it's one of the best, because people forget they're exercising. It works the whole body and lifts your mood at the same time, so it's far easier to **stick with** than a dull gym routine.

Hobbies

Interests & Hobbies · sp1_hobbies

1. What hobbies do you have? (NEW)

Reading is my main one, usually with a cup of tea in the evening. I also enjoy long walks by the river and watching cricket, which becomes something of an **obsession** during big tournaments.

2. Did you have any hobbies as a child? (NEW)

Plenty. I collected stamps, flew kites on the rooftop and played cricket whenever I could. Kite flying was my favourite, and I'd spend hours trying to **outmanoeuvre** the neighbours' kites and cut their strings.

3. Do you prefer doing hobbies alone or with others? (your no. 60)

It depends on the hobby. Reading and writing I much prefer in **solitude**, in a quiet corner. But sport and travel are far better shared, because the fun is really in the company.

4. Is there a new hobby you would like to try? (your no. 57)

Yes, I'd love to learn photography properly. I already enjoy taking casual shots, so mastering the technical side, like lighting and composition, feels like a natural and exciting **progression**.

5. Do you think it's important to have hobbies? (NEW)

I really do. Hobbies give you a break from the pressure of work and let you do something purely for enjoyment. Without them, life can easily become a **monotonous** cycle of working, eating and sleeping.

Films and cinema

Entertainment & Culture · sp1_films

1. Do you like watching films? (your no. 61)

I do, very much. It's my go-to way to unwind at the weekend. I enjoy a good thriller or a thoughtful drama, and I especially like films that are genuinely **thought-provoking** long after they've ended.

2. What kind of films are popular in your country? (NEW)

Commercial action films and romantic dramas have always been popular here, along with Indian and Hollywood blockbusters. Recently, though, some Bangladeshi directors have made **critically acclaimed** films that are attracting a younger, more discerning audience.

3. Do you prefer watching films at home or at the cinema? (your no. 62)

Both have their charm, but I usually watch at home for the comfort. That said, for a big, visually **spectacular** film, the cinema experience is hard to beat, so I save those for the big screen.

4. What was the last film you watched? (NEW)

It was a historical drama about the Liberation War, which I watched with my father. It was quite heavy in places, but it was **beautifully shot**, and it sparked a long conversation between us about what my grandparents lived through at that time.

5. Do you think films can help people learn a language? (NEW)

Without a doubt. My English listening improved a lot through watching films with subtitles. You pick up natural expressions, **intonation** and slang that textbooks rarely teach, and it's far more enjoyable than studying grammar.

TV and streaming

Entertainment & Culture · sp1_tv

1. Do you watch much television? (your no. 63)

Not traditional TV, no. Like a lot of people my age, I've shifted almost **entirely** to streaming, so I watch what I want, when I want. It gives me far more control over my viewing.

2. Do you use streaming services? (your no. 79)

All the time. They've completely **transformed** how I watch things. Having a huge library available whenever I want is incredibly convenient, and I honestly can't imagine going back to fixed TV schedules.

3. What kind of programmes do you like? (your no. 64)

I gravitate towards documentaries and the occasional gripping drama. Documentaries in particular appeal to me, because I get to relax and gain a bit of **insight** at the same time, which feels like time well spent.

4. Did you watch much TV when you were a child? (NEW)

Quite a lot, especially cartoons after school and cricket matches with my father. Back then the whole family gathered around one television, so watching something together was a real **communal** experience, which I sometimes miss.

5. Do you think people watch too much TV nowadays? (NEW)

I think screen time in general is the issue now rather than TV itself. With streaming, it's so easy to **binge-watch** an entire series in one weekend, and many people, including me occasionally, lose track of time completely.

Social media

Entertainment & Culture · sp1_social-media

1. Which social media apps do you use most? (NEW)

Facebook, mainly, because it's by far the most widely used platform in Bangladesh. It's where my family and friends share news, and for many local businesses it's become **indispensable** for reaching customers.

2. Do you often post things online? (NEW)

Not very often. I'm more of a **passive** user, scrolling and reading rather than sharing. When I do post, it's usually photos from a trip or a family occasion, just to keep relatives in the loop.

3. Do you use social media a lot? (your no. 65)

More than I'd like to admit. I use it to stay in touch and follow the news, but I've noticed how easily an hour **vanishes**. I'm trying to use it more intentionally rather than out of pure habit.

4. Do you think social media is good for young people? (NEW)

It's a **double-edged sword**. It helps them learn, connect and express themselves, but it can also fuel anxiety and constant comparison with others. I think the key is teaching young people to use it wisely rather than banning it.

5. Has social media changed the way people communicate? (NEW)

Enormously. People message constantly but talk face to face less, and conversations have become much shorter and more **fragmented**. On the positive side, it's much easier for me to stay in touch with friends who've moved abroad.

Festivals and celebrations

Entertainment & Culture · sp1_festivals

1. What festivals do you celebrate? (your no. 66)

The two Eids are the biggest for us, along with cultural events like Pohela Boishakh, the Bengali New Year. They're wonderful occasions, full of food, family and colour, and the whole community becomes **vibrant**.

2. Which festival do you enjoy the most? (NEW)

Eid-ul-Fitr, without a doubt. After a month of fasting, there's a wonderful sense of relief and joy, and the whole family comes together, often at our village home. The **jubilant** mood lasts for days.

3. How do you usually celebrate special occasions? (your no. 67)

Usually with family and a large meal, which is really at the heart of any celebration here. We dress up, visit relatives, and the day is loud, lively and warm. Food is always the **centrepiece**.

4. How did you celebrate festivals when you were a child? (NEW)

Eid was the highlight of my year. I'd get new clothes, and older relatives would give us salami, a small gift of money. My cousins and I would compare how much we'd collected, which was **fiercely competitive**.

5. Do you think festivals have changed over the years? (NEW)

In some ways, yes. People now send greetings online instead of visiting everyone in person, and celebrations have become more **commercialised**, with lots of shopping. But the core of it, family and food, has stayed exactly the same.

Museums

Entertainment & Culture · sp1_museums

1. Are there many museums in your hometown? (NEW)

Not really. Sirajganj is a modest town, so there's nothing major. The best known is Tagore's old family estate at Shahzadpur, which has been turned into a museum and is quite **atmospheric**.

2. Do you like visiting museums? (your no. 69)

Yes, actually. I find them fascinating, especially history museums, because they bring the past to life in a way books can't. I don't go nearly often enough, but each visit is genuinely **enlightening**.

3. When did you last visit a museum? (NEW)

About a year ago, I went to the Liberation War Museum in Dhaka while visiting my sister. It was an incredibly moving experience, and some of the personal letters on display were genuinely **harrowing** to read.

4. Did you go to museums on school trips? (NEW)

Only once or twice, as school trips weren't very common where I grew up. I remember being **captivated** by the old coins and weapons, though, and asking the guide far too many questions.

5. Do you think museums will still be popular in the future? (NEW)

I think so, as long as they adapt. Young people expect interactive displays and digital content now, so museums that feel dull and **static** may struggle. But seeing real historical objects in person will always have its appeal.

Concerts and events

Entertainment & Culture · sp1_events

1. Have you ever been to a concert? (your no. 70)

A few times, yes, mostly local ones. There's a special energy to live music that a recording just can't capture. Being surrounded by a crowd who love the same songs is genuinely **exhilarating**.

2. What kind of events are held in your town? (NEW)

Mostly local fairs, religious gatherings and cultural programmes on national days. The Baishakhi fair is probably the biggest, with stalls selling handicrafts and snacks, and it draws a **sizeable** crowd from the surrounding villages.

3. Do you enjoy going to public events? (your no. 77)

I do, in moderation. Cultural fairs and festivals have a wonderful atmosphere, and I like being part of the crowd. Very large, **chaotic** events can be a bit much for me, though, so I pick and choose.

4. Do you prefer watching events live or online? (NEW)

Live, if possible, because the atmosphere is half the experience. Watching online is convenient, but it feels a bit **detached**, as if you're looking in from the outside rather than actually taking part.

5. Is there an event you would love to attend in the future? (NEW)

I'd love to watch a cricket World Cup match in a big stadium, ideally with Bangladesh playing. Being among thousands of passionate fans would be a **once-in-a-lifetime** experience, and I'd happily travel abroad for it.

Traditional culture

Entertainment & Culture · sp1_tradition

1. What traditions are important in your family? (NEW)

Respecting elders is central, so we greet older relatives formally and seek their blessings at Eid. We also make pitha, traditional rice cakes, in winter, which is a **time-honoured** ritual my mother learned from my grandmother.

2. Do you think traditional culture is important? (your no. 71)

Very much so. It gives people a sense of identity and connects generations. In a fast-changing world, I think **preserving** our traditions, our language and festivals especially, matters more than ever.

3. Did your grandparents teach you about traditions? (NEW)

Very much so, especially my grandmother. She has little formal education, but she's a **treasure trove** of folk tales, proverbs and old customs. Listening to her stories as a child gave me a real sense of where I come from.

4. Do you ever wear traditional clothes? (NEW)

Quite often, actually. I wear a panjabi at Eid, at weddings and on Pohela Boishakh. It's comfortable and elegant, and wearing it gives me a quiet sense of **belonging** to something bigger than myself.

5. Do you think young people are losing interest in traditional culture? (your no. 80)

To some extent, yes, mainly because of global influences and social media. But I don't think it's **diminishing** entirely. Many young people still take great pride in their roots, just alongside a more modern lifestyle.

Local food

Entertainment & Culture · sp1_food-culture

1. What is a typical meal in Bangladesh? (NEW)

Rice is the foundation of almost every meal, usually with fish curry, lentils and some vegetables. There's even a saying that fish and rice make a Bengali, so it's **deeply rooted** in our identity.

2. Is food an important part of your culture? (your no. 72)

Enormously. In Bangladesh, food is at the centre of almost every gathering. Sharing a meal is how we express **hospitality**, so it's really far more than just eating.

3. What's your favourite local dish? (NEW)

Hilsa cooked in mustard sauce, without question. Hilsa is our national fish, and my mother's version is **unrivalled** in my opinion. Coming from a river town, fresh fish is something I'd miss terribly if I lived abroad.

4. Can you cook any local dishes? (NEW)

Only a few basic ones, like dal and a simple egg curry. My mother is an excellent cook, so I've never really had to **fend for myself** in the kitchen, which I know will have to change if I study abroad.

5. Has the food in your country changed in recent years? (NEW)

Quite noticeably. Fast food outlets and cafés have **mushroomed** in towns as well as cities, and young people love burgers and pizza. Still, when it comes to family gatherings, traditional home cooking always wins.

News

Entertainment & Culture · sp1_news

1. Do you follow the news? (your no. 74)

Yes, I like to stay **informed**, mostly through news apps and a bit of online reading. I try not to overdo it, though, because too much news can be draining. A quick daily catch-up is usually enough.

2. What kind of news are you most interested in? (NEW)

Mostly education and international news, since both relate to my job. Changes to student visa rules abroad, for example, directly affect the students I advise, so I **keep a close eye** on them.

3. How do you usually get your news? (your no. 75)

Almost entirely online, through my phone. It's quick and I can check headlines whenever I have a spare moment. I rarely watch the news on television any more, which feels **outdated** to me now.

4. Did your family watch the news together when you were young? (NEW)

Every evening, yes. My father **religiously** watched the eight o'clock news, and we all had to stay quiet until it finished. As a child I found it boring, but now I realise how much I picked up just by listening.

5. Do you trust the news you read online? (NEW)

Not everything, no. There's a lot of misleading content online, especially on social media, so I try to **cross-check** stories with reliable sources before believing them. I think media literacy should really be taught in schools now.

Comedy

Entertainment & Culture · sp1_comedy

1. Who makes you laugh the most? (NEW)

My grandfather, surprisingly. He's in his eighties but still incredibly sharp, and he has a wonderfully **dry sense of humour**. He'll say something outrageous with a completely straight face, and the whole family ends up in fits of laughter.

2. Do you like watching comedy shows? (your no. 78)

Yes, I love a good laugh at the end of a long day. Comedy is the easiest way for me to switch off. I especially enjoy clever, **observational** humour that plays on everyday situations.

3. Are you good at telling jokes? (NEW)

Not especially. I always rush the punchline or start laughing before I finish. I'm much better at **witty** remarks in the moment, reacting to what's happening around me, than at telling a prepared joke.

4. What did you find funny when you were a child? (NEW)

Mostly slapstick, like cartoons where characters fell over or got chased. My sister and I used to watch Mr Bean together and laugh until our stomachs hurt. That kind of physical comedy is **universally** funny, I think.

5. Do you think humour is different in different cultures? (NEW)

Definitely. A lot of humour depends on wordplay and shared references, so it often gets **lost in translation**. I've noticed that some Bengali jokes simply don't work in English, however carefully I try to explain them.

Plans and decisions

Daily Life & Opinions · sp1_plans

1. Do you like making plans? (your no. 86)

I do, generally. Having a rough plan gives me direction and stops me wasting time. That said, I try not to over-plan, because some of the best moments come from being a little **spontaneous**.

2. Do you usually plan your weekends? (NEW)

Loosely. I'll usually have one or two things in mind, like visiting relatives or catching up on reading, but I leave plenty of room for rest. After a busy week, a **laid-back** weekend is exactly what I need.

3. Are you good at making decisions? (your no. 89)

I'd say I'm decisive with small things, but I take my time over big ones, weighing up the options carefully. Occasionally I **deliberate** for too long, but I'd rather be thorough than rush and regret it.

4. Who do you ask for advice when you have an important decision to make? (NEW)

Usually my father. He ran his own business for over thirty years, so he has a very practical, **level-headed** way of looking at things. For more personal matters, though, I often talk to my elder sister.

5. Is it better to plan for the future or live in the moment? (NEW)

I think you need a balance. Planning ahead gives you security, especially with things like careers and savings. But if you're **fixated on** the future all the time, you can easily miss the joy of what's happening right now.

Being organised

Daily Life & Opinions · sp1_organised

1. Are you an organised person? (your no. 97)

Fairly, yes. I like to keep things in order, both my space and my schedule, because clutter genuinely stresses me out. A little organisation up front spares me a lot of **hassle** later.

2. How do you keep track of your tasks? (NEW)

I rely mostly on my phone's calendar and a simple to-do list. At work I'm handling applications for lots of students with different deadlines, so writing everything down is **non-negotiable** for me.

3. Are you more productive in the morning or the evening? (your no. 87)

Definitely the morning. My mind is **sharpest** then, so I tackle my hardest tasks early. By the evening my focus fades, so I save lighter activities for later in the day.

4. Were you organised when you were a child? (NEW)

Not at all, I'm afraid. My school bag was always a mess and I was forever losing pencils. My mother **despaired of** me at times, so being organised is definitely something I learned later in life.

5. Do you think it's important for students to be organised? (NEW)

Absolutely, and I see it every day in my job. The students who stay organised tend to meet deadlines calmly, while the others end up **scrambling** at the last minute and making careless mistakes on their applications.

Change

Daily Life & Opinions · sp1_change

1. Do you often change your daily routine? (NEW)

Not much during the week, as my working hours are fairly fixed. I do try to vary my weekends, though, because doing exactly the same thing every day can make life feel a bit **stale**.

2. Do you welcome change in your life? (your no. 88)

Cautiously, yes. I'm comfortable with routine, but I've learned that a bit of change usually leads to growth. So even when it feels **daunting** at first, I try to see it as an opportunity rather than a threat.

3. Has anything changed in your life recently? (NEW)

Yes, my father retired recently after running his business for over thirty years. It's been a real **period of adjustment** for the whole family, since he's at home all day now, but it's lovely to see him finally relaxing.

4. Is there anything you would like to change about your life? (NEW)

I'd like to study abroad at some point, which would be a big change. After years of helping other students do it, I feel ready to step out of my own **comfort zone** and experience it myself.

5. Do you think older people find change harder than young people? (NEW)

Generally, yes, though not always. My grandfather is in his eighties and still **remarkably adaptable**, and he even video calls my sister in Dhaka. But many older people understandably feel more secure with familiar routines.

Patience

Daily Life & Opinions · sp1_patience

1. Are you a patient person? (your no. 90)

Reasonably, yes, though it depends on the situation. I'm quite patient with people, but I can get **restless** when I'm stuck waiting, in traffic for instance. It's something I'm consciously working on.

2. Is patience important in your job? (NEW)

Hugely important. Visa and admission processes can take months, and students naturally get anxious. Part of my role is reassuring them and staying calm and **composed**, even when they call me for the tenth time about the same thing.

3. Were you patient as a child? (NEW)

Not in the slightest. I wanted everything immediately, whether it was my food, a new toy or my turn at batting. My parents constantly told me to wait, which I found completely **infuriating** at the time.

4. Who is the most patient person you know? (NEW)

My mother, without question. She looks after our home, helps care for my grandparents and still finds time for everyone. I've never seen her lose her temper, which is honestly **admirable** given how much she juggles.

5. Do you think people are less patient nowadays than in the past? (NEW)

I'd say so. We're used to **instant gratification** now, with fast internet, quick deliveries and endless entertainment on our phones. As a result, waiting even a few minutes can feel unbearable to many people.

Colours

Daily Life & Opinions · sp1_colours

1. Do you have a favourite colour? (your no. 91)

I do, it's blue. I find it calming and easy on the eye, so a lot of my clothes and even my room lean towards it. It has a soothing quality that I'm naturally drawn to.

2. What colours do you usually wear? (NEW)

Mostly understated shades like navy, grey and white for everyday wear, since they look smart for work. On festival days, though, I'm happy to wear something brighter to match the mood.

3. Is there a colour you don't like? (NEW)

Not strongly, but I'm not keen on very bright orange or neon shades. They feel a bit loud and garish to me, especially on clothes, although I can see why some people love them.

4. Do colours have special meanings in your country? (NEW)

Yes, quite a few. Red and white are strongly associated with Pohela Boishakh, and the green and red of our flag are symbolic too, representing the land and the sacrifice of those who fought for independence.

5. Do you think colours can affect people's mood? (NEW)

I really believe they can. Soft blues and greens make a room feel calm, while warm colours tend to be more energising. That's probably why hospitals and offices choose their colour schemes so deliberately.

Lucky numbers

Daily Life & Opinions · sp1_numbers

1. Are you good with numbers? (NEW)

Reasonably good, I'd say. My business studies involved plenty of accounting and statistics, and I often helped my father with his shop accounts, so I'm fairly proficient with everyday calculations and budgets.

2. Did you enjoy maths at school? (NEW)

I did, mostly. I liked that there was always a clear answer, unlike essay questions. Geometry was my weak point, though, and some of those proofs left me utterly baffled.

3. Is there a number you consider lucky? (your no. 92)

Not really, to be honest. I'm not very superstitious about numbers. I know many people have a lucky one, but I've never felt that any particular number has made a difference in my life.

4. Do people in your country believe in lucky numbers? (NEW)

Some do, though it's not as big a thing as in some other countries. You'll occasionally hear of people paying extra for a phone number with a distinctive pattern, but most people don't take it too seriously.

5. Do you think people remember numbers less than they used to? (NEW)

Definitely. I remember knowing dozens of phone numbers by heart as a child, but now I barely know my own sister's. We've outsourced our memory to our phones, which is convenient but slightly worrying.

Gifts

Daily Life & Opinions · sp1_gifts

1. Do you enjoy giving gifts? (your no. 93)

I really do. I love the challenge of finding something that suits the person perfectly, and their reaction when they open it is the best part. A **thoughtful** gift means far more than an expensive one.

2. What was the last gift you bought for someone? (NEW)

A set of picture books for my four-year-old nephew. He's at that age where he wants stories read to him constantly, so I chose ones with **vivid** illustrations. My sister says he takes them to bed every night.

3. Do you like receiving gifts? (your no. 94)

Of course, who doesn't? But what I appreciate most is the thought behind it. A small, meaningful present from someone who knows me well means much more than something **lavish** given without much care.

4. When do people give gifts in your country? (NEW)

Mainly at Eid, weddings and birthdays, although birthdays are a more recent custom in many families. At weddings especially, gift-giving is quite an **elaborate** affair, and relatives sometimes feel pressure to give something impressive.

5. Do you think it's better to give money or a gift? (NEW)

It depends on the person. Money is practical, especially for newly married couples, and Eid salami is a much-loved custom. But a carefully chosen gift shows real **consideration**, so for close friends I'd always choose something personal.

Helping others

Daily Life & Opinions · sp1_helping

1. Do you enjoy helping other people? (your no. 98)

I really do. My whole job is essentially about helping people reach their goals, and I find that deeply **fulfilling**. Even small acts of help brighten my day, and they usually come back around in some form.

2. How do you usually help people in your family? (NEW)

Mostly with practical things. I sort out bills and online forms for my parents, and I help my younger sister with her English. It's nothing **heroic**, but it takes a bit of pressure off everyone.

3. Did your parents teach you to help others? (NEW)

Very much so. My father often let struggling customers pay later, and my mother always shares food with the neighbours. Growing up around that kind of **generosity**, helping others just became second nature to me.

4. Do people in your country often help their neighbours? (NEW)

Traditionally, yes, especially in villages and small towns like mine. If someone's ill or there's a wedding, neighbours **rally round** without being asked. In big cities like Dhaka, though, people tend to keep themselves to themselves more.

5. Do you think people are less helpful than they used to be? (NEW)

Not less helpful, just busier. When there's a flood, I've seen people raise money and deliver supplies remarkably quickly, often **mobilising** through social media. The kindness is still there, it simply looks different now.

Talking to strangers

Daily Life & Opinions · sp1_strangers

1. Do you find it easy to talk to strangers? (your no. 99)

It depends on the setting, but generally yes. I'm fairly comfortable striking up a conversation, and you often learn something interesting. A little friendliness goes a long way in putting people at ease.

2. In what situations do you talk to strangers? (NEW)

Most often while travelling, on long bus journeys to Dhaka, for instance. Four hours is a long time, so chatting to the person beside you is almost inevitable. I've had some surprisingly deep conversations that way.

3. Were you told not to talk to strangers as a child? (NEW)

Yes, my mother was quite strict about it, especially in crowded places like markets. Looking back, it was a perfectly reasonable rule, although in our small neighbourhood almost nobody was really a stranger.

4. Are people in your country friendly towards strangers? (NEW)

Generally, very. Bangladeshis are known for their warmth, and it's quite normal for someone to invite a traveller for tea or walk them somewhere rather than just pointing. Foreign visitors often mention how welcoming people are.

5. Do you think it's safe to talk to strangers online? (NEW)

It can be, but you have to be cautious. It's very easy for people to misrepresent themselves online, so I'd never share personal details with someone I hadn't met. Young people especially need to be careful.

Happiness

Daily Life & Opinions · sp1_happiness

1. Would you say you're a happy person? (NEW)

I'd say so, yes. I have a supportive family, a job that feels meaningful and good health. I've learned not to take things for granted, and that alone makes me feel quite fortunate most days.

2. What kinds of things make you happy? (your no. 100)

Simple things, mostly. Time with people I love, a good book, a quiet evening after a productive day. I've realised over time that lasting contentment rarely comes from big events, but from small, everyday moments.

3. What made you happy when you were a child? (NEW)

Very simple pleasures, honestly. Flying kites on the roof, visiting my grandparents in the village and eating mangoes straight from their trees. Life felt blissfully uncomplicated back then, with no deadlines or responsibilities to worry about.

4. Do you think money can buy happiness? (NEW)

Only up to a point. Having enough to live comfortably certainly reduces stress, but beyond that, relationships and purpose matter far more. Some of the most cheerful people I know, like my grandmother, live very frugally indeed.

5. Do you think people are happier now than in the past? (NEW)

It's hard to say. Life is certainly more comfortable, but people seem more stressed and constantly compare themselves with others online. My grandparents had far less, yet they seem more at peace than many young people I know.

Part 2 · Cue cards

1. Describe a person who has influenced you

People · your card 1 · sp2_people_01 · 260 words (yours: 164)

- who the person is
- how you know them
- what they did
- and how they influenced you

I would like to talk about someone very close to home. The person who has influenced me most is my father, who ran a small business in Sirajganj for over thirty years and has only recently retired. Obviously I have known him all my life, but I think I only really started to understand him as a teenager, when I began helping out in his shop after school. Growing up, I watched him deal with setbacks that would have **discouraged** most people, yet he always stayed calm and kept going. There were slow seasons, especially during the monsoon, when hardly anyone came in, but he never let his worries spill over into family life. What shaped me was not any single piece of advice, but the quiet example he set day after day. He treated every customer, however difficult, with the same **integrity**, and he taught me that a good reputation is built slowly and lost quickly. When I was struggling to choose a career, he never pushed me in one direction; instead he encouraged me to be **self-reliant** and make my own decisions. Looking back, almost everything I value about hard work and honesty can be traced to him, and I try to bring the same patience to my job at the consultancy, especially with anxious students. His influence has been **profound**, and I still catch myself asking what he would do in a tricky situation. In many ways he remains my quiet role model, even now that I am an adult, and I suspect he always will be.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you still ask your father for advice? Yes, quite often, especially about money or big decisions. Since he retired he has more time to talk, so we usually chat over tea in the evening, and his advice is still remarkably **level-headed**.

Would you like to be like him in the future? In many ways, yes. I would love to have his patience and honesty, although I probably will not run a shop. I just hope people eventually see me as someone as trustworthy as he is.

Part 3 link: Role Models · Family & Relationships

2. Describe a time when you spent time with a child

People · your card 2 · sp2_people_02 · 254 words (yours: 174)

- when it was
- who the child was
- why you spent time with them
- and explain what you did

I would like to describe a lovely afternoon I spent with my nephew. Not long ago, during the winter, my elder sister paid us a surprise visit from Dhaka with her four-year-old son, and I ended up spending a whole afternoon with him. My sister had some errands to run in town with my mother, so I happily volunteered to keep him entertained. I had always found him endearing, but this was the first time we had really had a proper day together, just the two of us. He was remarkably **inquisitive** for his age, firing off questions about almost everything, some of which genuinely stumped me, like why the river never runs out of water. We built a fort out of cushions, drew a few clumsy animals, and I read him a couple of stories, putting on silly voices that he found hilarious. Later we walked down to the bank of the Jamuna to watch the boats, which he absolutely loved. What struck me most was how **perceptive** children are: he picked up on my

mood instantly and kept trying to cheer me up. By evening I was exhausted, but it was the most **rewarding** kind of tiredness. It reminded me that spending time with a child forces you to slow down and be fully present, something adults rarely manage. Honestly, that afternoon was **a welcome escape** from my usual routine, and I have made a point of seeing him more often since, even if that means a long bus journey to Dhaka.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you enjoy spending time with children in general? Yes, I do, although I find it quite tiring. Children are so honest and **unfiltered** that you cannot pretend around them, and I think that is rather refreshing compared with the adult world.

Would you like to have children of your own one day? I think so, but not for a few years. I would like to be settled in my career first, and perhaps finish studying abroad, so that I can give them proper time and attention.

Part 3 link: Parenting & Childhood · Family & Relationships

3. Describe someone you know who has a lot of responsibilities

People · your card 3 · sp2_people_03 · 252 words (yours: 167)

- who the person is
- what responsibilities they have
- how they handle them
- and how you feel about them

When I think about someone with a lot on their plate, one person immediately stands out. The person who comes to mind is my mother, who somehow manages to juggle an enormous number of duties without ever seeming **overwhelmed**. Besides running the entire household, she ~~looks~~ helps look after my elderly grandparents in our ancestral village, which means travelling back and forth quite often, and she still finds time to help neighbours during any crisis. On top of that, she manages the household budget and keeps a close eye on my younger sister's studies. As for how she handles it all, what amazes me is how **methodical** she is; she plans her days carefully so nothing important slips through the cracks. She is usually up before everyone else, and by the time we sit down to breakfast half her list is already done. I have often seen her handle a sick relative, a household emergency and a family gathering all in the same week, yet she rarely complains. She has this quiet **resilience** that I deeply admire, and she genuinely believes that looking after others is a privilege rather than a burden. Whenever I feel stretched by my own comparatively minor workload, I think of her and feel slightly embarrassed. She has taught me that carrying responsibility gracefully is a skill in itself. Honestly, I consider her the most **dependable** person I know, and the whole family leans on her more than we probably realise. I really should tell her that more often.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you help your mother with her responsibilities? I try to, although not as much as I should. I do the shopping at the weekend and sometimes go with her to the village, but she still **shoulders** most of the work herself.

Do you think you will have more responsibilities in the future? Almost certainly. As my parents get older, I expect to take on more at home, and my career will bring its own pressures. I just hope I can cope with them as calmly as she does.

Part 3 link: Family & Relationships · Work-Life Balance

4. Describe a person you admire

- who the person is
- how you know about them
- what qualities they have
- and why you admire them

Someone I genuinely admire is a former teacher of mine who went far beyond what his job required. I knew him through secondary school in Sirajganj, where he taught **English**, **mathematics**, but his real gift was noticing students who were quietly struggling. I was one of them for a while, because I found algebra completely baffling in my first year with him. In terms of his qualities, he was endlessly **patient**, staying behind after class to help anyone who asked, and he never made you feel foolish for not understanding. What I admired most was his **humility**; despite being extremely knowledgeable, he always spoke to us as equals. He had a way of making difficult ideas feel **accessible**, often using examples from the local market or cricket scores, and he clearly cared about the person, not just the grade. Years later, I still remember specific things he said that shaped how I think. As for why I admire him, I think what sets people like him apart is that they are motivated by a genuine desire to help rather than any reward. He was never well paid, and he could easily have earned more from private coaching, but he chose to help struggling students for free instead. He left a **lasting impression** on hundreds of students, and I count myself lucky to have been one of them. In fact, in my own job I often try to explain things to students the way he once explained things to me.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Are you still in touch with him? Not regularly, but I bump into him now and then in town. He is retired now, and he always asks about my work. It is quite touching that he still remembers me after all these years.

Would you ever like to become a teacher? Perhaps in some form. My job already involves a lot of guiding and explaining, and I find that side of it deeply **fulfilling**, but I am not sure I have the patience for a classroom of teenagers.

Part 3 link: Education Systems · Role Models

5. Describe an intelligent person you know

People · your card 5 · sp2_people_05 · 253 words (yours: 156)

- who the person is
- how you know them
- what makes them intelligent
- and how you feel about them

I would like to talk about a friend whose mind I have always found slightly intimidating. One of the most intelligent people I know is a close friend from university who studied physics, while I was doing business administration. We met because we lived in the same student hostel, and we have stayed close ever since, even though he now lives in Rajshahi. What sets him apart is not just how much he knows, but how quickly he grasps complicated ideas that leave the rest of us bewildered. He has this **analytical** mind that breaks any problem into neat, logical steps. I remember him explaining a **statistics** concept I had struggled with for weeks in about five minutes, and suddenly it made perfect sense. Yet he is never arrogant about it, which makes his intelligence all the more **impressive**. He is also **incredibly intellectually curious**, always reading about subjects far outside his field, from history to economics. I think real intelligence is exactly this combination of sharpness and open-mindedness, rather than simply getting top marks. As for how I feel about him, talking to him is genuinely **stimulating**, because he challenges your assumptions without ever making you feel small. I will admit that I sometimes feel a little slow beside him, but mostly I just feel grateful. Honestly, I always come away from our

conversations having learned something, and that is rare. I suspect he will end up doing research abroad one day, and I will be very proud of him when he does.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you think intelligence is something people are born with? Partly, but I think curiosity and effort matter just as much. My friend was clearly gifted, but he also read constantly, so his intelligence was nurtured as much as it was inherited.

Do you often ask him for help? Now and then, mostly when I need to make sense of numbers at work. He is always happy to help, although he usually ends up teaching me far more than I actually asked for.

Part 3 link: Learning Methods · Lifelong Learning

6. Describe a famous person you would like to meet

People · your card 6 · sp2_people_06 · 251 words (yours: 152)

- who the person is
- what they are famous for
- what you know about them
- and why you would like to meet them

If I could meet any famous person, it would probably be a well-known entrepreneur whose story I find genuinely inspiring. He ~~built~~ is famous for building a huge technology company from almost nothing, starting out with a handful of friends and very little money. What fascinates me, though, is not the wealth but the perseverance behind it. I have read a great deal about him, in interviews and in a biography I borrowed from a friend, and I know how many times he failed before succeeding, which I find strangely reassuring. ~~Meeting~~ Several of his early ventures went bankrupt, and at one point even people close to him thought he should give up. What draws me to him is his reputation for thinking in genuinely unconventional ways, seeing opportunities others dismiss. As for why I would like to meet him, I would love to ask how he stayed motivated during the years when everything seemed to be collapsing. I imagine he would be surprisingly down-to-earth, because people who have struggled tend to be. Since I studied business administration, I would also be curious to hear what ~~draws me to him is his reputation for thinking he thinks young people in genuinely unconventional ways, seeing opportunities others dismiss.~~ a country like Bangladesh should focus on. I think a single conversation with someone like that could be more enlightening than any book. Realistically it will never happen, but if it did, I would come prepared with a long list of questions and simply listen. Even a few minutes with him would give me a story to tell my family for years.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Would you like to be famous yourself? Not really. I think fame brings a lot of pressure and very little privacy. I would much rather be respected by the people around me than recognised by strangers in the street.

Do you think famous people are good role models? Some are, especially those who worked hard and stayed humble. But many are admired for the wrong reasons, so young people need to be quite discerning about whose example they follow.

Part 3 link: Fame & Celebrity · Role Models

7. Describe a friend you have known for a long time

People · your card 7 · sp2_people_07 · 260 words (yours: 162)

- who the person is
- how long you have known them
- what you do together

- and why the friendship has lasted

I would like to talk about my closest friend, whom I have known since our very first week at university, so roughly ~~ten~~ seven years now. We were both studying business administration and were placed in the same project group, and something just clicked almost immediately, probably because we were both from small towns and slightly overwhelmed by the big campus. By the end of that first term we were sharing notes, meals and far too many cups of tea. Over the years our lives have taken very different directions, yet the friendship has proved remarkably **lasting**. He now works for a bank in Dhaka, while I am still in Sirajganj, so we do not actually see each other often, but whenever we meet it feels as though no time has passed. When we do manage to meet, we usually go for long walks by the river or watch a cricket match together, and in between we talk on the phone most weekends. I think what has kept us close is a shared sense of humour and a kind of **unspoken** understanding that we will always be there for each other. He is the one person I can be completely **candid** with, without fear of judgement. What I value most is that our friendship has never felt like hard work; it is genuinely **effortless**. Honestly, in a world where people drift apart so easily, having one friendship that has lasted this long feels like something worth protecting, and I hope we are still arguing about cricket when we are old men.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you think you will stay friends in the future? I am fairly sure we will. We have already survived distance and busy jobs, so I cannot imagine much that would pull us apart now. If anything, the friendship keeps **deepening** as we get older.

How do you usually keep in touch? Mostly through phone calls and messages. We have a habit of calling each other on Friday evenings, and even if it is only for ten minutes, it keeps us up to date with each other's lives.

Part 3 link: Friendship · Digital Communication

8. Describe a stranger who helped you

People · your card 8 · sp2_people_08 · 248 words (yours: 159)

- when it happened
- who the person was
- how they helped you
- and how you felt about it

I would like to describe a small act of kindness that has stayed with me for years. A few years ago I was travelling ~~in an unfamiliar city~~ alone to Chattogram for a job interview, and on my first evening I got hopelessly lost, with a dying phone and no idea where my hotel was. The streets all looked the same in the dark, and I was starting to panic. A middle-aged stranger, who turned out to be a local schoolteacher, noticed me looking anxious and stopped to ask if I needed help. What struck me was how genuinely **considerate** he was; not only did he give me directions, he actually walked me halfway there. He could easily have ignored me, as most people would have, so his kindness felt almost **remarkable**. Along the way we chatted, and he told me a little about the area, which turned a stressful moment into a pleasant one. He even recommended a small tea stall near my hotel, which I went back to every day that week. I was incredibly **grateful**, and I remember trying to offer him something in return, which he politely refused. That small act of kindness has genuinely stayed with me, and it made me more willing to help strangers myself, especially students who come into our office looking lost and nervous. It was a reminder that a little **compassion** costs nothing but can mean a great deal. I never even learned his name, but I still think of him fondly.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you often help strangers? I try to, in small ways. If someone looks lost or needs directions, I usually stop. After my own experience, I know how **disorienting** it feels to be alone somewhere completely unfamiliar.

Do you think people are less helpful to strangers nowadays? In big cities, perhaps a little, because everyone is in a hurry and slightly suspicious. But in smaller towns like mine, people still stop to help, and I find that very reassuring.

Part 3 link: Ethics & Moral Values · Trust & Honesty

9. Describe a family member you are close to

People · your card 9 · sp2_people_09 · 251 words (yours: 157)

- who the person is
- how close you are
- what you do together
- and why you get along

I would like to talk about someone I see every single day. The family member I am closest to is my younger sister, despite the fact that we argue like any siblings do. She is a few years younger than me ~~but~~ and still a student, and she is easily the most hard-working person in our house. In many ways she feels more like a friend than a sibling. We share almost everything, from silly jokes to serious worries, and she is the first person I turn to when something is bothering me. What makes our bond so strong is that we are **completely brutally honest** with each other, even when the truth is uncomfortable. As for what we do together, we enjoy simple things, like watching films, walking along the Jamuna in the evening, or just talking late into the night over cups of tea. Sometimes I help her with her English, and in return she tells me when my ideas are ridiculous. She has this ability to make me laugh no matter how **miserable** I am feeling, which is a real gift, ~~We enjoy simple things together, like watching films or just talking late into the night.~~ especially after a long, tiring day at work. I think the reason we get along so well is that siblings who grow up together develop an almost **intuitive** understanding of one another. We can often tell what the other is thinking from a single look across the dinner table. Honestly, I feel incredibly **fortunate** to have her, because not everyone is lucky enough to be close to their family.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you think you will stay close as you get older? I really hope so. She may move away for work or marriage one day, but I think our bond is strong enough to survive the distance, just as it has with my elder sister.

Do you ever argue with her? Of course, usually about trivial things like the television remote. But our arguments never last long, and by dinner time we have normally forgotten what we were **squabbling** about in the first place.

Part 3 link: Family & Relationships · Conflict & Mediation

10. Describe a good leader you know or have heard about

People · your card 10 · sp2_people_10 · 246 words (yours: 151)

- who the person is
- what they lead
- what qualities they have
- and why you think they are a good leader

I would like to describe ~~a former~~ my first manager ~~of mine,~~ at the education consultancy where I work, who I think embodies what good leadership really means. She has since moved to our head office in Dhaka, but I worked under her for almost two years. She led a fairly large team of counsellors, and what set her apart was that she **led by example** rather than by giving orders. If

we had a queue of anxious students, she would sit down and help with applications herself. In terms of her qualities, she was genuinely **approachable**, so people felt comfortable bringing problems to her before they escalated. Rather than taking credit, she was quick to **acknowledge** everyone's contribution, which made the whole team want to work harder. She also had a talent for staying calm under pressure, which was **reassuring** during stressful periods, such as the frantic weeks before university application deadlines. What I admired most was her fairness; she treated everyone equally, regardless of seniority. As for why I think she was a good leader, too many leaders confuse authority with respect, but she understood that respect has to be earned. Under her, the team was noticeably more **motivated** and loyal, and hardly anyone left, which is unusual in our industry. Honestly, she set a standard for how I would want to lead people myself one day, and whenever I help a new colleague settle in, I try to remember how she treated me as a nervous beginner.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Would you like to be a leader yourself? Yes, eventually. I would like to lead a small team one day, but I know I still need more experience. Leadership is not just about giving instructions, it is about earning people's trust.

Are you still in contact with her? Yes, we message occasionally, and she still gives me advice about my career. She was the one who first encouraged me to think seriously about studying abroad myself, which I really appreciate.

Part 3 link: Leadership · Job Satisfaction

11. Describe a creative person you admire

People · your card 11 · sp2_people_11 · 252 words (yours: 163)

- who the person is
- what they create
- why you think they are creative
- and how you feel about their work

I would like to talk about someone whose imagination I find quite amazing. A creative person I really admire is a friend of mine who works as a graphic designer for an advertising agency in Dhaka. We were in the same year at university, although she was always more interested in art than in accounting. She designs logos, posters and packaging for all kinds of local brands, and she also paints in her spare time. What amazes me is how she can take a dull, ordinary brief and turn it into something genuinely **striking**. She seems to see possibilities that the rest of us simply miss. I have watched her sketch ideas that at first look random, then slowly come together into something clever and **original**. She is also fearless about experimenting, which I think is the heart of real creativity; she is not afraid to fail. Talking to her about her process is fascinating, because she draws inspiration from the most **unlikely places**, like the painted rickshaws in our town or old films. Her work has this **distinctive** style that you can recognise instantly, which is quite an achievement in a crowded field. ~~Talking to her about her process is fascinating, because she draws inspiration from the most unexpected places, like street signs or old films.~~ Honestly, spending time around her makes me want to be more imaginative in my own work, even if that only means designing a slightly better presentation for students. I think creativity like hers is partly a gift and partly relentless practice, and she has plenty of both. I genuinely believe she will have her own studio one day.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you consider yourself a creative person? Not especially, at least not artistically. I am more creative with words and ideas than with pictures. I would love to learn to draw, but I suspect I have no **flair** for it whatsoever.

Would you like to have some of her work at home? Definitely. She once gave me a small painting of the Jamuna at sunset, and it hangs in my room. I would happily buy more of her work if she ever decided to sell it.

Part 3 link: Music & the Arts · Hobbies & Leisure

12. Describe a polite person you know

People · your card 12 · sp2_people_12 · 251 words (yours: 154)

- who the person is
- how you know them
- how they behave politely
- and how you feel about them

I would like to talk about someone at my office whose manners I have always admired. The most polite person I know is an older colleague of mine, whose manners are almost old-fashioned in the best possible way. I got to know him when I joined the education consultancy, because he was the one who showed me how everything worked in my first week, when I was nervous and constantly making small mistakes. No matter how busy or stressed he is, he always greets everyone warmly and remembers small details about their lives, like a colleague's child's exams or someone's sick parent. What makes his politeness feel genuine rather than forced is that it is completely **consistent**; he treats the office cleaner with exactly the same respect as the director. He is also a wonderful listener, never interrupting, which is **surprisingly rare a rarity** these days. With students and parents, he stays unfailingly respectful, even when they are rude or impatient on the phone. I have noticed that his **courtesy** has a ripple effect, making the whole team more considerate towards one another. In meetings, even when he disagrees, he does so **tactfully**, so no one ever feels attacked. As for how I feel about him, I genuinely think politeness is an underrated quality, and he is living proof of how much smoother it makes everyday interactions. Honestly, being around him quietly reminds me to mind my own manners, and I think I have become a slightly better person for working beside him.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you think people are less polite nowadays? In some ways, yes, particularly online, where people say things they would never say face to face. But I still see plenty of **everyday courtesy** in my town, especially towards older people.

Were you taught to be polite as a child? Very much so. My parents were quite strict about greeting elders properly and saying thank you, and I am grateful now, because good manners have helped me a great deal at work.

Part 3 link: Ethics & Moral Values · Emotional Intelligence

13. Describe a person who is good at their job

People · your card 13 · sp2_people_13 · 248 words (yours: 161)

- who the person is
- what their job is
- why they are good at it
- and how you feel about them

I would like to talk about ~~my~~ someone whose work I have seen at close quarters for many years. The person is our family doctor, who is genuinely excellent at what he does. He runs a small practice near our home in Sirajganj and has looked after my family since I was a child. Beyond his obvious medical knowledge, what makes him stand out is how he treats patients as people rather than cases. He is incredibly **thorough**, always taking the time to explain things clearly instead of rushing you out of the door. I have noticed that he has a calming presence, which is **invaluable**

when you are worried about your health. He also keeps himself up to date, so his advice always feels current and trustworthy. What impresses me most is his **dedication**; he clearly sees medicine as a vocation, not just a job. I remember him coming to our flat late one night during the monsoon when my father had a high fever, which he certainly did not have to do. Because of this, the entire community trusts him completely, and appointments are always fully booked. I think being good at a job like his requires both skill and genuine **empathy**, and he has both in abundance. As for how I feel about him, I have enormous respect for him. Honestly, he has set my expectations of what a good professional should be, and I try to bring some of his patience to my own work.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Would you like to have a job like his? Not really. I admire doctors enormously, but I do not think I could cope with the pressure or the sight of blood. I am much happier helping people in a less **high-stakes** way.

Do you think doctors are well respected in your country? Generally yes, especially good ones like him. Doctors are highly regarded in Bangladesh, and many parents dream of their children becoming one, although the profession is extremely demanding.

Part 3 link: Job Satisfaction · Career Choices

14. Describe an older person you respect

People · your card 14 · sp2_people_14 · 247 words (yours: 157)

- who the person is
- how you know them
- what they are like
- and why you respect them

I would like to talk about a man my whole family looks up to. The older person I respect most is my grandfather, who is now in his eighties but still remarkably sharp. He lives with my grandmother in our ancestral village home not far from Sirajganj, and we visit them as often as we can. He worked the family land for most of his life, and he lived through some genuinely difficult times, and yet he has never become bitter or cynical about life. In terms of what I respect most he is his wisdom; whenever like, he is gentle and quick-witted, and he still wakes up at dawn to walk around the fields. He is also incredibly **humble** about his own achievements, rarely talking about the hardships he overcame. I love listening to his stories, because each one seems to carry a subtle lesson without ever being preachy. Despite his age, he remains genuinely **open-minded**, curious about new technology and interested in what young people think. He even asks me to show him cricket highlights on my phone, and he has strong opinions about every player. What I respect most is his **wisdom**; whenever the family faces a problem, he has this quiet way of putting things in perspective. I also think there is something we can all learn from his **contentment**; he seems at peace with his life in a way that is rare. Honestly, I hope I can grow old with even half of his grace and good humour.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you spend a lot of time with him? Not as much as I would like, because of work. But whenever we visit the village, I make sure to sit with him for a while, usually in the courtyard with tea, just listening to him **reminisce**.

Do you think older people are respected enough in your country? Mostly, yes. Respect for elders is deeply rooted in Bangladeshi culture, and grandparents often live with their families. However, I think that tradition is weakening slightly in the big cities.

Part 3 link: Generational Differences · Family & Relationships

15. Describe a businessperson you admire

People · your card 15 · sp2_people_15 · 254 words (yours: 157)

- who the person is
- what business they run
- what they have achieved
- and why you admire them

When I think about business, one success story from my own country always comes to mind. A businessperson I really admire is the founder of a local company that started as a tiny shop and grew into a respected national brand. The business makes food products, things like biscuits and snacks that you can find in almost every corner shop in Bangladesh. What I find inspiring is not just the commercial success, but the way he treated his employees like family throughout. He was known for reinvesting profits into his staff and community rather than simply **maximising** his own wealth. In terms of what he achieved, I have read that he took real risks in the early years, when the venture could easily have **collapsed**. Over time, though, he turned a single shop into several factories, providing jobs for a great many people, including in rural areas where work is scarce. That kind of courage, combined with a clear **vision**, is what separates genuine entrepreneurs from the rest. He also stayed grounded despite his success, which earned him enormous loyalty. As for why I admire him, it is partly personal, because my father ran a small business for over thirty years, so I know how hard it is simply to survive. What I admire most is that he proved you can build something profitable while remaining **ethical**. Honestly, in an age when many businesses cut corners, his example is refreshing, and it has shaped how I think about running a company myself one day.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Would you like to start your own business? Possibly, one day. With my background in business administration, it is tempting, but I would want some experience abroad first. Starting a company without proper preparation seems far too **precarious** to me.

Do you think successful businesspeople should give back to society? Yes, I do. Businesses depend on their communities, so it seems fair that they share some of their success, whether through charity, fair wages or supporting local education.

Part 3 link: Success & Ambition · Money & Wealth

16. Describe a teacher who influenced you

People · your card 16 · sp2_people_16 · 257 words (yours: 157)

- who the teacher was
- what they taught
- how they taught
- and how they influenced you

I would like to talk about a teacher who, in a way, is part of the reason I can speak English today. The teacher who influenced me most was my secondary school English teacher, who genuinely changed how I saw the subject. Before her class, I found English dull and mechanical, just grammar rules to memorise for exams. She taught us English language and literature for two years, and she had this gift for making lessons feel **engaging**, often using stories, songs and debates instead of dry exercises. Sometimes she would ask us to act out scenes from short stories, which felt terrifying at first but was great fun, and it made the language feel alive for the first time. What set her apart was her genuine belief in her students; she could spot potential we could not see in ourselves. She was also endlessly **encouraging**, praising effort rather than just results, which built my confidence enormously. As for how she influenced me, I still remember

how she pushed me to enter a writing competition I would never have attempted alone. I did not win, but I was shortlisted, and that small success meant the world to me. That single act of **faith** in me changed my relationship with the language completely. Honestly, a large part of why I am comfortable using English today is **attributable** to her, including in my job, where I use it every single day. I think great teachers do exactly this: they light a spark that keeps burning long after the classroom.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Are you still in touch with her? Sadly not directly, as she moved to another district some years ago. But I heard through a friend that she is still teaching, and I like to think she is still **igniting** that same spark in her students.

Do you think teachers are more important than textbooks? Definitely. A textbook gives you information, but a good teacher gives you the motivation to use it. I think most people remember a great teacher far longer than any book they studied.

Part 3 link: Learning Methods · Education Systems

17. Describe a person who gave you good advice

People · your card 17 · sp2_people_17 · 253 words (yours: 155)

- who the person was
- what the advice was
- when they gave it
- and how it helped you

I would like to talk about a conversation that genuinely changed the direction of my life. A person who gave me **genuinely** really good advice was an uncle of mine, my father's younger brother, at a point when I was feeling completely lost about my future. It was just after I had **just** finished my studies, and I was **paralysed** by the number of choices in front of me. Some friends were preparing for government jobs, others were going abroad, and I had no idea which way to turn. He sat me down one evening after dinner and told me something simple but profound: that it is better to try and fail than to spend your life wondering. What made his advice so valuable was that he spoke from experience, having **taken risks** left a safe job himself to try something new in his thirties. He encouraged me to stop overthinking and **just take the plunge**, even if the first step **however** was a small one. That conversation was genuinely **pivotal**, because it shifted me from fear to action. I ended up making a decision I had been putting off for months, and it turned out well: the following week I applied for a position at an education consultancy, and I have been working there ever since. Looking back, his words were exactly what I needed at that **crucial** moment. Honestly, I still repeat that advice to friends who find themselves stuck, and to nervous students too, because I have seen for myself how much difference it can make.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you usually take advice from other people? Yes, but I try to be selective. I listen to people who have real experience of the situation, and then I **weigh up** their views before deciding. In the end, the decision has to be mine.

Have you ever given someone advice that helped them? I hope so. In my job I advise students every day about universities and courses, and a few have come back to thank me, which is one of the most satisfying parts of the work.

Part 3 link: Career Choices · Role Models

18. Describe a talented person you know

People · your card 18 · sp2_people_18 · 246 words (yours: 157)

- who the person is

- what their talent is
- how they developed it
- and how you feel about their talent

I would like to talk about someone whose talent never stops surprising me. A genuinely talented person I know is a school friend who is an extraordinary musician, particularly on the guitar. We grew up in the same neighbourhood in Sirajganj, and he still plays at local weddings and cultural events. What makes him special is that he seems to play almost **instinctively**, as though the instrument is an extension of himself. He can pick up a song after hearing it once and play it back perfectly, whether it is an old Bengali folk song or a modern pop hit. I know for a fact, though, that this apparent ease is the result of years of relentless practice. He started as a child on a cheap second-hand guitar and was so **dedicated** that he would play for hours until his fingers were sore. He never had formal lessons; he learned by listening to recordings and copying older musicians, sometimes slowing the songs down so he could catch every note. Watching him perform is genuinely **mesmerising**; he can shift from a gentle melody to something powerful in seconds. What I respect most is that despite his obvious gift, he remains humble and is always eager to learn from others. I think raw talent only gets you so far, and his discipline is what turned potential into real **mastery**. Honestly, seeing someone so devoted to their craft is inspiring, and it reminds me that excellence is rarely accidental.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Have you ever tried to learn the guitar? Once, briefly. He gave me a few lessons, but I gave up after about a month because my fingers hurt and I clearly had no **aptitude** for it. I am much better at listening.

Do you think he could become a professional musician? I think he easily could, if he wanted to. The problem is that music is a risky career here, so he treats it as a passion alongside his regular job, at least for now.

Part 3 link: Music & the Arts · Hobbies & Leisure

19. Describe a person who often helps others

People · your card 19 · sp2_people_19 · 252 words (yours: 156)

- who the person is
- who they help
- how they help
- and why you think they do it

I would like to talk about someone who lives just one floor below us. The most helpful person I know is a neighbour of ours who seems to spend half her life looking after other people. She is a retired schoolteacher, and she has lived in our building for as long as we have. Whether it is checking on the elderly residents, collecting parcels, or cooking for a family going through a hard time, she is always the first to step in. She also helps younger children in the building with their homework for free. As for how she helps, what strikes me is that her generosity is completely **selfless**; she never expects anything in return. She has this natural **warmth** that makes people feel comfortable asking her for help, which many are too proud to do. During a difficult period in our own family, when my mother had to stay in the village for weeks to look after my grandparents, she quietly supported us in ways we did not even ask for, sending over meals almost every evening and checking whether my sister needed anything. As for why she does it, I genuinely think some people are simply wired to be **altruistic**, and she is one of them. I also suspect it gives her a sense of purpose since she retired. Her kindness has a way of bringing the whole neighbourhood closer together. Honestly, she is a living reminder that small, consistent acts of **generosity** matter far more than grand gestures.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you help your neighbours too? I try to. I carry heavy shopping up the stairs for older neighbours and help with anything technical, like setting up phones. It is a small contribution compared with hers, but it all **adds up**.

Do you think people help each other less than in the past? Somewhat, especially in cities where people barely know their neighbours. In smaller towns like mine, though, that community spirit is still quite strong, and I really hope it lasts.

Part 3 link: Ethics & Moral Values · Social Isolation & Loneliness

20. Describe a neighbour you like

People · your card 20 · sp2_people_20 · 249 words (yours: 160)

- who the person is
- how long they have been your neighbour
- what they are like
- and why you like them

Our building is full of friendly people, but one neighbour really stands out. I would like to talk about an elderly gentleman who lives in the flat opposite ours on the third floor and has ~~lived next-door-to-us~~ been there for as long as we have, which is well over a decade now, so I ~~can remember~~ have practically grown up around him. Despite the age gap, we have always got on remarkably well. He is the sort of neighbour everyone wishes they had: friendly, respectful and never **intrusive**. He is a retired government officer who lives alone now that his children have moved abroad, so he enjoys a bit of company. He keeps an eye on our ~~house~~ flat when we ~~travel~~, visit my grandparents in the village, and in return we help him with anything that requires climbing a ladder or heavy lifting, like carrying his shopping up the stairs. What I like most is his endless supply of fascinating stories from his younger years, which are genuinely **captivating**. He is also incredibly **considerate**, always mindful of noise and careful never to overstep. On Friday evenings he sometimes invites me in for tea, and we end up discussing cricket and politics for hours. I think good neighbours are a kind of quiet blessing that people underestimate until they lose them. Over the years he has become almost like extended family, and the ~~street~~ building would feel noticeably **emptier** without him. Honestly, his presence is a big part of what makes our neighbourhood feel like home.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you think it is important to have good neighbours? Absolutely. Neighbours are often the first people who can help in an emergency, long before family arrives. Living near people you trust also gives you real **peace of mind** every day.

Do you know most of your neighbours well? Most of the ones in our building, yes. We greet each other on the stairs and exchange food during Eid, although I know the newer families less well than those who have been here for years.

Part 3 link: Social Isolation & Loneliness · Public Spaces

21. Describe a person who speaks a foreign language well

People · your card 21 · sp2_people_21 · 247 words (yours: 153)

- who the person is
- which language they speak
- how they learned it
- and how you feel about their ability

I would like to talk about a friend whose language skills I find genuinely impressive. A person who speaks a foreign language impressively well is a friend of mine who is almost **fluent** in Japanese,

despite never having lived there. We met at university, and she is now preparing to apply for a master's degree in Japan, which is partly how we reconnected, since I helped her with her application at the consultancy where I work. Before that, we had not spoken properly for a couple of years. As for how she learned it, what amazes me is that she taught herself largely through films, music and online conversation, which shows extraordinary discipline. She practised every single day for years, even writing short diary entries in Japanese script. Her pronunciation is so **authentic** that native speakers are often surprised she is not from Japan. I think what makes her so good is that she was never afraid of making mistakes, which is where most learners get stuck. She immersed herself completely, treating the language as a passion rather than a chore. Watching her switch effortlessly between **two languages** Bengali and Japanese is genuinely **admirable**, and it makes me slightly envious. She often says that learning a language opens a window into a whole culture, and I think she is right. Honestly, her **commitment** is inspiring, and it has motivated me to be more serious about improving my own English, especially since I hope to study abroad myself one day.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Would you like to learn another foreign language? Yes, I would love to learn Arabic properly, since I can already read it a little from studying the Quran as a child. Understanding it fully would make my prayers feel far more meaningful.

Is learning English important in your country? Very important. English opens doors to higher education and better jobs, and in my work I see every day how much students' futures **hinge on** their English test scores.

Part 3 link: Globalisation of Culture · Learning Methods

22. Describe a hardworking person you know

People · your card 22 · sp2_people_22 · 249 words (yours: 157)

- who the person is
- what they do
- how they show their hard work
- and how you feel about them

I would like to talk about a friend whose energy honestly puts me to shame. The hardest-working person I know is a close friend who is building his own small business from scratch. He runs a little café near the college in Sirajganj, which he opened about two years ago with his savings and a small loan. His work ethic is genuinely **relentless**; he is often up before dawn and still working late into the night. As for how he shows it, what impresses me is that he never seems to cut corners, no matter how **exhausted** he is. He handles everything himself in these early stages, from serving customers to doing the accounts, and he does it all with a smile. He even cleans the café himself at night so that he does not have to hire extra staff yet. I think what drives him is a deep sense of **determination** to build something of his own rather than work for someone else. There have been moments when I worried he was pushing himself too hard, especially when he stopped seeing friends for months, but his energy is remarkable. Watching his effort slowly pay off has been genuinely **inspiring** to witness, and the café is now busy most evenings. As for how I feel about him, I am enormously proud of him. Honestly, he has completely changed my idea of what commitment looks like, and he reminds me that success is usually far less glamorous than people imagine.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you consider yourself a hard-working person? Fairly, yes, although not to his extreme. I work long hours during application season, but I also try to protect my evenings, because I think rest is essential if you want to **sustain** your effort.

Do you think hard work always leads to success? Not always. Hard work is essential, but luck, timing and opportunities matter too. Still, people who work consistently hard give themselves a much better chance than those who do not.

Part 3 link: Success & Ambition · Work-Life Balance

23. Describe a person who made you laugh

People · your card 23 · sp2_people_23 · 250 words (yours: 160)

- who the person is
- how you know them
- what they did
- and how you felt

I would like to talk about someone who has made me laugh more than anyone else I know. The funniest person I know is an old school friend who has an incredible talent for making people laugh. We sat next to each other for most of secondary school, and we still meet up whenever he is back in Sirajganj, usually at our old favourite tea stall. What makes him special is that his humour is completely **spontaneous**; he does not tell rehearsed jokes but reacts to whatever is happening in the moment. I remember one particularly dull afternoon during our final exams when the stress was unbearable, and within minutes he had the whole group in stitches. He did a perfect impression of a nervous exam invigilator, complete with a dramatic search for a missing pencil. His timing is **impeccable**, and he has a gift for finding the funny side of even the most awkward situations. What I appreciate most is that his jokes are never **malicious**; he laughs with people, not at them. As for how I felt, I laughed so much that my stomach hurt, and for the first time in weeks I completely forgot about the exams. Honestly, he has lifted my mood on countless bad days, which is a genuine gift. I think people who can make others laugh so easily are quietly valuable, because laughter is such good medicine. Being around him is always **uplifting**, and I feel lucky to count him as a friend.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you think you have a good sense of humour? I think so, although mine is drier and quieter than his. I enjoy **wordplay** and gentle teasing more than big jokes, and my family says I am funniest when I do not mean to be.

Is laughter important in your life? Very much. After a stressful day at work, a good laugh with my family over dinner helps me unwind more than anything else. I think it keeps us close as well.

Part 3 link: Happiness & Wellbeing · Friendship

24. Describe a sportsperson you admire

People · your card 24 · sp2_people_24 · 247 words (yours: 157)

- who the person is
- what sport they play
- what they have achieved
- and why you admire them

As a big cricket fan, I did not have to think very long about this one. A sportsperson I genuinely admire is a famous cricketer from my country, who is something of a national hero. He has played for Bangladesh for many years, and he has been part of some of the team's most memorable victories against much bigger cricketing nations. Beyond his obvious talent, what I admire is the **humility** he shows despite enormous fame. He came from a modest background and worked his way up through sheer **perseverance**, which makes his story relatable to ordinary people. On the field he is famous for staying calm under pressure, a quality that separates good players from truly great ones. What impresses me most is his **consistency**; he performs at a

high level year after year, which requires incredible discipline. Off the field, he is known for his charity work, which shows real character. I think athletes like him are role models precisely because of how they carry themselves, not just their statistics. His **dignity** in both victory and defeat is something young people can genuinely learn from. I still remember watching one of his match-winning innings with my father and younger sister, all of us shouting at the television and my mother rushing in from the kitchen to see what had happened. Honestly, he makes the whole nation proud, and rightly so, and whenever he walks out to bat, the entire country seems to hold its breath.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Have you ever watched him play live? Not yet, unfortunately. Tickets for big matches in Dhaka sell out quickly, and it is a long journey from Sirajganj. But watching him in a stadium is definitely on my **bucket list**.

Do you play cricket yourself? Only casually these days. I played a lot as a child with friends in the neighbourhood, but now I mostly watch it, usually with my father, who is an even bigger fan than I am.

Part 3 link: Role Models · Fame & Celebrity

25. Describe a person you would like to work with

People · your card 25 · sp2_people_25 · 255 words (yours: 159)

- who the person is
- what they do
- why you would like to work with them
- and how you feel about it

I would like to talk about someone who taught me a great deal in a very short time. A person I would love to work with is a former mentor of mine who now runs a successful consultancy in Dhaka, advising small businesses on strategy. I got to know him during an internship in my final year of business administration, and even in ~~that short time~~ those three months I learned an enormous amount. What makes him an ideal colleague is that he is both brilliant and genuinely **collaborative**; he treats junior people as partners rather than subordinates. He has a way of bringing out the best in a team by giving people real **ownership** of their work. I remember him letting me present part of a report to a client, which was terrifying but hugely valuable. As for why I would like to work with him, I think working alongside him again would be incredibly **stimulating**, because he constantly pushes those around him to think bigger. He is also refreshingly honest, offering feedback that is direct but never harsh. As for how I feel about the idea, it excites me, although I know I would need more experience before I could keep up with him. Honestly, I believe the people you work with shape your career more than the job itself, and he is exactly the kind of person who makes you better. Being part of a team he leads would be a genuine **privilege**, and perhaps one day, after studying abroad, I will get that chance.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you prefer working alone or in a team? It depends on the task, but generally I prefer teamwork. Other people spot mistakes I miss and bring ideas I would never think of. Working alone can feel quite **isolating** after a while.

Are you in touch with him now? Yes, occasionally. We connected on a professional networking site, and he sometimes comments on my posts. Last year he even offered to write me a reference if I apply for a master's abroad.

Part 3 link: Job Satisfaction · Professional & Soft Skills

26. Describe a confident person you know

- who the person is
- how you know them
- how they show confidence
- and how you feel about them

I would like to talk about someone whose confidence I have always slightly envied. A strikingly confident person I know is a former classmate who now works in sales for a mobile phone company. We studied business administration together, and we were often in the same group for presentations, so I had plenty of chances to watch her in action. From the day I met her, she had this natural **self-assurance** that drew people to her. What I find interesting is that her confidence never tips over into arrogance; she is genuinely comfortable in her own skin. As for how she shows it, she can walk into a room full of strangers and start a conversation without the slightest **hesitation**, which I have always envied. In class presentations, while the rest of us were shaking, she spoke clearly and even enjoyed the difficult questions. I think a lot of her confidence comes from thorough preparation, so she rarely feels caught off guard. She is also unafraid of failure, treating setbacks as **temporary short-lived** rather than devastating. Watching her handle difficult situations calmly has taught me a great deal. As for how I feel about her, I admire her enormously. Honestly, I think confidence like hers is partly a personality trait and partly a skill you can build. Being around her is genuinely **empowering**, because her belief in herself somehow rubs off on the people nearby. I certainly became a better presenter just by watching her, and I still borrow some of her techniques at work.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Are you a confident person? More than I used to be. I was quite shy at university, but my job forces me to speak to students and parents every day, and that has gradually helped me **come out of my shell**.

Do you think confidence can be learned? Yes, I believe so. Practice and preparation make a huge difference. The more often you face something that frightens you, like public speaking, the less frightening it becomes over time.

Part 3 link: Professional & Soft Skills · Peer Pressure

27. Describe a person who apologised to you

- who the person was
- what happened
- how they apologised
- and how you felt afterwards

I would like to talk about an apology that actually made a friendship stronger. I remember an occasion when a close friend apologised to me after a misunderstanding that had strained our friendship for weeks. It happened about two years ago, and the friend was someone I had known since school. We had fallen out over something fairly trivial, ~~that~~ a comment he made about me in a group chat, which both of us had blown out of proportion. For a few weeks we barely spoke, and it felt strange not having him around, because we used to talk almost every day. Then one evening he turned up at our flat unannounced and asked if we could go for a walk by the river. What made his apology memorable was how **sincere** it was; he did not make excuses or try to shift the blame. He admitted openly that he had been in the wrong, which takes real **humility**. I think apologising properly is genuinely difficult, because it requires swallowing your pride. His honesty completely **disarmed** me, and any lingering resentment melted away almost instantly. In the end I apologised too, for my own stubbornness. We ended up talking for hours and our friendship actually became stronger than before. Honestly, that experience taught me how

powerful a genuine apology can be in **repairing** a relationship. It also reminded me that admitting fault is a sign of strength, not weakness, something many people never seem to learn.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you find it easy to apologise? Not always, to be honest. Like most people, I can be a bit proud, but I have learned that a quick, genuine apology usually **defuses** a situation far better than defending myself.

Do you think people apologise less nowadays? Perhaps a little. People often send a quick sorry by message instead of saying it in person, which feels less meaningful. A face-to-face apology still carries much more weight, I think.

Part 3 link: Conflict & Mediation · Trust & Honesty

28. Describe a well-dressed person you know

People · your card 28 · sp2_people_28 · 249 words (yours: 156)

- who the person is
- how you know them
- how they dress
- and how you feel about their style

I would like to talk about a colleague whose sense of style everyone in our office notices. A person whose style I genuinely admire is a colleague of mine who always manages to look effortlessly elegant. She joined our consultancy about a year ago as a senior counsellor, and we often work together on university applications, so I see her almost every day. She never seems to be trying too hard, yet every outfit looks carefully considered. What I find impressive is how **versatile** her wardrobe is; she can look professional at work and stylish at a social event with equal ease. At the office she usually wears a simple salwar kameez or a sari in muted colours, and at weddings she looks even more graceful, without ever seeming overdressed. She favours simple, classic pieces over loud trends, which gives her a timeless, **sophisticated** look. I think what makes her stand out is her attention to small details, like how well things fit and the way colours **complement** one another. She once told me that dressing well is less about money and more about knowing what suits you, which struck me as genuinely wise. As for how I feel about her style, I find it quietly inspiring. Honestly, being around her has made me a little more thoughtful about my own appearance, and I now iron my shirts rather more carefully. I think the way you present yourself quietly shapes how others perceive you, and she understands that **instinctively**.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you care much about fashion? Not a great deal. I like to look neat and presentable, especially for work, but I rarely follow trends. I prefer **understated** clothes that are comfortable and will not go out of style quickly.

What do people in your country usually wear on special occasions? Traditional clothes, mostly. Men wear a panjabi, especially at Eid, and women often wear colourful saris. Weddings are the most formal occasions, and people dress very elaborately for them.

Part 3 link: Fashion & Trends

29. Describe a person who encouraged you to achieve a goal

People · your card 29 · sp2_people_29 · 250 words (yours: 165)

- who the person is
- what the goal was
- how they encouraged you
- and how you felt about it

I would like to talk about someone who, quite honestly, stopped me from giving up. A person who encouraged me to achieve an important goal was my elder cousin, at a time when I was preparing for a major exam and had almost lost faith in myself. The goal was to get into a good public university to study business administration, and the admission test was extremely competitive. After a disappointing mock test, I had convinced myself that I was not capable, and I was ready to give up. She refused to let me quit, and her belief in me was genuinely **unwavering**. Rather than just offering empty words, she sat with me, helped me plan, and kept me **accountable** week after week. She made me a detailed timetable and called every Friday to check my progress. What I appreciated most was that her support was practical, not just emotional. Whenever I felt **demoralised**, she would remind me how far I had already come. Thanks largely to her, I stayed disciplined and eventually achieved a result I am still proud of, and I got a place on the course I wanted. As for how I felt, I was overjoyed and hugely relieved, but above all grateful. Honestly, I am not sure I would have managed it without her constant encouragement. That experience taught me how much difference one supportive person can make, and I try to be that **encouraging** presence for others now, especially the nervous students I work with.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you still set goals for yourself? Yes, although they are different now. At the moment my main goal is to strengthen my profile so I can study abroad. I find that breaking a goal into small steps makes it feel **within reach**.

Do you think encouragement is more important than talent? In many cases, yes. Plenty of talented people give up because nobody believes in them, while ordinary people achieve a lot with the right support. Ideally, of course, you need both.

Part 3 link: Success & Ambition · Education Systems

30. Describe a childhood friend

People · your card 30 · sp2_people_30 · 247 words (yours: 161)

- who the person was
- how you met
- what you did together
- and whether you are still in touch

When I think back to my childhood, one face always comes to mind. I would like to talk about my best friend from childhood, who lived just a few houses down from us in Sirajganj. We met when we were barely five years old, on the very first day of primary school, and quickly became **inseparable**. Almost every afternoon was spent playing cricket in the lane, exploring the neighbourhood or getting into harmless mischief. During the monsoon we used to race paper boats in the flooded streets, and in the dry season we flew kites from the rooftops until our mothers called us in for dinner. Those years were wonderfully **carefree**, with none of the responsibilities that come later. What made our friendship special was how easily we understood each other, without any of the awkwardness that adults sometimes have. As for whether we are still in touch, sadly his family moved to **another city** Rajshahi when we were teenagers, and we gradually drifted apart, which I still find a little **melancholy**. We do reconnect occasionally, usually by phone around Eid, and it is lovely how quickly the old bond resurfaces. The last time we met, we spent the whole evening laughing about the things we had done as boys. Honestly, childhood friendships have a special kind of **innocence** that is hard to recreate later in life. I look back on those days with enormous fondness, and I feel grateful to have had such a good companion growing up.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Would you like to spend more time with him? Definitely. I have been meaning to visit him in Rajshahi for ages, but work always gets in the way. This year I am determined to finally make the trip and spend a proper weekend together.

Do children today have as much freedom as you did? Probably not. Many parents worry more about safety now, and children spend more time indoors on screens. I think they miss out on the kind of outdoor adventures we **took for granted**.

Part 3 link: Friendship · Parenting & Childhood

31. Describe a person you recently met and want to know more about

People · your card 31 · sp2_people_31 · 248 words (yours: 158)

- who the person is
- where you met
- what you talked about
- and why you want to know them better

I would like to talk about someone I met only a few weeks ago but have not stopped thinking about. Recently I met someone at a friend's gathering who genuinely intrigued me, and I have been hoping to get to know her better. The gathering was a small dinner at a friend's home in Dhaka, when I was there visiting my elder sister. She works in an unusual field, environmental research, which immediately made her stand out in a room full of bankers and engineers. She studies how river erosion is affecting farming communities in the north of the country. What struck me was how **articulate** she was; she could explain complex ideas in a way that was easy to follow and genuinely interesting. We talked about climate change, the Jamuna swallowing land near my grandparents' village, and even her plans to do a PhD abroad. We ended up talking for over an hour, and the conversation never once felt **tedious**. She has clearly travelled widely and has a very **broad-minded** outlook, which I found refreshing. ~~I think the reason~~ As for why I want to know her better, it is ~~that~~ because she has a rare combination of intelligence and warmth. Too often first meetings feel superficial, but this one felt genuinely meaningful. We exchanged contacts, so I am hopeful we will meet again the next time I am in Dhaka. Honestly, it is quite ~~rare~~ unusual to feel ~~such an instant connection~~ **rapport** with someone, and I do not want to let it fade.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you find it easy to talk to new people? It depends on the situation. At work I am comfortable because I know my role, but at social events I can be a bit hesitant at first. Once a conversation gets going, though, I usually **warm up** quickly.

How do you usually make new friends? Mostly through people I already know, like friends of friends or colleagues. I have made a few friends through work as well, since I meet so many different people at the consultancy.

Part 3 link: Friendship · Climate Change

32. Describe a person who is a good parent

People · your card 32 · sp2_people_32 · 250 words (yours: 155)

- who the person is
- how you know them
- how they raise their children
- and why you think they are a good parent

I would like to talk about someone in my own family whose parenting I genuinely admire. A person I consider an excellent parent is my elder sister, and watching ~~whom~~ her raise her two children has been a real education. She lives in Dhaka with her husband and children, including a lively four-year-old son, and we see them whenever they visit Sirajganj or I go to stay with them. As for how she raises them, what impresses me is how she balances warmth with **discipline**; she is affectionate but never lets her children become spoiled. She listens to them genuinely, treating even their small worries as important, which I think builds real trust. Rather than simply giving orders, she explains the reasons behind rules, so her children grow up thinking for themselves. She limits their screen time, reads to them every night and makes sure they spend plenty of time with their grandparents, which I think matters enormously. She is also remarkably **patient**, even on the difficult days when most people would lose their temper. As for why I think she is a good parent, what I admire most is that she leads by example, modelling the values she wants them to **absorb**. I think parenting is one of the hardest jobs in the world, and she makes it look almost effortless. Honestly, her children are turning out kind and confident, which is the clearest possible proof of her **nurturing** approach. I suspect our mother taught her more than she realises.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you think you would be a good parent? I hope so. I think I would be patient and fair, like my sister, but I would probably struggle with discipline because I tend to give in too easily. I would definitely ask her for **guidance**.

Do parents today have an easier job than in the past? In some ways yes, with more information and support available. But they also face new pressures, like managing screen time and intense competition in education, which makes parenting quite demanding.

Part 3 link: Parenting & Childhood · Technology & Children

33. Describe a generous person you know

People · your card 33 · sp2_people_33 · 251 words (yours: 154)

- who the person is
- how you know them
- how they are generous
- and how you feel about them

I would like to talk about a man whose kindness is known throughout our neighbourhood. The most generous person I know is an old family friend who seems to find genuine joy in giving. For many years he ran a shop next to my father's in the market, so I have known him since I was a small boy, and he still calls me by my childhood nickname. His generosity is not just about money, though he is quietly charitable; it is more about his time and attention. Whenever anyone is in trouble, he is the first to offer help, often before being asked. What makes his kindness so **genuine** is that he never seeks recognition for it; in fact, he prefers to help **discreetly**. I remember him supporting a struggling family in our neighbourhood for months without anyone knowing, paying their children's school fees until the father found work again. I only found out years later, through my father. During Ramadan, he also quietly sends food to families who cannot afford much for iftar. I think true generosity like his is increasingly **uncommon** in a world that often prizes self-interest. As for how I feel about him, I have enormous respect for him, and being around him is a gentle reminder to be more giving myself. He genuinely believes that we are all better off when we look after one another, and he lives by that principle. Honestly, his **benevolence** has left a lasting impression on everyone who knows him.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you think people in your country are generous? Generally, yes. Charity is an important part of our culture and religion, especially during Ramadan and Eid, when people make a real

effort to share food and money with those who are **less fortunate**.

Is it better to give money or time? Both matter, but I think time is often more valuable. Money solves immediate problems, whereas giving someone your time and attention shows that you genuinely care about them as a person.

Part 3 link: Ethics & Moral Values · Money & Wealth

34. Describe a person who has an interesting job

People · your card 34 · sp2_people_34 · 252 words (yours: 157)

- who the person is
- what their job is
- why it is interesting
- and how you feel about it

I would like to talk about a friend whose job I find almost unbelievably exciting. A person with a genuinely interesting job is a friend of mine who works as a wildlife photographer. We met through a mutual friend a few years ago, and he now works freelance for magazines and conservation groups. His work takes him to remote corners of the world, capturing animals in their natural habitats, although his favourite place is still the Sundarbans, closer to home. What makes his job so **fascinating** is the unpredictability; no two days are ever the same, and patience is everything. He once spent nearly a week waiting quietly to photograph a single rare bird, which shows extraordinary **dedication**. He has also told me about spending nights on a boat in the mangrove forest, hoping for a glimpse of a tiger, which he finally saw on his third trip. I find the combination of adventure, artistry and science in his work genuinely **enviable**. Of course, he is quick to point out that it is far less glamorous than it looks, involving long hours in **harsh** conditions, from heat and mosquitoes to heavy rain. Still, I think there is something wonderful about a job that keeps you so connected to nature. As for how I feel about it, listening to his stories always makes my own routine feel a little dull. Honestly, he has one of the few careers that I think I could happily do myself, provided someone else carried the heavy equipment.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Would you like to try wildlife photography yourself? I would love to try it once, perhaps on a short trip to the Sundarbans with him. But I suspect I lack the patience to sit still for days, so it would probably remain a hobby at best.

Do you think interesting jobs are more important than well-paid jobs? For me, balance matters. A fascinating job that barely pays is hard to sustain, but a well-paid job you find **soul-destroying** is worse. Ideally, you find work that offers both.

Part 3 link: Job Satisfaction · Wildlife & Conservation

35. Describe a person from a different culture you know

People · your card 35 · sp2_people_35 · 250 words (yours: 160)

- who the person is
- where they are from
- what you have learned from them
- and how you feel about the friendship

I would like to talk about a friendship that has taught me a lot about the wider world. A person from a different culture whom I know well is a friend from university who grew up in Turkey. She came to our university in Bangladesh for a year as an exchange student, and we were in several of the same classes. Her home town is Izmir, on the Aegean coast, and she has shown me so many photos that I feel I almost know it. Getting to know her has been genuinely **eye-opening**.

because our backgrounds are quite different in some ways yet surprisingly similar in others. She has taught me a great deal about her country's food, festivals and customs, which I find fascinating. What I appreciate most is how her perspective has broadened my own; she often challenges assumptions I did not even realise I held. Our conversations are always **enriching**, and we enjoy comparing how our two cultures approach things like family and hospitality. We even discovered that our families celebrate Eid in quite similar ways. As for how I feel about the friendship, I think friendships across cultures are especially valuable, because they quietly **break down stereotypes**. She is warm, curious and completely without prejudice, which makes her wonderful company, and we still video call every couple of months. Honestly, knowing her has made me more **open-minded**, and it has confirmed my belief that people everywhere have far more in common than we tend to assume.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Would you like to visit her country? Very much. She has invited me to Istanbul and Izmir many times, and I would love to see the historic mosques and try the food she always talks about. Hopefully I can go within the next few years.

Is it easy to make friends with people from other cultures? It can take a little more effort at first, because of language and different customs. But once you get past that initial **awkwardness**, I think those friendships are often especially close and rewarding.

Part 3 link: Globalisation of Culture · Friendship

36. Describe a wise older relative

People · your card 36 · sp2_people_36 · 250 words (yours: 156)

- who the person is
- how you are related
- why you think they are wise
- and how they have helped you

I would like to talk about the person our whole family turns to in difficult times. The wisest person in my family is undoubtedly my grandmother, who despite having little formal education has an extraordinary understanding of people and life. She lives with my grandfather in our ancestral village home not far from Sirajganj, and we visit them often, especially during Eid, when the whole family gathers in the old house. What makes her so wise is not book knowledge but decades of hard-won experience, raising a large family through floods and lean years. She has this **uncanny** ability to sense when something is wrong, often before anyone says a word. Whenever the family faces a difficult decision, we instinctively turn to her, because her judgement is remarkably **sound**. She rarely tells you what to do; instead she asks the right questions and lets you reach your own conclusion. I think that is the mark of genuine wisdom, and it means you actually learn something. Her advice is always **grounded** in common sense rather than emotion, which is why it is so reliable. As for how she has helped me, over the years she has helped me through several tough moments simply by putting things in perspective. When I was nervous about starting my first job, she reminded me that everyone is a beginner once, and that honesty matters more than cleverness. Honestly, I treasure my conversations with her, and I know I will miss her **counsel** enormously one day.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you visit her often? Fairly often, usually once or twice a month with my parents. The village is not far, so we can go for the day. Sitting with her on the veranda is one of the most **tranquil** parts of my month.

Do you think older people are wiser than younger people? Often, but not always. Age gives people experience, but wisdom depends on whether they reflect on it. Some young people

are remarkably wise, and some older people never seem to learn.

Part 3 link: Generational Differences · Family & Relationships

37. Describe a person who solved a problem in a clever way

People · your card 37 · sp2_people_37 · 249 words (yours: 154)

- who the person is
- what the problem was
- how they solved it
- and how you felt about it

I would like to describe a former colleague who once solved a tricky problem at work in a genuinely clever way. He worked with me at the education consultancy until last year, when he left to do a master's degree in Australia. Our team was stuck on a project because of a scheduling conflict that seemed impossible to resolve. We had organised a university fair, but two of the most popular universities could only send representatives at exactly the same time, and we had only one hall big enough for the crowds we were expecting. While the rest of us were arguing, he calmly suggested a completely different approach that none of us had considered. He proposed dividing the hall with screens and running both sessions side by side. What impressed me was how **resourceful** he was; he found a simple solution hidden in plain sight. His thinking was refreshingly **lateral**, approaching the problem from an angle nobody else had tried. Within an hour, something that had frustrated us for days was neatly sorted out, and the fair went smoothly. As for how I felt, I was relieved but also slightly embarrassed that I had not thought of it myself. I think his real strength is staying calm and **rational** when everyone else is panicking. That episode taught me that the best solutions are often surprisingly simple, once someone **ingenious** points them out. Honestly, I still think about his approach whenever I feel stuck on a difficult problem myself.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Are you good at solving problems? Reasonably good, I think, especially practical ones. I tend to be methodical rather than creative, so I break problems into steps. I have learned, though, that stepping away for a while often brings a **breakthrough**.

Do you think problem-solving skills can be taught? Yes, to some extent. Schools can encourage it by giving students open-ended tasks instead of memorisation. But experience is the best teacher, because real problems rarely come with clear instructions.

Part 3 link: Professional & Soft Skills · Learning Methods

38. Describe a person you enjoy talking to

People · your card 38 · sp2_people_38 · 248 words (yours: 158)

- who the person is
- how you know them
- what you talk about
- and why you enjoy it

I would like to talk about the friend whose company I probably enjoy most. A person I always enjoy talking to is a close friend of mine who has a genuinely curious mind. We met at a book club at the local library about four years ago, and since then we have met for tea almost every week, usually at a small café near the river. Our conversations can start with something trivial and end up exploring philosophy, travel or politics, which I find endlessly **stimulating**. Last week, for instance, we started talking about a cricket match and somehow ended up debating whether ambition really makes people happy. What makes talking to him so enjoyable is that he actually listens, rather than just waiting for his turn to speak. He is also wonderfully **open-minded**, so I

can share half-formed thoughts without fear of being judged. I think good conversation is a bit of an art, and he is a master of it, although he would never admit that. He knows when to be serious and when to be **playful**, which keeps things from ever feeling heavy. Honestly, I always come away from our chats feeling energised and having learned something new. In a world where so much communication happens through screens, having someone you can talk to for hours is genuinely **precious**. I never take those conversations for granted, and I think they have made me a far better listener and a slightly more thoughtful person as well.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you prefer talking face to face or online? Face to face, definitely. You can read someone's expressions and tone properly, and the conversation flows more naturally. Online chats are convenient, but they often feel rather **stilted** by comparison.

Are you a talkative person? It depends on who I am with. With close friends and family I can talk for hours, but in large groups of strangers I tend to be quieter and listen more than I speak.

Part 3 link: Digital Communication · Friendship

39. Describe a patient person you know

People · your card 39 · sp2_people_39 · 249 words (yours: 160)

- who the person is
- how you know them
- how they show patience
- and how you feel about them

I would like to talk about someone whose calm I still try to copy. The most patient person I know is a former teacher of mine, whose calm never seemed to break no matter how testing the situation. She taught us Bengali literature at my higher secondary college in Sirajganj, so I was in her class for two years. Teaching a class of restless teenagers is difficult enough, but she handled even the most disruptive students with remarkable **composure**. As for how she showed patience, rather than raising her voice, she would pause, take a breath and respond calmly, which was far more effective. I remember one boy who constantly interrupted her lessons; instead of punishing him, she gave him small responsibilities, and by the end of the year he was one of her best students. What I admired was that her patience was not **passive**; it came from genuine understanding of why students behaved as they did. She gave people time to learn at their own pace, never making anyone feel rushed or stupid. I think patience like hers is genuinely **underrated**, because it requires enormous self-control. Watching her, I realised how much damage impatience can do and how much trust patience can build. Honestly, she has made me consciously try to be more **tolerant** in my own daily interactions, though I still have a long way to go. At work, when a student asks me the same question for the fifth time, I often think of her.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Are you a patient person? Moderately. I am patient with students and older relatives, but I get rather **irritable** in traffic or long queues. It is something I am actively working on, with mixed results so far.

Why do you think people are less patient nowadays? Mainly because technology has made everything instant. We are used to fast deliveries and immediate replies, so waiting for anything now feels frustrating, even when the delay is perfectly reasonable.

Part 3 link: Emotional Intelligence · Smartphones & Devices

40. Describe a younger person you admire

People · your card 40 · sp2_people_40 · 249 words (yours: 153)

- who the person is

- how you know them
- what they have done
- and why you admire them

I would like to talk about someone much younger than me who really inspires me. A younger person I genuinely admire is my teenage cousin, who is remarkably mature for her age. She is my uncle's daughter and lives in Bogura, not far from us, so we see each other at family gatherings and during Eid. Despite being only sixteen, she has a level of **determination** that puts many adults to shame. As for what she has done, alongside her studies she has started a small online venture selling her own handmade crafts, such as embroidered bags and jewellery, which she runs entirely by herself. She takes the photos, manages the orders and even arranges the deliveries, all from her bedroom desk after school. What impresses me is how **disciplined** she is with her time, balancing school, hobbies and her little business without ever seeming stressed. She is also refreshingly **self-aware**, knowing exactly what she wants and unafraid to pursue it. As for why I admire her, I think her generation faces a lot of pressure, yet she handles it with a calm confidence I did not have at her age. At sixteen, I was mainly worried about cricket scores and exam results, and I certainly could not have run a business. Watching her, I feel genuinely **optimistic** about the future. Honestly, she reminds me that age has little to do with wisdom or drive, and I sometimes catch myself learning from her rather than the other way around.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you think young people today are more mature than in the past? In some ways, yes. They have access to so much information and opportunity that many grow up faster. However, they also face more pressure, which can be quite **overwhelming** for some of them.

Would you like to start a small business like hers? Possibly, as a side project. With my business background it would be interesting, but at the moment my job keeps me very busy, and my priority is preparing to study abroad.

Part 3 link: Generational Differences · Success & Ambition

41. Describe a person who is good at cooking

People · your card 41 · sp2_people_41 · 253 words (yours: 155)

- who the person is
- what they cook
- how they learned
- and how you feel about their cooking

I would like to talk about the person whose food I would choose over any restaurant's. The best cook I know is my mother, whose food has a reputation among everyone who has ever tasted it. She cooks almost every meal for our family, and her specialities are traditional Bengali dishes like hilsa in mustard sauce, beef curry and, at Eid, a rich biryani that relatives talk about for weeks. She never followed formal recipes; instead she learned from her own mother as a girl and refined everything through years of practice. What makes her cooking special is her **intuitive** sense of flavour; she seems to know exactly how much of each spice to add without measuring. Her traditional dishes are genuinely **exquisite**, and guests often ask for the recipes, which she happily shares. I think part of what makes her food so good is the care she puts into it; cooking for her is an act of love, not a chore. Whenever the family gathers, her kitchen becomes **the beating heart** of the house. As for how I feel about her cooking, it is simply the taste of home to me, and even a plain bowl of dal tastes better when she makes it. Honestly, no restaurant has ever quite matched the comfort of a meal she has prepared. I only wish I had paid closer attention over the years, because her skill feels almost **irreplaceable**, and if I do study abroad one day, it is the thing I will miss most.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Can you cook yourself? Only a few basic dishes, like rice, dal and an omelette. I really need to learn more before I study abroad, so I have started asking my mother to teach me, though I am a rather **clumsy** pupil.

Do you prefer home-cooked food or eating out? Home-cooked food, without a doubt. Eating out is enjoyable occasionally, but restaurant food is often too oily for me, and nothing beats sitting down to dinner with my family.

Part 3 link: Food & Cuisine · Traditions & Customs

42. Describe a person who kept a promise to you

People · your card 42 · sp2_people_42 · 251 words (yours: 155)

- who the person was
- what the promise was
- how they kept it
- and how you felt about it

I would like to talk about a friend who once kept a promise to me under genuinely difficult circumstances. **During** He is a university friend who lives in a nearby town, and we have been close for years, ever since we shared a desk in our first accounting class. A few years ago, my family moved into the flat where we live now, and it was a stressful period **he** because my father was still busy with his business and we had very little help. My friend had promised to help me move **house** everything on a particular weekend. As it happened, that same weekend he was offered something far more appealing, a free trip to Cox's Bazar with his colleagues, yet he turned it down without a second thought. What struck me was how **reliable** he proved to be, when it would have been easy to make an excuse. He showed up early, worked tirelessly all day carrying boxes and furniture up to the third floor, and never once made me feel like a burden. As for how I felt, I was touched and slightly humbled, because I knew what he had given up. I think keeping promises, especially inconvenient ones, is a real **test of character**, and he passed it completely. His **dependability** deepened my trust in him enormously. Honestly, in a world where people break commitments so casually, someone who genuinely honours their word is rare and **invaluable**. That day taught me the kind of friend I want to be myself.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you always keep your promises? I try very hard to. If I am not sure I can do something, I would rather not promise it at all. Breaking a promise, even a small one, can **erode** trust surprisingly quickly.

Did you ever do something similar for him? Yes, last year I travelled to his town to help with his sister's wedding preparations, even though it was a busy time at work. It felt good to finally return the favour.

Part 3 link: Trust & Honesty · Friendship

43. Describe a quiet person you know

People · your card 43 · sp2_people_43 · 250 words (yours: 157)

- who the person is
- how you know them
- what they are like
- and how you feel about them

I would like to talk about someone at work whom I completely misjudged at first. A quiet person I know well is a colleague of mine who rarely speaks unless he has something worth saying. He handles visa documents at the education consultancy where I work, and we have shared an office

for about two years. At first I mistook his silence for coldness, but I soon realised he is simply **reserved** rather than unfriendly. As for what he is like, what I have come to appreciate is that when he does speak, people genuinely listen, because his words carry weight. He is an exceptional **observer**, noticing details in meetings that the more talkative people miss entirely. Once he spotted a small error in a student's visa application that the rest of us had missed for days, which saved the student a great deal of trouble and possibly a rejected visa. I think our culture tends to reward loud, outgoing personalities, so quiet people are often **overlooked**, which is a shame. Over time I have discovered that he is thoughtful, kind and surprisingly funny once you get to know him. His calm presence is actually quite **soothing** in a busy office, especially during the stressful application season. As for how I feel about him, I like and respect him enormously. Honestly, he has taught me that you do not have to be the loudest voice in the room to be respected, and I have a lot of time for him.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Would you describe yourself as quiet? Somewhere in the middle, I think. I can be talkative with people I know well, but in new situations I prefer to listen and **get the measure of** people before saying much.

Do you think quiet people make good leaders? Yes, they can be excellent leaders. They often listen carefully and think before acting, which leads to better decisions. Leadership is not only about speaking loudly; it is about earning respect.

Part 3 link: Emotional Intelligence · Leadership

44. Describe a person who has travelled a lot

People · your card 44 · sp2_people_44 · 245 words (yours: 152)

- who the person is
- where they have been
- what they have learned
- and how you feel about their experiences

I would like to talk about the most well-travelled person in my family. A person who has travelled extensively is an uncle of mine, my mother's elder brother, who spent much of his career working abroad as an engineer. He has lived on several continents and visited dozens of countries, from the Gulf to Malaysia, Germany and Canada, and his stories are genuinely **captivating**. He has recently moved back to Bangladesh and lives in Dhaka, so I see him whenever I visit my elder sister there. What I find most interesting is not the places themselves, but how travel has shaped his outlook; he is remarkably **tolerant** and open to different ways of life. He often says that seeing how others live cured him of taking anything for granted. He also learned to be patient and adaptable, because nothing abroad ever went quite according to plan, from missed trains to misunderstood menus. Listening to him is almost like receiving **an informal education** in geography and culture. I think people who travel widely tend to develop a certain wisdom that is hard to gain any other way. As for how I feel about his experiences, I am a little envious, to be honest, and his stories have made me determined to explore more of the world myself. ~~Honestly,~~ starting, I hope, with studying abroad. Whenever I hear ~~his stories,~~ them, I feel a pang of **wanderlust** and a renewed appreciation for how **vast** and varied the world really is.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Would you like to travel as much as he has? I would love to, although perhaps not for work. I would rather travel slowly, spending weeks in one place to properly **soak up** the culture, instead of rushing from city to city.

Which country would you most like to visit? Probably Canada or the UK, partly because many of my students go there and I would like to see what their lives are like. I am also

fascinated by Japan's mix of tradition and technology.

Part 3 link: Travel & Tourism · Globalisation of Culture

45. Describe a person who is a good listener

People · your card 45 · sp2_people_45 · 258 words (yours: 161)

- who the person is
- how you know them
- how they listen well
- and how you feel about them

I would like to talk about the person I go to whenever I need to talk something through. The best listener I know is a close friend of mine, and it is a quality I value in her enormously. We met at university, where we were in the same tutorial group, and she now teaches at a school in Sirajganj, so we still meet regularly. In an age when most people are just waiting for their turn to speak, she gives you her complete, **undivided** attention. She puts her phone away, makes eye contact and never glances around the room while you are talking. When I talk to her about a problem, she never rushes to offer solutions; instead she lets me express myself fully first, which is surprisingly rare. She asks thoughtful questions that show she has genuinely been paying attention. What makes her such a good listener is her natural **empathy**; she seems to feel what you are feeling. As for how I feel about her, I always come away from our conversations feeling lighter, as though a weight has been shared. Last year, when I was unsure whether to apply for a master's degree abroad, she listened to me for an entire evening without once telling me what to do. I think being truly listened to is one of the most **comforting** experiences a person can have. Honestly, her ability to listen without judgement is a genuine gift, and it is a big part of why she is so **treasured** by everyone who knows her.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Are you a good listener yourself? I am getting better. My job has taught me to listen carefully, because students often reveal their real worries only if you give them time. But I still sometimes **jump in** too quickly when I get excited.

Why do you think some people are poor listeners? Often because they are distracted, particularly by their phones, or because they are more interested in sharing their own opinions. Listening properly takes patience and genuine interest in the other person.

Part 3 link: Emotional Intelligence · Digital Communication

46. Describe a city you have visited

Places · your card 1 · sp2_places_01 · 258 words (yours: 157)

- which city it was
- when you went there
- what you did
- and how you felt about it

I would like to talk about a trip I made to Kolkata, in India, a couple of years ago, which left a lasting impression on me. I went during the winter with two friends from university, and we spent about five days there. It is an old, historic city, and what struck me immediately was its wonderful sense of character. The streets were **bustling** with activity, full of markets, trams and street food that smelled incredible. What I loved most was the blend of old and new; grand colonial buildings stood alongside modern shops, creating a genuinely **atmospheric** feel. I spent my days exploring museums and wandering through the older neighbourhoods, which felt almost **timeless**. We also rode one of the old trams, which rattled along at a wonderfully slow pace. We visited the Victoria Memorial, and I spent a whole afternoon on College Street, which is lined with

second-hand bookshops, so as a keen reader I was completely **in my element**. The people were remarkably friendly and always happy to point me in the right direction, and since so many of them speak Bengali, I never felt like a complete outsider. Of course, it was crowded and chaotic at times, but that energy was part of its charm. Honestly, I found the whole experience genuinely **invigorating**, and it gave me a real appreciation for the city's rich cultural heritage. In a way it also felt strangely familiar, because we share so much history, language and food. I would go back without hesitation, ideally for longer next time.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Would you like to go back to Kolkata? Yes, definitely. Next time I would like to stay longer and explore some of the smaller neighbourhoods and old cafés. I would also love to go during Durga Puja, when the whole city is beautifully lit up.

Do you prefer visiting cities or the countryside? It depends on my mood, really. Cities are exciting for a few days, but I get tired of the noise quite quickly, so for a proper rest I would usually choose the countryside.

Part 3 link: Travel & Tourism · Urban Development

47. Describe a place near water that you like

Places · your card 2 · sp2_places_02 · 259 words (yours: 157)

- where it is
- how often you go
- what you do there
- and why you like it

The place I would like to describe is the riverside near my **hometown**, home in Sirajganj, beside the Jamuna river, which has always been a favourite spot of mine. It is only a short rickshaw ride from our flat, along the embankment on the edge of town. I try to go there **whenever I visit home**, two or three times a week, usually in the early evening once I have finished work. There is something deeply **calming** about sitting by the water and watching the sun set over it. The gentle sound of the current is wonderfully **soothing**, and it seems to wash away the stress of daily life. I usually go for a slow walk along the bank, or simply sit with a cup of tea from one of the little stalls and let my mind wander. Sometimes I watch the fishing boats coming in, or children playing near the water's edge. What I love most is how **tranquil** it is compared to the noise of the **city** town centre. There is often a cool breeze coming off the water, which is a blessing in the heat, especially in the sticky weeks before the monsoon. Of course, the river has another side too; in the rainy season it swells enormously, and **riverbank erosion** has cost many local families their land over the years. Perhaps that is why I respect it as much as I love it. Honestly, being near water has a **therapeutic** effect on me that is hard to explain. It is my favourite place to think, and I always leave feeling refreshed.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do many people go there? Yes, quite a lot, especially in the evenings and on holidays. Families come to enjoy the breeze and young people gather to chat, but if you walk a little further along the bank it becomes much quieter.

Has the riverside changed since you were a child? Yes, a fair bit. The embankment has been strengthened, and there are more tea stalls and lights now. It is busier than before, but the view across the water is exactly the same.

Part 3 link: Public Spaces · Happiness & Wellbeing

48. Describe a quiet place you like to spend time in

Places · your card 3 · sp2_places_03 · 243 words (yours: 153)

- where it is
- how you found it
- what you do there
- and why you like it

A quiet place I really treasure is a small reading corner in ~~my local~~ the public library in our town, just a ten-minute walk from our flat. I stumbled upon it by chance a few years ago, when I was looking for somewhere to prepare for my university exams, and I have been going ever since. Tucked away near the back, behind the tall shelves of old newspapers, it is a **secluded** little spot that most people seem to overlook. I usually go there to read or study, because the silence helps me concentrate in a way that is impossible at home, where my younger sister is often revising and the television is on in the next room. These days I mostly go on a free afternoon with a novel or a book about business. There is something wonderfully peaceful about being surrounded by books, with only the occasional turning of a page to break the quiet. In our increasingly noisy world, finding somewhere so genuinely **serene** feels like a small luxury. I often **lose track of time** there, completely **absorbed** in whatever I am reading. Honestly, it has become a kind of **sanctuary** for me, a place to escape the constant distractions of modern life, and I deliberately leave my phone on silent at the bottom of my bag. I always feel calmer and more focused after spending an afternoon there, and I think everyone deserves a corner like that somewhere in their life.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you prefer studying at home or in a library? Definitely in a library. At home there are too many distractions, like the television, my phone and family conversations, whereas in a library everyone around me is focused, which makes it much easier to concentrate.

Do many young people in your town use the library? Fewer than before, I think. A lot of students now study online or at coaching centres, but during exam season the library still fills up with young people looking for a quiet place to revise.

Part 3 link: Happiness & Wellbeing · Learning Methods

49. Describe a historical place you have visited

Places · your card 4 · sp2_places_04 · 256 words (yours: 164)

- where it is
- when you visited
- what you saw
- and how you felt about it

A historical place that genuinely moved me was ~~an ancient~~ the Sixty Dome Mosque ~~complex~~ in Bagerhat, in the south-west of Bangladesh, which I visited during a trip ~~a while~~ to Khulna about three years ago. It dates back ~~several centuries~~, to the fifteenth century, and stepping inside felt like travelling back in time. The architecture was absolutely **magnificent**, with ~~intricate carvings~~ thick brick walls and ~~towering~~ long rows of slender stone pillars supporting dozens of small, rounded domes. ~~that must have taken decades to build~~. What struck me most was the sense of history embedded in the walls; you could almost feel the countless generations who had passed through. A local guide explained its **significance**, telling us that it was built in the time of Khan Jahan Ali and that the whole area is now a UNESCO World Heritage Site, which made the experience far richer than simply looking at old stones. I also wandered around the grounds and the large pond beside it, and I was surprised to learn that the mosque is still used for prayers today, so it is a living place rather than just a monument. I found myself genuinely **awestruck** by the craftsmanship of an era without modern machinery. Places like this are an important reminder of our **heritage**, and I think it is vital that we preserve them, especially as damp and salt are a real threat to old brickwork in that region. Honestly, I came away with a deeper

appreciation of the past and how much skill and devotion went into these monuments. It was easily one of the most memorable trips I have taken.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Would you recommend it to foreign visitors? Absolutely. It is one of the most important historical sites in Bangladesh, and combining it with a trip to the Sundarbans makes perfect sense, because both are in the same part of the country.

Did you learn about it at school? Yes, briefly, in our history lessons, but reading about it in a textbook is nothing compared to standing inside. Seeing it in person made the history feel real rather than just facts to memorise.

Part 3 link: Traditions & Customs · Travel & Tourism

50. Describe a place you would like to visit in the future

Places · your card 5 · sp2_places_05 · 247 words (yours: 154)

- where it is
- how you know about it
- what you would do there
- and why you want to go

A place I have long dreamed of visiting is Switzerland, particularly the Alpine region. I first became **captivated** by it through photographs and documentaries, which made the scenery look almost unreal, and more recently through my job, because I work at an education consultancy and a few of our students have gone there to study hospitality. When they send photos back, I must admit I feel a little envious. The idea of snow-capped mountains, crystal-clear lakes and charming villages is incredibly **appealing** to me, especially as someone who has never actually seen snow. If I ever go, I would love to take the scenic train routes that wind through the mountains, which are said to be breathtaking. I would also like to go hiking beside one of the lakes and perhaps visit a small village where cheese is still made in the traditional way. I imagine the air there is wonderfully fresh, **a world away from** the ~~pollution~~ dust and traffic I am used to. What draws me most is the promise of such **pristine** natural beauty, which is increasingly rare. I would also love to experience the local culture and food, of course. Honestly, it is at the very top of my ~~travel~~ **bucket list**, and I am determined to get there one day, even though it is famously expensive. I think some places are worth saving up for, and this is definitely one of them, so I have quietly started putting a little money aside each month.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Would you prefer to go alone or with others? With others, ideally my family or a couple of close friends. Beautiful places are more enjoyable when you can share them, and I think my parents would be amazed to see snow for the first time.

How long would you like to stay there? At least two weeks, if I could afford it. I would not want to rush from one place to another; I would rather travel slowly and actually enjoy each place properly.

Part 3 link: Travel & Tourism · Globalisation of Culture

51. Describe a park or garden you like

Places · your card 6 · sp2_places_06 · 254 words (yours: 154)

- where it is
- how often you go
- what it looks like
- and why you like it

The place I would like to describe is a **large** public park not far from where I live, which is a real green oasis in the middle of ~~the city~~, our town. It is only about ten minutes' walk from our flat, so it is very easy to reach. I try to visit at least once a week, usually ~~at~~ on Friday afternoons, and more often in winter when the ~~weekend~~ weather is pleasant. It is beautifully **landscaped**, with wide lawns, ~~mature~~ tall shady trees and a small ~~lake where people feed~~ pond in the ~~ducks~~ middle, surrounded by flower beds that are at their best in early spring. There is also a ~~crowded, concrete city~~, walking track around the edge and a little play area for children. Sirajganj is getting more built up every year, so having such a **lush** green space nearby is genuinely precious. I usually go there to walk, read or simply sit on a bench and **watch the world go by**. What I love most is how it brings the community together; families picnic, children play cricket on the grass and elderly ~~couples stroll~~ men sit chatting for hours. The atmosphere is always **relaxed** **laid-back** and cheerful, and nobody seems to be in a hurry. Honestly, spending time surrounded by greenery has a noticeably **restorative** effect on me, especially after a stressful week at work. Sometimes I take my four-year-old nephew there when my elder sister visits from Dhaka, and watching him run around is a joy in itself. I think every **city** town needs places like this, and I feel lucky to have one so close.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you think your town needs more parks? Yes, definitely. The town is growing quickly and new buildings are going up everywhere, so green spaces are shrinking. More parks would give children somewhere safe to play and give everyone a place to breathe.

What do you usually do there at the weekend? Mostly I walk a few laps of the track and then sit under a tree with a book. Sometimes I meet a friend there, and we buy roasted peanuts from a vendor and chat for an hour.

Part 3 link: Public Spaces · Urban Development

52. Describe a place where you like to relax

Places · your card 7 · sp2_places_07 · 246 words (yours: 154)

- where it is
- when you go there
- what you do
- and why it helps you relax

The place where I relax most completely is actually the rooftop of our building, which offers a surprisingly lovely view ~~of~~ over the ~~city~~ town. We live on the third floor, so it is just a short climb up the stairs, and on a clear evening you can see the rooftops stretching out towards the river. I go up there most evenings, especially after a long or stressful day at the office. There is something wonderfully **liberating** about being up high, away from the noise and crowds below. I usually take a cup of tea, put on some quiet music and simply watch the sky change colour as the sun goes down. Some of our neighbours grow plants in pots up there, so it feels almost like a small garden. The gentle breeze ~~up there~~ is genuinely **refreshing**, and it seems to clear my head. What makes it so relaxing is the sense of **solitude**; it is my own little escape where no one bothers me. I often do my best thinking there, or sometimes just switch off entirely. During the monsoon I stand under the shelter of the stairwell and watch the rain sweep across the town, which is strangely calming. My job involves a lot of talking and problem-solving, so I need a moment to **unwind** before dinner with my family. Honestly, having a spot like this has been **invaluable** for my mental wellbeing. It costs nothing, yet it does more for my mood than almost anything else.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you ever go up there with other people? Occasionally. My younger sister sometimes comes up after she finishes studying, and during Eid the whole family goes up in the evening. Mostly, though, I prefer to keep it as my own quiet time.

Is it easy to find places to relax in your town? Not always. Sirajganj is fairly calm compared with Dhaka, but it is still getting busier, and most public places are quite noisy. That is why a private spot like our rooftop is so valuable.

Part 3 link: Happiness & Wellbeing · Work-Life Balance

53. Describe a building you find interesting

Places · your card 8 · sp2_places_08 · 244 words (yours: 157)

- where it is
- what it looks like
- what it is used for
- and why you find it interesting

A building I find genuinely fascinating is the National Parliament **building** House in Dhaka, known in Bengali as the Jatiya Sangsad Bhaban, which is considered an architectural masterpiece. It stands in the Sher-e-Bangla Nagar area of the capital, surrounded by an artificial lake and wide lawns. Designed by **a famous** the American architect Louis Kahn, it is unlike anything else in the country. What makes it so striking is its bold, **geometric** design, using simple shapes like circles and triangles cut into vast concrete walls. Despite its size, it has a strange sense of lightness and elegance, especially when the whole building is reflected in the still water around it. I find it interesting because it manages to be both **modern avant-garde** and timeless at the same time, even though it was completed in the early 1980s. The way natural light filters through the openings is genuinely **ingenious**, changing the whole feel of the interior throughout the day. It serves as the seat of our government, so it carries real **symbolic importance** too. I have mostly seen the interior in photographs, but I once walked around the grounds while visiting my sister, and the scale of it was quite overwhelming up close. Honestly, every time I see it I notice some new detail I had missed before. I think great architecture like this is a form of art, and it is something the country can **rightly be proud of**. I would love to see inside properly one day.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Would you like to see inside it? Very much. I have seen photographs of the interior, with light pouring through the huge openings, and I would love to experience that in person if I ever get the chance to go inside.

Do you think modern buildings in Bangladesh are well designed? Some are, but many new buildings are rather plain concrete blocks put up in a hurry. I think architects should learn from buildings like this one, which are practical but also genuinely beautiful.

Part 3 link: Urban Development · Music & the Arts

54. Describe a place you visited on holiday

Places · your card 9 · sp2_places_09 · 258 words (yours: 161)

- where you went
- who you went with
- what you did
- and how you felt about it

I would like to talk about a holiday I took to Cox's Bazar, home to one of the longest natural sea beaches in the world. I went **there last winter** with a few close friends from university, and it turned out to be one of the most memorable trips of my life. **We took an overnight bus from Dhaka, which was tiring, but the excitement kept us going.** The beach itself was absolutely

stunning, stretching as far as the eye could see. We spent our days swimming, walking along the shore and watching the most spectacular sunsets I have ever seen. One morning we hired a jeep and drove along the Marine Drive towards Inani beach, with green hills on one side and the sea on the other, which was unforgettable. We also stopped at Himchari, where a small waterfall runs down the hillside, although it was only a trickle in the dry season. In the evenings we sampled fresh seafood, which was **delectable**, especially the grilled fish from the little stalls near the beach. What made it special was the combination of natural beauty and good company, which is a hard thing to beat. We laughed constantly and stayed up late talking, just like in our student days. Being by the sea was genuinely **rejuvenating** after months of ~~city~~ office life. Honestly, there is something about the vastness of the ocean that puts your everyday worries **into perspective**. I came home feeling completely recharged, and it left me with **cherished** memories that I still look back on fondly.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Would you go back to Cox's Bazar? Yes, without a doubt. Next time I would like to take my parents, because my mother has never seen the sea properly, and I think watching the sunset there together would be very special.

Do you prefer holidays with friends or with family? Both have their charms. With friends, trips are more spontaneous and adventurous, while family holidays are calmer and more comfortable. At my age, I probably enjoy the energy of travelling with friends slightly more.

Part 3 link: Travel & Tourism · Friendship

55. Describe a place that was full of noise

Places · your card 10 · sp2_places_10 · 241 words (yours: 159)

- where it was
- when you went there
- why it was noisy
- and how you felt about it

A place I remember as being incredibly noisy was Chawkbazar, a large wholesale market I visited in ~~the Old part of the city~~. Dhaka. I went there one morning last year, while I was staying with my elder sister, to help my brother-in-law buy things in bulk for a ~~relative with some shopping~~, family wedding, and the sheer volume of sound was overwhelming from the moment we stepped out of the rickshaw. The lanes are extremely narrow, and every inch is filled with shops, porters carrying huge loads on their heads and handcarts squeezing past. Traders were shouting out their prices, customers were haggling loudly, and the constant honking of vehicles added to the **chaos**. It was genuinely **deafening** at times, and I struggled to hear the person next to me. Yet there was an undeniable energy to it all; the noise felt alive rather than unpleasant. I found the whole scene strangely **exhilarating**, even if I would not want to be there every day. After a couple of hours, though, I was desperate for some quiet, as the constant **din** became exhausting, and I had a slight headache by the time we left. Coming from Sirajganj, which is relatively calm, I was amazed that people work in that environment every single day. Honestly, it gave me a real appreciation for peace and quiet, which I usually **take for granted**. It was a fascinating, if overwhelming, glimpse of everyday commerce, and I felt I had seen the real heartbeat of the capital.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you mind noisy places in general? I can tolerate them for a short while, especially if there is a good reason to be there, but I definitely prefer quiet places. After a long day, noise wears me out far more quickly than hard work.

Is your hometown noisy? Not really, compared with Dhaka. There is traffic and plenty of rickshaw bells in the town centre, but the residential area where we live is fairly quiet, especially in the evenings.

Part 3 link: Pollution · Urban Development

56. Describe a café or restaurant you like

Places · your card 11 · sp2_places_11 · 254 words (yours: 160)

- where it is
- what it is like
- what you usually have there
- and why you like it

A café I am particularly fond of is a small, cosy place tucked away on a quiet street near my office in Sirajganj. I discovered it by accident about a year ago, when I ducked inside to escape a sudden monsoon downpour, and I have been a regular ever since. What makes it special is not just the ~~coffee~~, tea, though ~~that~~ their milk tea with a hint of cardamom is excellent, but the wonderfully **inviting** atmosphere. It has soft lighting, comfortable seating and quiet music, which makes it perfect for unwinding. There are only about eight tables, and the walls are decorated with old photographs of the town and the river. The staff are genuinely friendly and remember my usual order, which gives it a lovely **personal touch**. I usually have a cup of tea with a plate of singara, or a chicken sandwich if I have skipped lunch. I often go there to read or catch up with a friend, and I never feel rushed to leave. In a ~~city full of noisy~~, town where most places to eat are loud and crowded, ~~chains~~, finding somewhere so **intimate** feels like a real treat. The food is simple but consistently good, which is all I really want. Sometimes I even meet students from the consultancy there for an informal chat about their applications, because it is much more relaxed than the office. Honestly, it has become a bit of a second home, and I think a good café is **worth its weight in gold** for how **welcoming** it can be.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you prefer going to cafés alone or with friends? It depends on my mood. If I want to read or think, I go alone, but most of the time I go with a friend, because a café is really about good conversation as much as the tea.

Are cafés popular in your town? They are becoming more popular, especially among young people. Traditionally, people gathered at roadside tea stalls, which are still everywhere, but a few modern cafés have opened recently and they are usually quite busy.

Part 3 link: Food & Cuisine · Hobbies & Leisure

57. Describe a place in your hometown that you like

Places · your card 12 · sp2_places_12 · 263 words (yours: 160)

- what the place is
- where it is
- what you do there
- and why you like it

A place in my hometown that I have always loved is the old ~~central~~ square in the centre of Sirajganj, which is really the heart of the town. It sits at a busy crossroads not far from the main bazaar, and almost every rickshaw in town seems to pass through it at some point. It has been there for generations, and it holds a lot of **nostalgia** for me. As a child I would play there, and even now I find myself **drawn back to** it ~~whenever~~ most weekends. My father used to take me there on the back of his bicycle to buy sweets, and I ~~visit~~ still go to the same sweet shop today. The square is surrounded by old shops, ~~and a beautiful~~ some with faded signboards that must be

decades old, ~~clock tower~~, giving it a wonderfully **quaint** character. In the evenings it comes alive, with families strolling, vendors selling snacks and friends gathering to chat. I usually meet a couple of old school friends there, and we sit at a tea stall and talk about cricket or work for an hour or so. What I love most is that it has remained largely unchanged over the years, which is comforting in a fast-moving world. It feels like a place where the whole community naturally comes together, whatever their age or background. Honestly, being there always fills me with a warm sense of **belonging**. It is a simple place, but it means a great deal to me and to everyone who grew up there, and I hope it is never **torn down** in the name of development.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Has the square changed much since you were a child? A little. Some of the old shops have been replaced by mobile phone shops, and there is more traffic now. But the basic layout and the evening atmosphere are exactly as I remember them.

Would you take a visitor there? Yes, definitely. If someone wanted to understand everyday life in Sirajganj, I would take them there in the evening, buy them some sweets and just let them watch the town go by.

Part 3 link: Public Spaces · Traditions & Customs

58. Describe a natural place you have visited (mountain or forest)

Places · your card 13 · sp2_places_13 · 242 words (yours: 158)

- where it is
- when you went
- what you saw there
- and how you felt

A natural place that took my breath away was Lawachara National Park, a hilly, forested ~~region~~ **visited** area near Sreemangal in the north-east of the country. I went there with my family about two years ago, during a short winter holiday, hoping to escape ~~the city~~ our usual routine for a few days. The moment we arrived, I was struck by how **lush** and green everything was, with rolling tea gardens stretching across the hills on the way in. Walking through the forest, surrounded by tall trees and birdsong, was a genuinely **humbling** experience. At one point our guide pointed out a family of gibbons high up in the branches, and we all stood completely still, hardly daring to breathe. The air was wonderfully clean, and the whole landscape felt **untouched** by the chaos of modern life. We spent our days hiking along the forest trails and simply admiring the views, which were spectacular. We even crossed the railway line that runs straight through the forest, which felt like a scene from an old film. What struck me most was the profound sense of peace; being in such **pristine** nature made all my worries seem trivial. My grandfather, who could not join us, made me describe every detail on our next visit to the village. Honestly, I came away with a renewed appreciation for the natural world and a determination to protect it. It reminded me how important it is to **disconnect** and reconnect with nature.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you often visit natural places like this? Not as often as I would like. Work keeps me busy, so I usually manage one proper trip a year. In between, walking by the Jamuna is my way of staying connected to nature.

What could be done to protect places like this? I think visitor numbers should be controlled, and people should be taught not to leave litter or make noise. Local communities should also benefit from tourism, so they have a reason to protect the forest.

Part 3 link: Wildlife & Conservation · Environmental Protection

59. Describe a place where you would like to live

Places · your card 14 · sp2_places_14 · 243 words (yours: 160)

- where it is
- what it is like
- what you would do there
- and why you would like to live there

If I could live anywhere, I would choose a quiet coastal town, somewhere that balances natural beauty with a sense of community. I am thinking of somewhere like the area around Inani, south of Cox's Bazar, where green hills come right down towards the beach. I have always been drawn to the sea, so waking up to the sound of waves would be genuinely **idyllic** for me. I imagine a place that is peaceful but not isolated, with friendly neighbours, a small market and a slower pace of life. What appeals to me most is the idea of escaping the relentless **hustle and bustle** of ~~the city~~, big cities like Dhaka, which ~~can be~~ I find exhausting whenever I visit. I would love to spend my mornings walking along the shore and my evenings watching the sunset. During the day I could work remotely, advising students online, which is becoming quite possible in my field. At the weekends I might learn to fish or simply read on a balcony facing the sea. I think such an environment would be far more **conducive** to a healthy, balanced lifestyle. Of course, I would still want decent amenities nearby, such as a hospital and good internet, so it would need to be reasonably **well connected**, and close enough for my parents to visit. Honestly, the thought of such a calm, **wholesome** existence is very appealing. Perhaps one day, when my career allows it, I will make that dream a reality.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you think you will actually live there one day? Perhaps, though probably not for many years. For now my family and my career are here, but it is a dream I keep at the back of my mind, maybe for later in life.

Would your family be happy if you moved away? My parents would probably worry at first, as they like having us close. But if I were within a day's journey and visited often, I think they would gradually come round to the idea.

Part 3 link: Housing · Urban Development

60. Describe a place where you like to shop

Places · your card 15 · sp2_places_15 · 259 words (yours: 170)

- where it is
- what you buy there
- how often you go
- and why you like it

A place I really enjoy shopping is Jamuna Future Park, a ~~large~~, huge, modern shopping mall in Dhaka, which I usually visit when I am staying with my elder sister. It is one of the ~~city-centre~~-biggest shopping centres in the country, so you could easily spend a whole day there. I mostly buy clothes, especially new shirts and a panjabi before Eid, and sometimes books or small gifts for my younger sister. I go there perhaps ~~once~~ every two or ~~twice a month, usually when~~ three months, depending on how often I ~~need clothes or want~~ travel to ~~treat myself~~. Dhaka. What I like about it is that everything is **under one roof**, which makes it wonderfully **convenient**. It has ~~a huge variety~~ **vast array of** shops, from local brands to international ones, so ~~there is plenty of choice~~. I can compare prices without walking from market to market in the heat. Beyond the shopping itself, it is a pleasant place to spend a few hours; it is clean, air-conditioned and has good places to eat. I often go with ~~friends~~, my sister and her husband, and my nephew loves the play area, so it doubles as a ~~social~~ family outing. What makes it enjoyable is the lively but

comfortable atmosphere, which is never too **overwhelming**, except perhaps in the last few days before Eid. Honestly, even when I do not buy much, I enjoy just browsing and **window-shopping**. I think a good shopping centre is designed to be an experience, not just a transaction, and this one gets that balance right. ~~making it a genuinely pleasant way to relax.~~ Back home, I still prefer local shops for everyday things, but for special purchases this is my favourite place.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you prefer shopping in malls or in local markets? For clothes and special purchases, I prefer malls because of the choice and fixed prices. For everyday things like fruit and vegetables, I always go to the local market, where everything is fresher and cheaper.

Do you ever shop online? Yes, more and more, mainly for books and small electronics. It is convenient, but I still like to see and touch clothes before buying them, so for those I usually go to a shop.

Part 3 link: Consumer Behaviour & Shopping

61. Describe a place you visit often

Places · your card 16 · sp2_places_16 · 253 words (yours: 160)

- what the place is
- where it is
- what you do there
- and why you go so often

A place I visit almost every day is a small gym near my home, which has become an important part of my routine. It is on the ground floor of a building just two streets away from our flat, so I can walk there in five minutes. I started going a couple of years ago to improve my health, after I realised that sitting at a desk all day was giving me back pain, and it quickly became a habit I genuinely look forward to. It is nothing fancy, but it is clean, well-equipped and rarely too crowded. I usually go straight after work and spend about an hour there, doing a mix of weights and running on the treadmill, followed by some stretching. It is one of the few times my mind switches off completely. What keeps me coming back is how **energising** a workout is after a long day at a desk. There is also a real sense of **camaraderie** among the regulars, which makes it feel welcoming rather than intimidating; ~~I usually spend~~ we encourage each other and sometimes argue about ~~an hour there,~~ cricket between sets. The trainer knows everyone by name, and ~~it is one of the few times my mind switches off completely.~~ he has been very patient with me. Beyond the physical benefits, it has become a valuable **outlet for stress**. Honestly, going there consistently has been genuinely **transformative** for both my body and my mood, and even my mother says I seem more cheerful these days. I think having a place that keeps you **disciplined** and healthy is worth its weight in gold.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you prefer exercising alone or with others? I actually like a mix. I do my workout on my own, but having other people around keeps me motivated, and it is always easier to push yourself when someone is cheering you on.

Are gyms popular where you live? They have become much more popular in recent years. When I was younger, hardly anyone in Sirajganj went to a gym, but now several have opened, and they are mostly full of young people.

Part 3 link: Happiness & Wellbeing · Hobbies & Leisure

62. Describe a tourist attraction you have visited

Places · your card 17 · sp2_places_17 · 268 words (yours: 155)

- what it is
- where it is
- what you did there
- and how you felt about it

A tourist attraction that genuinely impressed me was the Sundarbans, the world's largest mangrove forest, which stretches across the south-west of Bangladesh and into India. I visited it about two years ago on a three-day boat tour that started from Khulna. It is a vast, **remote** wilderness, famous for being home to the Royal Bengal Tiger. Gliding through the narrow waterways surrounded by dense forest was an unforgettable experience. The mangrove trees themselves were fascinating, with their roots sticking up out of the mud like hundreds of little spikes, which helps them breathe when the tide comes in. We slept on the boat, and at night the silence was broken only by the calls of birds and the sound of the water. What made it so special was how **untamed** everything felt; this was nature completely on its own terms. During the day we took smaller boats into the creeks and walked along wooden trails with armed forest guards. We spotted deer, monkeys, exotic birds and even crocodiles, though sadly no tigers. The whole trip was genuinely **exhilarating**, partly because of the slight sense of danger. Our guide explained how ecologically important the area is, especially as a natural barrier that protects the coast from cyclones, which deepened my appreciation. I found the sheer scale and **biodiversity** of the place utterly **captivating**. Honestly, it is one of the few tourist attractions that fully **lived up to the hype**. It also made me realise how vital it is to protect such fragile natural wonders before they disappear, especially as rising sea levels are already putting the forest under pressure.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Would you go back to the Sundarbans? Yes, I would love to, ideally in a different season to see how it changes. And of course I am still hoping that one day I will be lucky enough to catch a glimpse of a tiger.

Is it popular with foreign tourists? It attracts some foreign visitors, but I think it is still underrated internationally. Most tourists there are Bangladeshis, which is a pity, because it is genuinely one of the most remarkable places in the region.

Part 3 link: Wildlife & Conservation · Travel & Tourism

63. Describe a place where you studied

Places · your card 18 · sp2_places_18 · 244 words (yours: 154)

- where it was
- when you studied there
- what it was like
- and how you felt about it

The place I would like to describe is my university campus, where I spent some of the most **formative** years of my life. It was a large, leafy campus on the outskirts of the city, with old buildings, a big central field and plenty of open green space. I studied there for four years, doing a BBA with a focus on management, and I graduated a few years ago. What I loved was how **vibrant** the atmosphere was; there was always something happening, from lectures and presentations to club activities and cultural programmes. I joined the debating club, which did wonders for my confidence and my English. The library in particular became a second home, a wonderfully **studious** environment that made it easy to focus, especially before exams. Beyond the academics, the campus was where I made lifelong friendships and grew as a person, partly because it was my first time living away from my family. Looking back, those years were genuinely **pivotal** in shaping who I am today, and even the skills I use at work now, like advising students and giving presentations, started there. There was a real sense of community, and

everyone seemed to be striving towards something together. I still remember the long conversations over cheap tea at the canteen after classes. Honestly, I feel a strong sense of **nostalgia** whenever I think about it. I think a good campus offers far more than an education, and mine certainly did.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you still visit your university? Only occasionally, when I have work nearby or there is an alumni event. It always feels a little strange, because the faces are all new, but walking across the field still brings back lots of memories.

What did you like least about studying there? Probably the stressful exam periods, when the library was so full you could hardly find a seat, and missing home cooking. Still, those challenges were part of the experience, and they taught me independence.

Part 3 link: Higher Education · Education Systems

64. Describe a library you have visited

Places · your card 19 · sp2_places_19 · 247 words (yours: 154)

- where it is
- how often you go
- what you do there
- and why you like it

A library I am very fond of is the **central** public library in **my city, which** Sirajganj, a modest but well-kept building not far from the town centre. It is not grand, but it has a **genuinely beautiful old building, quiet dignity** about it, with rows of tall wooden shelves and long reading tables. I try to go a couple of times a month, usually on a free afternoon when I need to study or simply want some quiet. The moment you step inside, you are enveloped in a wonderfully **hushed** atmosphere that immediately calms the mind. It has **an enormous** a decent collection of Bengali literature as well as some English books, so I can always find something interesting to read. I usually borrow novels, but I also read the daily newspapers there and occasionally look through books on business and management. What I love most is the sense of **reverence** people seem to have there; everyone respects the silence, which is increasingly rare. I usually sit at the same desk in a quiet corner near **a large window, the back**, which is my favourite spot. There is something deeply **satisfying gratifying** about being surrounded by **thousands** so many books and knowing I will never run out of **books, things to discover**. Many students from less well-off families also rely on it for exam preparation, which makes it even more valuable to the town. Honestly, in an age of screens and constant noise, a library feels almost like a **sanctuary**. I think these places are precious, and I hope they never disappear.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you think libraries will still exist in the future? I think so, but they will need to change. They will probably offer more digital resources and study spaces, but people will always need quiet places where they can read and think.

Do you prefer printed books or e-books? Printed books, without doubt. I read on my phone when I am travelling, but I love the feel of a real book, and I remember what I read much better on paper.

Part 3 link: Lifelong Learning · The Internet & Information

65. Describe a beautiful place you have been to

Places · your card 20 · sp2_places_20 · 248 words (yours: 156)

- where it is
- when you went

- what made it beautiful
- and how you felt about it

One of the most beautiful places I have ever been to is ~~a hill station I visited~~ Sreemangal, in the tea-growing region of Sylhet, which is often called the ~~country~~ tea capital of Bangladesh. I had been once before with my family, but I went ~~during the~~ again last winter ~~which~~ with a couple of friends from work, and winter is the ideal time, ~~and~~ so the scenery was absolutely **breathtaking**. Endless rolling hills covered in neat rows of tea bushes stretched out in every direction, glowing green in the sunlight, with tall shade trees dotted between them. In the early morning, a thin mist hung over the valleys, giving the whole place an almost **ethereal** quality. I remember simply standing and staring, completely **spellbound** by the view. Later in the day we watched the tea pickers at work, moving along the rows with baskets on their backs, and we tried the famous seven-layer tea at a little shop in town, which was as colourful as it was strange. What made it so beautiful was the untouched, **serene** nature of it all, so far from the ~~noise~~ traffic and dust of the ~~city~~ roads back home. I took countless photos, but honestly none of them captured how magical it felt in person. Being in such a beautiful place had a genuinely uplifting effect on my mood, and I felt almost **at one with** my surroundings. It is a memory I return to whenever I need a moment of calm, and I would happily go back every winter if I could.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Would you like to go back there? Yes, definitely. Next time I would like to stay in one of the cottages near the forest and spend more time walking, rather than rushing around trying to see everything in a couple of days.

Do you prefer hills or beaches? It is a difficult choice, but probably hills. Beaches are wonderful, but places like Sreemangal feel calmer and cooler, and I love the endless shades of green and the quiet of the early morning.

Part 3 link: Travel & Tourism · Happiness & Wellbeing

66. Describe a crowded place you have been to

Places · your card 21 · sp2_places_21 · 258 words (yours: 159)

- where it was
- when you went
- why it was crowded
- and how you felt about it

A remarkably crowded place I remember was ~~a major festival celebration~~ the Eid fair held on an open ground in the ~~city~~ centre ~~during~~ of our town last year, on the day after Eid-ul-Fitr. After Eid prayers at the mosque and visits to relatives the day before, I went with some old school friends to soak up the atmosphere, and the sheer number of people was staggering. It was so crowded because families from all the surrounding villages come into town for the fair, everyone has a few days off work, and children have new clothes and Eid money to spend. The ground and the streets around it were absolutely packed, with families, vendors and performers filling every inch of space. There were stalls selling toys, bangles and sweets, a small Ferris wheel and even a group of folk singers. At times it was genuinely difficult to move, and the crowd felt almost **overwhelming**. Yet despite the crush, there was an **infectious** sense of joy in the air that was hard to resist. The whole place was **buzzing** with energy, music and the smell of street food. While I would not want to deal with such crowds every day, on that occasion it felt like part of the celebration. I did lose my friends for about twenty minutes, and we only found each other again by shouting. Honestly, being **swept along** with so many happy people was strangely **uplifting**. It reminded me how such shared events bring an entire community together, even if you do lose a bit of personal space in the process.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you usually enjoy crowds? Not really. I find them tiring in everyday situations, such as busy markets or traffic. But at festivals it is different, because everyone shares the same happy mood and the crowd becomes part of the fun.

How do people in your town celebrate Eid? The day starts with prayers at the mosque, then people visit relatives, share special food like semai and give money to children. Over the next few days, many families go to fairs or visit friends.

Part 3 link: Festivals & Celebrations · Traditions & Customs

67. Describe a place with beautiful views

Places · your card 22 · sp2_places_22 · 263 words (yours: 162)

- where it is
- how you got there
- what you could see
- and how you felt about it

A place with truly beautiful views that I will never forget was the top of a ~~small mountain~~ hill in Bandarban, in the Chittagong Hill Tracts, which I hiked up during a trip with friends about three years ago. We travelled by bus to Bandarban town, then took a jeep along winding mountain roads to a small village, and from there we climbed on foot for about three hours with a local guide. The climb was fairly demanding, especially in the heat, but the reward at the summit was more than worth the effort. The final stretch was so steep that we had to use our hands in places, and I was drenched in sweat by the time we reached the top. From the ~~top~~, summit, the view was absolutely **panoramic**, stretching across valleys, forests and ~~a distant~~ the Sangu river winding through the landscape far below. Layer after layer of green hills faded into the blue distance, and clouds were drifting past almost at eye level. I remember feeling a genuine sense of **elation** as I caught my breath and took it all in. The scale of the scenery was **humbling**, making me feel wonderfully small against such a vast backdrop. We stayed up there for nearly an hour, simply admiring the view, sharing some biscuits and taking photographs. There is something special about a view you have earned through effort, which makes it feel **all the more rewarding**. Honestly, it was one of those rare moments when the natural world **takes your breath away**. I still picture that view whenever I need a moment of calm.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you enjoy hiking? Yes, although I do not get many chances, because there are no hills near Sirajganj. When I travel, though, I always try to include a walk or a hike, because it is the best way to see a place properly.

Did you take a lot of photos there? Plenty, but none of them really did the view justice. Nowadays I try to take a few photos and then put my phone away, so I can actually enjoy the moment.

Part 3 link: Travel & Tourism · Hobbies & Leisure

68. Describe a place where you learned something new

Places · your card 23 · sp2_places_23 · 261 words (yours: 161)

- where it was
- what you learned
- how you learned it
- and how you felt about it

A place where I learned something genuinely new was a small pottery studio in Dhaka, where I ~~visited during~~ took a one-day weekend workshop while I was staying with my elder sister last

year. I had always been curious about working with clay, partly because Bengal has such a long tradition of terracotta and clay pots, so when my sister showed me an advert online, I signed up **on a whim**. What I learned was the basics of shaping clay on a potter's wheel, from centring the lump of clay to slowly pulling up the walls of a bowl. From the moment I sat at the wheel, I realised how much more **demanding** the craft is than it looks. My first few attempts collapsed hopelessly, which was **humbling** but oddly enjoyable. The instructor was wonderfully patient, guiding us step by step, sometimes placing her hands over ours so we could feel the right pressure, until I finally shaped something recognisable. There were only six of us, so we got plenty of individual attention and learned a lot from each other's mistakes as well. What I found most valuable was learning to be patient with myself; the process required real **perseverance**. There was something deeply satisfying about creating something with my own hands, away from screens. By the end of the day I had made a slightly wobbly bowl that I was absurdly proud of, and it now sits on my desk at home. Honestly, the experience was surprisingly **therapeutic**, and it reminded me how rewarding it is to step outside your **comfort zone** ~~and learn something completely different..~~

Rounding-off questions (new)

Have you done pottery since then? Not yet, unfortunately, because there is no studio near Sirajganj. But I have been looking for another workshop in Dhaka, and I would love to try again and hopefully make something less wobbly.

Do you think adults should keep learning new skills? Absolutely. Learning something new keeps your mind active and stops life from becoming routine. It does not have to be useful for work; even a hobby like pottery can teach you patience and confidence.

Part 3 link: Lifelong Learning · Hobbies & Leisure

69. Describe a public place that was recently built or renovated

Places · your card 24 · sp2_places_24 · 260 words (yours: 156)

- what it is
- where it is
- what it is like now
- and how you feel about it

A public place that was recently renovated in my **city** town is the ~~old~~ riverside ~~promenade~~, walkway along the Jamuna, which has been beautifully transformed over the last couple of years. It runs along the embankment on the edge of Sirajganj, not far from where I live. It used to be quite neglected and run-down, with broken paving, rubbish piling up and hardly any lights, so most people avoided it after dark, and the change has been remarkable. Now it features a wide walking path, proper lighting, rows of young trees and plenty of seating, making it far more **accessible** to everyone, including elderly people and families with small children. The whole area feels clean, modern and genuinely **welcoming**, which it never did before. On any given evening it is now full of people walking, jogging or simply relaxing by the water, and a few tea stalls have opened nearby. What I appreciate most is how the renovation has **revitalised** a part of the **city** town that was previously ignored. It has become a real gathering point for the community, and I often bump into neighbours and old classmates there. My parents now walk there most evenings, which is good for my father now that he has retired. Honestly, I think this kind of investment in public spaces is **commendable**, because it improves everyone's quality of life. My only concern is that it must be properly maintained, or it could **fall into disrepair** again. It has quickly become one of my favourite places to unwind, and it shows what good urban planning can achieve.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you think more public places should be improved? Definitely. There are several parks and fields in our town that are in poor condition, and improving them would benefit everyone, especially children and elderly people who have few other places to go.

Who should pay for improvements like this? Mainly the local government, as it is a public space. But I think local businesses could also contribute, because a pleasant area attracts more visitors, which is good for their trade as well.

Part 3 link: Public Spaces · Government & Public Policy

70. Describe a place away from home where you stayed

Places · your card 25 · sp2_places_25 · 243 words (yours: 154)

- where it was
- why you stayed there
- what it was like
- and how you felt about it

A place away from home where I once stayed was a small guesthouse in the hills near Rangamati, during a short break with my family last year. We ~~chose it~~ stayed there because my father had just retired, and we wanted to mark the occasion with a few quiet days somewhere ~~quiet and~~ away from the usual tourist crowds. A friend of my father's recommended it, so we booked it without really knowing what to expect. It turned out to be a wonderfully **charming** little place, run by a warm local family. The rooms were simple but **immaculately** clean, and the view from the balcony, looking out over the hills and the blue water of Kaptai Lake, was **spectacular**. What made the stay so memorable was the genuine **hospitality** of the hosts, who treated us like old friends and cooked delicious home-style meals, including fresh fish from the lake. In the afternoons we took a boat out on the lake, and in the evenings we sat on the veranda drinking tea and chatting until late. Waking up to birdsong and ~~mountain~~ fresh hill air was a world away from my ~~noisy city~~ usual office routine. I felt completely relaxed there in a way that hotels rarely achieve, and it was lovely to see my parents so happy and rested. Honestly, the whole experience was thoroughly **refreshing**, and it reminded me that the best trips are often about atmosphere rather than luxury. I would happily go back and stay there again.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you prefer guesthouses or hotels? For a relaxing break, I prefer guesthouses, because they feel more personal and you meet local people. For a work trip, though, a hotel is more practical, as everything is organised and predictable.

Would you recommend the area to others? Definitely. Rangamati is beautiful, especially around the lake, and it feels quite different from the rest of Bangladesh. I would just advise people to avoid the peak holiday season, when it gets much busier.

Part 3 link: Travel & Tourism · Family & Relationships

71. Describe a market you have visited

Places · your card 26 · sp2_places_26 · 249 words (yours: 155)

- where it is
- what is sold there
- what you did there
- and how you felt about it

A market I find genuinely fascinating is ~~a traditional~~ the old bazaar in the ~~old part~~ centre of ~~my city~~. Sirajganj, which has been trading for as long as anyone can remember. I love wandering through it whenever I get the chance, usually on a weekend morning. It is a wonderfully **vibrant**

place, with narrow lanes crammed with stalls selling everything from fresh vegetables, fish and spices to fabrics and handicrafts. Because our district is well known for handloom weaving, there are also shops piled high with colourful saris, lungis and gamchas, many of them made by weavers in nearby villages. The colours, smells and sounds combine to create an atmosphere that is completely **immersive**. What I enjoy most is the lively art of haggling, which is expected and almost a game between buyer and seller. I usually go there to buy fresh produce for my mother or small gifts, though half the fun is simply browsing. Before Eid I always buy a new lungi there for my grandfather, because he insists that local cloth is better than anything from Dhaka. The market has a raw, **authentic** character that modern shopping malls completely lack. Honestly, there is something special about a place where commerce has happened the same way for generations. Of course, it can be muddy and chaotic during the monsoon, but I have learnt to **take that in my stride**. It feels genuinely alive, and I always come away with a small treasure and a real sense of having experienced something **quintessentially** local.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you think traditional markets will survive? I hope so, and I think they will, at least in towns like mine. Many people still prefer fresh food and a personal relationship with sellers, although supermarkets and online shopping are slowly attracting younger customers.

Are you good at bargaining? Not as good as my mother, who is an expert. I usually start too high and give in too quickly, so when I need something important, I take her with me.

Part 3 link: Consumer Behaviour & Shopping · Traditions & Customs

72. Describe a place you go to be alone

Places · your card 27 · sp2_places_27 · 256 words (yours: 153)

- where it is
- how often you go
- what you do there
- and why you go there alone

A place I go to be completely alone is a quiet stretch of the riverbank a short walk from my home, well beyond the busy part of the embankment where people gather in the evenings. To reach it, you follow a narrow path past a few fields and a clump of bamboo, and then the river suddenly opens up in front of you. I tend to go there once or twice a week, and more often whenever I feel overwhelmed and need to clear my head. It is a **secluded** spot that few people seem to know about, which is exactly why I love it. I usually just sit on the grass under an old tree, watch the water and let my thoughts settle. Occasionally I bring a book, but more often I do nothing at all, which I rarely get to do these days. There is something deeply **restorative** about being alone in nature, with no phone buzzing and no one demanding my attention. I go alone because at home and at work I am constantly surrounded by people, and although I love them, I also need time to **recharge my batteries**. I find that a bit of **solitude** helps me process my feelings and make sense of whatever is bothering me. Far from feeling lonely, I feel more like myself there than almost anywhere else. Honestly, in a world that never seems to stop, having a private place to simply be is **genuinely precious** a **rare luxury**. I always return home feeling calmer and more centred.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you think it is important to spend time alone? Yes, I do. Time alone gives you space to reflect and understand your own feelings. Without it, I think people can become stressed and lose touch with what really matters to them.

Does your family know about this place? My younger sister does, and she teases me about my secret hideout. My parents know I go for walks by the river, but I do not think they know

exactly where I go.

Part 3 link: Social Isolation & Loneliness · Happiness & Wellbeing

73. Describe a famous place in your country

Places · your card 28 · sp2_places_28 · 259 words (yours: 154)

- what it is
- where it is
- why it is famous
- and whether you would recommend it

A famous place in my country that I think everyone should see is the National Martyrs' Memorial, which honours those who died in our war of independence in 1971. It is located in Savar, on the outskirts of Dhaka, about an hour's drive from the city centre depending on the traffic. It is a deeply **poignant** and symbolic site, and it holds enormous significance for the nation. The memorial itself is architecturally striking, with ~~a series of~~ seven triangular structures of different heights rising towards the sky, and I have read that they represent the key stages of our struggle for independence. It is famous not only for its design but also because every year, on Independence Day and Victory Day, huge crowds come to lay wreaths there, led by the country's leaders. I first visited it on a school trip and went again a few years ago with my younger sister. Visiting it is a genuinely moving experience, as it **commemorates** such an important chapter of our history. What makes it so meaningful is that it represents the sacrifice and courage of ordinary people, farmers, students and workers alike. I think it is important for younger generations to visit and understand their **heritage**. The surrounding grounds are peaceful and beautifully maintained, with a lake and mass graves nearby, which adds to the **solemn** atmosphere. Honestly, I would recommend it to any visitor, ideally early in the morning, because it offers real insight into what shaped our country. It is a place that inspires both reflection and a quiet sense of **patriotism**.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do schools in Bangladesh take students there? Yes, many schools organise trips there, especially around Victory Day and Independence Day. I think it is a valuable experience, because it helps young people connect emotionally with the history they read about.

Are there other monuments like this in your country? Yes, the Central Shaheed Minar in Dhaka commemorates the Language Movement of 1952. On the twenty-first of February, huge numbers of people walk there barefoot at dawn to lay flowers.

Part 3 link: Traditions & Customs · Travel & Tourism

74. Describe a place you enjoyed visiting as a child

Places · your card 29 · sp2_places_29 · 249 words (yours: 152)

- where it was
- who you went with
- what you did there
- and why you enjoyed it

A place I absolutely loved visiting as a child was my grandparents' village home, not far from Sirajganj, where ~~we would spend our holidays~~ they still live today. Although it is not a long journey, as a small boy it felt like travelling to another world. I went there ~~every year~~ with my ~~family~~, parents and my two sisters, usually during the school holidays and always for Eid, and those visits are among my happiest childhood memories. Often my cousins came too, so the house would be full of noise and laughter. The house was surrounded by open fields and ponds, which felt like ~~an endless~~ a **boundless** playground to a small child. I would spend whole days

climbing mango trees, ~~catching fish~~ fishing with my grandfather and running around barefoot with my cousins. In the monsoon we would jump into the pond from the bank, and my grandmother would scold us and then feed us hot rice and fish. Everything felt wonderfully **carefree**, far from the rules and routines of ~~city~~ school and town life. What made it so special was the sense of freedom and the warmth of the whole extended family gathered together. The pace of life there was so gentle and **unhurried**. Honestly, looking back, those visits filled me with a deep sense of **belonging** that I still treasure. ~~Sadly,~~ We still visit often, and my mother helps look after my grandparents, but the village has changed a lot since then, ~~but~~ with more concrete houses and fewer open fields. Even so, the memories remain **vivid** and precious to me.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do children today still enjoy visiting villages? Some do, but many are so used to screens that they get bored without the internet. My nephew loves it, though, especially chasing the chickens, so I think it depends on how children are introduced to it.

Do you still enjoy going there now? Very much, though for different reasons. Now I enjoy sitting with my grandparents, listening to their stories and helping them out, rather than climbing trees. It feels calm and grounding compared with work.

Part 3 link: Parenting & Childhood · Family & Relationships

75. Describe a sports venue or stadium you have visited

Places · your card 30 · sp2_places_30 · 242 words (yours: 161)

- what it is
- where it is
- what you did there
- and how you felt about it

A sports venue I visited that left a strong impression on me was ~~our~~ the Sher-e-Bangla National Cricket Stadium ~~where~~ in Mirpur, Dhaka, which is the main home ground of the Bangladesh team. I ~~watched an~~ went there a couple of years ago with my brother-in-law to watch a one-day international, ~~match~~, and it was my first time watching live cricket at that level. Cricket is almost a religion in my country, so the atmosphere was electric long before the game even started; people were queuing outside hours in advance, with their faces painted red and green. The stadium was absolutely **packed to the rafters**, with ~~tens of~~ thousands of fans singing, blowing horns and waving flags. When our team ~~scored~~, hit a boundary or took a wicket, the roar of the crowd was genuinely **thunderous**, and I could feel the energy in my chest. What made it so memorable was the incredible sense of **unity**; complete strangers were hugging and celebrating together as one. Watching a match on television simply cannot compare to being there in person. The whole experience was thrilling and completely **immersive**. We bought snacks from the vendors walking up and down the stands and stayed until the very last ball. Honestly, by the end I had lost my voice from cheering, but I did not care in the slightest, especially as we won comfortably. It was one of the most exciting days of my life, and I would **jump at the chance** to go again.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you prefer watching sports live or on TV? Live, definitely, for the atmosphere, although I watch most matches on television because tickets are hard to get and the stadium is far from Sirajganj. At home, at least, you get the replays and commentary.

Do you play cricket yourself? Only casually now. As a boy I played every afternoon with friends in the field near our house, but these days I prefer watching, and I occasionally join a friendly match during the holidays.

Part 3 link: Hobbies & Leisure

76. Describe a place you would like to visit again

Places · your card 31 · sp2_places_31 · 248 words (yours: 160)

- where it is
- when you first went
- what you did there
- and why you want to return

A place I would love to visit again is Darjeeling, a small ~~mountain~~ hill town in India, which I went to a few years ago and which completely charmed me. I first went there with two friends from university just after our final exams, crossing the border by land and taking a shared jeep up the winding mountain roads. I only stayed a few days, which was nowhere near long enough to appreciate it fully. The town was wonderfully picturesque, with ~~cobbled streets~~, steep lanes, old ~~stone houses~~ colonial buildings and ~~stunning views~~ tea gardens clinging to the hillsides, and on clear mornings we could see the snowy Himalayan peaks in ~~every direction~~ the distance. On that first visit I explored the local trails, rode the famous toy train for a short stretch and sampled the regional food, especially the momos, but I feel I only scratched the surface. What draws me back is the incredibly tranquil pace of life there, which was a world away from my hectic routine. There is a certain magnetic quality to some places that stays with you long after you leave, and this town has it. I have often found myself daydreaming about returning and staying longer next time, perhaps in spring when the views are clearer. I would also like to take my parents, because my father loves tea and would enjoy visiting a proper tea estate. Honestly, some destinations simply leave you wanting more, and revisiting it would be a genuine delight. I hope to make it happen soon.

Rounding-off questions (new)

What would you do differently next time? I would stay much longer, at least a week, and go in spring when the views are clearer. I would also like to stay in a small family-run guesthouse rather than a hotel.

Do you prefer visiting new places or returning to familiar ones? Generally I prefer new places, because I love discovering something different. But a few special places, like Darjeeling, are worth returning to, because you notice things you missed the first time.

Part 3 link: Travel & Tourism · Globalisation of Culture

77. Describe a peaceful place you know

Places · your card 32 · sp2_places_32 · 250 words (yours: 157)

- where it is
- how you know it
- what it is like
- and why it feels peaceful

A place I associate with real peace is an old, quiet mosque near my grandparents' home in our ancestral village, which I have known since childhood. It sits at the edge of a pond, shaded by a huge old banyan tree, and it is small, with whitewashed walls and a single dome. I first went there as a little boy, holding my grandfather's hand for Friday prayers, and I still go with him whenever we visit, even though he walks much more slowly now. It is not grand or famous, but it has a wonderfully tranquil atmosphere that I have never found elsewhere. Whenever I visit, I am struck by the deep sense of calm the moment I step inside. The thick walls seem to shut out the noise of the world completely, leaving only silence and the occasional sound of birds outside. Inside, the floor is cool and the light is soft, because the windows are small. Even for a few minutes, sitting there is genuinely meditative, and it helps me clear my mind of everyday

worries. What makes it so peaceful is not just the quiet, but the sense of **stillness** and reflection it encourages, and perhaps also the memories of my grandfather teaching me there. In our fast-paced, noisy lives, such places feel increasingly rare and valuable. Honestly, I always leave feeling lighter and more **centred**. I think everyone needs a place like this, somewhere they can retreat to and simply be **still** at peace for a while.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you go there often? Whenever we visit my grandparents, which is quite often, usually for Friday prayers with my grandfather. Even when I am busy, I try to stop there for a few minutes before we head back to town.

Is it easy to find peaceful places nowadays? It is getting harder, especially in towns and cities, where noise and crowds are everywhere. That is why places like this feel so precious, and why I think we should protect them.

Part 3 link: Happiness & Wellbeing · Public Spaces

78. Describe a hotel you have stayed in

Places · your card 33 · sp2_places_33 · 240 words (yours: 156)

- where it was
- when you stayed there
- what it was like
- and how you felt about it

A hotel that genuinely exceeded my expectations was a resort in Cox's Bazar where I stayed ~~at~~ during a family holiday by the sea, about a year after I started working. It was the first holiday I had helped to pay for, so it felt quite special, and the whole family came, including my elder sister, her husband and their two children. We stayed for four nights in December, when the weather is cool and dry. From the moment we arrived, the service was **impeccable**, and the staff **went out of their way** to make us feel welcome, even arranging a small cake when they found out it was my mother's birthday. The room was spacious and immaculately clean, with a balcony overlooking the ocean, which was **breathtaking** at sunrise. What impressed me most was the attention to detail; everything felt thoughtfully designed and genuinely **luxurious** without being pretentious. The food was excellent, especially the seafood at dinner, and the whole atmosphere was wonderfully relaxing. I remember spending hours by the pool with my nephew, feeling completely at ease, while my parents walked on the beach. Of course, it was not cheap, but the experience felt **worth every penny**. Honestly, a well-run hotel can make or break a holiday, and this one made ours truly special. It set a standard that has been hard to match since. I still remember that stay as one of the most comfortable of my life.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you usually stay in hotels when you travel? Not usually. On most trips I stay with relatives or in cheaper guesthouses to save money, so that resort was a real treat. It was worth it once, but I could not afford that every time.

What do you think makes a good hotel? Friendly, attentive staff most of all, followed by cleanliness and comfort. A beautiful building helps, but if the staff are rude or careless, even the most luxurious hotel will not feel welcoming.

Part 3 link: Travel & Tourism · Consumer Behaviour & Shopping

79. Describe a place with clean and fresh air

Places · your card 34 · sp2_places_34 · 258 words (yours: 162)

- where it is
- when you went there

- what you did
- and why the air was so pleasant

A place I associate with wonderfully clean air is a tea estate in the hills ~~that~~ near Sylhet, which I visited a couple of years ago ~~Coming from~~ during the winter. I had just spent a ~~polluted city~~, few days in Dhaka, so the difference in air quality was immediately noticeable and genuinely **refreshing**. The moment I stepped off the bus, I could not stop taking deep breaths of the cool, **crisp mountain** air. It felt as though my lungs were being cleaned out after ~~years~~ days of ~~city~~ breathing in the capital's smog and dust. I spent my days walking through the tea gardens and chatting with some of the workers, and in the mornings I climbed a small hill to watch the sunrise over the rows of tea bushes. The fresh air made even simple activities feel **invigorating**, and I slept better than I had in months. What made it so pleasant was the complete absence of heavy traffic, brick kilns and ~~industry~~; factories; the environment felt truly **unpolluted**. The endless trees and bushes all around must have helped too, and the dew on the leaves in the early morning made everything smell wonderfully green. Honestly, the experience made me realise ~~how much~~ that clean air is something we **take clean air for granted**, and how badly urban pollution affects us, especially children and older people like my grandparents. I came away not only feeling healthier but also more conscious of environmental issues, and now I try to walk short distances instead of taking an auto-rickshaw. It is a place I would return to just to breathe properly again.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Is air pollution a problem where you live? In Sirajganj it is not as bad as in Dhaka, but it is getting worse, mainly because of dust, traffic and brick kilns in the dry season. During the monsoon the air is much cleaner.

Would you like to live somewhere like that? For a while, yes, but perhaps not permanently. The tea gardens are quite remote, and I would miss my family and the convenience of town. A long holiday there every year would be ideal.

Part 3 link: Pollution · Climate Change

80. Describe a museum or art gallery you have visited

Places · your card 35 · sp2_places_35 · 250 words (yours: 156)

- where it is
- when you went
- what you saw
- and how you felt about it

A museum I found genuinely fascinating was the Bangladesh National Museum in ~~the capital~~, Shahbag, Dhaka, which I first visited on a school trip years ago and again more recently with my younger sister. Although it is quite a long journey from Sirajganj, both visits were well worth the effort. It houses an impressive collection spanning our country's history, from ancient artefacts to modern art, spread over several floors. What I found most **captivating** was the section on ancient ~~civilisations~~, Bengal, with ~~relies thousands~~ terracotta plaques, stone sculptures and old coins, some of them more than a thousand years old, beautifully preserved behind glass. Walking through the galleries felt like stepping through different eras, which was genuinely **enlightening**. I also spent a long time in the Liberation War gallery, where there are photographs, letters and personal belongings of people who fought in 1971, and that part was very emotional. My sister was particularly interested in the paintings by Zainul Abedin, one of our most celebrated artists. I have always believed that museums are an **underrated** way to learn, far more vivid than any textbook. Seeing real historical objects gave me a much deeper appreciation of the past, and it made the stories my grandfather tells feel more real. The building itself was grand and well maintained, adding to the **sense of occasion**. Honestly, I could easily

have spent an entire day there without getting bored. I think places like this are **invaluable**, because they keep our history alive for future generations to discover and appreciate.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you often go to museums? Not as often as I would like, as there are few museums near Sirajganj. Whenever I visit Dhaka for more than a couple of days, though, I try to spend an afternoon in a museum or gallery.

Should museums be free? I think entry should be free or very cheap, especially for students, because museums are educational. If people have to think twice about the price, the ones who would benefit most will simply stay away.

Part 3 link: Music & the Arts · Lifelong Learning

81. Describe a place that is important to your family

Places · your card 36 · sp2_places_36 · 270 words (yours: 154)

- what the place is
- where it is
- why it is important
- and how you feel about it

A place that holds deep importance for my family is our ancestral home in the village, not far from Sirajganj, which has been in the family for generations. It is surrounded by rice fields, with a pond at the back and a big courtyard in the middle. Although we now live in ~~the city~~, a flat in town, this house remains a powerful symbol of our roots. My grandparents still live there, and my mother often goes to help look after them, so we are back and forth all the time. Every major family occasion, from weddings to ~~festivals~~, Eid, seems to bring us all back there, and my elder sister travels from Dhaka with her children for the big celebrations. The house itself is old and simple, with a tin roof and wooden beams, but it is filled with **sentimental** value that no amount of money could replace. My ~~grandparents lived~~ father grew up there, and his old wooden school desk is still in one of the rooms. Walking through ~~its~~ those rooms fills me with a strong sense of **continuity** and belonging. What makes it so important is that it connects the whole extended family across the generations, and my grandfather loves telling stories about the people who lived there before him. In a fast-changing world, having such an **enduring** anchor feels genuinely precious. Honestly, I hope we manage to keep it in the family for many years to come, even though some relatives have talked about selling part of the land. It is far more than a building; it is the ~~heart~~ **cornerstone** of our family's identity, and I feel **deeply attached** to it.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you think your family will keep the house? I really hope so. There is some talk about the land, but my father feels strongly that the house should stay in the family, and I think most of us agree with him.

Do young people in Bangladesh still care about their ancestral homes? Many do, especially at Eid, when huge numbers of people travel back to their villages. But as more young people settle in cities or abroad, those ties are becoming weaker, which I find a little sad.

Part 3 link: Family & Relationships · Traditions & Customs

82. Describe a place with interesting architecture

Places · your card 37 · sp2_places_37 · 267 words (yours: 158)

- what it is
- where it is
- what the architecture is like
- and why you find it interesting

A place with genuinely interesting architecture that comes to mind is Ahsan Manzil, an old palace in Old Dhaka, right on the bank of the Buriganga river. It was built in the nineteenth century as the residence of the Nawabs of Dhaka, and today it is a museum, which I visited ~~in~~ while staying with my sister last year. People often call it the ~~heart~~ Pink Palace because of ~~the old city. Built centuries ago,~~ its colour, and it is a striking example of the ~~region's traditional~~ Indo-Saracenic style, which mixes European and Mughal influences. What fascinated me was the ~~intricate craftsmanship; every archway~~ the arches, pillars and ~~pillar was covered in detailed carvings that must have taken years~~ balconies are full of detail, and a grand staircase at the front leads up to ~~complete.~~ the large dome at the centre of the building. The building is **ornate** without feeling excessive, and it blends beauty with clever practical design, such as ~~courtyards~~ high ceilings and wide verandas that keep the ~~interior~~ rooms cool in the heat. I found it remarkable how **sophisticated** the ~~engineering~~ design was, considering it was built ~~entirely by hand.~~ long before air conditioning. Inside, the rooms display furniture, portraits and household objects from the period, which give you a sense of how the family lived. Standing inside, I felt a real sense of admiration for the skill of the people who created it. Honestly, modern buildings, for all their convenience, rarely have this kind of soul. I think architecture like this tells us a great deal about the culture and values of the past, which is exactly what makes it so **compelling** to me. It also reminds me how important it is to **conserve** such buildings in a city that is changing so fast.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you prefer old or modern buildings? For beauty and character, I definitely prefer old buildings. Modern buildings are more comfortable and practical, of course, but they often look the same, whereas old buildings tell you something about the place and its history.

Was it crowded when you visited? Yes, fairly crowded, as it is one of the most popular sights in Old Dhaka. There were school groups and families everywhere, but it was still possible to find quieter corners to look around.

Part 3 link: Traditions & Customs · Urban Development

83. Describe a village or countryside area you have visited

Places · your card 38 · sp2_places_38 · 251 words (yours: 162)

- where it is
- when you went
- what it was like
- and how you felt about it

A countryside area I visited that I still think about fondly is a small farming village ~~a few~~ in Bogura district, about two hours from ~~the city.~~ Sirajganj by road. I went there last year during the harvest season to visit a university friend's family, and ~~it was a wonderful change~~ although I know village life well from ~~urban life.~~ my grandparents' home, this place felt even more remote and peaceful. The village was surrounded by endless green paddy fields, and everything moved at a wonderfully **leisurely** pace. Most families there grow rice and vegetables, and many keep a few cows and chickens, so the day starts very early. What struck me most was how genuinely **content** the people seemed, despite having far fewer material comforts than ~~city dwellers.~~ people in towns and cities. My friend's mother cooked for us on a clay stove, and the food, fresh from their own fields and pond, was some of the best I have ever eaten. We spent our days walking along the narrow paths between the fields, and I even tried my hand at cutting rice, which was far harder than it looked. In the evenings we sat talking under a sky absolutely full of stars. ~~which is impossible to see in the city.~~ The air was clean and the atmosphere was completely **unhurried**. Honestly, the experience gave me a real appreciation for a simpler way of life. It made me question how much of ~~the city's~~ our constant rush is actually necessary. I came

away feeling calm and strangely **refreshed** **rejuvenated**, and I would love to spend more time somewhere like that, **away from it all**.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Would you like to live in a village like that? For a few months, perhaps, but probably not permanently. I love the peace, but my work depends on good internet and being near clients, and I would miss the conveniences of town life.

Are villages in Bangladesh changing? Yes, quite rapidly. Most villages now have electricity, mobile phones and better roads, and many young people move away for work. Life is more comfortable, but some of the traditional community spirit is fading.

Part 3 link: Urban Development · Generational Differences

84. Describe a place where you like to walk

Places · your card 39 · sp2_places_39 · 266 words (yours: 154)

- where it is
- how often you go
- who you go with
- and why you like walking there

A place I love to walk is a tree-lined avenue in **a large** the park near my home, which runs along one side of the park beneath tall rain trees and a few old mango trees. It is only about ten minutes from our flat, so it is very easy to fit into my day. I try to go there most evenings **either** after work, and on Friday mornings I sometimes go early, before the heat builds up. Usually I go alone, **or** but occasionally I go with a friend, and now that my father has retired he sometimes joins me, which has become a nice chance for us to talk. What makes it perfect for walking is the shade from the mature trees and the wide, well-kept paths. It is far enough from the main roads that the noise fades away, leaving a wonderfully **peaceful** calm atmosphere. I find that walking there is not just good exercise but also genuinely **meditative**; it is when I do some of my best thinking. The changing light in the evening, as the sun filters through the leaves, makes the whole place feel **serene**. Sometimes I listen to music or a podcast, and other times I simply enjoy the **quiet** sound of birds settling down for the night. When I walk with my father, he tells me how the town looked when he was young, which I find fascinating. Honestly, this simple daily walk has become one of the most **rejuvenating** parts of my routine. It clears my head, **lifts my mood** **spirits** and gives me a small **pocket of calm** in an otherwise busy day.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you think walking is a good form of exercise? Yes, it is probably the most underrated one. It is free, anyone can do it and it is gentle on the body, yet it still keeps you fit, especially if you walk briskly every day.

Do many people walk there? Quite a lot, particularly in the early morning and the evening. You see older people walking for their health, families strolling with children and a few serious joggers who overtake everyone.

Part 3 link: Public Spaces · Happiness & Wellbeing

85. Describe your ideal home

Places · your card 40 · sp2_places_40 · 262 words (yours: 164)

- what it would look like
- where it would be
- what features it would have
- and why it would be ideal for you

If I could design my ideal home, it would be a comfortable two-storey house on the edge of a quiet town, balancing modern convenience with a connection to nature. It would not need to be huge or **extravagant**; I value comfort and warmth far more than showing off. I picture large windows that let in plenty of natural light, making the whole space feel open and **airy**, and a wide veranda where the family could sit together in the evenings with tea. Ideally, it would be somewhere near Sirajganj, perhaps within sight of the Jamuna, so that I could stay close to my parents and grandparents. As for features, a small garden would be essential, somewhere I could grow a few **plants** vegetables, plant a mango tree and relax outdoors. Inside, I would want a cosy reading corner with shelves full of books and a proper kitchen, since those are the **heart** rooms where I spend most of **any home** my time. A spare bedroom would also be important, so that my elder sister and her children could stay whenever they visit from Dhaka. The house would need to be built **with the monsoon in mind**, raised slightly off the ground so that it never floods. What matters most to me is that it feels genuinely **welcoming**, both to family and to guests. I would also love it to be in a peaceful area with clean air and friendly neighbours. Honestly, my idea of an ideal home is less about luxury and more about creating a **sanctuary** where I can truly relax and feel at peace.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Is your current home similar to your ideal home? In some ways. Our flat is comfortable and in a quiet area, but it has no garden and not much natural light. The biggest similarity is that it is full of family, which matters most.

Would you prefer to live in a house or a flat? A house, ideally, because of the space and the possibility of having a garden. Flats are more practical and secure in towns, though, so for now I am perfectly happy where I am.

Part 3 link: Housing

86. Describe a difficult decision you once made

Experiences · your card 1 · sp2_experiences_01 · 251 words (yours: 162)

- what the decision was
- when you made it
- why it was difficult
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about a decision that honestly kept me awake at night for weeks. One of the hardest decisions I have faced was turning down a stable job to pursue something more uncertain but closer to what I actually wanted. This was about two years ago, just after I had been offered a comfortable position with good pay at a bank, only a few months after finishing my BBA. At the same time, a small education consultancy offered me a role helping students apply to study abroad, which paid less but felt far more meaningful. On paper ~~it~~ the bank was the sensible choice, which is exactly what made walking away so **agonising**. In my town, a bank job is seen as a real achievement, so I knew people would question my judgement. I spent weeks weighing it up, going back and forth, because the secure option felt safe while the other was a genuine **gamble**. What ultimately tipped the balance was realising I would probably **bitterly regret** not taking the risk far more than any short-term setback. Telling my family was nerve-wracking, since they naturally worried, but they came round once they saw how **determined** I was. As for how I felt, I was anxious for a long time, but also strangely **liberated**. Looking back, it was a real turning point, and although the following months were rocky, it taught me that the most rewarding paths are rarely the most comfortable. I still feel it was the right call.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Did your family agree with your decision in the end? Yes, eventually. My father was the first to support me, probably because he ran his own business for over thirty years and understood taking a chance. My mother took a little longer to feel comfortable.

Do you find it easy to make decisions in general? Not really, to be honest. For small things I'm quick, but with big decisions I tend to overthink. These days I try to set myself a deadline so I don't go round in circles forever.

Part 3 link: Career Choices · Success & Ambition

87. Describe a time you helped someone

Experiences · your card 2 · sp2_experiences_02 · 244 words (yours: 158)

- who you helped
- what the situation was
- how you helped them
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to describe a time I helped a new colleague at the education consultancy where I work. A time I clearly remember helping someone was when a younger colleague was struggling badly with a project and close to panicking. It was during our busiest season last year, and he had been asked to prepare several students' university applications with very tight deadlines. He was new and clearly **overwhelmed**, afraid to admit he was falling behind. I noticed he seemed stressed, so I quietly offered to sit with him after work and go through it together. Over a couple of evenings, we broke the task into manageable steps and slowly untangled the problem. I also showed him the checklist I use for each application and how to deal with the most urgent deadlines first. What I found most **rewarding** was watching his confidence gradually return as things started to make sense. He was incredibly grateful, though honestly, helping him did not feel like a chore at all. I think we underestimate how much a small act of **generosity** can mean to someone at a low point. It also reminded me of the times people had helped me when I was new and lost. Honestly, that experience left me feeling genuinely **fulfilled**, and it strengthened our working relationship enormously. These days he is one of the most **dependable** people in our office, and I like to think those evenings played a small part in that.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you often help your colleagues? Fairly often, yes. Our office is quite small, so we depend on each other a lot. If someone is stuck, it is usually quicker for everyone if we pitch in rather than let the problem grow.

Did he ever return the favour? He did, actually. A few months later I was buried in visa paperwork before a holiday, and he stayed late to help me finish. It felt good to know the support went both ways.

Part 3 link: Ethics & Moral Values · Emotional Intelligence

88. Describe a time when you were very busy

Experiences · your card 3 · sp2_experiences_03 · 242 words (yours: 161)

- when it was
- why you were busy
- what you had to do
- and how you felt about it

The busiest time I can remember was about a year ago, and I still feel slightly tired just thinking about it. A period when I was extraordinarily busy was during the final weeks before a major deadline at work, which happened to coincide with a family event. At the consultancy, it was the peak of the application season, when lots of students were trying to submit their university

applications at once, and at the same time my cousin was getting married in our ancestral village. I found myself juggling long working hours with preparations at home, and there simply were not enough hours in the day. My schedule was absolutely **relentless**; I would wake early, work through lunch and often continue late into the night. Then at weekends I travelled to the village to help with the arrangements for the wedding. At times it felt genuinely **overwhelming**, and I worried I might **drop the ball** on something important. What got me through was staying organised, making detailed lists and **prioritising ruthlessly**. Somehow I managed to meet the deadline and see the family event through successfully. As for how I felt, I was exhausted but also quietly proud. Looking back, ~~although it was exhausting,~~ it taught me a great deal about managing pressure, and I discovered I was more **capable** under stress than I had thought. Honestly, while I would not want to repeat it too often, it was a valuable lesson in resilience and time management.

Rounding-off questions (new)

How do you usually relax after a busy period? I like to take a long walk by the Jamuna in the evening, or just sit at home with a cup of tea and a book. After that busy month, I mostly caught up on sleep.

Do you think people are busier now than in the past? I think so. My father worked hard, but his work mostly stayed at the shop. Now phones mean work follows us home, so it is much harder to switch off completely.

Part 3 link: Work-Life Balance · Happiness & Wellbeing

89. Describe a time you received good news

Experiences · your card 4 · sp2_experiences_04 · 257 words (yours: 159)

- what the news was
- how you received it
- who told you
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about the day I found out I had got my current job, because it was a real turning point for me. A moment of wonderful news that I will never forget was when I found out I had been accepted for a position I had desperately wanted. It was a role at an education consultancy, helping students apply to study abroad, which suited both my BBA and my own interest in international education. I had applied weeks earlier and had almost given up hope, so the email from the director caught me completely **off guard**. I was actually sitting at a tea stall with a friend when my phone buzzed, and I assumed it was another rejection. I remember reading it several times, hardly able to believe it, feeling utterly **elated**. My first instinct was to call my family, who had supported me throughout the stressful application process. My mother answered, and I could hear her telling my father and sister in the background before I had even finished. Their reaction was just as **overjoyed** as mine, which made the moment even sweeter. What made the news so meaningful was how hard I had worked and how uncertain the outcome had felt. The relief was almost as strong as the happiness; it was genuinely **euphoric**. That evening we celebrated together over my mother's cooking, and I felt an immense sense of **accomplishment**. Honestly, it remains one of the happiest days of my life, and it reminded me that persistence really can pay off.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Who is usually the first person you share good news with? Usually my mother, because she worries about me the most, so good news means a lot to her. My younger sister is a close second, since she tends to find out everything anyway.

Do you prefer to receive news by phone or in person? In person, if possible. You can see someone's face and share the moment properly. That said, for something like a job offer, an email is fine, because you can read it again and again.

Part 3 link: Success & Ambition · Happiness & Wellbeing

90. Describe a time you learned a new skill

Experiences · your card 5 · sp2_experiences_05 · 256 words (yours: 157)

- what the skill was
- why you learned it
- how you learned it
- and how you felt about it

A skill I taught myself **relatively-recently** during my university years was cooking, which I had always avoided out of sheer laziness. At home, my mother has always done the cooking, so I never really had to lift a finger in the kitchen. That changed when I moved to Dhaka for my BBA and started sharing a small flat with three other students. Living away from home, I got tired of eating out and decided it was time to become **self-sufficient**. I started with simple recipes from online videos, and my early attempts were genuinely disastrous. There was a real **learning curve**, and I burned more meals than I care to admit, which was quite **discouraging** at first. I also rang my mother constantly, asking how much turmeric to add or how long to cook the lentils. But I **persevered**, and gradually things started to improve. What I found most rewarding was the moment I cooked a proper **meal** chicken curry that actually tasted good, and my flatmates asked for more. Beyond the practical benefit, cooking turned out to be surprisingly relaxing, almost **therapeutic** after a stressful day. I also realised how much work my mother had been doing for years without a word of complaint. It gave me a real sense of independence and pride. Honestly, learning this skill changed my daily life for the better, and it reminded me that most things become manageable if you are willing to fail a few times first. Now that I am back home, I even cook for the family occasionally.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you still cook now? Now and then. My mother still rules the kitchen, but on Fridays I sometimes make a simple curry or fried rice for everyone. My younger sister is my harshest critic, which keeps me honest.

What skill would you like to learn next? I'd love to learn to play the guitar properly. I listen to a lot of music, and being able to play a few songs for friends and family would be really satisfying.

Part 3 link: Learning Methods · Lifelong Learning

91. Describe a memorable journey you have taken

Experiences · your card 6 · sp2_experiences_06 · 267 words (yours: 160)

- where you went
- how you travelled
- who you were with
- and why it was memorable

I'd like to describe a train journey I took a couple of years ago, because my friends and I still talk about it. A journey that stands out vividly in my memory was a long train ride I took through the countryside with a group of close friends. We were **heading** travelling from Dhaka to **a holiday destination**, Sylhet to see the tea gardens, but honestly the journey itself turned out to be the highlight. There were four of us, all old university friends, and we had managed to get seats together in the same carriage. We set off early in the morning with bags of snacks and far too much luggage. The train wound slowly through **picturesque** landscapes of green paddy fields,

rivers and small villages, and later past gentle hills covered in tea. We spent hours chatting, playing cards and simply watching the ever-changing scenery, which was wonderfully **relaxing** **soothing**. At almost every station, vendors came on board selling tea and snacks, which only added to the fun. What made it so memorable was not the destination but the shared experience and the sense of freedom. There was something almost **nostalgic** about the slow rhythm of train travel, so different from the rush of flying. We laughed until our sides ached and made memories I still treasure. Honestly, that journey taught me that travel is often about the moments in between rather than just arriving. It remains one of my most **cherished** trips, precisely because it was so **unhurried** and full of good company. By the time we arrived, we were tired, but none of us wanted it to end.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Would you like to make that journey again? Definitely. I'd love to do it again, maybe with my younger sister this time, since she has never been to Sylhet. Though I suspect it would not feel quite the same without my friends.

Do you prefer travelling by train or by bus? By train, without a doubt. Buses in Bangladesh can be quite cramped and the roads are often jammed, whereas on a train you can stretch your legs and actually enjoy the view.

Part 3 link: Travel & Tourism · Transportation

92. Describe a time you were late for something

Experiences · your card 7 · sp2_experiences_07 · 261 words (yours: 153)

- what you were late for
- why you were late
- what happened
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about a morning I would honestly rather forget. A time I was embarrassingly late was for an important job interview a few years ago, just after I had finished university. The interview was in Dhaka, so I stayed the night before at my elder sister's flat, thinking that would give me plenty of time. I had planned everything carefully, but on the day, the traffic was absolutely **horrendous** due to an unexpected road closure. I sat helplessly in a ~~taxi~~, CNG auto-rickshaw, watching the minutes tick away, growing more **anxious jittery** by the second. I kept checking my watch every thirty seconds, as if that would somehow make the traffic move. I called ahead to apologise, which was **mortifying**, and eventually arrived nearly half an hour late, **flustered** and sweating. To my relief, the interviewers were surprisingly understanding, and the interview went reasonably well despite my terrible start. One of them even joked that being stuck in Dhaka traffic was practically a local tradition, which helped me relax a little. As for how I felt, I was ashamed at first and then hugely relieved. However, the whole experience taught me a valuable lesson about leaving a proper buffer for the unexpected. Since then I have become almost **obsessive** about arriving early for anything important. Honestly, the stress of that day was enough to change my habits for good. I now always plan for delays, because I never want to feel that particular kind of panic again. It was a bad day, but I am oddly grateful for it now.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Did you get the job in the end? No, I didn't, though I don't think it was only because I was late. Luckily, a few weeks later I was offered my current job at the consultancy, which suits me much better anyway.

Are people in your country usually on time? Honestly, not always. Traffic in the cities is so unpredictable that people tend to be quite relaxed about being a little late. For formal things like interviews, though, punctuality really matters.

93. Describe a time you solved a difficult problem

Experiences · your card 8 · sp2_experiences_08 · 255 words (yours: 158)

- what the problem was
- how you approached it
- how you solved it
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about a problem at work that had nothing to do with paperwork and everything to do with people. A difficult problem I once solved involved a serious misunderstanding between two members of a team I was working with at the consultancy. One of them handled students' documents and the other handled visa files, and each felt the other was causing delays. Their disagreement had escalated to the point where it was affecting everyone's work. At first I was reluctant to get involved, because it was not really my responsibility, but I could see the whole office was suffering. Rather than taking sides, I decided to sit down with each of them separately to understand their perspectives. It quickly became clear that the whole conflict stemmed from poor communication rather than any real **malice**. I then arranged a calm conversation between them over tea, acting as a neutral **mediator**. It was a delicate situation that required a lot of **tact**, but eventually they **cleared the air**. We also agreed on a simple shared checklist, so nobody would be left guessing about who was doing what. What I found most rewarding was seeing them work together productively again afterwards. Honestly, resolving that tension felt like a genuine achievement, and it taught me the value of listening carefully before **jumping to conclusions**. It made me realise that many difficult problems are really just communication failures in disguise, and patience is often the best tool. I still feel quite proud of how that turned out.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do the two colleagues get on well now? Surprisingly well, yes. They still tease each other now and then, but it is friendly. They even sit together at lunch, which nobody in the office would have predicted a year ago.

Do you enjoy solving problems like this? I do, as long as they don't happen too often. I find it satisfying to untangle a situation and see people relax again, although it can be quite draining while it is going on.

Part 3 link: Conflict & Mediation · Professional & Soft Skills

94. Describe an achievement you are proud of

Experiences · your card 9 · sp2_experiences_09 · 261 words (yours: 165)

- what it was
- when it happened
- how you achieved it
- and why you are proud of it

There are a few things I am proud of, but one stands out above the rest. An achievement I am genuinely proud of was completing a challenging professional qualification while working full time. It was a certificate course in international student counselling, which I finished last year to become better at my job. Balancing study with a demanding job was far harder than I had anticipated. For nearly a year, I sacrificed most of my evenings and weekends, which required real **discipline**. I would come home from the office, have dinner with my family and then **burn the midnight oil** at my desk, often with a cup of tea going cold beside me. There were moments when I felt like giving up, especially when the material seemed impossibly difficult. On those

nights, a quick walk by the river usually helped me clear my head and start again. What kept me going was a stubborn **determination** to finish what I had started. When I finally passed the final exam, the sense of relief and pride was overwhelming. My father was so delighted that he bought sweets for half the neighbourhood. What made it so meaningful was that I had earned it entirely through my own effort and **persistence**. Honestly, that accomplishment gave me a huge confidence boost and proved to myself that I could handle serious challenges. It remains one of my proudest moments, not because of the qualification itself, but because of the **resilience** it took to get there. It taught me I am capable of far more than I thought.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Has the qualification helped you in your job? Yes, quite a lot. I feel more confident advising students now, especially about choosing courses and preparing for interviews, and my manager has started giving me some of the more complicated cases.

How did your family support you during that time? They were very patient. My mother kept bringing me tea late at night, and my younger sister, who is a serious student herself, often studied beside me, which kept both of us motivated.

Part 3 link: Success & Ambition · Lifelong Learning

95. Describe a time you tried something for the first time

Experiences · your card 10 · sp2_experiences_10 · 259 words (yours: 157)

- what it was
- when you tried it
- why you tried it
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about the first time I spoke in front of a large audience, because it was a genuine milestone for me. A memorable first for me was trying public speaking at a fairly large event, something I had always dreaded. ~~I was~~ It happened about a year ago, when our consultancy organised a study abroad seminar for students and parents in a hall in Sirajganj. My manager asked me to give a short presentation, and my instinct was to refuse, but I forced myself to accept, partly because I knew I could not avoid it forever. In the days leading up to it, I was genuinely **terrified**, rehearsing constantly and imagining every possible disaster. I even practised in front of my younger sister, who turned out to be a surprisingly tough audience. When the moment came, my heart was pounding and my mouth was dry. But once I started speaking, something surprising happened; I gradually became more **composed**, and the words began to flow. By the end, I actually felt a rush of **exhilaration**. It was far from perfect, but I had done it, and the sense of achievement was immense. A few parents even came up afterwards with questions, which told me I had made sense. I was still shaking a little, but I was smiling from ear to ear. Honestly, pushing through that fear was genuinely **liberating**, and it taught me that we are often far more capable than our anxiety suggests. Since then I have been much more willing to **step outside my comfort zone**.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Have you given any presentations since then? Yes, several. We now hold seminars every few months, and I usually present the section on applications. I still get a few butterflies beforehand, but nothing like that first time.

Would you like to try any other new things in the future? I'd really like to study abroad myself one day. After helping so many students do it, I think experiencing it first-hand would be both challenging and incredibly worthwhile.

Part 3 link: Professional & Soft Skills · Success & Ambition

96. Describe a time you felt nervous

Experiences · your card 11 · sp2_experiences_11 · 258 words (yours: 158)

- when it was
- why you were nervous
- what happened
- and how you felt afterwards

I'd like to talk about my first day at the education consultancy where I still work. A time I felt intensely nervous was on my first day at a new job, walking into an office full of complete strangers. It was only a few months after I had finished my BBA, and it was my first proper full-time job. I had really wanted the role, which somehow made me even more **apprehensive** about making a bad impression. The night before, I barely slept, and I think I ironed my shirt at least twice. I even left home forty minutes early, just in case the rickshaw got stuck in traffic. My mind was racing with worries about whether I would fit in or make some embarrassing mistake. I remember my hands were slightly shaking as I introduced myself. To my relief, my new colleagues were warm and **welcoming**, which gradually **put me at ease**. One senior colleague took me out for tea and explained how everything worked, which made a huge difference. By lunchtime, most of my nerves had **melted away**, and I began to feel genuinely **optimistic** about the job. Looking back, I realise that my anxiety had been almost entirely in my head. What I learned was that nervousness before something important is completely natural, and it usually fades once you actually begin. That experience taught me to trust that things generally turn out far better than my worried mind predicts. When I got home that evening, my family were waiting to hear every detail over dinner.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you still feel nervous at work sometimes? Occasionally, mostly before meeting parents who are very worried about sending their child abroad. But it is a useful kind of nervousness now, because it makes me prepare properly.

What do you usually do to calm your nerves? I take a few slow breaths and remind myself that I have prepared. If I have time, a short walk and a cup of tea usually help me feel settled again.

Part 3 link: Emotional Intelligence · Job Satisfaction

97. Describe a time you gave advice to someone

Experiences · your card 12 · sp2_experiences_12 · 256 words (yours: 163)

- who you gave advice to
- what the situation was
- what advice you gave
- and how it turned out

I'd like to talk about some advice I gave to one of my oldest friends from university. A time I gave advice that actually made a difference was when a this close friend was agonising over whether to change careers. He had been working in a bank for two years and was deeply unhappy in his job, because what he really wanted was to teach, but he was terrified of the **uncertainty** of starting over. He came to me feeling completely stuck, and I could see he just needed someone to help him think clearly. We met at our usual tea stall by the river and talked for hours. Rather than telling him what to do, I encouraged him to **weigh up** what he truly valued in the long term. I shared my own experience of taking a similar risk when I chose my current job, which seemed to **reassure** him. I also suggested he speak to a few teachers first, to see what the job was really like day to day. My main advice was that regret over never trying is usually worse than the fear of failing. It was a genuinely **delicate** conversation, because I did not want to push him into

anything. In the end, he made the change and is now far happier teaching at a college. He told me recently that our conversation was the push he needed. Honestly, seeing him thrive was incredibly **gratifying**, and it reminded me that sometimes the best help is simply helping someone find their own answer.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do people often come to you for advice? Quite often, actually, probably because of my job. Students and their parents ask me about studying abroad every day, and friends seem to assume I am good with big decisions too.

Is there anyone whose advice you always trust? My grandfather. He is in his eighties but still remarkably sharp, and he has a way of cutting through a problem with one simple question. I always come away seeing things more clearly.

Part 3 link: Career Choices · Friendship

98. Describe a time you worked as part of a team

Experiences · your card 13 · sp2_experiences_13 · 258 words (yours: 160)

- what the task was
- who was in the team
- what your role was
- and how you felt about the experience

I'd like to describe a group project from my BBA, because it taught me a lot about working with other people. A memorable experience of teamwork was a group project during my university years, where we had to deliver a major presentation in just two weeks. The task was to design a complete marketing plan for a small local business and then present it to our lecturers. Our team was made up of five people with very different personalities and strengths. One was brilliant with numbers, another was a confident speaker, and one was very creative with design. At first, coordinating everyone was genuinely challenging, and there were a few **clashes** over how to approach things. My role naturally became that of the organiser, keeping track of deadlines and making sure everyone stayed **on the same page**. What made it work in the end was our willingness to **compromise** and play to each other's strengths. We met almost every evening in the library, often staying until it closed. As we got closer, the atmosphere became genuinely **collaborative**, and the project came together beautifully. On the day itself, everyone played their part, and it felt like a genuine team effort. We ended up receiving one of the highest marks in the class. Honestly, the experience taught me more about cooperation than any lecture could, and I felt really proud of what we had built together. It showed me that a good team is far more than the sum of its parts, provided everyone is **committed** to the same goal.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Are you still in touch with the people from that team? With most of them, yes. We have a group chat that is still surprisingly active, and whenever a couple of us are in Dhaka at the same time, we try to meet up for dinner.

Do you prefer working alone or in a team? It depends on the task. For detailed paperwork I like to work alone and concentrate, but for planning or solving problems, I think a team usually comes up with far better ideas.

Part 3 link: Professional & Soft Skills · Leadership

99. Describe a time you complained about something

Experiences · your card 14 · sp2_experiences_14 · 262 words (yours: 156)

- what you complained about
- who you complained to

- what happened
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about a complaint I made last year, which turned out much better than I expected. A time I had to make a complaint was over a faulty product I had bought online, which stopped working within days. It was a pair of wireless headphones that I used for listening to music on my evening walks by the river. I was quite frustrated, as it had been fairly expensive and I felt genuinely **let down**. I contacted the company's customer service, determined to stay calm and polite rather than **lose my temper**, which I find rarely helps. I explained the situation clearly and provided all the necessary evidence, including photos and my order details. When I had heard nothing after two days, I phoned their helpline and patiently explained it all again. To my surprise, the representative was genuinely **apologetic** and handled the matter far better than I expected. They arranged a full refund and even offered a discount on a future purchase, which I thought was a **gracious** gesture. The whole thing was sorted out in less than a week. What I learned from the experience was that complaining effectively is really about being clear and reasonable rather than angry. Honestly, the whole thing was resolved far more **amicably** than I had feared, and I felt quite satisfied afterwards. It also made me realise that most companies genuinely want to keep their customers happy. It reminded me that a firm but respectful approach usually gets the best results, and I have used the same approach several times since.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you often complain when something goes wrong? Not very often. I only complain when it really matters, like when I have paid good money for something. For small things, I usually decide it is not worth the time and energy.

Do you still shop online after that experience? Yes, I do, but I am more careful now. I read the reviews properly and check the return policy before buying anything expensive, which I never used to bother with.

Part 3 link: Consumer Behaviour & Shopping

100. Describe a time you helped a stranger

Experiences · your card 15 · sp2_experiences_15 · 255 words (yours: 170)

- when it happened
- who the stranger was
- how you helped
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to describe a small moment of kindness that happened in the main market in Sirajganj a few months ago. A time I helped a stranger was when I came across an elderly man who had stumbled and dropped his shopping on a busy street. There were vegetables and a bag of rice spread across the road, and rickshaws were **weaving around** him. Most people simply walked past, which I found rather **disheartening**. I stopped to help him gather his things and made sure he was not hurt. Luckily, apart from a small scrape on his hand, he was fine. He seemed a little shaken, so I stayed with him for a few minutes and offered to walk him to a nearby bench outside a tea stall. He was incredibly grateful, and we ended up having a lovely short chat; it turned out he was a retired schoolteacher who now lived alone, since his children had moved to Dhaka for work. What struck me was how such a small gesture clearly meant a great deal to him. Honestly, it took only a couple of minutes of my time, yet it felt genuinely meaningful. It reminded me that we often overlook small chances to be kind because we are so **caught up in** our own lives. That brief encounter left me feeling **warm** **heartened** for the rest of the day, and it made me more **attentive** to people around me who might need help. I still see him in the market sometimes, and he always waves.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you think people help strangers less than in the past? In big cities, perhaps. Everyone is in a hurry and slightly wary of strangers. In smaller towns like mine, people still tend to stop, although even here I notice it happening less.

Has anyone ever helped you when you were a stranger somewhere? Yes, when I got lost in Chattogram once, a shopkeeper drew me a little map and pointed me in the right direction. I have never forgotten how kind he was.

Part 3 link: Ethics & Moral Values · Social Isolation & Loneliness

101. Describe a time you changed your plan

Experiences · your card 16 · sp2_experiences_16 · 257 words (yours: 162)

- what the original plan was
- why you changed it
- what you did instead
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about a trip that did not go to plan at all, but still turned out well. A time I had to change my plans quite suddenly was when a long-awaited trip with friends fell through at the last minute due to bad weather. The original plan was to spend three days in Cox's Bazar, but a cyclone warning was issued the day before we were due to leave, and our bus was cancelled. I had been looking forward to it for weeks, so the cancellation was initially a **real crushing disappointment**. Rather than sulking about it, though, we decided to be flexible and **make the best of** the situation. We ended up organising a day trip to a ~~nearby town instead~~, char, one of the sandy river islands in the Jamuna, something none of us had planned. We hired a small boat, packed a picnic and spent the afternoon walking on the sandbanks and watching the fishermen bring in their nets. To our surprise, it turned out to be a wonderful day, arguably better than the original plan. What I took from it was that rigidity often leads to frustration, whereas being **adaptable** opens up unexpected opportunities. It was a good reminder that plans **falling apart** is not always a bad thing. Honestly, some of my best experiences have come from **spontaneous** changes like that, and I remember feeling surprisingly content on the boat home as the sun went down. I now try to hold my plans a little more loosely and stay open to whatever comes.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Did you manage to go to Cox's Bazar later? Yes, about three months later, once the weather had settled. It was lovely, but funnily enough, when we talk about that year, it is usually the day on the char that we remember.

Do you usually plan your trips carefully? I plan the essentials, like transport and where to stay, but I leave the rest fairly open. Too much planning makes a trip feel like work, and the unexpected moments are often the best.

Part 3 link: Travel & Tourism · Hobbies & Leisure

102. Describe a time you got lost somewhere

Experiences · your card 17 · sp2_experiences_17 · 250 words (yours: 162)

- where you were
- how you got lost
- what you did
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about the time I got lost in Chattogram, a city I had never visited before. It was about three years ago, when I went there with some university friends on a short study tour. A time I got hopelessly lost was during ~~a~~ that trip, ~~to an unfamiliar city~~, when I wandered off from

my group one afternoon to explore the older part of the city near the port. Before long I realised I had no idea where I was, and to make matters worse, my phone battery had died. I felt a growing sense of **panic** as the ~~streets~~ narrow lanes all started to look the same, and I was completely **disoriented**. Rather than making it worse by rushing, I forced myself to ~~stay calm~~ **keep a level head** and think logically. I asked a friendly shopkeeper for directions, and although ~~there~~ his local dialect was ~~a bit of a language barrier~~, quite hard for me to follow, he was very ~~helpful~~ patient and even drew me a little map on a scrap of paper. Eventually I found my way back to a landmark I recognised and reunited with my relieved group, who had been searching for me for nearly an hour. I felt rather **sheepish**, and my friends teased me about it for the rest of the trip. Looking back, although it was stressful at the time, it turned into a strangely memorable ~~adventure~~ **escapade**. It taught me to pay more attention to my surroundings and always ~~carry~~ memorise a ~~paper map or at least memorise~~ few key landmarks. Honestly, getting lost made me a more careful traveller.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you usually rely on your phone for directions? Yes, far too much, if I am honest. Since that day, though, I always make sure my phone is charged, and I try to notice a couple of landmarks wherever I go.

Have you been back to Chattogram since then? Once, for work, to attend an education fair. This time I stayed close to the venue, but I did recognise the lane where the kind shopkeeper had helped me, which made me smile.

Part 3 link: Travel & Tourism · Smartphones & Devices

103. Describe a time you celebrated a special occasion

Experiences · your card 18 · sp2_experiences_18 · 272 words (yours: 160)

- what the occasion was
- who you celebrated with
- what you did
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to describe a celebration that my whole family still talks about. A special occasion I celebrated with real joy was my parents' wedding anniversary, which ~~the whole family~~ my sisters and I organised as a surprise last year. We had been planning it secretly for weeks, which made the anticipation even more exciting, and keeping it from my mother was not easy, because she notices everything. My elder sister came from Dhaka with her husband and their two children, and my grandparents travelled in from the village. We decorated the house, invited close relatives and arranged all their favourite food, including the biryani my father loves. My younger sister was in charge of the cake, and I handled the guest list. The look of genuine surprise and delight on my parents' faces was absolutely **priceless**. It was a wonderfully **heartwarming** evening, full of laughter, old stories and a few happy tears. My grandmother even told us how my parents first met, which none of us had heard before. What made it so special was seeing the whole family come together to honour them. In our increasingly busy lives, these gatherings feel ~~increasingly rare~~ **few and far between**, and so all the more precious. My four-year-old nephew kept trying to blow out the candles before anyone else, which had everyone in fits of laughter. I remember feeling an overwhelming sense of gratitude and love that evening. Honestly, occasions like this remind me of what truly matters. The whole event was thoroughly ~~memorable~~ **unforgettable**, and I think it meant just as much to us as it did to my parents. It is a night I will always **treasure**.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you often celebrate special occasions with your family? Yes, especially Eid, when everyone tries to be together. We are a close-knit family, so even smaller occasions like birthdays usually end with a big dinner at home.

What did your parents say about the surprise? My father was lost for words, which is rare for him. My mother cried a little and then immediately started worrying whether there was enough food for everyone, which made us all laugh.

Part 3 link: Festivals & Celebrations · Family & Relationships

104. Describe a time you had to wait for something

Experiences · your card 19 · sp2_experiences_19 · 259 words (yours: 162)

- what you were waiting for
- how long you waited
- what you did while waiting
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about a wait that felt far longer than it really was. A time I had to wait anxiously was for the results of an important exam, which took several weeks to arrive. It was my HSC exam, the final exam at the end of college, and my university plans depended on it. That waiting period was genuinely **agonising**, because so much depended on the outcome, and there was absolutely nothing I could do to change it. I waited about two months in total. Every day felt longer than the last, and I found myself constantly checking for updates. To distract myself, I tried to stay busy with hobbies and spending time with friends, which helped a little. I read a lot of novels, played cricket in the evenings and took long walks by the river with my father. Still, the **suspense** was always there, **lurking** in the back of my mind. I remember trying to prepare myself mentally for both possible outcomes, which was difficult. On the day they were published online, my whole family crowded round the computer with me. When the results finally came and turned out to be positive, the relief was **immense**, and my mother immediately handed out sweets to the neighbours. What that experience taught me was how to cope with uncertainty, which is a genuinely useful skill. Honestly, learning to **sit with that discomfort** rather than let it consume me was ~~valuable~~ invaluable. I now handle waiting far better than I used to, knowing that worrying rarely changes the result.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Are you usually a patient person? More than I used to be. I can wait calmly for most things now, but I still find traffic jams and slow internet surprisingly hard to tolerate, so there is room for improvement.

What do you usually do while waiting for something? I normally read. I always keep a book or an e-book on my phone, so if I am stuck waiting somewhere, the time passes far more pleasantly and I don't feel it is wasted.

Part 3 link: Education Systems · Happiness & Wellbeing

105. Describe a time you made a promise to someone

Experiences · your card 20 · sp2_experiences_20 · 269 words (yours: 160)

- who you made the promise to
- what you promised
- whether you kept it
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about a promise I made to my younger sister, who means a great deal to me. A promise I made and worked hard to keep was ~~to my younger sister~~, when I assured her I would help her prepare for her exams. It was about a year ago, before her HSC exams, and she was

struggling with accounting, which happens to be one of my stronger subjects from my BBA. At the time I was extremely busy at work, so it was a fairly bold commitment. She was quite anxious and had started to lose confidence, which worried all of us. As the weeks went on, keeping that promise became genuinely **challenging demanding**, because my own workload kept **piling up**. There were evenings when I was exhausted and tempted to cancel, but I felt a strong sense of **obligation** not to let her down. So I pushed through, spending several evenings a week going over her subjects with her at the dining table after dinner. I also made her a simple timetable so she could see her progress week by week. My mother kept us going with endless cups of tea. When she eventually did well, the pride I felt was **immense**, and our bond grew even stronger. Keeping that promise meant missing a few cricket matches with friends, but I never regretted it for a moment. What I learned was that keeping a promise, especially an inconvenient one, is a real measure of **character**. Honestly, seeing how much my help meant to her made every tiring evening worthwhile. It reinforced my belief that your word should always mean something.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you think it is important to keep promises? Absolutely. If you break promises often, people stop trusting you, and that trust is very hard to win back. So I try not to promise anything unless I am sure I can deliver.

Does your sister still ask you for help with her studies? Sometimes, but less and less. She is at university now and very hard-working, so these days she is more likely to correct my mistakes than ask me to explain anything.

Part 3 link: Trust & Honesty · Family & Relationships

106. Describe a time you were pleasantly surprised

Experiences · your card 21 · sp2_experiences_21 · 263 words (yours: 157)

- what happened
- when it happened
- why it surprised you
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about a birthday that started badly and ended as one of my favourite days. A time I was pleasantly surprised was on my birthday a couple of years ago, when I was convinced everyone had forgotten. It was a working day, nobody at the office said a word, and even my family seemed unusually quiet at breakfast. The day had passed quietly, and honestly I felt a little **dejected**, assuming no one had remembered. When I got home in the evening, tired and expecting ~~an empty flat~~, a quiet dinner, my friends and family jumped out and surprised me with a party. I was completely **taken aback**; I genuinely had no idea they had been planning it. It turned out my younger sister had organised the whole thing and had sworn everyone to secrecy. My friends had apparently been hiding in my room for almost an hour. The whole thing was wonderfully **thoughtful**, with my favourite food, decorations and even a homemade cake. What moved me most was realising how much effort they had gone to in secret. That moment turned a gloomy day into one of the happiest I can remember, and I felt a real lump in my throat. What surprised me most was how convincingly everyone had **kept a straight face** all day. Honestly, the surprise meant far more to me than any expensive gift could have. Even my grandparents called from the village later that night to wish me well. It was a powerful reminder of how **fortunate** I am to have such caring people in my life.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you like surprises in general? Pleasant ones, yes. I am not keen on surprises at work, like a sudden deadline, but a surprise like that party is wonderful, because it shows someone was thinking about you.

Have you ever organised a surprise for someone else? Yes, for my father when he retired. I gathered his old friends and relatives for a small celebration, and seeing his face was worth all the secret planning.

Part 3 link: Friendship · Happiness & Wellbeing

107. Describe a time you had a disagreement with someone

Experiences · your card 22 · sp2_experiences_22 · 258 words (yours: 160)

- who it was with
- what the disagreement was about
- how it was resolved
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about a disagreement with one of my closest friends, Rafi, whom I have known since school. A disagreement that I remember clearly was with ~~a close friend~~ him over how to handle a shared responsibility during a group trip to Sylhet last year. The two of us were in charge of the money and the plans, but we had quite different ideas about budgeting and planning, and the discussion became rather **heated**. We are both quite stubborn, and for a moment it felt as if the whole trip might be spoiled. He wanted to book comfortable hotels and see as much as possible, while I wanted to keep costs down so everyone could afford it. At the time, I felt genuinely frustrated because I was sure my approach was more sensible. However, once we both calmed down, we realised the argument was largely down to poor communication. We sat down and each explained our reasoning properly, which helped enormously. In the end we reached a **compromise** that combined the best of both ideas: simple guesthouses, but a couple of special day trips. What I learned was the importance of listening rather than simply trying to win the argument. Honestly, resolving it **amicably** actually strengthened our friendship rather than damaging it. It taught me that disagreements are a normal part of any close relationship, and how you handle them matters far more than the disagreement itself. I now try to stay far more **open-minded** during such moments, and to **bite my tongue** before saying something I might regret.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you often disagree with your friends? Not often, and usually about small things like where to eat or which cricket team is better. Serious disagreements are rare, and when they happen, we try to talk them through calmly.

How did the trip go in the end? It went really well. The guesthouses were simple but clean, and the day trip to the tea gardens was the highlight. Rafi even admitted that my budget left us more money for good food.

Part 3 link: Conflict & Mediation · Friendship

108. Describe a time you saw something interesting in the sky

Experiences · your card 23 · sp2_experiences_23 · 265 words (yours: 162)

- what it was
- when you saw it
- who you were with
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to describe something I saw in the night sky a few years ago, which I still think about. Something genuinely interesting I once saw in the sky was a spectacular meteor shower during a ~~trip to~~ stay at my grandparents' home in our ancestral village. The ~~countryside. I was staying somewhere~~ village is far from ~~the~~ any city lights, which made the night sky incredibly clear. ~~A~~

~~friend~~ My cousin, who follows these things online, told me the shower was expected, so a group of us, including my younger sister, stayed up late and lay on a mat in the ~~grass~~ courtyard to watch. It was a cool, clear night in December, just after the rice harvest. When the first streaks of light shot across the sky, we were all completely **mesmerised**. It was a genuinely **awe-inspiring** sight, and the sheer scale of the universe suddenly felt very real. We lay there for over an hour, gasping each time a bright meteor appeared. Even my grandfather came out to join us for a while and told us about the stars he used to navigate by as a young man. What made it so special was the shared sense of wonder among us. Some of the younger cousins fell asleep on the mat, but I stayed awake until the very end. Honestly, in ~~the-city~~ towns and cities we forget how **magnificent** the night sky can be. That experience left me feeling small in the best possible way, and it sparked a lasting fascination with astronomy. It is a memory I will always find genuinely **humbling**, and it made me appreciate the **unspoilt** darkness of the countryside.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you often look at the stars? Not as often as I would like. In Sirajganj there is a bit too much light at night, but whenever we visit the village, I make a point of stepping outside after dinner to look up.

Would you like to learn more about astronomy? Yes, I would. I have started reading about it a little, and one day I would love to look through a proper telescope and see the rings of Saturn with my own eyes.

Part 3 link: Urban Development · Pollution

109. Describe a time technology helped you solve a problem

Experiences · your card 24 · sp2_experiences_24 · 269 words (yours: 162)

- what the problem was
- what technology you used
- how it helped
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about a time technology got me out of a tricky situation abroad. A time technology genuinely saved me was when I was travelling ~~abroad~~ in Nepal with two friends and struggled with a serious language barrier. It was my first proper trip abroad, so I was already slightly on edge. We had just arrived in Kathmandu late in the evening, and I found myself unable to communicate with a taxi driver, which was becoming quite ~~stressful~~ **nerve-racking**. He spoke almost no English, and our few words of Nepali were not enough to explain where our guesthouse was. Then I remembered a translation app on my phone, which turned out to be a **lifesaver**. I simply typed what I wanted to say, and it translated it instantly, allowing us to understand each other. It even read the sentence out loud, and the driver laughed and nodded. It felt almost **miraculous** that a small device could bridge such a gap so easily. What impressed me most was how **seamless** and quick the whole process was. Without it, I honestly do not know how I would have managed. The experience really opened my eyes to how **indispensable** technology has become in daily life. While I sometimes worry that we rely on it too heavily, moments like that remind me of its genuine value. It turned a potentially frustrating situation into a smooth one, and I was extremely grateful for it. In the end we reached the guesthouse safely, and the driver even recommended a good place for breakfast. We ended up using that app for the rest of the trip.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you use translation apps in your daily life? Occasionally at work, when a student sends me a document in a language I don't know. But for English I prefer to rely on myself, because I want to keep improving my own skills.

Do you think technology makes travelling easier? Definitely. Maps, booking apps and translation tools remove a lot of the stress. The only downside is that people sometimes stare at their screens instead of enjoying where they are.

Part 3 link: Smartphones & Devices · Artificial Intelligence

110. Describe a time you spent in nature

Experiences · your card 25 · sp2_experiences_25 · 266 words (yours: 162)

- where you were
- when it was
- what you did
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about a few days I spent deep in the Sundarbans, the huge mangrove forest in the south of Bangladesh. A time I spent immersed in nature that I remember fondly was a ~~camping~~ three-day boat trip ~~in a forest reserve~~ there with a few friends, about two winters ago. We had grown tired of ~~the city~~ busy streets and craved a proper escape into the wild. From the moment we arrived, the change was **striking**; the air was fresh, and the only sounds were birdsong, ~~and~~ rustling leaves and the water lapping against the boat. We spent the days ~~hiking~~, gliding along narrow channels, spotting deer, monkeys and even crocodiles on the muddy banks, although sadly no tigers. We slept in small cabins on the boat, and the crew cooked fresh fish for us every evening. Early one morning we walked along a wooden trail through the forest, and the silence was almost eerie. In the evenings we sat ~~around a fire~~ on the deck under a sky full of stars. Being so completely disconnected from screens was genuinely **refreshing**, almost like a reset for my mind, because there was hardly any phone signal. What I found most **rejuvenating** was the simple, slow pace of it all. There is something deeply **grounding** about being surrounded by nature with none of the usual distractions. Honestly, I returned home feeling calmer and more clear-headed than I had in months. The experience made me realise how much modern life disconnects us from the natural world, and how **restorative** it is to reconnect. I would love to go back one day and take my younger sister with me.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you often spend time in nature? Not as much as I'd like, but I do walk by the Jamuna most evenings. It is not a forest, of course, but watching the river and the open sky helps me unwind after work.

Were you worried about seeing a tiger? A little, to be honest, although the guides were very experienced and we mostly stayed on the boat. Part of me was actually disappointed not to catch even a glimpse of one.

Part 3 link: Wildlife & Conservation · Travel & Tourism

111. Describe a time you missed an important event

Experiences · your card 26 · sp2_experiences_26 · 264 words (yours: 169)

- what the event was
- why you missed it
- what happened
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about an event I still feel a little sad about missing. A time I sadly missed an important event was a close friend's wedding, which I had genuinely been looking forward to. He was one of my best friends from university, and the wedding was in Rajshahi about two years ago. Unfortunately, I ~~fell seriously ill~~ **came down with** a high fever just a day before and was simply too unwell to travel. It was supposed to be the first time our whole university group had

been together in years. I was absolutely **devastated**, because I had promised to be there and had even helped with some of the preparations. Lying at home while the celebration went on without me was deeply **frustrating**, especially when photos and videos kept arriving on my phone. I remember feeling guilty, even though the situation was entirely out of my control. My mother insisted I stay in bed, and of course she was right. My friend was incredibly understanding, which only made me feel worse about missing it. To make up for it, I visited them as soon as I recovered and gave them a **heartfelt** gift, a framed photo of our old university group. Honestly, the experience taught me how unpredictable life can be and how we cannot always control our circumstances. It also showed me the value of a **forgiving** friend. Although I still regret missing it, I have **made peace with** the fact that some things are simply beyond our control. My friend and his wife still joke that I owe them a dance.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you often go to weddings? Quite often, actually. Weddings in Bangladesh are big occasions, and between relatives, neighbours and friends, there always seems to be one coming up, especially in the winter season.

How did your friend react when you told him you couldn't come? He was very kind about it. He told me to rest and not to worry, and he even called me during the reception so I could say a few words to everyone.

Part 3 link: Friendship · Festivals & Celebrations

112. Describe a time you were proud of a family member

Experiences · your card 27 · sp2_experiences_27 · 259 words (yours: 160)

- who the person was
- what they did
- why it made you proud
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about my younger sister, who is probably the most hard-working person I know. A time I felt enormously proud of a family member was when ~~my younger sister graduated~~ she finished at the top of her ~~class after years of hard work~~ year in her HSC exams and received an award at her college's prize-giving ceremony last year. I had watched her study relentlessly for two years, often sacrificing her social life, so her success felt thoroughly **deserved** **well-deserved**. The whole family went to the ceremony, and my parents were dressed in their best clothes. In our family, education has always been treated as something precious, so this meant a great deal to my parents. Sitting in the audience, ~~during her graduation~~, I felt **a lump in my throat** as her name was called out for ~~a~~ the special award. It was a genuinely **emotional** moment for the whole family, and my mother could not stop wiping her eyes. What made me so proud was not just the achievement itself, but the **perseverance** and discipline she had shown to get there. I remembered all the times she had doubted herself and kept going anyway, sometimes studying until two in the morning. Honestly, seeing her hard work pay off so publicly was one of the most **uplifting** experiences I have had. Afterwards, we went out for sweets and tea, and she could not stop smiling. I told her ~~afterwards~~ how proud I was, and I meant every word. It was a powerful reminder that dedication truly does pay off in the end, and it made me want to push myself harder too.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you and your sister get on well? Very well. We tease each other constantly, as siblings do, but she is also the person I talk to when something is bothering me. She gives surprisingly wise advice for her age.

How did your family celebrate her success? We had a special dinner at home, and my mother cooked all her favourite dishes. My father also phoned my grandparents in the village, who were absolutely delighted to hear the news.

Part 3 link: Family & Relationships · Education Systems

113. Describe a time you spent money on something special

Experiences · your card 28 · sp2_experiences_28 · 260 words (yours: 164)

- what you bought
- why it was special
- how you saved for it
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about the first really expensive thing I ever bought for myself. A time I spent money on something genuinely special was when I bought my first proper laptop with money I had saved myself. It was during my second year at university, and I paid for it with the money I earned from private tuition, teaching two schoolchildren in the evenings. It took me months of careful budgeting, as it was a significant amount for me at the time. I had to be quite **frugal**, cutting back on unnecessary spending to reach my goal. I kept a small notebook where I wrote down every taka I saved. I stopped eating out, walked instead of taking rickshaws, and said no to a few trips with friends. When I finally had enough and walked into the shop to buy it, the feeling was incredibly **satisfying**. It was a mid-range model, nothing fancy, but to me it felt like the most valuable thing in the world. What made it so special was that I had earned it entirely through my own effort and patience, without asking my father for anything. It was not just a purchase; it felt like a genuine **accomplishment**. The laptop went on to become essential for my studies and work, so it turned out to be a wise investment too. Honestly, buying something you have saved hard for feels far more rewarding than a casual, **impulsive** purchase. That experience taught me the value of patience and **delayed gratification**, a lesson I still carry with me.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you still have that laptop? I do, although it is quite slow now. My younger sister used it for her studies for a while, and these days it mostly sits on my desk at home for watching cricket highlights.

Are you good at saving money now? Reasonably good, yes. I put a little aside every month, partly because I would like to study abroad one day, and that goal makes it much easier to resist unnecessary spending.

Part 3 link: Money & Wealth · Consumer Behaviour & Shopping

114. Describe a time you overcame a fear or challenge

Experiences · your card 29 · sp2_experiences_29 · 267 words (yours: 159)

- what the fear or challenge was
- when it happened
- how you overcame it
- and how you felt afterwards

I'd like to talk about a fear that followed me for most of my life. A significant fear I managed to overcome was my long-standing fear of water, which had followed me since childhood, when I slipped into a pond and swallowed a lot of water before someone pulled me out. Growing up beside the Jamuna, not being able to swim was both limiting and slightly embarrassing. For years I avoided swimming entirely, ~~which was both limiting and slightly embarrassing.~~ I would always find an excuse when my friends went to the river. Eventually, about two years ago, I decided enough was enough, and ~~signed up for adult swimming lessons.~~ my cousin in the village, who is a

strong swimmer, offered to teach me in the pond behind my grandparents' house. The first few sessions were genuinely **terrifying**, and I nearly gave up several times. My ~~instructor~~, cousin, however, was incredibly patient and encouraging, which made all the difference. Every weekend we travelled to the village, and he would stand beside me in the water, holding me up until I found my balance. Slowly but surely, my confidence began to grow, and I became less **petrified** of the deep ~~end~~ water. The moment I finally swam ~~a full length~~ from one side of the pond to the other unaided was absolutely **exhilarating**, and my grandfather clapped from the bank. Overcoming that fear gave me a huge sense of achievement that went far beyond swimming itself. Honestly, it taught me that most fears shrink once you **confront them directly head-on** rather than avoiding them. It was a genuinely **empowering** experience, and it made me braver about tackling other things I had been putting off out of fear.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you swim regularly now? Not regularly, but whenever we visit my grandparents in summer, I go into the pond with my cousins. I am still not a strong swimmer, but I am no longer afraid, which is what matters.

Do you think children should learn to swim? Absolutely, especially in a country with so many rivers and ponds like Bangladesh. It is a basic safety skill, and it is much easier to learn as a child than as an adult.

Part 3 link: Lifelong Learning · Hobbies & Leisure

115. Describe a time something made you very happy

Experiences · your card 30 · sp2_experiences_30 · 270 words (yours: 163)

- what happened
- when it happened
- who you were with
- and why it made you happy

I'd like to describe a day that made me happier than I had felt in a long time. A moment that filled me with genuine happiness was a spontaneous reunion with old friends I had not seen in years. We had all drifted apart after finishing our ~~studies~~, BBA, scattered by work and life, some in Dhaka, some in Chattogram and a couple abroad. Then, quite unexpectedly, one of them organised a get-together last winter, and almost everyone managed to come. I was so excited that I took the early morning bus from Sirajganj and arrived far too early. We met at a small restaurant near our old university campus in Dhaka. The moment we all saw each other again was absolutely **heartwarming**; it felt as though no time had passed at all. We spent hours **reminiscing**, laughing about old memories and catching up on each other's lives. We even walked past our old classrooms and the tea stall where we used to spend far too much time. What made it so special was the **effortless**, genuine warmth between us. In our busy adult lives, such **carefree** gatherings have become increasingly rare. I remember feeling completely content, surrounded by people who knew the real me. Honestly, that day reminded me how important old friendships are, and how easily we let them slip away. The whole reunion was thoroughly **joyful**, and it left me determined to make more effort to stay in touch. We stayed so long that the restaurant staff eventually had to ask us, very politely, to leave. Since then, we have tried to meet at least once a year.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you find it hard to stay in touch with old friends? Sometimes, yes. Everyone is busy with work and family now. But a quick message or a phone call now and then keeps the connection alive, even if we can't meet often.

What else usually makes you happy? Simple things, mostly. A good dinner with my family, a cricket match on television, or a quiet walk by the river in the evening. I don't think happiness needs to be complicated.

Part 3 link: Friendship · Happiness & Wellbeing

116. Describe a time you stayed calm in a difficult situation

Experiences · your card 31 · sp2_experiences_31 · 260 words (yours: 163)

- what the situation was
- when it happened
- how you stayed calm
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about a moment when I surprised myself by staying calm. A time I managed to stay calm under real pressure was during a minor emergency at a family gathering, when ~~an elderly relative~~ my grandfather suddenly felt faint. It happened last Eid at my grandparents' village home, where the whole family had gathered for lunch. It was a very hot afternoon, and he had been busy greeting guests all morning. There was an immediate sense of ~~panic~~ alarm among everyone, and the atmosphere quickly became **chaotic**, with people shouting advice from every direction. For some reason, I felt a strange sense of clarity and knew someone had to **take charge**. I calmly helped him sit down in the shade, brought water, and reassured everyone while we decided whether to call ~~for help~~ the local doctor. I also asked the children to step back and give him some air. My younger sister ran to fetch a hand fan, which helped a lot. Staying **composed** was not easy, because I love him dearly, but I knew that adding to the panic would only make things worse. Thankfully, he recovered within a few minutes, and ~~the situation~~ it turned out he was ~~far less serious than we feared~~, simply tired and dehydrated. Afterwards, several ~~people~~ relatives told me how **reassuring** my calmness had been, which surprised me. Honestly, I had not known I was capable of keeping such a level head. That experience taught me that staying **rational** in a crisis is a genuinely valuable ability, and it gave me more confidence in myself. My grandmother still mentions it whenever the family gets together.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Is your grandfather well now? Yes, thankfully. He is in his eighties but still remarkably sharp and active. Since that day, though, we make sure he rests more and drinks plenty of water, especially during the hot months.

Do you think staying calm can be learned? I think so, at least partly. Some people are naturally calmer, but practice and experience help a lot. The more difficult situations you face, the less likely you are to panic.

Part 3 link: Emotional Intelligence · Leadership

117. Describe a time you received help from someone

Experiences · your card 32 · sp2_experiences_32 · 263 words (yours: 160)

- who helped you
- what the situation was
- how they helped
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about someone who made a big difference to me when I first moved to Dhaka. A time I received invaluable help was when I was moving to ~~a new city for work~~ the capital to start university and felt completely overwhelmed by everything. I had never lived away from home before, and the size and noise of the city frightened me a ~~former colleague~~, little. I remember my mother packing enough food for a week, as if Dhaka had no restaurants. A senior student from

my hometown, who was already ~~lived there~~, in his third year, went out of his way to help me settle in. My father had got his number from a family friend, and he met me at the bus station on my very first day. He helped me find accommodation, showed me around, and introduced me to people, which was incredibly **generous** of him. He even taught me which buses to take and where to find cheap but decent food near campus. Without his support, those first few weeks would have been far more **daunting** and lonely. What struck me was that he expected absolutely nothing in return; his kindness was completely ~~genuine~~, **selfless**. I remember feeling deeply ~~grateful~~, **indebted** to him, especially since we had ~~not even been that close~~ barely known each other before. His help made an enormous difference to how quickly I adjusted. Honestly, the experience reminded me how much a small act of kindness can mean to someone in a vulnerable situation. It also inspired me to be equally **supportive** when I later saw ~~others~~ first-year students struggling to settle in. I still remember his generosity fondly.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Are you still in contact with him? Yes, we still message each other now and then. He works in Dhaka now, and whenever I visit my elder sister there, I try to meet him for a cup of tea.

Do you think people help each other more in small towns or big cities? In small towns, I think. People know each other, so helping feels natural. In big cities, people are kind too, but they are often too rushed to notice when someone is struggling.

Part 3 link: Urban Development · Friendship

118. Describe a time you taught something to someone

Experiences · your card 33 · sp2_experiences_33 · 257 words (yours: 163)

- what you taught
- who you taught
- how you taught it
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about the time I taught my mother to use a smartphone, which was more of a challenge than I expected. A time I taught something to someone was when I helped ~~my mother~~ her learn ~~to use a smartphone, which~~ the basics about two years ago, because she had always found smartphones intimidating. She was keen to stay in touch with ~~relatives abroad~~ my elder sister in Dhaka and see her grandchildren more often, but felt hopelessly lost with the technology. I decided to teach her step by step, and I quickly realised how much **patience** it required. I had to slow right down and explain things I **take completely for granted**, like swiping, typing a message or finding the camera. I wrote the steps in Bengali on a small card, which she kept beside her phone for months. There were moments of frustration on both sides, but she kept pressing the wrong buttons and then apologising, which made us both laugh. We persevered, usually with a cup of tea in the evenings. What made it so **rewarding** was watching her confidence grow, until she could video-call her grandchildren all by herself. Her delight was genuinely **touching**, and it made every patient hour worthwhile. Honestly, the experience taught me as much as it taught her; it made me far more **empathetic** towards people who struggle with technology. It reminded me that teaching is really about seeing things through someone else's eyes. Seeing how much it improved her daily life was deeply satisfying. Now she sends me more messages than anyone else I know.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you enjoy teaching people things? I do, as long as the person is keen to learn. In my job I explain application processes to students every day, so I suppose teaching has become a natural part of my life.

What else would you like to teach your mother? Maybe online banking, so she doesn't have to queue at the bank. She is a little nervous about using money on her phone, though, so I will take it very slowly.

Part 3 link: Generational Differences · Lifelong Learning

119. Describe a time you had an interesting conversation

Experiences · your card 34 · sp2_experiences_34 · 253 words (yours: 164)

- who you talked with
- what you talked about
- where it happened
- and why it was interesting

I'd like to describe a conversation with a complete stranger that I still think about. An interesting conversation I remember well was with an elderly ~~stranger~~ man I happened to sit next to during a long train journey from Dhaka back to Sirajganj. It was about a year ago, and the train was delayed, so we had plenty of time. What began as polite small talk gradually turned into a genuinely **fascinating** discussion. He was a retired schoolteacher who had lived through decades of enormous change and shared stories that were both moving and eye-opening. He told me how, before the Jamuna bridge was built, crossing the river meant a long and unpredictable ferry journey, sometimes taking half a day. I found his perspective on life incredibly **insightful**, shaped by experiences so different from my own. Time seemed to fly by as we talked about history, family and how much the world had changed. He was also curious about my work and asked me lots of questions about why so many young people want to study abroad. What made it so ~~memorable~~ **thought-provoking** was how open and ~~thoughtful~~ reflective he was with a complete stranger. By the end of the journey, I felt as though I had learned more than I would from any book. Honestly, that conversation reminded me how much wisdom ordinary people carry, if only we take the time to listen. It was a wonderfully **enriching** encounter, and it made me more willing to **strike up** conversations with people I do not know.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you often talk to strangers? More than I used to. On trains and buses I sometimes start a conversation if the other person seems friendly. Not everyone wants to chat, of course, so I try to read the situation first.

Who do you usually enjoy talking to the most? My grandfather, probably. He has a story for everything and a very dry sense of humour. Whenever we visit the village, I end up sitting with him for hours.

Part 3 link: Generational Differences · Digital Communication

120. Describe a time you took a risk

Experiences · your card 35 · sp2_experiences_35 · 264 words (yours: 163)

- what the risk was
- why you took it
- what happened
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about the biggest professional risk I have taken so far. A significant risk I once took was leaving a secure position to join a small, unproven ~~start-up~~ education consultancy that had only just opened. I had been working in the accounts office of a large company for a few months after my BBA, which was safe but, honestly, quite dull. It was a genuinely **daunting** decision, because the new company had no guarantee of success and I was giving up stability. Everyone around me thought I was being **reckless**, which made me doubt myself at times. My mother kept

asking whether I was sure, almost every evening at dinner. However, I felt a strong pull towards the opportunity, because I genuinely wanted to help students study abroad, and I decided to trust my instincts. The early months were certainly **turbulent**; we had very few clients, and there were moments when I feared I had made a terrible mistake. Gradually, though, the company **found its feet**, and the experience turned out to be one of the most rewarding of my career so far. What I gained in skills and confidence was **immeasurable**. Honestly, taking that leap taught me that calculated risks are sometimes necessary for real growth. It reinforced my belief that playing it safe is not always the wisest choice. Looking back, I am genuinely glad I was **brave** bold enough to ~~be so bold~~, follow my instincts, and I feel a quiet pride whenever I see how far the company has come. Today it is a busy office with a steady stream of students.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Are you generally someone who likes taking risks? Not really. I am quite careful by nature, and I like to think things through. But I have learned that a well-considered risk can be worth taking, especially when you are young.

How did your parents feel about the risk? They were worried at first, naturally. My father, having run his own business for over thirty years, understood the idea of starting small, and his support gave me a lot of confidence.

Part 3 link: Career Choices · Success & Ambition

121. Describe a time you got up very early

Experiences · your card 36 · sp2_experiences_36 · 256 words (yours: 164)

- when it was
- why you got up early
- what you did
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about a morning when I got up far earlier than I ever normally would. A time I got up unusually early was to watch the sunrise from a hilltop during a short trip to Bandarban with friends, about two years ago. We had to wake at around four in the morning, which was genuinely **brutal**, especially as none of us are naturally early risers. The reason was simple: people had told us that the sunrise over the hills, with clouds drifting below you, was something you had to see at least once. Half asleep, we made the climb in the dark, questioning why we had agreed to it, with only our phone torches to guide us. Our guesthouse owner had kindly woken us with hot tea before we set off. It was surprisingly cold, and I remember wishing I had brought a thicker jacket. But the moment the sun began to rise over the horizon, all the tiredness **melted away**. The view was absolutely **breathtaking**, with the sky shifting through shades of orange and pink, and a sea of clouds stretching out beneath us. It was a genuinely **serene** moment, and we stood there in near silence, simply taking it in. What made it so worthwhile was that we had earned that view through real effort. Honestly, that early start turned out to be **one of the most memorable experiences crowning moment** of the whole trip. It taught me that sometimes the best moments require sacrificing a bit of comfort, and I would happily do it again.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Are you usually an early riser? Not naturally. On working days I get up around seven, which is early enough for me. At the weekend I try to sleep in a little, although the call to prayer usually wakes me anyway.

Do you think getting up early is good for people? For many people, yes. The morning is quiet and you can get a lot done before the day becomes busy. But I think it depends on the person, since some people genuinely work better at night.

Part 3 link: Travel & Tourism · Hobbies & Leisure

122. Describe a time you failed at something and learned from it

Experiences · your card 37 · sp2_experiences_37 · 258 words (yours: 163)

- what you failed at
- when it happened
- why you failed
- and what you learned

I'd like to talk about a failure that I am actually quite grateful for now. A failure that ultimately taught me a great deal was when I performed poorly in an important exam early in my studies. It was a financial accounting exam in the first year of my BBA, and I came very close to failing it. I had been **overconfident** and had not prepared nearly as thoroughly as I should have. I had done well at college, so I assumed university would be just as easy, and I spent far too much time with friends. My classmates were surprised, because I had always seemed so relaxed about studying. When the results came out, I was genuinely **disappointed in myself**, **crestfallen**, and it was a humbling experience. I remember phoning my father and struggling to tell him. At first I felt quite **demoralised**, but after some reflection I realised the failure was entirely my own doing. Rather than dwelling on it, I decided to treat it as a **wake-up call**. I completely changed my study habits, becoming far more **disciplined** and organised, and I started reviewing my notes every evening instead of cramming at the last minute. The next time around, my results improved dramatically, which proved the lesson had sunk in. Honestly, that early failure was one of the most **instructive** experiences of my life. It taught me that setbacks are not the end of the world but valuable opportunities to grow. I now genuinely believe that how you respond to failure matters far more than the failure itself.

Rounding-off questions (new)

How did your father react when you told him? Much more calmly than I expected. He told me that his business had failed more than once in the early years, and that what matters is getting back up. That conversation really helped.

Do you think failure is important for young people? Yes, in small doses. Failing early, when the stakes are low, teaches you humility and resilience. People who never fail can struggle badly when something finally goes wrong later in life.

Part 3 link: Education Systems · Success & Ambition

123. Describe a time you were excited about an upcoming event

Experiences · your card 38 · sp2_experiences_38 · 258 words (yours: 157)

- what the event was
- when it was
- why you were excited
- and how you felt when it happened

I'd like to describe the build-up to my first trip abroad, because I don't think I have ever been so excited. An event I was intensely excited about was a long-planned holiday **abroad**, to Nepal, my first proper trip outside **the country**, Bangladesh. It was last winter, and I was going with two close friends from university after we had been saving for almost a year. For weeks beforehand I was almost unable to think about anything else, and the **anticipation** was overwhelming. I spent hours researching places to visit and imagining what it would be like to see the Himalayas with my own eyes. Helping students travel abroad is my job, but this time it was finally my turn, which made it even more special. The night before departure I was so **restless** that I barely slept, and I

checked my passport at least five times. My younger sister made me promise to bring her back a souvenir. When the day finally arrived and the plane took off, I felt a rush of pure **exhilaration**. The trip itself lived up to every expectation, filled with new sights, foods and experiences, especially the view of snow-capped mountains from Pokhara. What made the excitement so special was that it was building towards something I had dreamed about for years. Honestly, the joy of looking forward to it was almost as good as the trip itself. That experience taught me that anticipation is a wonderful part of any adventure. It remains one of the most **memorable** **unforgettable** and genuinely **thrilling** experiences of my life.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Where would you like to travel next? I'd love to visit somewhere in Europe, perhaps the UK, since so many of my students go there. Ideally I would go as a student myself, which is something I really hope to do one day.

Do you enjoy planning trips? Very much. Reading about a place, choosing where to stay and making a rough plan is half the fun for me. My friends usually leave the planning to me, which I don't mind at all.

Part 3 link: Travel & Tourism · Happiness & Wellbeing

124. Describe a special meal you had

Experiences · your card 39 · sp2_experiences_39 · 267 words (yours: 161)

- what the meal was
- where you had it
- who you were with
- and why it was special

I'd like to talk about a meal that, for me, sums up what Eid is really about. A special meal that stands out in my memory was a large family feast during Eid last year, prepared **entirely** mostly by my mother and grandmother. We celebrated at my grandparents' home in our ancestral village, and the whole extended family gathered **at our home**, there, which is increasingly rare these days. My elder sister came from Dhaka with her husband and children, and my uncles and cousins came too. My job was to help my grandfather greet the guests and make sure everyone had a seat. The table was **laden with** traditional dishes, like beef curry, chicken roast, polao and several kinds of sweets, and the aromas alone were **mouthwatering**. What made the meal so special was not just the food, though it was absolutely delicious, but the sense of togetherness. We spent hours eating, talking and laughing, with several generations gathered around one table, from my grandfather in his eighties to my four-year-old nephew. There is something deeply **comforting** about a home-cooked meal shared with people you love. In our busy lives, such **unhurried** gatherings feel genuinely precious. I remember feeling completely content, surrounded by family and good food. After lunch, the older men sat in the courtyard drinking tea while the children played. Honestly, meals like that are about far more than eating; they are about connection and belonging. It is a **treasured** memory, and it reminds me that the best meals are the ones shared with the people who matter most. I am already looking forward to the next Eid.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Can you cook any of those dishes yourself? Only a simple chicken curry, I am afraid. The Eid dishes take real skill and a lot of time, so I leave them to my mother and grandmother and happily do the washing up instead.

Do you prefer eating at home or in restaurants? At home, definitely. Restaurants are nice for a change, but nothing compares to my mother's cooking, and eating together at home feels far more relaxed and personal.

125. Describe a time you visited a place for the first time

Experiences · your card 40 · sp2_experiences_40 · 252 words (yours: 161)

- where you went
- when you went
- what you did there
- and how you felt about it

A I'd like to talk about my first visit ~~that~~ to Dhaka, which made a lasting impression on me. A first visit that I still remember vividly was my trip to the capital ~~city~~, when I was about seventeen, which ~~I had never seen despite living in the country all my life~~ was surprising since it is only a few hours from Sirajganj by road. I went there with my father for a short admission coaching course, and everything about it felt new and slightly **overwhelming** at first. The city was enormous, fast-paced and far busier than my quiet hometown, with endless traffic, crowds and noise. We stayed with a relative in Mirpur, and I remember standing on the roof at night, amazed by how many lights there were. Once I got my bearings, though, I found it genuinely **exhilarating**. I spent my free time exploring historical sites, markets and museums, soaking it all in, often with a cousin who lived there as my guide. I especially loved the old part of the city, with its narrow lanes, rickshaws and centuries-old buildings. What struck me most was the sheer diversity of people and experiences packed into one place. I found the whole experience thoroughly **eye-opening**, and it **broadened my perspective horizons** considerably. Honestly, visiting somewhere completely unfamiliar reminded me how much there is to discover beyond your own small world. Although it was a little daunting at times, I came away feeling more **confident self-assured** and independent. It made me eager to explore even more new places, and a couple of years later I went back there to study.

Rounding-off questions (new)

How often do you go to Dhaka now? Fairly often, maybe once every month or two. My elder sister lives there with her family, and I also go for work sometimes, to attend education fairs or meet university representatives.

Would you prefer to live in Dhaka or in your hometown? My hometown, at least for now. Dhaka has more opportunities, but it is exhausting and crowded. In Sirajganj life is calmer, and I can walk by the river whenever I like.

Part 3 link: Urban Development · Travel & Tourism

126. Describe a time you did something to make someone happy

Experiences · your card 41 · sp2_experiences_41 · 252 words (yours: 165)

- who you did it for
- what you did
- why you did it
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about something I did for my father, who has always put his family first. A time I went out of my way to make someone happy was when I organised a small surprise for ~~my father~~ him on his retirement last year. He had ~~worked hard~~ run a small business for ~~decades~~, over thirty years, often putting the family's needs before his own, so I wanted to do something meaningful. He is quite a modest man, and I knew he would never ask for any kind of celebration himself. With help from my mother and sisters, I secretly gathered old friends, relatives and ~~relatives~~ a few of his long-time customers, and arranged a modest gathering at home to honour him. My

mother cooked his favourite dishes, and my younger sister made a small album of old photos from his shop. The look of genuine surprise and joy on his face was absolutely **priceless**. He was clearly **touched** that so many people had come to celebrate him, and at one point his voice broke as he thanked everyone. What made it so special was seeing someone who rarely asks for anything finally being appreciated. Honestly, the whole thing was as rewarding for me as it was for him. There is a unique kind of happiness that comes from making someone else feel **valued**. It reminded me that thoughtful gestures often mean far more than expensive gifts. Seeing him so **content at peace** that evening is a memory I will always **treasure**, and it deepened our bond.

Rounding-off questions (new)

How does your father spend his time now that he has retired? He reads the newspaper for hours, visits his friends at the local tea stall and spends a lot of time in the village with my grandparents. He seems more relaxed than I have ever seen him.

Do you often do things to make your family happy? I try to. Usually it is small things, like bringing home sweets or taking my mother to visit her parents. I think those little gestures matter more than big occasions.

Part 3 link: Family & Relationships · Happiness & Wellbeing

127. Describe a time you reached an agreement after a disagreement

Experiences · your card 42 · sp2_experiences_42 · 259 words (yours: 162)

- who it was with
- what the issue was
- how you reached agreement
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about a disagreement during my BBA that ended far better than I expected. A time I reached a hard-won agreement was during a group project when **two of us** a classmate and I had fundamentally different visions for the final result. We were designing a business plan for a small café, and I wanted to focus on low prices for students, while he wanted a more upmarket place with a stylish design. Initially, neither of us was willing to **budge**, and the disagreement threatened to **derail** the entire project. The tension was uncomfortable, and progress **ground to a halt**, which was frustrating for the rest of the group. Eventually I suggested we step back and actually listen to each other's reasoning properly, so we met one evening over tea to talk it through. The rest of the group were clearly relieved to see us talking calmly again. Once we did, I realised his idea had genuine merit that I had dismissed too quickly. Through calm discussion, we managed to blend both approaches into something better than either original plan: **affordable food in a comfortable, attractive setting**. Reaching that **compromise** required real humility on both sides, but it was worth it. What I learned was that being stubborn rarely helps, whereas being flexible often leads to a superior outcome. Honestly, the final result was far stronger for having combined our ideas, and I felt relieved and quite proud. It taught me that the best solutions often emerge from disagreement, provided both people are willing to be **reasonable level-headed** and open-minded.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Are you still friends with that classmate? Yes, we actually became good friends after that project. He now works for a bank in Dhaka, and we still joke about our imaginary café whenever we meet up.

Do you find it easy to change your mind? Easier than I used to. When someone gives me a good reason, I am happy to change my view. What I find harder is admitting it straight away, but I am working on that.

128. Describe a time you were impressed by something

Experiences · your card 43 · sp2_experiences_43 · 258 words (yours: 162)

- what impressed you
- when it happened
- why it impressed you
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about a performance that completely changed how I think about music. A time I was genuinely impressed was when I ~~watched~~ went to a ~~live orchestra perform for the first time~~. large classical music festival in Dhaka with my elder sister and her husband a few years ago. I had always enjoyed music, but I had never experienced anything on that scale in person. The festival ran through the night in a huge open-air venue, with thousands of people sitting on the ground and listening in near silence. We had brought a thin mat and a flask of tea, like most of the people around us. From the moment the performance began, I was completely **captivated**. The sheer ~~coordination~~ skill of ~~dozens of~~ the musicians, ~~playing~~ a sitar player and a tabla player responding to each other in perfect harmony, was absolutely **remarkable**. What impressed me most was the emotion they managed to convey purely through their instruments, with no words at all. The sound ~~in the concert hall~~ was so rich and powerful that I felt it **resonate** in my chest. It was a genuinely **mesmerising** experience, quite unlike listening to a recording on my phone. I came away with a whole new appreciation for the years of discipline behind such a performance, since musicians like that often train from childhood. Honestly, it left me feeling deeply **moved**, and it reminded me of the extraordinary things humans can achieve through dedication. By the time we left, the sun was coming up, and ~~teamwork~~. I was tired but completely inspired. I have been eager to attend more live performances ever since.

Rounding-off questions (new)

What kind of music do you usually listen to? Mostly Bengali songs, both old classics and some modern bands, and a bit of English pop. I listen while walking by the river in the evening, which is probably my favourite time for music.

Have you ever wanted to learn a musical instrument? Yes, the tabla, after that festival. I never actually started, though, because I didn't have the time. Perhaps one day, when life is a little less busy, I will finally give it a try.

Part 3 link: Music & the Arts · Traditions & Customs

129. Describe an adventurous thing you have done

Experiences · your card 44 · sp2_experiences_44 · 263 words (yours: 168)

- what you did
- when you did it
- who you were with
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about the most adventurous thing I have ever done, which was a trek in the hills of Bandarban. An adventurous thing I did that pushed me well outside my comfort zone was going on a fairly challenging trek ~~through hilly terrain~~ to Keokradong, one of the highest peaks in Bangladesh, with a group of four friends from university. It was about two years ago, in the dry season, when the paths are safer. I am not the most outdoorsy person, so agreeing to it was already a stretch for me. The trail was steep and **gruelling** in places, and at several points I genuinely wondered whether I could make it. My legs ached and my lungs burned, but my friends kept ~~encouraging~~ **egging me on**. We stopped in small villages along the way, where local people

offered us water and bananas, which was incredibly kind. We spent the night in a simple guesthouse beside a lake on the way. Reaching the summit after hours of effort was absolutely **exhilarating**, and the **panoramic** view of endless green hills was more than worth it. What made it so rewarding was proving to myself that I was tougher than I had believed. Honestly, I surprised myself with how much I enjoyed the challenge, despite the discomfort. That experience gave me a real taste for adventure and a newfound confidence in my own **resilience**. It taught me that stepping outside your comfort zone, while difficult, is often where the most memorable experiences are found. My mother, of course, was relieved to see me home in one piece.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Would you do something like that again? Yes, I think so, although I would train a bit beforehand this time. My friends have been talking about a trek in Nepal, and I would love to join them if work allows.

Do you think young people today are adventurous enough? Some are very adventurous, but many spend most of their free time on screens. I think a little adventure, even something small, builds confidence in a way that nothing online can.

Part 3 link: Travel & Tourism · Hobbies & Leisure

130. Describe a time you kept trying although it was difficult

Experiences · your card 45 · sp2_experiences_45 · 255 words (yours: 164)

- what you were trying to do
- why it was difficult
- how you kept going
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about learning to drive, which tested my patience more than almost anything else. A time I had to keep pushing through real difficulty was while learning to drive about two years ago, which I found far harder than I had expected. I wanted to learn because my father had recently retired and was no longer comfortable driving long distances, so someone in the family needed to take the car to the village. The roads here are full of rickshaws, buses and people crossing without warning, so even a short drive felt stressful. I struggled with confidence behind the wheel and failed my first test, which was genuinely **disheartening**. Part of me was tempted to give up entirely and rely on ~~public transport~~ buses and rickshaws instead. However, I knew driving would be a valuable skill, so I forced myself to **persevere**. I booked more lessons, practised **regularly** early in the mornings when the roads were quiet and slowly **chipped away at** my nervousness. Progress was frustratingly slow at times, and it required a lot of **patience**. When I finally passed on my second attempt, the sense of accomplishment was immense, precisely because it had not come easily. Honestly, that experience taught me the value of **persistence** more than almost anything else. It proved that giving up at the first setback would have cost me a skill I now use ~~every day~~ regularly. My grandparents are always delighted when I drive my parents to visit them, and I have carried that lesson into other challenges ever since.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you enjoy driving now? On quiet roads, yes, especially the drive to my grandparents' village, which passes through lovely green fields. In busy town traffic, though, I still find it more tiring than enjoyable.

Do you think it is important for young people to learn to drive? It is useful, but not essential for everyone. In big cities, public transport or ride-sharing can be easier. In smaller towns, though, being able to drive gives you a lot more independence.

Part 3 link: Lifelong Learning · Transportation

131. Describe a gift you received that was important to you

Objects · your card 1 · sp2_objects_01 · 269 words (yours: 167)

- what it was
- who gave it to you
- when you received it
- and why it was important

I'd like to talk about something small that I keep on my desk at home. A gift that means a great deal to me is a fountain pen my father gave me when I finished my studies. That was when I completed my BBA, just before I started my job at an education consultancy. It is not particularly expensive, but its **sentimental** value is enormous. It has a dark blue body with a thin silver clip, and it writes beautifully. He handed it to me with a short note saying he hoped I would use it to sign many important documents in my career. I remember reading the note twice with a **lump in my throat**. What made it so special was the **thoughtfulness** behind it, rather than the object itself. My father ran a small business for over thirty years, and I think he knew better than anyone how much a signature can carry. My father is not a man of many words, so this gesture was genuinely **touching**. I keep it safely on my desk and use it only on special occasions. In fact, I used it to sign my first employment contract, which felt like keeping a small promise to him. Every time I hold it, I am reminded of his quiet faith in me. Honestly, it is the kind of gift that grows more **precious** with time. I think the best presents are those that carry meaning and memory, not just a high price tag. This pen is something I intend to keep for the rest of my life and perhaps pass on one day.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you still use the pen? Yes, but only for important things, like signing contracts or writing Eid cards. I'm quite careful with it, because refilling a fountain pen and cleaning it properly takes a bit of patience.

Have you ever given your father a gift like that? Not quite like that, but when he retired, my sisters and I gave him a good-quality watch. He insisted it was unnecessary, but he has worn it every single day since.

Part 3 link: Consumer Behaviour & Shopping · Family & Relationships

132. Describe a gift you gave to someone

Objects · your card 2 · sp2_objects_02 · 286 words (yours: 163)

- what it was
- who you gave it to
- why you chose it
- and how they reacted

I'd like to describe a present I made for someone rather than bought, because it is the one I'm proudest of. A gift I was particularly pleased with was a photo album I put together for my mother's birthday. My mother has spent her whole life looking after all of us, and I felt she deserved something that celebrated that. Rather than buying something generic, I wanted to give her something genuinely **meaningful**. I chose an album because I knew she would never ask for anything for herself, and memories matter far more to her than possessions. I spent weeks gathering old family photographs and arranging them chronologically, adding little notes beside each one. Some of them I found in a dusty trunk at my grandparents' village home, including a faded picture of her wedding day, and my elder sister secretly sent me a few from Dhaka as well. It was surprisingly time-consuming, but the effort felt worthwhile. When she opened it, her reaction was absolutely **priceless**; she was moved to tears as she flicked through the memories. She kept stopping at certain pages to tell us the story behind each picture, and we

ended up sitting around the dining table for hours. What made it so special was that it cost very little money but a great deal of ~~thought~~ care. She told me it was the most **heartfelt** gift she had ever received, which **meant the world to me**. Honestly, seeing her so **delighted** was far more rewarding than giving an expensive present ever could be. That experience confirmed my belief that the best gifts are personal ones that show you truly know the person. It is something she still treasures and shows to visitors.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you enjoy choosing gifts for people? Yes, very much, although it takes me a long time. I like noticing what people mention in passing, so that the gift feels **personalised** rather than something picked up at the last minute.

Would you make a homemade gift again? Definitely. I'm actually planning one for my grandparents, a small booklet of old family stories and photos, because I think they would value that far more than anything from a shop.

Part 3 link: Family & Relationships · Consumer Behaviour & Shopping

133. Describe a useful object in your home

Objects · your card 3 · sp2_objects_03 · 257 words (yours: 166)

- what it is
- how you use it
- how often you use it
- and why it is useful

I'd like to talk about something very ordinary that sits on our kitchen counter. A genuinely useful object in my home is my electric kettle, which I honestly could not do without. It is a simple steel one that my younger sister and I bought for the family a couple of years ago. It might sound trivial, but as someone who drinks tea several times a day, it is completely **indispensable**. I use it mainly to boil water for tea, but my mother also uses it when she needs hot water for cooking, and my sister makes instant noodles with it during late-night study sessions. I use it first thing in the morning, throughout the day, and last thing at night. On a typical day it must be switched on six or seven times, especially when guests drop by, which happens a lot in our household. What makes it so useful is how quickly and efficiently it boils water, saving me a lot of time. Before I had it, using the stove felt slow and **cumbersome** by comparison. It is also wonderfully **convenient**, with an automatic switch-off that means I never have to watch it. ~~I use it first thing in the morning, throughout the day, and last thing at night.~~ Such a simple **appliance** has become woven into my daily routine without my even noticing. Honestly, it is a perfect example of how the most ordinary objects are often the most useful. I think we tend to overlook these everyday items, yet they quietly make life far more **manageable**. If it broke tomorrow, I would replace it immediately without a second thought.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Who else in your family uses the kettle? Pretty much everyone. My mother uses it while cooking, my younger sister relies on it during late-night study sessions, and my father makes his afternoon tea with it now that he's retired.

Is there anything about it you would improve? Perhaps the size. When relatives visit, we have to boil water two or three times for everyone's tea, so a slightly larger one would be more **practical** for a household like ours.

Part 3 link: Consumer Behaviour & Shopping · Sustainability

134. Describe a piece of technology you find useful

Objects · your card 4 · sp2_objects_04 · 265 words (yours: 168)

- what it is
- how you use it
- how you learned to use it
- and why it is useful

I'd like to talk about the piece of technology I reach for more often than anything else. A piece of technology I find genuinely useful is my smartphone, which has become an extension of my daily life. I know that is a fairly obvious choice, but its sheer **versatility** is remarkable. It functions as my alarm, camera, map, bank and library all in one device. At work, I use it constantly to reply to students' messages, check university deadlines and join video calls with admissions officers abroad. In the evenings, I use it to read e-books, listen to music or video-call my elder sister and her children in Dhaka. I learned to use it intuitively, simply by exploring its features over time. Nobody really taught me; I just experimented, made a few mistakes and occasionally watched a short tutorial when I got stuck. Funnily enough, I've now become the person my parents turn to whenever their own phones misbehave. What makes it so useful is how it **consolidates** dozens of tasks that once required separate tools. ~~I learned to use it intuitively, simply by exploring its features over time.~~ It has made my life significantly more **efficient**, allowing me to work, communicate and organise on the move. Of course, I am aware there is a downside; it can be quite **addictive** if you are not careful. Still, used sensibly, it is an incredibly powerful tool. Honestly, it is hard to imagine how people managed everyday tasks before smartphones existed. I think it is a perfect example of how technology has become deeply **embedded** in modern life, for better or worse, and I would struggle to function without mine.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you think you use your smartphone too much? Probably, yes, especially in the evenings. I've started leaving it in another room while I read, which helps me **switch off** properly and makes that time feel far more restful.

Is there any other technology you find useful? My laptop, definitely. For long documents and university applications at work, a phone just isn't enough, so the two complement each other rather well and I use both every day.

Part 3 link: Smartphones & Devices · The Internet & Information

135. Describe something you bought that was expensive

Objects · your card 5 · sp2_objects_05 · 261 words (yours: 164)

- what it was
- why you bought it
- how you paid for it
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about the most expensive thing I've ever bought for myself. Something expensive I bought after much deliberation was a good-quality laptop for my work and studies. It was a significant purchase for me, so I did not take the decision lightly. I needed it because my old one was painfully slow, and in my job at an education consultancy I'm constantly preparing documents and applications for students. I also wanted something reliable for the online courses I take in the evenings, since I'm hoping to study abroad myself one day. I researched extensively for weeks, comparing models to make sure I was making a **sensible** choice. I had saved for it gradually, which made me appreciate its value even more. I **put aside** a portion of my salary every month for almost a year, and in the end I paid for it in full, because I didn't want to be paying it off in instalments. When I finally bought it, I felt a mixture of excitement and slight **apprehension** at spending so much. However, it quickly proved to be a genuinely **worthwhile** investment, as I use it every single day. Its speed and reliability have made my work far more productive. Honestly, although the price was high, the value it has provided over the years has

been **immense**. It taught me that spending more on something you use constantly is often smarter than buying a cheaper version that disappoints. I have never once regretted the purchase, and I think it was one of my wiser financial decisions.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Have you bought anything expensive since then? Nothing on that scale. I tend to be quite careful with money, and I'd rather save towards bigger goals, such as studying abroad, than make **impulse purchases** that I might regret later.

Do you prefer to save up or to buy things on credit? I definitely prefer to save up first. My father ran his business for over thirty years without borrowing more than he needed, and I suppose I've inherited that cautious attitude.

Part 3 link: Money & Wealth · Consumer Behaviour & Shopping

136. Describe a photograph you like

Objects · your card 6 · sp2_objects_06 · 275 words (yours: 163)

- what is in the photograph
- when it was taken
- who took it
- and why you like it

I'd like to describe a photograph that I look at almost every day. A photograph I treasure is one of my entire extended family gathered together at a reunion several years ago. It was taken during Eid in the courtyard of my grandparents' home in the village, with everyone squeezed onto a few plastic chairs and a mat on the ground. My grandparents are sitting in the middle, surrounded by their children and grandchildren, and a couple of neighbours who wandered in at the last minute. It captures a rare moment when everyone, across three generations, was in the same place at the same time. It was taken by my cousin, who had just bought his first proper camera and insisted on setting a timer so he could run into the frame himself. In fact, you can just about see him mid-jump, still trying to reach his spot. What makes it so **precious** is that some of the older relatives in it, like my great-uncle, have since passed away. Whenever I look at it, I am filled with a warm sense of **nostalgia**. The photo is not technically perfect; it is slightly blurry and someone is looking the wrong way, but that only **adds to its charm**. What I love is how it froze a genuinely happy, **fleeting** moment forever. It reminds me of the importance of family and how quickly time passes. Honestly, no professionally staged photograph could ever mean as much to me. I keep a printed copy framed on my wall, and it never fails to make me smile. It is a powerful reminder of how **irreplaceable** these moments and people are.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you take many photographs yourself? Quite a few, but mostly on my phone, and I rarely print them. I'd like to change that, because a printed photo somehow feels more permanent than thousands of images **buried in** a phone gallery.

Would you like to take a similar photo in the future? Yes, very much. I'd love to organise another family photo at my grandparents' home next Eid, especially now that my sister's children are old enough to sit still, or at least try.

Part 3 link: Family & Relationships · Generational Differences

137. Describe a book you have recently read and enjoyed

Objects · your card 7 · sp2_objects_07 · 280 words (yours: 167)

- what the book was
- what it was about
- why you read it

- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about a book that I finished a few weeks ago and still find myself thinking about. A book I recently read and thoroughly enjoyed was a work of non-fiction about human psychology and decision-making. ~~A friend had recommended~~ It was about the **mental shortcuts** we all take, and ~~I was immediately intrigued by the subject.~~ way our emotions and habits push us towards choices that are not always logical. The book explained, in a remarkably accessible way, why people so often behave irrationally. A friend had recommended it, and I was immediately **intrigued** by the subject. Part of the reason I picked it up was my job, because at the education consultancy I watch students make huge decisions about their futures, sometimes for surprisingly emotional reasons, and I wanted to understand that better. What I found most **compelling** was how it used real experiments to illustrate its points, which made the ideas stick. I read it far more quickly than I expected, because it was genuinely **gripping** despite being educational. Most evenings I would sit down to read one chapter with a cup of tea and end up reading three. It completely changed how I think about my own choices and biases. Honestly, a good non-fiction book that leaves you seeing the world differently is a real treasure. Since finishing it, I have found myself noticing these psychological patterns in everyday life, even in the way I shop or argue with my sister. I think the best books are the ones that stay with you long after the final page, and this one certainly did. I have already recommended it to several friends, calling it one of the most **enlightening** books I have read in years.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you usually prefer fiction or non-fiction? These days I lean towards non-fiction, because I like learning something useful. That said, I still enjoy a good Bengali novel now and then, especially on long bus journeys or rainy monsoon afternoons.

Do you prefer printed books or e-books? Printed books, without a doubt. I like the feel of the pages and being able to **scribble** notes in the margins, although e-books are admittedly handy when I'm travelling.

Part 3 link: Hobbies & Leisure · Lifelong Learning

138. Describe a piece of clothing you like to wear

Objects · your card 8 · sp2_objects_08 · 241 words (yours: 161)

- what it is
- when you wear it
- where you got it
- and why you like it

I'd like to talk about a jacket that I probably wear more than anything else I own. A piece of clothing I am particularly fond of is a simple, well-made jacket I bought a few years ago. It's a plain navy one with a soft lining and a couple of deep inside pockets. It is nothing flashy, but it has become a real **staple** of my wardrobe. I wear it mostly in winter, because the mornings in the north of Bangladesh can get surprisingly chilly, and it's perfect for my early walks by the river. What I love about it is how **versatile** it is; I can wear it to work, to a casual outing or even a semi-formal event. I bought it in Dhaka while I was visiting my elder sister, and she helped me choose it after I'd spent ages hesitating between two colours, so it also carries a nice memory. It fits me perfectly and is remarkably comfortable, which matters far more to me than following trends. ~~I bought it during a trip abroad, so it also carries a nice memory.~~ Despite years of regular use, it has proved incredibly **durable** and still looks good. Honestly, I have come to appreciate quality over quantity when it comes to clothes. A single well-chosen item like this is worth more than a dozen cheap ones. It has become something of a **signature piece** for me, and I always feel **confident** wearing it. I suspect I will keep wearing it until it finally falls apart.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you usually wear traditional or Western clothes? Mostly Western clothes for work, like shirts and trousers. But for Eid, weddings and Friday prayers I prefer a panjabi, which feels more comfortable and more in keeping with the occasion.

Do you enjoy shopping for clothes? Not particularly, to be honest. I tend to put it off until I really need something, and I'd rather buy one good item than spend hours browsing through shops full of things I don't need.

Part 3 link: Fashion & Trends · Consumer Behaviour & Shopping

139. Describe something you would like to own in the future

Objects · your card 9 · sp2_objects_09 · 285 words (yours: 165)

- what it is
- why you want it
- how you would get it
- and how you would feel about owning it

I'd like to talk about something that is still a long way off for me, but which I think about quite often. Something I would genuinely love to own one day is a house of my own, ideally with a small garden. I picture a modest two-storey house on the edge of Sirajganj, not far from the river, with a few mango trees and space for my mother to grow vegetables. Right now it feels like a distant dream, but it is one I am steadily working towards. The main reason I want it is the sense of security and permanence that comes with owning your own home. ~~Renting~~ We live in a comfortable flat on the third floor, but I've always ~~feels somewhat temporary, whereas~~ longed for a patch of land of our own, something I only really enjoy when we visit my grandparents in the village. A home of my own would be a real sanctuary, and a place where my father could enjoy his retirement surrounded by greenery. As for how I'd get it, I plan to save carefully over the coming years, which will require patience and discipline. I'll probably need a home loan as well, and I hope that gaining more experience, perhaps even studying abroad, will eventually improve my earnings. I imagine the feeling of finally getting the keys would be absolutely exhilarating, a real milestone. It represents stability, achievement and a place to build a future. Honestly, I think there is something deeply satisfying about having a space that is truly yours. While I know it is a long-term goal that will take considerable effort, it is one I am determined to reach. It keeps me motivated to work hard and save wisely.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you think you will achieve this goal? I hope so, although realistically it will take quite a few years. As long as I stay disciplined with my savings and keep progressing in my career, I think it's an attainable goal.

Would you prefer to live in a house or a flat? A house, ideally. Flats are practical and secure, but I've always loved open space, fresh air and the idea of stepping out into my own garden with a morning cup of tea.

Part 3 link: Housing · Success & Ambition

140. Describe something you made yourself

Objects · your card 10 · sp2_objects_10 · 267 words (yours: 167)

- what it was
- how you made it
- why you made it
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about the first thing I ever built with my own hands. Something I once made myself that I am quite proud of was a small wooden shelf for my room. I had never really done any woodwork before, so it was genuinely **ambitious** for a complete beginner. I watched a few online tutorials, gathered some basic tools and set to work, expecting disaster. I bought a few planks from a carpenter's workshop near our local market and borrowed a saw and a drill from my father, who still keeps a box of tools from his business days. I measured everything on our balcony floor, cut the pieces, screwed them together and sanded the edges. The process was far more **challenging** than I anticipated, involving plenty of mistakes and a couple of bruised fingers. It was very much a case of **trial and error**. But I persevered, and after a weekend of effort, I had a shelf that actually stood up straight. I made it mainly because my books had outgrown the space on my desk, and I liked the idea of building something myself for once. The sense of **satisfaction** I felt was surprisingly intense, far greater than simply buying one. What made it special was that I had created something functional with my own two hands. Honestly, there is a unique pride that comes from making something yourself. It now sits in my room holding my books, and every time I look at it, I feel a little glow of accomplishment. It gave me a real appreciation for the value of **craftsmanship**.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Have you made anything else since then? Only small things, like a wooden stand for my phone and a simple frame for a family photo. Nothing ambitious, but each project has made me a little more confident with tools.

Do you think people make fewer things by hand nowadays? I think so. Everything is so cheap and easy to order online that making things yourself can seem pointless, although I think it's a **dying art** that is well worth reviving.

Part 3 link: Hobbies & Leisure · Learning Methods

141. Describe an object that has sentimental value to you

Objects · your card 11 · sp2_objects_11 · 283 words (yours: 165)

- what it is
- where it came from
- how long you have had it
- and why it is important to you

I'd like to talk about something small that I keep in a drawer beside my bed. An object with deep sentimental value to me is an old wristwatch that belonged to my grandfather. He wore it for decades, and ~~after~~ a few years ago, when the small dial became hard for him to read, he ~~passed away~~, took it ~~was given~~ off his wrist and gave it to me. He lives in our ancestral village not far from Sirajganj, and I still remember him pressing it into my hand during one of our visits and telling me to look after it better than he had. So I've had it for about four years now. The watch itself is fairly worn and no longer even keeps perfect time, yet I would not trade it for anything. The leather strap is cracked and the glass has a tiny scratch across it, but I've deliberately never had it polished. What makes it so **precious** is the memories it carries; I remember him glancing at it constantly throughout my childhood. Holding it now brings back a flood of warm, **nostalgic** feelings. It is a **tangible connection** to a man I ~~loved~~ love and ~~admired~~ admire deeply. He is in his eighties now but still remarkably sharp, and he always asks whether I'm taking care of it. I keep it safely stored and only take it out occasionally, almost like a **relic**. Honestly, its emotional worth is completely disconnected from its monetary value. I think objects like this become **irreplaceable** precisely because of the people and memories attached to them. One day I hope to pass it on to my own children, along with the stories of the wonderful man who ~~once wore~~ gave it to me.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you ever wear the watch? Only occasionally, usually when I visit my grandfather. He always notices straight away and smiles, which makes it feel like a small, shared ritual between the two of us.

Do you think young people value old things as much as older people do? Perhaps not always. Many young people prefer new things, but I think we come to appreciate old objects later in life, once we understand the memories and stories behind them.

Part 3 link: Generational Differences · Family & Relationships

142. Describe something you lost that was important to you

Objects · your card 12 · sp2_objects_12 · 280 words (yours: 167)

- what it was
- how you lost it
- what you did about it
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about something I lost a couple of years ago, which still bothers me a little when I think about it. Something important I once lost was a small notebook in which I had jotted down ideas and personal reflections for over a year. It was a plain brown notebook, but it held everything from favourite quotations to plans for my career and thoughts about studying abroad. I must have left it somewhere while travelling, and by the time I realised, it was gone. I was coming back from Dhaka on a crowded bus after visiting my sister, and I think it slipped out of my bag when I dozed off. I was genuinely distraught, because its contents were irreplaceable and deeply personal. I retraced my steps and asked around, but sadly it never turned up. I even phoned the bus company and went back to the ticket counter the next day, but nobody had handed anything in. For days I felt a real sense of loss, almost as though I had lost a part of myself. What upset me most was that no amount of money could recover what was written inside. Eventually I had to ~~accept~~ come to terms with the fact that it was gone and try to move on. The experience taught me a valuable lesson about backing things up and being more careful with things that matter. These days I keep my notes on my laptop as well as on paper. Honestly, it still stings a little when I think about it. It made me realise how attached we can become to seemingly ordinary objects, simply because of what they represent to us.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Are you generally a careful person with your belongings? Much more careful now than I used to be. After losing that notebook, I always double-check my bag before getting off a bus, and I keep important things in one zipped pocket.

Have you ever found something that someone else lost? Yes, once I found a wallet on a rickshaw seat. I tracked the owner down using a card inside it, and he was so relieved that he insisted on buying me a cup of tea.

Part 3 link: Trust & Honesty · Consumer Behaviour & Shopping

143. Describe a piece of furniture you like

Objects · your card 13 · sp2_objects_13 · 257 words (yours: 162)

- what it is
- where it is
- how you use it
- and why you like it

I'd like to talk about a piece of furniture that most visitors wouldn't even notice. A piece of furniture I am genuinely fond of is a large, comfortable armchair in the corner of my room. It is

old and a little worn, but it is easily my favourite spot in the entire ~~house~~ flat. It used to sit in our living room when I was a child, and when my parents bought a new sofa set, I rescued it before it could be given away. I positioned it right beside a window, so I get plenty of natural light and a pleasant view of the quiet street below our third-floor flat. I use it mainly for reading, and it has become my personal little **retreat**. After a long day at the consultancy, I often sit there with a book, or simply listen to music with my eyes closed. My younger sister occasionally borrows it to revise for her exams, though she always gives it back rather **reluctantly**. What I love about it is how wonderfully comfortable it is; I can **sink into** it for hours without any discomfort. ~~I positioned it right beside a window, so I get plenty of natural light and a pleasant view.~~ There is something deeply **cosy** about having a dedicated chair just for relaxing and reading. Honestly, some of my most peaceful moments have been spent in that chair with a good book and a cup of tea. It might not be the most stylish piece of furniture, but its comfort makes it **invaluable** to me. I think everyone needs a favourite spot like this, and that chair is undoubtedly mine.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Would you ever replace the chair? Not unless it completely falls apart. It has been **reupholstered** once already, and I'd happily do that again rather than buy a new one, because a new chair simply wouldn't feel the same.

Do you prefer modern or traditional furniture? I prefer traditional wooden furniture, the kind that lasts for generations. My grandparents still have a carved wooden bed in the village that's older than my father, and it's still perfectly solid.

Part 3 link: Happiness & Wellbeing · Housing

144. Describe a traditional or handmade item you own

Objects · your card 14 · sp2_objects_14 · 267 words (yours: 164)

- what it is
- where it came from
- what it is used for
- and why you value it

I'd like to talk about something I own that is closely connected to where I come from. A traditional handmade item I own and treasure is a beautifully woven shawl made by artisans in a rural part of my country. In fact, it was woven on a handloom in a village near Sirajganj, an area well known for its weaving. It was given to me by my grandmother, who bought it from a ~~relative~~ weaver she has known for years, and it is a wonderful example of local **craftsmanship**. What makes it special is that it was made entirely by hand, using techniques passed down through generations. The intricate patterns and vivid colours are genuinely **exquisite**, and no two pieces are ever exactly alike. Mine is a deep maroon with a fine cream border, and if you look closely you can see tiny irregularities that show a human being made it. I use it mainly during the cooler months, and it always draws compliments. I wrap it around my shoulders on foggy winter mornings, and I also wear it to weddings and family gatherings, because it looks smart over a panjabi. Beyond its practical use, I value it because it represents a fading **heritage** that deserves to be preserved. In a world dominated by mass-produced goods, owning something so **authentic** feels increasingly meaningful. Honestly, I feel a sense of responsibility to look after it well. It connects me to my culture, to my grandmother and to the skilled hands that created it. I think items like this are far more valuable than anything **churned out** by a factory.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do many young people in Bangladesh wear handmade clothes? Fewer than before, sadly, although handloom fabrics are becoming fashionable again among some young people. Social media has helped, because small weavers can now sell directly to customers.

Would you buy another handmade item? Definitely. Next time I visit my grandparents, I'd like to buy a couple of handwoven gamchhas from the local weavers, both to use and to support their livelihoods.

Part 3 link: Traditions & Customs · Globalisation of Culture

145. Describe a gadget you find helpful in daily life

Objects · your card 15 · sp2_objects_15 · 268 words (yours: 172)

- what it is
- how it works
- how often you use it
- and why it is helpful

I'd like to talk about a small gadget that I carry with me almost everywhere. A gadget I find genuinely helpful in daily life is a pair of wireless earphones I bought a while ago. They might seem like a small thing, but they have become surprisingly indispensable. They connect to my phone by Bluetooth as soon as I take them out of their little charging case, and a single tap on either earbud lets me pause music or answer a call. The case recharges them whenever I put them back, so one full charge usually lasts me several days. I use them constantly, whether I am commuting, exercising or simply trying to concentrate on work. I'd say I wear them for at least two or three hours every day, including on my evening walks by the river. What makes them so useful is the freedom they offer; without any wires, I can move around completely unhindered. They also block out background noise, which is a real blessing ~~in a noisy city~~ on our busy streets, where rickshaw bells and horns never seem to stop. I honestly appreciate how such a compact device can make everyday tasks so much more pleasant. Listening to music or podcasts during my commute has transformed what used to be a tedious part of my day. It is a perfect example of a small piece of technology that is genuinely practical rather than just a gimmick. Honestly, I would replace them immediately if they broke. I think the best gadgets are the ones you barely notice using, because they have become so seamlessly woven into your routine.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you ever worry about using earphones too much? A little, yes. I try to keep the volume moderate and take them out when I'm walking along busy roads, because it's important to stay aware of rickshaws and traffic around me.

What other gadget would you like to buy? Perhaps an e-reader. I read a lot, and it would be handy on long bus journeys to Dhaka, since carrying several books at once is rather cumbersome.

Part 3 link: Smartphones & Devices · Music & the Arts

146. Describe a toy you enjoyed playing with as a child

Objects · your card 16 · sp2_objects_16 · 280 words (yours: 169)

- what it was
- who gave it to you
- how you played with it
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about a toy that kept me busy for most of my early childhood. A toy I absolutely adored as a child was a set of building blocks my parents gave me one birthday. They were bright plastic pieces in red, yellow and blue, packed into a bucket that seemed enormous to me at the time. My father brought them back from a trip to Dhaka, which made them feel even more special, since toys like that were hard to find in our town back then. It might sound simple, but it kept me endlessly entertained for years. I would spend hours constructing houses, towers and

imaginary cities, completely lost in my own little world. Sometimes I tried to copy the bridge over the Jamuna, and it collapsed more times than I can count. What I loved was how the blocks allowed for endless creativity; I could build almost anything I could imagine. When my younger sister was old enough, I let her join in, and we built whole villages together on the living room floor. Looking back, I think that toy quietly **nurtured** my imagination and problem-solving skills. It was wonderfully **engaging** in a way that required real involvement, unlike the passive screens children have today. I have very fond, **nostalgic** memories of sitting on the floor surrounded by my creations. Honestly, I think the best toys are the ones that let children invent and build rather than just watch. That simple set taught me patience and creativity without my ever realising it. It remains one of the toys I remember most warmly from my childhood, and I would happily give one to a child today.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do children today still play with toys like that? Some do, but many prefer tablets and phones. My four-year-old nephew in Dhaka absolutely loves building blocks, though, so perhaps they haven't completely lost their **appeal** after all.

Did you have any other favourite toys? I also loved a small plastic cricket bat that I used in endless matches with the neighbourhood children, usually until someone hit the ball over a wall and we had to go and apologise.

Part 3 link: Parenting & Childhood · Technology & Children

147. Describe something you bought recently that you are happy with

Objects · your card 17 · sp2_objects_17 · 266 words (yours: 163)

- what it was
- where you bought it
- why you bought it
- and why you are happy with it

I'd like to talk about a fairly modest purchase that has turned out to be surprisingly useful. Something I bought recently that I am delighted with is a good-quality water bottle designed to keep drinks cold for hours. It's an insulated steel bottle in dark green, just the right size to fit in the side pocket of my bag. I bought it ~~sounds trivial, but~~ from an online shop after comparing a few options, and it ~~has genuinely improved my daily routine.~~ arrived at our flat within a couple of days. I bought it because I had been trying to drink more water and stay healthier. I used to go through half the working day without drinking anything, and I'd often come home in the evening feeling tired and dehydrated, especially in summer. It sounds trivial, but it has genuinely improved my daily routine. What makes me so happy with it is how well it actually works; my water stays refreshingly cold even in the intense heat. During the hottest months, when the afternoons are almost **unbearable**, that makes a real difference. It has proved far more **practical** than I expected. The build quality is excellent, so it feels **durable** and worth the money. Beyond the practical benefit, it has genuinely encouraged me to develop a healthier habit, which is an unexpected bonus. Honestly, it is one of those small, **sensible** purchases that quietly makes life a little better. I now carry it everywhere I go. I think the most **satisfying** purchases are often the modest, useful ones rather than the flashy, expensive ones. It has quickly become an essential part of my daily kit.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you usually think carefully before buying things? Yes, usually. I compare a few options, read reviews and ask myself whether I'll actually use it. That habit has saved me from quite a few **impulsive** purchases over the years.

Do you prefer shopping online or in person? It depends. For practical items like this bottle, online is quicker and often cheaper, but for clothes or anything I want to touch and try, I still prefer going to a shop.

Part 3 link: Consumer Behaviour & Shopping · Sustainability

148. Describe a musical instrument you would like to learn

Objects · your card 18 · sp2_objects_18 · 284 words (yours: 164)

- what it is
- why you want to learn it
- how you would learn it
- and how you would feel about playing it

I'd like to talk about an instrument I've wanted to play for as long as I can remember. A musical instrument I have long wanted to learn is the piano, which I have always found genuinely **captivating**. There is something about its rich, versatile sound that appeals to me enormously. It can sound gentle and calm one moment and powerful the next, and I think that range is what **draws me to it**. The main reason I want to learn it is that I have always regretted never pursuing music as a child. Music has always been a big part of my life; I listen to it on my way to work and while I read, but I've only ever been a listener, never a player. I imagine learning it would be both challenging and deeply **rewarding**. As for how I'd learn, I would probably start with online lessons and gradually move to a proper teacher, since patience and consistency are essential. Pianos are quite rare in my town, so I'd begin with a small digital keyboard in my room and practise for half an hour each evening. I know progress would be slow at first, requiring real **perseverance**. Still, the thought of one day being able to play a piece I love is genuinely exciting. I think playing an instrument would also be a wonderful way to relax and express myself. I can even imagine playing simple tunes for my little nephew when my elder sister visits from Dhaka. Honestly, I believe it would be a hugely **fulfilling** hobby that I could enjoy for the rest of my life. It is definitely something I intend to make time for once my schedule allows.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Did you learn any music at school? Very little, apart from singing the national anthem and a few songs for cultural programmes. Music wasn't really treated as a serious subject, which I think was a **missed opportunity**.

Is there any other instrument you'd like to learn? Perhaps the harmonium, because it's so central to traditional Bengali music. My grandmother loves old songs played on it, so learning it would let me play for her in the village.

Part 3 link: Music & the Arts · Hobbies & Leisure

149. Describe a piece of art you like

Objects · your card 19 · sp2_objects_19 · 259 words (yours: 169)

- what it is
- where you saw it
- what it looks like
- and why you like it

I'd like to talk about a painting I came across almost by accident. A piece of art that has stayed with me is a large landscape painting I saw at ~~a local gallery~~ an art exhibition in Dhaka a while ago. I was visiting my elder sister, and her husband suggested we spend an afternoon at a gallery, which isn't something I would normally do. It depicted a rural scene at sunset, with rich, warm colours that seemed to glow. There was a wide river in the foreground with a small wooden boat, a line of palm trees along the bank, and a few farmers walking home across the fields. I am

no art expert, but something about it was genuinely **captivating**. The artist's use of light was remarkably **skilful**, making the whole scene feel alive. The sky was painted in layers of orange and gold, and the water reflected every shade of it. What drew me in was the incredible sense of peace it conveyed; I could almost feel the calm of that imaginary evening. ~~The artist's use of light was remarkably skilful, making the whole scene feel alive.~~ I stood in front of it for far longer than I expected, completely **absorbed**. What I appreciate about art like this is its ability to **stir genuine emotion** without a single word. Honestly, it reminded me of the quiet countryside around my grandparents' village, and of ~~my own childhood~~, evening walks along the Jamuna, which made it feel personal. I think a truly good piece of art creates a lasting **impression**, and that painting certainly did. I still think about it, and I would love to see it again.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you often go to art galleries? Not very often, to be honest, since there aren't many in my town. But whenever I'm in Dhaka, I try to visit an exhibition, because it's a refreshing change from my usual routine.

Have you ever tried painting yourself? Only at school, and the results were quite **underwhelming**. I enjoy looking at art far more than creating it, although I'd like to try sketching one day, just to relax.

Part 3 link: Music & the Arts

150. Describe an object you use every day

Objects · your card 20 · sp2_objects_20 · 265 words (yours: 166)

- what it is
- how you use it
- how long you have had it
- and why it is important to you

I'd like to talk about something I pick up every single morning before I leave home. An object I genuinely use every single day is my backpack, which has become an essential part of my routine. ~~I have had it for several years now, and it has proved remarkably durable despite constant use.~~ It's a plain black one made of tough, water-resistant material, which is very handy during the monsoon. It carries everything I need for the day, from my laptop and documents to my water bottle and other essentials. What makes it so useful is how practical and well-organised it is, with plenty of compartments. I keep students' files in the main section, my laptop in a padded sleeve, and small things like keys, pens and a charger in the front pocket, so I never waste time searching for anything. It is comfortable to carry even when heavily loaded, which is genuinely **invaluable** during long commutes. I have had it for several years now, and it has proved remarkably **durable** despite constant use. My elder sister gave it to me when I started my final year at university, so it has been with me through exams, job interviews and my first years at the consultancy. Honestly, I rely on it so much that I would feel completely lost without it. It might seem like an ordinary object, but it plays a surprisingly important role in keeping my day organised. Over the years it has become a bit worn, but I have grown quite **attached** to it. I think it is a perfect example of how the most **mundane** objects often turn out to be the most useful ones in daily life.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Would you buy a new backpack soon? Not unless it breaks. One of the zips is starting to stick, but I'd rather get it repaired, because it still does its job perfectly and I know exactly where everything goes.

Do you usually carry a lot with you? Probably more than I need. Between my laptop, student files, a charger and my water bottle, it gets quite heavy, so I'm trying to **travel lighter** and keep

more documents digitally.

Part 3 link: Consumer Behaviour & Shopping · Sustainability

151. Describe a vehicle you would like to own

Objects · your card 21 · sp2_objects_21 · 268 words (yours: 162)

- what it is
- why you want it
- how you would use it
- and how you would feel about owning it

I'd like to talk about something I hope to own in the next few years. A vehicle I would love to own one day is a reliable, fuel-efficient car, ideally something practical rather than flashy. ~~Living~~ I'm thinking of a small family car with enough room for my parents and my younger sister. Even in a ~~busy city~~, modest town like Sirajganj, having my own car would make daily life significantly more **convenient**. The main reason I want one is the freedom it offers; I would no longer depend on crowded public transport or unreliable schedules. At the moment, getting anywhere means haggling with rickshaw drivers or squeezing onto packed buses, especially on the long journey to Dhaka. I imagine using it for my daily commute and for weekend trips out of ~~the city~~, town, which I rarely manage now. Above all, I'd use it to drive my parents to my grandparents' village home, which we visit often, and to see my elder sister and her children in Dhaka whenever we like. What appeals to me most is the sense of **independence** it would bring. I would probably choose something environmentally friendly, since fuel efficiency matters to me. Owning a car would feel like a real **milestone**, a sign of stability and progress. I think my father, who worked so hard for so many years, would be especially proud to sit in the passenger seat. Honestly, though it is a considerable expense, I think it would genuinely improve my quality of life. It is a goal I am steadily working towards, and I know the sense of freedom would make it thoroughly **worthwhile**.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Can you drive at the moment? Not very well, honestly. I've had a few lessons from a cousin, but I'd need proper training before driving on our roads, because traffic can be quite **unpredictable**, especially on the highways.

Would you prefer an electric car? Ideally, yes, because it would be better for the environment. But charging points are still rare outside the big cities here, so for now a fuel-efficient car seems far more realistic.

Part 3 link: Transportation · Pollution

152. Describe something you borrowed from someone

Objects · your card 22 · sp2_objects_22 · 261 words (yours: 161)

- what it was
- who you borrowed it from
- why you borrowed it
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about something I borrowed last year that turned out to be a great help. Something I once borrowed that proved incredibly useful was a professional camera I borrowed from a close friend for a family event. The event was a small gathering we held at home when my father retired after running his business for over thirty years. My elder sister came from Dhaka with her family, and my grandparents travelled in from the village, so I knew it was a day worth remembering. I had wanted to capture the occasion properly but could not justify buying an expensive camera for a single day. My friend, who is a keen photographer, generously offered to

lend me his, which was very **considerate** of him. I was slightly nervous about handling such a valuable and **delicate** piece of equipment. He kindly gave me a quick lesson on how to use it, which I really appreciated. The photos it produced were of a quality I could never have achieved with my phone, so I was genuinely **grateful**. My favourite is a shot of my father laughing with my grandfather, which now sits framed in our living room. I made sure to return it promptly and in perfect condition, as I did not want to **betray his trust**. I also printed a few of the best photos for him as a small thank-you. Honestly, the whole experience reminded me how valuable it is to have **generous** friends. It also made me consider eventually investing in a decent camera of my own.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you often borrow things from others? Not often. I don't like troubling people, so I only borrow when it's really necessary, and I always make sure I return things quickly and in the same condition.

Do you lend your own things to friends? Yes, usually books. I'm happy to lend them, although I've learnt to write my name inside the cover, because a few have **mysteriously vanished** over the years.

Part 3 link: Friendship · Trust & Honesty

153. Describe a piece of jewellery or accessory you own

Objects · your card 23 · sp2_objects_23 · 251 words (yours: 166)

- what it is
- where you got it
- when you wear it
- and why it is special to you

I'd like to talk about the only piece of jewellery I really own. A piece of jewellery that is special to me is a simple silver ring that ~~once~~ my grandmother gave me. It originally belonged to ~~my grandmother. After~~ her father, and she ~~passed-away,~~ had kept it ~~was-given~~ wrapped in a cloth in a small tin box for decades. She gave it to me when I got my first job, during one of our visits to the village, and I have treasured it ever since. It is not particularly valuable in monetary terms, but its **sentimental** worth is immeasurable. ~~I wear it on special occasions, and doing so makes me feel closely connected to her.~~ The ring is quite plain and old-fashioned, yet that simplicity is part of its **charm**. I wear it on special occasions, such as Eid, weddings and family gatherings, and doing so makes me feel closely connected to her. My grandmother has very little formal education, but she is one of the wisest people I know, and when she gave it to me, she simply said that honest work deserved something honest to wear. Every time I put it on, it brings back warm memories of ~~a woman I loved dearly,~~ that afternoon on her veranda. What makes it so meaningful is that it is a **tangible link** to my family's past. Honestly, it is one of my most **cherished** possessions, precisely because of the memories attached to it rather than its appearance. I intend to look after it carefully and one day pass it on within the family. Items like this become genuinely **irreplaceable**, carrying stories that no new purchase ever could.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do men in Bangladesh often wear jewellery? Not much, generally. A simple silver ring or a watch is quite common, but most men keep it modest. Women, on the other hand, often wear beautiful gold jewellery at weddings and festivals.

Would you ever sell it? Never, no matter how much someone offered. It's not about the money at all; selling it would feel like giving away a piece of my family's history, and my grandmother would be **heartbroken**.

Part 3 link: Family & Relationships · Traditions & Customs

154. Describe something that saves you time

Objects · your card 24 · sp2_objects_24 · 279 words (yours: 166)

- what it is
- how you use it
- how it saves time
- and how you feel about it

I'd like to talk about an app on my phone that has changed the way our family handles everyday errands. Something that saves me a remarkable amount of time is a food-delivery and grocery app on my phone. As someone with a busy schedule, it has become genuinely **invaluable**. I mostly use it to order groceries for the household, things like rice, lentils, cooking oil and vegetables, and occasionally a takeaway on evenings when my mother deserves a break from cooking. I simply choose the items, pay through my mobile wallet and pick a delivery time that suits us. Instead of spending hours travelling to shops and queuing, I can order everything I need in a few minutes. What makes it so useful is how **efficient** the whole process is; the items arrive at my door within hours. It also means my mother no longer has to carry heavy bags back from the bazaar in the heat. This frees up time I can then spend on work or relaxation, which matters enormously to me. Honestly, it has completely transformed how I manage my errands. I am aware there is a slight risk of becoming overly **reliant** on such conveniences, but used sensibly it is a genuine time-saver. I still enjoy going to the local market now and then, because there is something about **haggling** with the vegetable sellers that no app can replace. In a fast-paced world where time is arguably our most precious resource, tools like this are extremely welcome. It is a perfect example of how technology, at its best, can make everyday life more **manageable**. I honestly do not know how I coped before it existed.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do older people in your family use apps like this? My parents are gradually getting used to it. My father now **browses** the app himself, although he still likes to phone me before ordering anything, just to check he's pressing the right button.

Is there anything you dislike about the app? Sometimes the vegetables aren't as fresh as the ones from the market, and deliveries can be delayed during heavy monsoon rain. But overall, the benefits far outweigh those small frustrations.

Part 3 link: Consumer Behaviour & Shopping · Work-Life Balance

155. Describe a magazine or newspaper you like to read

Objects · your card 25 · sp2_objects_25 · 247 words (yours: 161)

- what it is
- what it is about
- how often you read it
- and why you like it

I'd like to talk about something I read every week without fail. A publication I genuinely enjoy reading is a weekly current-affairs magazine that covers global news and analysis. It's an English-language magazine that deals with politics, economics, science and culture from around the world, along with longer features and book reviews. I read it regularly, usually at the weekend when I have time to digest it properly. I normally go through it on my laptop on Friday mornings with a cup of tea, and then return to a couple of the longer articles on Saturday evening. What I appreciate most is the depth of its reporting; unlike quick news headlines, it offers thoughtful, **in-depth** analysis. It helps me understand the context behind major events, which I find genuinely **enlightening**. That is especially useful in my job, because students often ask me about the situation in the countries they hope to study in. The writing is intelligent without being

pretentious, which makes even complex topics accessible. Reading it keeps me well **informed** about the world in a way that scrolling social media never could. Honestly, in an age of shallow, rapid news consumption, I value having a source that encourages proper reflection. It has also noticeably improved my vocabulary and general knowledge over time. I think it is important to consume some **substantial** content rather than just quick, fragmented updates. It has become a genuinely enjoyable weekend ritual that leaves me feeling both informed and **intellectually stimulated**.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you ever read local newspapers too? Yes, I skim a Bengali daily newspaper most mornings over breakfast, mainly for national news. The magazine is for deeper reading, whereas the newspaper keeps me **up to date** with what's happening at home.

Do you prefer reading news in print or online? Online, mostly, because it's quicker and more convenient. That said, my father still insists on a printed newspaper every morning, and I do enjoy sharing it with him over tea.

Part 3 link: Media & News

156. Describe something you have kept for a long time

Objects · your card 26 · sp2_objects_26 · 251 words (yours: 168)

- what it is
- how long you have had it
- why you have kept it
- and how you feel about it

I'd like to talk about something I've held onto since I was about ten years old. Something I have kept for many years is a childhood diary that I started writing when I was quite young. It's a thick notebook with a faded cartoon cover, full of my untidy handwriting, little drawings and even a few pressed flowers. I have held onto it for well over a decade now, moving it carefully from ~~home~~ one flat to ~~home~~ another whenever my family moved. These days it lives in a drawer in my desk. It contains my youthful thoughts, dreams and daily events, which are often **amusing** to read back now. There's one entry where I announced very seriously that I would become a famous cricketer, and another describing an argument with my younger sister over the last piece of a mango. I have kept it because it is a genuine **time capsule** of who I once was. Whenever I flick through it, I feel a wave of **nostalgia** for a simpler time in my life. What makes it so precious is that no amount of money could recreate those honest, **unfiltered** memories. It is fascinating, and occasionally **embarrassing**, to see how much my perspective has changed. Honestly, I think keeping such personal records is genuinely valuable. It reminds me of how far I have come and grounds me in my own history. I fully intend to keep it for the rest of my life; it is far too **meaningful** to ever throw away.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you still keep a diary now? Not a daily one, sadly. Life got busier, but I still jot down my thoughts in a notebook now and then, especially after important events, because I know I'll enjoy **looking back on** them later.

Would you let anyone read your old diary? Only my younger sister, and only certain pages. Some entries are far too embarrassing, although we had a good laugh when she found the one about our argument over the mango.

Part 3 link: Parenting & Childhood · Generational Differences

157. Describe a collection you have or would like to have

Objects · your card 27 · sp2_objects_27 · 272 words (yours: 164)

- what it is
- how it started
- how you add to it
- and why you enjoy it

I'd like to talk about a collection that takes up more and more space in my room every year. A collection I have gradually built up over the years is my collection of books, which has grown into something I am genuinely proud of. I now have a couple of hundred books, mostly novels and history, plus a few on business and psychology, in both Bengali and English. It started fairly innocently, with a few titles I loved, but it has since become a bit of an **obsession**. The very first ones were old storybooks my father bought me from a street stall when I was about twelve, and I still have every one of them. I add to it whenever I travel or come across an interesting title, so it keeps expanding steadily. My favourite time to buy is the big book fair in Dhaka every February, where I usually come home with a bag far heavier than I planned. My friends also know that a book is the safest gift for me. What I enjoy most is that each book represents a different idea, story or period of my life. There is something deeply **satisfying** about being surrounded by a personal library. Unlike many collections, mine is not just for display; I actually read and reread them. Honestly, my books have become almost like old friends, each with its own **significance**. I find the act of collecting them, and the memories attached to them, thoroughly **rewarding**. I think a good collection reflects who you are and what you value. I hope to keep growing mine for many years to come.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Where do you keep all your books? Mostly on the shelves in my room, including one I built myself. They've started spilling over onto my desk and even the floor, so I'll need more space quite soon.

Do you ever lend books from your collection? Yes, to close friends and my younger sister. I like sharing them, because discussing a book afterwards is half the pleasure, although I do keep a careful **mental note** of who has what.

Part 3 link: Hobbies & Leisure

158. Describe a device you would find hard to live without

Objects · your card 28 · sp2_objects_28 · 271 words (yours: 164)

- what it is
- how you use it
- why you rely on it
- and how you would cope without it

I'd like to talk about the device I'd miss most if it suddenly disappeared. A device I would genuinely struggle to live without is my mobile phone, which has become **deeply woven into** every part of my day. I rely on it for communication, work, navigation, banking and entertainment, all in one place. In the morning it wakes me up, at work I use it to answer students' questions and track application deadlines, and in the evening I video-call my elder sister in Dhaka so my parents can chat with their grandchildren. I also pay most of my bills through a mobile banking app. What makes it so **indispensable** is the sheer number of tasks it handles that once required separate tools. It is not just the convenience but the fact that so much of my daily life is organised through it. Most of my contacts, work files and appointments exist only on that phone. I am aware this level of **dependence** is not entirely healthy, and I do sometimes worry about it. Honestly, if I lost it, I think I would feel quite **disoriented**, at least for the first few days. ~~It is not just the convenience but the fact that so much of my daily life is organised through it. I am aware this level of dependence is not entirely healthy, and I do sometimes worry about it.~~ If I had to cope without it, I imagine I would eventually adapt, as

people did for generations before. I'd probably go back to writing things down in a notebook, keeping important numbers on paper and visiting people in person more often, which might not be such a bad thing. Still, in the short term it would be genuinely **disruptive**. It is a striking reminder of how quickly these devices have become essential rather than optional in modern life.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Have you ever tried a day without your phone? Once, during a visit to my grandparents' village, where the signal was very weak. It was frustrating at first, but by the evening it felt surprisingly **liberating** to simply sit and talk.

Do your parents rely on their phones as much? Not nearly as much. My father mainly uses his for calls and the news, and my mother uses hers to video-call my elder sister. They're far less attached than my generation.

Part 3 link: Smartphones & Devices · Digital Communication

159. Describe an object that is important in your culture

Objects · your card 29 · sp2_objects_29 · 260 words (yours: 164)

- what it is
- what it is used for
- how you know about it
- and why it is important

I'd like to talk about something you can see at almost every celebration in Bangladesh. An object of real cultural importance in my country is the traditional handloom sari, which carries deep significance. It is far more than a piece of clothing; it is a symbol of our heritage and identity. Woven by skilled artisans, each one is a genuine work of **craftsmanship**, often taking days or even weeks to complete. The finest example is probably the jamdani, a delicate, almost transparent cotton sari whose weaving tradition has been recognised internationally. Women wear handloom saris at weddings, at Eid and especially at Pohela Boishakh, when the streets are full of red and white. They are also given as gifts at important family moments. I have known about it my whole life, having seen the women in my family wear them at every important occasion. My mother keeps a few folded carefully in her cupboard for special days, and since Sirajganj has a long tradition of handloom weaving, I've often seen weavers at work in nearby villages. What makes it so important is that it represents a centuries-old tradition that is sadly **under threat** from mass production. Wearing one on special days feels like honouring our **ancestry**. The intricate designs are genuinely **exquisite**, and no two are ever identical. Honestly, I think it is vital that we protect such traditional crafts before they disappear. They connect us to our roots in a tangible way. I feel a real sense of pride whenever I see this beautiful item being worn and celebrated.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Have you ever bought a sari for someone? Yes, I bought a handloom sari for my mother last Eid. Choosing one was surprisingly difficult, because there were so many beautiful designs, but she loved the colour I picked.

Do young women in Bangladesh still wear saris? Yes, especially on special occasions like Pohela Boishakh and weddings. For everyday life, many prefer the salwar kameez, which is more practical, but the sari is still **deeply cherished**.

Part 3 link: Traditions & Customs · Globalisation of Culture

160. Describe something you own that you repaired or fixed

Objects · your card 30 · sp2_objects_30 · 267 words (yours: 163)

- what it was

- what was wrong with it
- how you fixed it
- and how you felt about it

I'd like to talk about something I brought back to life last year. Something I managed to repair myself was an old bicycle that had been sitting unused for years because of a series of faults. It was the bike I used to ride to school, and it had been gathering dust in a corner of our building's parking area ever since. The tyres were flat, the chain was rusted and the brakes barely worked. One of the pedals was also loose, so it made an awful clicking sound whenever anyone tried to ride it. Rather than throwing it away or paying for repairs, I decided to attempt to fix it myself, which was rather **ambitious** given my limited skills. I watched several tutorials, bought a few basic parts and set about it patiently over a weekend. I patched the inner tubes, scrubbed the rust off the chain and oiled it, then replaced the brake pads and tightened everything I could find. The bicycle mechanic near our local market kindly lent me a special tool when I got stuck. The process was more **fiddly** than I expected, and there were moments of real frustration. But gradually, piece by piece, the bicycle came back to life. When I finally took it for a ride along the river, the sense of **accomplishment** was genuinely satisfying. What pleased me most was that I had saved money and rescued something from the **scrap heap**. Honestly, repairing it myself was far more **rewarding** than simply buying a new one. It gave me a real appreciation for fixing things rather than discarding them.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you still ride the bicycle? Yes, mostly for short trips around town and for evening rides along the river. It's also a nice way to get some exercise without having to go to a gym.

Do you usually repair things or replace them? I try to repair them where possible. It's cheaper, less wasteful and more satisfying, although with modern electronics that's getting harder, because many simply aren't designed to be **repairable**.

Part 3 link: Sustainability · Consumer Behaviour & Shopping

161. Describe a hobby you enjoy

Activities & Ideas · your card 1 · sp2_activities_01 · 257 words (yours: 162)

- what it is
- how you started it
- how often you do it
- and why you enjoy it

A The hobby I ~~genuinely enjoy~~ I'd like to talk about is reading, which has been a part of my life since childhood. It started when my parents gave me story books, and I quickly became **hooked**. I still remember my father bringing home Bengali adventure stories from the market, and I would read them again and again until the pages were falling out. These days I read almost every evening before bed, mostly non-fiction and the occasional novel, and on Fridays I sometimes manage a couple of hours with a cup of tea. What I love about it is how it allows me to escape into different worlds and **broaden** my knowledge at the same time. Reading is also wonderfully **therapeutic**; after a stressful day, losing myself in a good book helps me unwind completely. I tend to switch between history, biographies and books about psychology, so there is always something new to look forward to. Beyond entertainment, it has noticeably improved my vocabulary and the way I express myself, which really helps in my job, since I spend a lot of time writing to students and universities. Honestly, in an age dominated by screens, I think reading is an increasingly **underrated** pleasure. It costs very little yet offers enormous rewards. I always keep a book on my bedside table, and I feel slightly restless if I go too long without one. ~~It~~ Looking back, those simple story books were a truly **formative** influence on me, and reading is a hobby I hope to keep for the rest of my life.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you prefer printed books or e-books? Printed books, without a doubt. I like the feel of the paper and being able to scribble notes in the margins. I do read on my phone when travelling, but it never feels quite the same.

Would you like your family to read more? My younger sister already reads a lot, so she doesn't need encouragement. I'd love my nephew in Dhaka to develop the habit, though, so I always bring him a colourful picture book when I visit.

Part 3 link: Hobbies & Leisure · Lifelong Learning

162. Describe a skill you would like to learn

Activities & Ideas · your card 2 · sp2_activities_02 · 266 words (yours: 169)

- what the skill is
- why you want to learn it
- how you would learn it
- and how it would help you

A skill I would really love to learn is public speaking, something I have always found rather **daunting**. I can talk comfortably to one student at a time, but standing in front of a room full of people is a completely different story. I want to learn it because being able to speak confidently in front of others is genuinely valuable, both professionally and personally. At the moment, the thought of addressing a large audience makes me quite nervous, and I would love to overcome that. In fact, my consultancy sometimes holds information sessions for students and parents, and I usually let my colleagues do the talking. I would probably start by joining a speaking club, where I could practise regularly in a supportive environment. There are a few groups like that in Dhaka, and some even meet online, which would suit someone living outside the capital like me. I might also record myself and watch it back, which sounds painful but would show me exactly what to improve. I know it would require stepping well outside my comfort zone and a good deal of **perseverance**. Still, I believe the reward would be immense. Being an effective communicator could open up all sorts of opportunities in my career, and it would make me far more **articulate** in meetings. Honestly, I think it is one of the most **empowering** skills a person can develop. It would also boost my confidence in everyday situations. It is definitely near the top of my list of things to work on once I have the time to commit to it properly.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Have you ever had to give a speech? Yes, once at my university farewell programme. I had to say a few words on behalf of my batch, and although my hands were shaking, everyone was kind, and I felt quite proud afterwards.

Do you think public speaking can be taught? I think so. Some people are naturally confident, but most good speakers have simply practised a lot. With honest feedback and regular practice, even a fairly **reserved** person can become comfortable in front of an audience.

Part 3 link: Professional & Soft Skills · Learning Methods

163. Describe a goal you hope to achieve in the future

Activities & Ideas · your card 3 · sp2_activities_03 · 263 words (yours: 169)

- what the goal is
- why it is important to you
- how you plan to achieve it
- and how you would feel if you achieved it

A goal I am genuinely determined to achieve is to build a successful career in a field I am passionate about, rather than simply working for a salary. For me, that field is education, and

more specifically helping students from small towns like Sirajganj get into good universities abroad. This matters to me because I believe finding your work meaningful is essential to a happy life. In my experience, a single good piece of advice at the right moment can change the direction of someone's life. I see many bright young people around me who have the ability but lack the right guidance, and I would love to help fill that gap. To achieve it, I am steadily developing my skills and gaining as much relevant experience as possible at the consultancy where I work. I also hope to do a master's degree abroad myself, so that I understand the whole journey first-hand. I know it will require patience and a lot of **persistence**, as such things rarely happen overnight. I try to set myself small, **attainable** targets along the way to stay motivated. Honestly, the thought of one day doing work that I find genuinely **fulfilling** is incredibly motivating. If I achieved it, I think I would feel an enormous sense of pride and satisfaction, especially seeing former students thrive. It is not about wealth or status for me, but about purpose. I am fully aware the road will be **challenging arduous**, but I am prepared to put in the effort, because I believe it will be thoroughly worth it in the end.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Have you told your family about this goal? Yes, and they are very supportive. My father ran his own business for over thirty years, so he understands better than anyone what it takes to build something slowly and **steadily**.

Do you think your goal might change in the future? The details might change, for example where I work or what my exact role is. But I think the core idea of helping young people make good decisions about their education will stay with me.

Part 3 link: Success & Ambition · Job Satisfaction

164. Describe a healthy habit you have

Activities & Ideas · your card 4 · sp2_activities_04 · 252 words (yours: 170)

- what the habit is
- when you started it
- how it helps you
- and why you think it is important

A healthy habit I have developed over the past couple of years is going for a brisk walk every evening. I usually head down to the embankment along the Jamuna, not far from our flat, and walk for about forty minutes as the sun goes down. I started it during a stressful period when I needed a way to clear my head, and it quickly became a daily ritual. At the time, I was working long hours and hardly moving at all, and I could feel it affecting both my energy and my mood. What I love about it is that it is so simple yet genuinely **beneficial**, both physically and mentally. After a long day at a desk, the fresh air and movement are wonderfully **refreshing**. It has noticeably improved my mood and helps me sleep far better at night. Sometimes my younger sister joins me, and we end up having the kind of relaxed conversations we rarely have at home. Honestly, this small habit has had a surprisingly **profound** effect on my overall wellbeing. I think habits like this are important because they are sustainable; unlike intense workouts, a daily walk is ~~easy to maintain~~, something you can **sustain** for years. It requires no equipment or gym membership, just a bit of consistency. I would genuinely recommend it to anyone. It has become one of the most valuable parts of my daily routine, and I would find it hard to give up now, especially on calm evenings when the river looks so **tranquil**.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you still walk during the monsoon? Not always. When it is pouring, I sometimes walk up and down the stairs of our building instead, which my neighbours find rather amusing. But I try not to let the weather become an excuse.

Do you prefer walking alone or with someone? Mostly alone, because it gives me time to think things through. That said, walks with my sister or a friend are lovely too; they are just more about conversation than quiet **reflection**.

Part 3 link: Happiness & Wellbeing · Work-Life Balance

165. Describe a sport or activity you would like to try

Activities & Ideas · your card 5 · sp2_activities_05 · 264 words (yours: 165)

- what it is
- why you want to try it
- how you would prepare for it
- and how you would feel doing it

A sport I have always wanted to try is scuba diving, which has fascinated me for as long as I can remember. The idea of exploring the underwater world, with its vibrant coral and marine life, is genuinely **captivating**. Growing up beside the Jamuna, I spent a lot of time in and around water, but I have only seen the sea a couple of times, at Cox's Bazar. I want to try it because I love the ocean and I am drawn to the sense of adventure it offers. I would most like to do it at Saint Martin's Island, which is the only coral island in Bangladesh. To prepare, I would need to take a proper certified course, since safety is **paramount** in an activity like this. I can swim, as I learned in my grandparents' village pond as a boy, but I would need to build up my stamina and get used to breathing through the equipment. I imagine my first dive would be both terrifying and **exhilarating** in equal measure. I have watched countless videos of divers gliding past shoals of fish, and I always find myself wishing I were there. There is something about entering a completely different environment that appeals to my sense of curiosity. Honestly, I think it would be an **unforgettable** experience, quite unlike anything I have done before. Of course, it requires overcoming a certain amount of fear, but I think that is part of the appeal. It is firmly on my list of things to do, and I am **determined** **resolved** to try it one day.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Would you go diving alone or with friends? Definitely with friends, and of course with a qualified instructor. Sharing something that nerve-racking with people you know makes it less frightening, and it gives you a story to laugh about together afterwards.

Is scuba diving popular in your country? Not really, although it is slowly growing. Most people here see the sea as somewhere to walk along the beach, so diving is still a fairly **niche** activity, mainly for adventurous young people.

Part 3 link: Hobbies & Leisure · Travel & Tourism

166. Describe a positive change you would like to make in your life

Activities & Ideas · your card 6 · sp2_activities_06 · 248 words (yours: 164)

- what the change is
- why you want to make it
- how you would do it
- and how it would improve your life

A positive change I genuinely want to make is to spend less time on my phone and social media. I have noticed that I waste far too many hours **scrolling** mindlessly, which leaves me feeling drained rather than refreshed. It usually starts innocently, checking one message, and suddenly forty minutes have disappeared. I want to make this change because I believe that time could be far better spent on hobbies, exercise or real relationships. Even at the dinner table, which is a special time in my family, I sometimes catch myself glancing at the screen, and I don't like that

about myself. To do it, I plan to set strict limits on certain apps and keep my phone out of reach during meals and before bed. I also want to replace the habit with something better, such as reading a few pages instead of reaching for my phone. I know breaking such an **ingrained** habit will require real **discipline**. Honestly, I think reducing screen time would have a hugely **beneficial** effect on my focus and mental wellbeing. It would allow me to be more **fully present** ~~in the moment~~ instead of constantly distracted. I have already started making small changes, such as turning off notifications for most apps, and I have noticed a difference. I seem to get through my work faster, and I actually finish the books I start. I think in our hyper-connected world, consciously stepping back from technology is one of the healthiest changes a person can make.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Has anyone in your family commented on your phone use? Yes, my mother, many times! She jokes that the phone is my second sister. She means it kindly, but it did make me realise how much of our time together I was wasting.

Do you think you will succeed in making this change? I think so, as long as I am realistic. I don't plan to give up my phone completely, since I need it for work, but cutting down gradually feels **achievable**.

Part 3 link: Smartphones & Devices · Social Media

167. Describe a subject you would like to study in the future

Activities & Ideas · your card 7 · sp2_activities_07 · 259 words (yours: 168)

- what the subject is
- why you are interested in it
- how you would study it
- and how it might help you

A subject I would love to study in the future is psychology, which I find **endlessly fascinating**. I have always been curious about why people think and behave the way they do. I became interested in it after reading a few popular books on the topic, which completely **captivated** me. My job has made that interest even stronger, because I meet many students who are anxious about their future, and I often wish I understood their worries better. I would ideally study it formally, perhaps through a postgraduate course, as I feel it deserves proper, in-depth study. Since my background is in business administration, I might first take a short introductory course online to see whether I can cope with the scientific side of it. What appeals to me most is how **applicable** it is to everyday life; understanding human behaviour is useful in almost any profession. I think it would help me become more **empathetic** and a better communicator, both personally and professionally. In my line of work, being able to read people and put them at ease is half the job. Honestly, I believe it is one of those subjects that genuinely changes how you see the world. You start noticing patterns in your own behaviour, and you become a little more patient with others. It bridges science and human experience in a way I find deeply appealing. It is definitely something I hope to pursue once my circumstances allow, because I think it would enrich both my career and my understanding of the people around me.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Would you like to work as a psychologist? Probably not as a full-time psychologist. I'd rather use what I learn in education and counselling, helping students manage stress and make confident decisions about their studies and careers.

Is psychology a popular subject in your country? It is becoming more popular, especially in Dhaka. A generation ago, people rarely talked about mental health, but young people now are much more open, so interest in the subject has grown **considerably**.

168. Describe a plan you have for the near future

Activities & Ideas · your card 8 · sp2_activities_08 · 251 words (yours: 163)

- what the plan is
- when you made it
- how you will carry it out
- and why it is important to you

A plan I have for the near future is to pursue further studies abroad, which has been a long-held ambition of mine. Ideally, I would like to do a master's in management, probably in the UK or Australia. I made this decision fairly recently, after realising that international experience would greatly benefit my career. Ironically, it was helping other students with their applications every day that finally convinced me to take the step myself. To carry it out, I have been researching universities, preparing for the required exams and saving diligently, since it is quite an **ambitious** undertaking. At the moment, I am working on my IELTS, practising a little every evening after work. The process is genuinely demanding, but I am approaching it in a **methodical**, step-by-step way. My younger sister has been a great help too, quizzing me on vocabulary over dinner. This plan is important to me because I believe studying in a different country would be a hugely **enriching** experience, both academically and personally. It would push me out of my comfort zone and expose me to new perspectives. Honestly, the thought of it is both exciting and slightly nerve-racking, especially the idea of being so far from my family. I know there will be challenges along the way, but I am fully committed to **seeing it through**. It represents a significant investment in my future, and I am determined to make it a reality, so that I can come back with skills that are genuinely **transferable**.

Rounding-off questions (new)

How does your family feel about your plan? They are proud but a little emotional about it. My mother worries about me living alone, while my father keeps reminding me that opportunities like this don't come twice, so I should grab it.

Would you come back to Bangladesh afterwards? Yes, I think so. My family is here, and I would like to use what I learn to help young people from towns like mine. Gaining experience abroad first would be a real bonus, though.

Part 3 link: Studying Abroad · Higher Education

169. Describe a way you like to relax

Activities & Ideas · your card 9 · sp2_activities_09 · 253 words (yours: 161)

- what you do
- when you do it
- where you do it
- and why it helps you relax

A way I love to relax is by listening to music while doing absolutely nothing else. It might sound simple, but in our busy lives, giving yourself permission to just be still is **surprisingly rare** something of a **rarity**. I usually do this in the evening, after we have had dinner as a family, lying on my bed or sitting on the rooftop of our building with a cup of tea. The rooftop is my favourite spot, because it is quiet up there and on clear nights you can feel a gentle breeze coming off the river. What makes it so relaxing is that it lets my mind completely **unwind** after a hectic day. Depending on my mood, I choose calming acoustic tracks or something more uplifting. I never use music as background noise at these times; I give it my full attention, which is what makes the difference. Quite often I end up listening to old Bengali songs that my parents used to play, which

feel like home to me. There is something almost **meditative** about focusing purely on the music and letting my thoughts settle. Honestly, this small ritual has become essential for my mental wellbeing. In a world that constantly demands our attention, having a way to properly **decompress** is genuinely valuable. It costs nothing and asks nothing of me, which is exactly why I love it. I always feel noticeably calmer and more centred afterwards, ready to face whatever comes next, and I think everyone deserves a little **sanctuary** like that.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you use headphones or play the music aloud? Usually headphones, because I don't want to disturb my sister while she's studying. On the rooftop, though, I sometimes play it quietly through my phone, which feels more relaxed and natural.

Have your ways of relaxing changed since you were a child? Quite a lot. As a child I relaxed by running around outside with my cousins. Now I need calm rather than excitement, which I suppose is a natural part of growing older.

Part 3 link: Music & the Arts · Happiness & Wellbeing

170. Describe a daily routine that is good for you

Activities & Ideas · your card 10 · sp2_activities_10 · 265 words (yours: 166)

- what it is
- when you do it
- how you keep it up
- and why it is good for you

A daily routine that has genuinely benefited me is waking up early and having a calm, **unhurried** start to my day. I get up around six, well before I need to, which gives me time for myself before the world wakes up. Our neighbourhood is very quiet at that hour, apart from the birds and the odd rickshaw bell, and I really value that peace. I use this quiet period to plan my day, read a little and enjoy a proper breakfast rather than rushing. My mother is usually up too, so we often share the first cup of tea together before the rest of the family is awake. What makes it so valuable is that it sets a productive, positive tone for everything that follows. I keep it up by going to bed at a reasonable hour, since **discipline** at night makes the mornings easier. I also leave my phone in another room, so I am not tempted to stay up late scrolling. Honestly, starting the day calmly rather than in a panic has had a **remarkable** effect on my mood and focus. It gives me a sense of control that lasts throughout the day, and I rarely feel that I am chasing my own schedule. When I have skipped it, perhaps after a late wedding or a long journey, I can really feel the difference. I think how you begin your morning genuinely shapes the rest of it. This routine has become one of the most **beneficial** habits I have ever developed, and I would recommend it to anyone who feels **perpetually** rushed.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Is it hard to keep this routine at the weekend? A little. On Fridays I sometimes allow myself an extra hour in bed, but I try not to change my sleep pattern too much, because Saturday mornings then feel much harder.

Were you an early riser as a child? Not at all. My mother practically had to drag me out of bed for school. It is funny how things change; now I am often the first one awake in our flat.

Part 3 link: Work-Life Balance · Happiness & Wellbeing

171. Describe a tradition in your country

Activities & Ideas · your card 11 · sp2_activities_11 · 265 words (yours: 165)

- what it is
- when it takes place

- what people do
- and why it is important

A tradition I love in my country is the celebration of Pohela Boishakh, the Bengali New Year. It takes place in mid-April and marks the beginning of the year according to our traditional calendar. It is a public holiday, so almost everyone is free to join in, whatever their background. On this day, people dress in traditional clothes, usually red and white, and the streets come alive with colourful processions, music and fairs. In Sirajganj, there is a big fair, or mela, where you can buy clay toys, handmade crafts and sweets, and children walk around with their faces painted. Many families start the morning with panta bhat, which is soaked rice, served with fried hilsa fish. What I find so special is how it brings the entire community together in a spirit of joy and **renewal**. Families gather to share traditional food, and there is a wonderful sense of **festivity** everywhere. It is important because it celebrates our cultural identity and heritage, which I think is vital to preserve. Unlike religious festivals, it belongs to every Bengali, which makes it wonderfully **inclusive**. In an increasingly globalised world, traditions like this help **keep our roots alive**. Honestly, the atmosphere on that day is genuinely **uplifting**, and it fills people with optimism for the year ahead. Every year I go to the fair with my younger sister, and even though we buy the same sweets and wander past the same stalls, it never loses its charm. I think it is a beautiful example of how a shared tradition can strengthen a whole community's sense of belonging.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Has the way people celebrate it changed? Somewhat. It has become more commercial, with shops running special offers and people posting endless photos online. But the heart of it, dressing up and spending the day together outdoors, has stayed the same.

Do young people still care about this tradition? Very much, in my experience. If anything, young people are the most enthusiastic, because it is colourful, joyful and a chance to **show off** traditional outfits with friends.

Part 3 link: Traditions & Customs · Festivals & Celebrations

172. Describe a festival you enjoy celebrating

Activities & Ideas · your card 12 · sp2_activities_12 · 256 words (yours: 165)

- what it is
- how you celebrate it
- who you celebrate with
- and why you enjoy it

A festival I thoroughly enjoy celebrating is Eid, which is one of the most important occasions in my culture. ~~I celebrate~~ There are actually two Eids each year, but the one after Ramadan is my favourite, because it ~~with my entire extended family, which is~~ follows a ~~big part~~ month of ~~why I love it so much~~ fasting and reflection. The day begins with special prayers at the Eidgah, the open prayer ground, followed by visiting relatives, exchanging gifts and, of course, an enormous feast. The atmosphere is wonderfully **joyous**, with everyone dressed in their finest clothes and children excitedly collecting small gifts of money, which we call salami. I celebrate it with my entire extended family, which is a big part of why I love it so much. We usually spend it at my grandparents' village home, and my elder sister travels up from Dhaka with her husband and children, so the house is full of noise and laughter. My four-year-old nephew always comes straight to me for his salami. What I enjoy most is the strong sense of **togetherness** it creates; in our busy lives, it is one of the few times the whole family gathers. The food, prepared over several days by my mother and grandmother, is absolutely **delectable**. Honestly, the warmth and generosity that fill the day are genuinely heartwarming. It is far more than a religious occasion; it is a celebration of family, gratitude and community, and many people share food with

neighbours and those less fortunate. I always look forward to it, and it leaves me feeling deeply **content** and grateful for the people in my life.

Rounding-off questions (new)

What is your favourite Eid dish? Definitely my mother's shemai, a sweet vermicelli dish cooked with milk and sugar. Eid morning doesn't feel complete until I have had a bowl of it, usually before we even leave for prayers.

Is Eid celebrated differently in cities and villages? A little. In Dhaka it can feel quieter, because so many people travel back to their home districts. In villages it is more communal, with the whole neighbourhood visiting each other's houses throughout the day.

Part 3 link: Festivals & Celebrations · Family & Relationships

173. Describe a piece of advice you would give a young person

Activities & Ideas · your card 13 · sp2_activities_13 · 265 words (yours: 166)

- what the advice is
- why it is important
- who you would give it to
- and how it might help them

A piece of advice I would give to any young person is not to be afraid of failure, but to see it as part of learning. It sounds like a cliché, but I think very few people actually live by it. I think this is genuinely important because so many young people are **paralysed** by the fear of getting things wrong. In my country especially, exam results are treated as a matter of family honour, so failing can feel like a disaster rather than a lesson. I would give this advice to my younger cousins, who sometimes hesitate to try new things in case they fail. I would also share it with the students I meet at work, many of whom are too scared to apply to good universities in case they are rejected. I would tell them that every successful person has failed countless times, and that setbacks are often the most **instructive** experiences of all. The key is to be **resilient** and to keep going. A rejection letter or a poor mark is simply information about what to improve next time, not a judgement on who you are. I believe this mindset could help them enormously, freeing them to take risks and pursue their dreams. Honestly, I wish someone had drilled this into me when I was younger, because I wasted opportunities out of fear. I think teaching young people to embrace failure rather than dread it is one of the most **valuable** **invaluable** lessons we can offer them. It builds courage and confidence for life, and it makes the journey far less **nerve-racking**.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Who gave you the best advice when you were younger? Probably my grandmother. She had little formal education, but she used to say that a tree that bends in the storm doesn't break. It took me years to appreciate how **profound** that was.

Do young people usually listen to advice? Not always, especially if it sounds like a lecture. I think they listen more when advice comes with a personal story, so they can see that you have actually been through it yourself.

Part 3 link: Parenting & Childhood · Role Models

174. Describe a rule at school or work that you agree with

Activities & Ideas · your card 14 · sp2_activities_14 · 256 words (yours: 169)

- what the rule is
- why it exists

- how people follow it
- and why you agree with it

A rule at my workplace that I genuinely agree with is the policy of allowing flexible working hours. I work at an education consultancy, where the workload goes up and down with application deadlines, so this rule makes a real difference. Rather than forcing everyone to arrive at a fixed time, we are allowed to start and finish within a reasonable window. This rule exists because the company recognises that people work best at different times and have different personal commitments. One of my colleagues, for example, drops her children at school every morning, and another prefers to start early and leave before evening. What I appreciate is that it treats employees as responsible adults, ~~which I find refreshing~~, rather than having them constantly **micromanaged**. People follow it responsibly, ensuring their work still gets done, and in my experience it has made everyone more productive. We simply agree on core hours for meetings and keep each other updated. I agree with it strongly because it has noticeably improved **morale** and reduced unnecessary stress, such as ~~commuting~~ sitting in ~~the worst of the~~ rush-hour traffic. Honestly, I think it is a genuinely **progressive** and sensible approach. It has made me far more loyal to the company, and I think it helps us keep good staff, who might otherwise be tempted by bigger firms in Dhaka. I believe rules like this, which trust employees and prioritise results over **rigid** attendance, are the future of work. They create a healthier and more balanced working environment for everyone, and I think other employers would be wise to **follow suit**.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Has anyone ever taken advantage of this rule? Once or twice, someone started arriving very late and missing meetings. Our manager had a quiet word with them, and it was sorted out quickly. On the whole, people respect the trust they are given.

Is there a rule at work you disagree with? Not strongly, but I find the dress code a little formal for days when we don't meet clients. Still, I understand why it exists, since first impressions matter in our line of work.

Part 3 link: Work-Life Balance · Job Satisfaction

175. Describe a film that made a strong impression on you

Activities & Ideas · your card 15 · sp2_activities_15 · 264 words (yours: 169)

- what the film was
- what it was about
- when you watched it
- and why it impressed you

A film that made a lasting impression on me was a drama I watched a couple of years ago about a family overcoming hardship. The story followed a father who loses his livelihood and struggles to keep his children in school, while trying to hide his worries from them. On the surface it was a simple story, but it dealt with its themes in a genuinely **profound** way. I watched it at home on a quiet evening with my parents, expecting light entertainment, and ended up completely **absorbed**. What impressed me most was how realistic and emotionally honest it was; the characters felt like real people rather than actors. The acting was wonderfully **understated**, with no dramatic speeches, just small looks and silences that said everything. There was one scene where the father quietly skips his own meal so the children can eat, and the whole room went silent. By the end, I was genuinely moved, and I found myself thinking about it for days afterwards. My father, who ran a small business for many years, went unusually quiet, and I think it reminded him of some difficult times of his own. It explored ideas about resilience and family in a way that ~~felt deeply relatable~~, really **resonated** with me. Honestly, I think the mark of a great film is that it stays with you long after the credits roll, and this one certainly did. It was far more than mere entertainment; it offered a real **insight** into the human condition. I have

recommended it to many friends since, and it remains one of my favourite films.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Would you watch it again? Yes, but not too soon. It is quite emotionally heavy, so I would save it for the right mood. I suspect I would notice even more details the second time around.

Do you prefer watching films at home or in the cinema? Mostly at home, partly because Sirajganj has limited cinema options. Watching with my family also means we can pause and talk about it, which I actually enjoy more than a silent cinema hall.

Part 3 link: Online Entertainment · Music & the Arts

176. Describe a song or piece of music that is important to you

Activities & Ideas · your card 16 · sp2_activities_16 · 253 words (yours: 167)

- what it is
- when you first heard it
- what it reminds you of
- and why it is important to you

A song that holds real significance for me is a particular folk melody that was often played in my home when I was a child. It is a bhatiali song, a traditional kind of boatman's song from our river region, slow and full of longing. I first heard it as a young boy, and it is deeply tied to memories of my grandparents. My grandfather used to hum it while we sat on the veranda of their village home, watching the boats move slowly along the river in the evening. Whenever I hear it now, it instantly transports me back to those carefree childhood days. What makes it so important is not the song itself but the powerful nostalgia it evokes. The gentle melody and heartfelt lyrics have a wonderfully soothing quality that I find comforting. It is amazing how a single piece of music can carry such emotional weight and instantly bring back a whole era of your life. Honestly, I think this is the true power of music; it becomes intertwined with our memories. My grandfather is in his eighties now, and he still hums it sometimes when we visit, which makes it feel even more precious to me. Listening to it now sometimes brings a tear to my eye, in the best possible way. It is a cherished reminder of my roots and the people I love, and I hope to pass it on one day, perhaps starting with my little nephew, so that it lives on in our family.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do young people in your country still listen to folk music? Fewer than before, but it has had a revival recently. Some young bands mix folk songs with modern instruments, which has introduced them to a whole new audience, especially online.

Can you play or sing this song yourself? I can sing a few lines, though not very well! I once tried learning it on a harmonium, but I didn't have the patience. Maybe I will try again with proper guidance.

Part 3 link: Music & the Arts · Traditions & Customs

177. Describe a website or app you find useful

Activities & Ideas · your card 17 · sp2_activities_17 · 255 words (yours: 167)

- what it is
- what you use it for
- how often you use it
- and why it is useful

A website I find genuinely useful is an online learning platform that offers courses on almost any subject imaginable. I use it regularly to develop new skills related to my work and personal

interests. Over the past year, for instance, I have done a course on digital marketing, which helps with promoting our consultancy, and another on advanced spreadsheets. I usually log on three or four evenings a week, for about an hour, and a bit longer on Fridays. What makes it so useful is how **accessible** it makes education; I can learn from experts around the world without leaving my home. That matters a lot when you live in a smaller town like Sirajganj, where specialist training is hard to find. I have taken several courses on it, and the quality of instruction has been genuinely impressive, with clear videos, short quizzes and forums where you can ask questions and get answers from other learners. It fits perfectly around my busy schedule, since I can learn at my own pace whenever I have free time. Honestly, I think platforms like this are **revolutionising** the way people learn. They **democratise** knowledge that was once available only to a privileged few. I find it incredibly **empowering** to be able to keep learning and improving myself so easily. In a rapidly changing world where continuous learning is essential, I think tools like this are **invaluable**. It has genuinely helped me grow both professionally and personally, and I recommend it to everyone, especially students preparing to study abroad.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Have you ever paid for an online course? Yes, a couple of times, when I needed a proper certificate. Most of what I learn is free, but paying for a course actually makes me more committed, because I don't want to waste the money.

Is online learning as good as learning in a classroom? For practical skills, I think it is almost as good. But a classroom gives you spontaneous discussion and a teacher who notices when you are confused, which is hard to **replicate** online.

Part 3 link: Learning Methods · The Internet & Information

178. Describe an interesting idea you have heard about

Activities & Ideas · your card 18 · sp2_activities_18 · 258 words (yours: 168)

- what the idea is
- where you heard it
- why it is interesting
- and how you feel about it

An interesting idea I came across recently is the concept of a four-day working week, which I find genuinely **intriguing**. I heard about it through an article discussing trials carried out by various companies in Europe. A colleague shared it in our office group chat, and it sparked quite a lively debate over lunch. The basic idea is that people work fewer days but remain just as productive, if not more so. What I find so fascinating is the claim that working less can actually make people more efficient, because they are better rested and more focused. It completely challenges the traditional assumption that longer hours mean more output. In Bangladesh, many people work six days a week, so for us the idea sounds almost like science fiction. Honestly, I think it is a genuinely **revolutionary** idea that could transform work-life balance. Of course, there are practical challenges, and it would not suit every industry. Hospitals, shops and farming, for example, simply cannot stop for three days, so it would probably need a rota system. Still, the **studies** early results suggesting improved wellbeing and unchanged productivity are quite **compelling**. Personally, I feel cautiously optimistic; I would love an extra day for my family and hobbies, but I think it would need to be introduced gradually. I think ideas like this are important because they force us to question **long-held assumptions** about how we live and work. It is definitely a concept I would love to see explored more widely, and I suspect it will gain **momentum** in the future.

Rounding-off questions (new)

What would you do with an extra day off? I would probably visit my grandparents in the village more often and spend more time reading. I might also finally start that public speaking course I keep putting off.

Do you think your employer would try it? Perhaps not straight away, because our busiest periods revolve around university deadlines. But a trial during quieter months could be **feasible**, and I think my manager would at least be open to discussing it.

Part 3 link: The Future of Work · Work-Life Balance

179. Describe a habit you would like to give up

Activities & Ideas · your card 19 · sp2_activities_19 · 261 words (yours: 165)

- what the habit is
- how it started
- why you want to give it up
- and how you plan to do it

A habit I would genuinely like to give up is my tendency to procrastinate, especially with tasks I find unpleasant. Paperwork is the worst example; I will happily reply to twenty student messages to avoid filling in one boring form. It started, I think, as a way of avoiding stress, but over time it has become quite **ingrained**. At university I often left assignments until the night before, and because I usually got away with it, I never learned to change. I want to give it up because it often leaves me rushing at the last minute, which is both stressful and **counterproductive**. I know that if I tackled things sooner, my life would be far calmer and more organised. It also isn't fair on my colleagues when they have to wait for my part of the work. To break the habit, I have started using to-do lists and breaking large tasks into smaller, more **manageable** steps. I have also tried the technique of simply starting a task for five minutes, which often removes the initial reluctance. Once I begin, I usually realise the task is not nearly as bad as I had imagined. I have also started tackling the task I dread most first thing in the morning, while my energy is high. Honestly, procrastination is a surprisingly **stubborn** habit to break, and I have to remain constantly **vigilant**. Still, I have made real progress, and I feel much better when I stay on top of things. It is a work in progress, but one I am fully committed to.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do other people in your family procrastinate? Not really, which makes it more embarrassing! My younger sister is incredibly disciplined and finishes her work days early. She often teases me about it, which is actually good motivation.

Is procrastination always a bad thing? Mostly, yes, but occasionally a little delay helps, because ideas have time to develop. The problem is when it becomes a **chronic** pattern and you are always working under pressure.

Part 3 link: Work-Life Balance · Professional & Soft Skills

180. Describe a personal quality that is important for success

Activities & Ideas · your card 20 · sp2_activities_20 · 254 words (yours: 160)

- what the quality is
- why it is important
- who you know that has it
- and how it leads to success

A personal quality I believe is essential for success is perseverance, the ability to keep going despite setbacks. In my view, talent alone is rarely enough; it is **persistence** that ultimately

makes the difference. I think this is important because the path to any worthwhile goal is inevitably filled with obstacles and failures. Anyone who expects a smooth journey is likely to give up the first time things go wrong. A close friend of mine embodies this quality perfectly; he failed several times before finally building a successful business, but he never gave up. His first venture, a small clothing shop, closed within a year, and his second barely covered its costs. What I admire is his refusal to be **discouraged** by temporary defeats. Each time, he studied what had gone wrong and tried again, and today he runs a thriving online shop. I have seen the same quality in my father, who kept his small business going for over thirty years through floods, price rises and difficult seasons. I genuinely believe that this kind of **resilience** is what separates those who succeed from those who quit. Honestly, in a world that often celebrates instant success, we forget how much quiet, stubborn effort lies behind most achievements. Perseverance keeps you moving forward when motivation fades, and motivation always fades at some point, however excited you were at the start. I think it is one of the most **underrated** qualities a person can have, and it is something I consciously try to **cultivate** in myself.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you think perseverance can be learned? I think so, mostly through experience. Every time you push through a difficulty and see the result, you become a bit more confident that you can do it again next time.

Is there a time you showed perseverance yourself? Getting my first job was one. I had several rejections after graduating, which was disheartening, but I kept improving my CV and interview skills until the consultancy finally offered me a position.

Part 3 link: Success & Ambition · Role Models

181. Describe something you do to help the environment

Activities & Ideas · your card 21 · sp2_activities_21 · 251 words (yours: 167)

- what you do
- when you started
- why you do it
- and how you feel about it

Something I make a conscious effort to do for the environment is reduce my use of single-use plastic. I started a couple of years ago, after seeing some genuinely **alarming** documentaries about ocean pollution. Around the same time, I noticed how much plastic was piling up along the banks of the Jamuna near my home, and it really hit me that this was not just a distant problem. Now I carry a reusable water bottle and cloth shopping bags everywhere, and I avoid plastic packaging wherever I can. Jute bags are easy to find in Bangladesh, so there is really no excuse. I have even persuaded my mother to take a basket to the market instead of coming home with a dozen polythene bags. I do it because I feel we all have a personal responsibility to protect the planet, however small our individual contribution. I am **under no illusion** that my efforts alone will solve the problem, but I believe change starts with individuals. Honestly, I think it is easy to feel helpless about huge issues like climate change, but taking small actions gives me **a sense of agency**. It also makes me more mindful of my consumption in general, and I think twice before buying things I don't really need. I feel genuinely good about doing my part, however modest. I think if enough people adopt these **sustainable** habits, the collective impact could be significant. It is a small change, but it lets me live with a **clear conscience** ~~behind it.~~

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do your friends do the same? A few of them do, and some started after teasing me about my cloth bag. Most still use plastic without thinking, though, so I try to set an example rather than lecture anyone.

What else would you like to do for the environment? I would like to join a riverbank clean-up group, as some young people organise them in our area. Planting a few trees on my grandparents' land in the village would also be a **worthwhile** project.

Part 3 link: Environmental Protection · Sustainability

182. Describe a way you keep fit and healthy

Activities & Ideas · your card 22 · sp2_activities_22 · 256 words (yours: 167)

- what you do
- how often you do it
- how you started
- and why it works for you

A way I keep fit and healthy is by going to the gym a few times a week, which has become an important part of my lifestyle. There is a small gym about ten minutes from our flat, and I usually go on Saturday, Monday and Wednesday evenings after work, for roughly an hour each time. I started a couple of years ago, initially just to lose a little weight, but it soon became something I genuinely enjoy. At first I felt quite self-conscious, because everyone else seemed to know exactly what they were doing, but one of the trainers kindly showed me the basics. What works for me is having a set routine, which keeps me **accountable** and stops me making excuses. Beyond the obvious physical benefits, I find exercise incredibly **therapeutic** for my mental health. After a stressful day, a good workout is the perfect **outlet** for releasing tension. On the days I don't go, I still take a walk by the river, so I am rarely completely inactive, even during the busiest weeks. Honestly, the sense of discipline it has given me has spilled over into other areas of my life. I feel more energetic, sleep better and generally more positive. It required real commitment to make it a habit, but now I would feel restless without it. I think finding a form of exercise you actually enjoy is the key to **sustaining** it long term, and for me, the gym is exactly that, a routine I would find very hard to **abandon**.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you ever go to the gym with a friend? Sometimes, with a university friend who lives nearby. Having a partner helps on days when I feel lazy, because I don't want to let him down, although we do end up chatting more than training.

Is going to the gym popular where you live? It is becoming more popular among young people, even in a modest town like Sirajganj. A few years ago there were hardly any gyms, but now several have opened, which shows how attitudes are changing.

Part 3 link: Happiness & Wellbeing · Hobbies & Leisure

183. Describe a course or class you would like to take

Activities & Ideas · your card 23 · sp2_activities_23 · 256 words (yours: 167)

- what it is
- why you want to take it
- where you would take it
- and how it would benefit you

A course I would genuinely love to take is one in creative writing, something I have long been curious about. I have always enjoyed writing, but I feel my skills are quite **rudimentary** and could benefit from proper guidance. I have a notebook full of half-finished short stories, mostly about village life and my grandparents' generation, but I never quite know how to shape them. I want to take it because writing well is such a valuable and **versatile** skill, useful in almost any field. In my job, for example, I often help students with their personal statements, and I can see how much a well-told story can strengthen an application. I would probably take it online, so I

could fit it around my work, though a face-to-face class with feedback would be ideal. There are occasional workshops in Dhaka, so I might try to attend one when I visit my elder sister. What appeals to me most is the chance to learn techniques from experienced writers and to receive **constructive criticism**. Honestly, I think a good course could help me express my ideas far more clearly and creatively. It would also give me a productive and **fulfilling** hobby outside of work. I believe learning should be a lifelong pursuit, and this is one course I am determined to take eventually. It is exactly the kind of skill that could enrich both my professional and personal life, and who knows, perhaps one day I will finally finish one of those stories and see it **in print**.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Would you write in English or Bengali? Probably both. Bengali feels more natural for stories about village life, because some expressions simply don't translate. But writing in English would help my work and reach a wider audience.

Have you ever shown your writing to anyone? Only to my younger sister, who is a very honest critic. She once told me a story was far too long and rather **repetitive**, which hurt a little, but she was absolutely right.

Part 3 link: Lifelong Learning · Hobbies & Leisure

184. Describe an ambition you have had for a long time

Activities & Ideas · your card 24 · sp2_activities_24 · 270 words (yours: 170)

- what it is
- when you first had it
- what you have done towards it
- and why it matters to you

An ambition I have held for many years is to one day start my own business. I first had this dream as a teenager, watching my father run his small enterprise with such dedication. He ran that business for over thirty years before retiring recently, and I saw both the freedom and the worry it brought him. What has always appealed to me is the idea of building something of my own and being **self-reliant**. More specifically, I would love to open my own education consultancy in Sirajganj, so that students here would not have to travel to Dhaka for reliable advice. Towards this goal, I have been gaining relevant work experience and quietly saving whatever I can. My current job has taught me how the whole process works, from counselling students to dealing with universities and visa requirements. I am also constantly learning about how businesses operate, since I know success requires far more than just a good idea. This ambition matters to me because it represents freedom, creativity and the chance to make a real impact. Honestly, I find the idea both thrilling and slightly **daunting**, given the risks involved. Still, I believe the potential rewards, both financial and personal, are worth it. My father always says that a business is like a child, needing constant care, and I think he is right. I know it will require enormous **perseverance**, but it is a dream I refuse to let go of. With my father's **hard-earned** advice and enough preparation, I am confident that one day ~~with enough preparation,~~ I will make it happen and prove myself as a genuinely **entrepreneurial** person.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Would you ask your father to help with your business? Definitely, at least as an adviser. He knows a great deal about managing money, dealing with customers and surviving difficult years, which is exactly the kind of practical wisdom no textbook can give you.

Do many young people in your country want to start a business? More and more, I think. Many young graduates are frustrated by limited job opportunities, so they start small online businesses. Social media has made it much easier to get started with very little **capital**.

Part 3 link: Success & Ambition · Career Choices

185. Describe a game or sport you enjoy playing or watching

Activities & Ideas · your card 25 · sp2_activities_25 · 254 words (yours: 166)

- what it is
- how you got into it
- how often you play or watch
- and why you enjoy it

A sport I absolutely love ~~both playing and watching~~, is cricket, which is almost a national obsession in my country. These days I mostly watch it, but I played a great deal when I was younger. I got into it as a child, playing casual games in the street with the neighbourhood kids, using a taped tennis ball and a bat my father bought me from the local market. What I love about it is the wonderful blend of strategy, skill and teamwork. As a spectator, I find major matches genuinely **thrilling**, especially when the national team is playing. I watch almost every international match Bangladesh plays, usually at home with my father, who analyses every shot as if he were the coach. The atmosphere during a big game is electric, and the whole country seems to come to a standstill. Honestly, there is a special sense of **unity** that cricket brings, uniting people across all backgrounds. I still ~~play casually~~ join a friendly game with old friends ~~whenever I can~~, now and then during the holidays, as it is a fun way to stay active. What makes it so **captivating** is its unpredictability; a match can turn completely in a single moment. Some of the most **nail-biting** evenings of my life have been spent in front of the television, waiting for the final ball. I think its enduring popularity here is thoroughly deserved. For me, cricket is far more than a game; it is a shared passion that connects millions of people and brings my family together in front of the screen.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Have you ever watched a match in a stadium? Only once, in Dhaka, when I was staying with my elder sister. The noise and the sea of red and green shirts were unforgettable, although honestly you see the action more clearly on television.

Do women in your family enjoy cricket too? Yes, my younger sister is just as passionate as I am, and even my mother keeps an eye on the score during big matches. Cricket really is a family affair in our **household**.

Part 3 link: Hobbies & Leisure · Fame & Celebrity

186. Describe a way you have changed in the last few years

Activities & Ideas · your card 26 · sp2_activities_26 · 258 words (yours: 164)

- what the change is
- what caused it
- how it has affected you
- and how you feel about it

A significant way I have changed over the last few years is that I have become far more patient and self-assured. In my younger days, I was quite **impulsive** and would get frustrated easily when things did not go my way. At university, I would argue with friends over the smallest things and make hasty decisions I later regretted. I think this change came about through a combination of life experience and facing a few genuine challenges. Starting work played a big part, because dealing with worried students and demanding deadlines forced me to stay calm. Around the same time, my father retired, and I found myself taking on more responsibility at home. Overcoming difficulties taught me that most problems are temporary and that panicking rarely helps. As a result, I now approach setbacks far more calmly and rationally. This shift has affected me profoundly; I feel more **grounded** and less anxious than I used to. It has also improved my

relationships, as I listen more and react less. Honestly, I am genuinely pleased with this change, because it has made me a more balanced person. I think personal growth like this is one of the quiet rewards of getting older. I no longer **sweat the small things** the way I once did. My mother says I have become more like my grandfather, which I take as the highest compliment. It is a change I am proud of, and it is genuinely **liberating** to feel this much calmer, as though a weight has been lifted from my shoulders.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Did anyone help you make this change? My grandfather, in a quiet way. Whenever I got worked up, he would just smile and tell me that no problem lasts forever. Seeing how calm he stays, even in his eighties, taught me a lot.

Is there anything about your younger self you miss? Perhaps a little of the fearlessness. When I was younger, I would try things without overthinking. Now I am more cautious, which is sensible, but occasionally I wish I were more **spontaneous**.

Part 3 link: Emotional Intelligence · Generational Differences

187. Describe something you would like to be better at

Activities & Ideas · your card 27 · sp2_activities_27 · 255 words (yours: 169)

- what it is
- why you want to improve
- how you would improve
- and how it would help you

Something I would genuinely like to be better at is managing my time more effectively. While I am fairly organised, I often find myself struggling to fit everything in, which leaves me feeling **stretched**. Between work, my IELTS preparation, family commitments and trying to keep up my reading, there never seem to be enough hours in the day. I am constantly **juggling** different things and rarely feel I am giving any of them my full attention. I want to improve because I believe better time management would reduce my stress and make me far more productive. To improve, I have started using planning tools and trying to prioritise my tasks more **ruthlessly**, focusing on what truly matters. Every Friday evening I sit down and plan the week ahead, which already helps, because I start Saturday knowing exactly what needs doing first. I am also learning to say no to commitments that are not worth my time, which is surprisingly hard in a culture where refusing an invitation can seem rude. Honestly, I think time is our most precious resource, and using it wisely is one of the most valuable skills a person can develop. If I mastered it, I believe I could achieve far more while feeling less **overwhelmed**. It would give me more time for the things I actually enjoy, like evening walks and dinner with my family, which is the whole point. It is an ongoing effort, but even small improvements have already made a noticeable and **tangible** difference to my daily life.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Who in your family manages time best? My younger sister, without question. She plans her study schedule weeks in advance and actually sticks to it. I have started borrowing some of her methods, although I would never admit that to her.

Do you think people were better at managing time in the past? Perhaps they had fewer distractions. My father's generation didn't have phones constantly buzzing, so it was easier to focus. Today the challenge is less about time and more about attention.

Part 3 link: Work-Life Balance · Professional & Soft Skills

188. Describe a skill you think everyone should have

Activities & Ideas · your card 28 · sp2_activities_28 · 264 words (yours: 165)

- what the skill is
- why it is important
- how people can learn it
- and how it benefits people

A skill I firmly believe everyone should have is basic cooking. In my view, it is a genuinely essential life skill that far too many people **neglect**. In Bangladesh, many young men grow up never having to cook, because mothers usually take care of the kitchen, and I was exactly the same until a few years ago. It is important because it directly affects your health, your finances and your independence. Relying entirely on takeaways and processed food is both expensive and unhealthy, whereas cooking allows you to eat well and **affordably**. This is especially relevant for students going abroad, and I always tell the students I advise to learn a few dishes before they leave. People can learn it easily these days, with countless free tutorials available online, so there really is no excuse. Honestly, I think learning to cook is one of the most practical and **empowering** things a person can do. It gives you control over what you put into your body, and it means you are never stuck when you end up living on your own. Beyond the health benefits, I find cooking to be a surprisingly **therapeutic** and creative activity. I ~~taught myself~~ learned a few years ago, when my mother spent several weeks in the village looking after my grandparents, and ~~it~~ she taught me the basics over the phone. Those weeks of burnt rice and oversalted dal were **humbling**, but they transformed my daily life for the better. I genuinely believe that if everyone learned to cook a few simple meals, both public health and personal wellbeing would improve considerably.

Rounding-off questions (new)

What dish can you cook best? Probably chicken curry with rice. It took me many attempts to get the spices right, but now even my mother says it is quite good, which is high praise from her.

Should cooking be taught in schools? I think so, at least the basics. It would help both boys and girls become more independent, and it could also challenge the old idea that cooking is only a woman's **responsibility**.

Part 3 link: Food & Cuisine · Skills & Qualifications

189. Describe a way technology has changed the way we live

Activities & Ideas · your card 29 · sp2_activities_29 · 262 words (yours: 169)

- what the change is
- how it happened
- what life was like before
- and how you feel about it

A way technology has profoundly changed our lives is in how we communicate with one another. The rise of smartphones and social media has made staying in touch almost **instantaneous**, regardless of distance. This happened incredibly quickly; within about a decade, cheap smartphones and mobile internet reached almost every corner of Bangladesh, even villages like my grandparents'. In the past, keeping in contact with faraway friends and family relied on letters or expensive phone calls, which now seems almost unimaginable. My father still remembers queuing at a shop in town to make a short, crackly call to a relative in Dhaka, and letters took over a week to arrive. Today, a video call across continents is effortless and free, which is genuinely **remarkable**. I speak to my elder sister in Dhaka almost every day, and my nephew loves showing me his toys on the screen. On the whole, I think this change has been overwhelmingly positive, keeping relationships alive that might otherwise have faded. However, I do have some **reservations**; I feel it has sometimes replaced deeper, face-to-face interaction

with shallower digital contact. There is a certain irony that we are more connected than ever yet arguably lonelier. At family gatherings, I sometimes notice everyone staring at their phones instead of talking to the people sitting right next to them. Honestly, like most technology, I think it is a **double-edged sword**. Used mindfully, it is an incredible tool, but it requires a degree of **discipline**. Overall, though, I am grateful for how it has shrunk the world and brought distant people closer.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do your grandparents use video calls? My grandfather does, surprisingly well for someone in his eighties. My grandmother prefers ordinary calls, because she finds it strange to see her own face on the screen, which always makes us laugh.

Do you still write letters or cards? Almost never, sadly. I do sometimes write a card for Eid or a birthday, and people seem to **treasure** them far more than a message, precisely because they are so rare now.

Part 3 link: Digital Communication · Smartphones & Devices

190. Describe a cultural event you would like to attend

Activities & Ideas · your card 30 · sp2_activities_30 · 257 words (yours: 172)

- what it is
- where it takes place
- why you want to attend
- and how you would feel there

A cultural event I would love to attend is the Lalon festival, a large traditional music gathering held every year in Kushtia, in the west of Bangladesh. It celebrates Lalon, a nineteenth-century mystic poet and ~~dance festival held annually in my~~ songwriter whose songs are still sung all over the country. Although I have seen it on television, I have never experienced it in person, which I would genuinely love to change. It takes place over several days at his shrine and showcases performers from all over the region, especially Baul singers, the wandering minstrels in their saffron robes. Kushtia is not too far from Sirajganj, so it would be quite easy to get there by bus, and I could stay for a couple of nights. I want to attend because I believe experiencing such an event live would be far more **immersive** and moving than watching a screen. What draws me to it is the celebration of our rich cultural **heritage**, which I think is increasingly important to preserve. Lalon's songs are about humanity and questioning divisions between people, and I find that message still feels **timeless**. I imagine the atmosphere would be absolutely **electric**, surrounded by thousands of people sharing the same appreciation for the art. Honestly, I think events like this are vital for keeping traditions alive and passing them to younger generations. It would be a wonderfully **enriching** experience, deepening my connection to my own culture. It is definitely on my list of things to do, and I hope to attend it next year with a couple of friends.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Would you take your family with you? Probably not the first time, as it gets very crowded and the music goes on late into the night. I would go with friends first, and perhaps take my younger sister another year.

Are cultural events like this popular with young people? More than you might expect. Many young people find Baul music refreshingly **authentic** compared with commercial pop, and some modern bands have even recorded new versions of Lalon's songs.

Part 3 link: Traditions & Customs · Music & the Arts

191. Describe a challenge that young people face today

Activities & Ideas · your card 31 · sp2_activities_31 · 266 words (yours: 166)

- what the challenge is
- why it exists
- who it affects
- and how you think it could be solved

A significant challenge facing young people today is the immense pressure created by social media. In my view, constant exposure to carefully curated, idealised versions of other people's lives has become genuinely **detrimental** to mental health. Everyone seems to be on holiday, getting engaged or landing a dream job, and it is easy to forget that these are just the highlights. This exists because platforms are designed to be **addictive**, encouraging endless comparison. The more time we spend scrolling, the more money these companies make, so they have little reason to change. It affects almost all young people, who often feel inadequate when measuring their real lives against these unrealistic highlights. I see it in my younger sister's friends, who worry about how many likes a photo gets, and in some of the students I advise, who compare themselves with classmates who have already gone abroad. I think it can lead to serious anxiety and a distorted sense of self-worth. To tackle it, I believe we need better education about using social media **mindfully**, along with a cultural shift towards valuing authenticity over appearances. Parents and teachers also need to talk about it openly, rather than simply banning phones. Honestly, I think the platforms themselves should also **bear some responsibility** for their design. It is a complex issue without a simple solution. Having grown up alongside this technology, I have felt its effects personally. I think raising awareness is the crucial first step, helping young people understand that what they see online is rarely the full, honest picture, and that real life is far more **nuanced**.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you think this problem is worse for girls or boys? It affects both, but perhaps differently. Girls often face more pressure about appearance, while boys feel pressure to look successful or wealthy. Neither is healthy, and both deserve more attention.

Would you ever give up social media completely? Probably not, because I use it to stay in touch with family and for work. But I have become far more **selective**, unfollowing accounts that make me feel worse rather than better.

Part 3 link: Social Media · Peer Pressure

192. Describe an important decision about your future you need to make

Activities & Ideas · your card 32 · sp2_activities_32 · 257 words (yours: 170)

- what the decision is
- why you need to make it
- what the options are
- and how you feel about it

An important decision I currently need to make about my future is whether to pursue further studies abroad or continue building my career at home. It is a genuinely **pivotal** choice that will shape the next several years of my life. I need to make it because application deadlines for next year's intake are approaching, and universities will not wait for me to make up my mind. On one hand, studying abroad would offer invaluable experience and open new doors, but it is expensive and involves leaving my family. My father has recently retired, and my mother often travels to the village to look after my grandparents, so I feel a certain responsibility to be around. On the other hand, staying would mean steady progress but perhaps fewer opportunities for growth. I have a good position at my consultancy, and my manager has hinted that more responsibility may come my way soon. I need to make this decision soon, which makes it feel quite **pressing**.

Honestly, I keep **going back and forth**, weighing the potential rewards against the risks and sacrifices. It is a rather **daunting** choice, precisely because both paths have real merit. I have been seeking advice from people I trust, including my father and my elder sister, and trying to think about what truly matters to me in the long run. Whatever I decide, I want it to be a well-considered choice rather than an **impulsive** one. I am confident I will eventually reach a sensible conclusion, and that I will have no regrets.

Rounding-off questions (new)

What does your family advise you to do? My father encourages me to go, saying that he and my sister can manage things at home. My mother is more hesitant, although she would never stop me. Their support makes the decision a little easier.

How do you usually make big decisions? I write down the pros and cons, talk to a few people I trust, and then give myself a few days. Rushing never works for me; I need time for things to **sink in**.

Part 3 link: Studying Abroad · Career Choices

193. Describe a useful habit for managing money

Activities & Ideas · your card 33 · sp2_activities_33 · 252 words (yours: 169)

- what the habit is
- how you developed it
- how it helps you
- and why you would recommend it

A useful habit I have developed for managing money is setting aside a fixed amount of savings every single month, before spending on anything else. I developed this habit a few years ago, after realising I was spending rather **carelessly** and never managing to save. When I got my first salary, I spent it on eating out and new gadgets, and by the end of the month there was nothing left. My father, who ran a small business for over thirty years, sat me down and explained how he had always put something aside, even in difficult years. Now, as soon as I receive my ~~income~~ salary, I transfer a set portion into a separate savings account. What makes it so effective is that it removes the temptation to spend that money, since it is out of sight. This habit has given me a genuine sense of **financial security** and a safety net for emergencies. It is also how I am funding my plans to study abroad, which would be impossible otherwise. Honestly, it has been one of the most **beneficial** financial decisions I have ever made. I would strongly recommend it to anyone, because it makes saving automatic rather than an afterthought. The key is to treat savings as a non-negotiable expense, just like any other bill. Over time, even small, consistent amounts add up **considerably**. It has taught me the value of discipline and **delayed gratification**, which are invaluable lessons in life, and I am grateful my father taught me early.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do young people in your country usually save money? Many try, but it is not easy with rising prices and the pressure to keep up with friends. Mobile banking has made saving simpler, though, and I think financial awareness is gradually improving.

Have you taught this habit to anyone else? Yes, my younger sister. I encouraged her to save a small part of her pocket money every month, and she was delighted when she could buy her own books without asking our parents.

Part 3 link: Money & Wealth · Consumer Behaviour & Shopping

194. Describe a social problem you care about

Activities & Ideas · your card 34 · sp2_activities_34 · 264 words (yours: 171)

- what the problem is

- why it matters to you
- who it affects
- and what could be done about it

A social problem I care deeply about is the lack of quality education available to children from poorer backgrounds. In my country, a child's future is too often determined by the wealth of their family, which I find genuinely **unjust**. Wealthier families can pay for private tutors and good schools, while poorer children often sit in overcrowded classrooms with too few teachers. This matters to me because I believe education is the most powerful tool for breaking the cycle of poverty. I also see it every day in my work, where the students who reach us are usually the lucky ones who had support from the start. It affects millions of talented children who never get the chance to **fulfil their potential** simply due to their circumstances. Near my hometown, for example, there are children living on the char lands, the river islands of the Jamuna, who have to cross the river by boat just to reach school, and many simply drop out. I think this is a tragic waste of human potential. To address it, I believe there needs to be far greater investment in public schools and more scholarship opportunities for the **disadvantaged**. Better pay for rural teachers would also help attract talented people. Honestly, I think providing equal access to good education is one of the most important things any society can do. It is an issue I feel strongly about, and I try to support relevant charities where I can. I genuinely believe that giving every child a fair start would create a more **equitable** and prosperous society for everyone.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Have you ever volunteered to help with this problem? A little. During university, I taught basic English to children in my grandparents' village during the holidays. It was only a few weeks, but seeing their enthusiasm was incredibly **rewarding**.

Do you think the situation is improving? Slowly, yes. More girls are in school now than a generation ago, and mobile phones give some access to online lessons. But the gap in quality between rich and poor areas is still very wide.

Part 3 link: Equality & Social Justice · Education Systems

195. Describe an outdoor activity you enjoy

Activities & Ideas · your card 35 · sp2_activities_35 · 266 words (yours: 167)

- what it is
- where you do it
- who you do it with
- and why you enjoy it

An outdoor activity I thoroughly enjoy is hiking, particularly in the **hilly** hill areas **outside** of Sylhet and Bandarban. Sirajganj itself is completely flat, so I usually go on a trip once or twice a year, often during the **city-** cooler winter months when the trails are dry. I usually go with a small group of close friends from university, which makes it even more enjoyable. We share the planning, travel overnight by bus and stay in simple guesthouses, which is all part of the adventure. What I love about it is the wonderful combination of exercise, fresh air and stunning scenery. After **being cooped up in the city**, months of office work and busy roads, spending a **day** few days in nature is genuinely **rejuvenating**. There is something deeply satisfying about reaching the top of a trail after a challenging climb and being rewarded with a **breathtaking** view. In Bandarban, you can sometimes stand above the clouds in the early morning, which I will never forget. Honestly, I find hiking to be both physically and mentally **restorative**; it clears my head like nothing else. It is also a great way to bond with friends, away from the distractions of daily life, as the phone signal is often weak anyway. I think spending time in nature is something modern life sorely lacks, and hiking is my favourite way to reconnect with it. Between trips, I make do with long walks along the river at home. I always return home feeling tired but genuinely **content**. It is easily one of my

favourite ways to spend a ~~weekend~~ holiday, and I am already counting down to our next excursion.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Does your family worry when you go hiking? My mother certainly does. She makes me promise to call her every evening and to avoid dangerous trails in the rainy season. It is a small price to pay for her peace of mind.

Would you like to hike in another country? Very much. I would love to trek in Nepal one day, perhaps on one of the shorter routes in the Himalayas. The scenery there must be even more awe-inspiring than anything we have here.

Part 3 link: Hobbies & Leisure · Public Spaces

196. Describe a new activity you have started recently

Activities & Ideas · your card 36 · sp2_activities_36 · 252 words (yours: 167)

- what it is
- when you started
- why you started it
- and how you feel about it

A new activity I have taken up recently is journaling, or writing down my thoughts each day. I started it a few months ago, after reading about its benefits for mental clarity and wellbeing. I bought a simple notebook from a stationery shop near my office, and I write in a mixture of Bengali and English, depending on what feels more natural. I began it because I often felt my mind was cluttered and I wanted a way to process my thoughts. Work had been particularly busy, and I was also thinking a lot about my future and whether to study abroad, so my head was full of unfinished worries. What I have discovered is that putting things down on paper is surprisingly therapeutic; it helps me make sense of my feelings. Each evening I spend a few minutes reflecting on my day, which has become a calming ritual. I usually write after dinner, when the house is quiet, sitting at my desk with a cup of tea. Honestly, I have found it far more beneficial than I expected. It has helped me become more self-aware and has noticeably reduced my stress. I also enjoy being able to look back and see how my thoughts have evolved over time; problems that felt huge a few months ago now seem quite small. I think it is a wonderfully simple yet rewarding practice. I intend to keep it up, as it has quickly become one of the most valuable parts of my daily routine.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Would you let anyone read your journal? Definitely not! It is completely private, which is exactly why I can be honest in it. My younger sister once tried to peek, and I have hidden it more carefully ever since.

Do you think journaling suits everyone? Not necessarily. Some people prefer talking things through or exercising to clear their minds. But I think anyone who tends to overthink would benefit from trying it for a few weeks.

Part 3 link: Happiness & Wellbeing · Hobbies & Leisure

197. Describe how you like to spend your weekends

Activities & Ideas · your card 37 · sp2_activities_37 · 267 words (yours: 168)

- what you usually do
- who you spend time with
- where you go
- and why you enjoy it

I like to spend my weekends striking a balance between relaxation and being productive. In Bangladesh, the weekend is Friday and Saturday, so it has a slightly different rhythm from the West. After a demanding week, my priority is usually to properly **unwind** and recharge. I often start by catching up on sleep, which I sacrifice during the week. On Friday, I go to the mosque with my father for the midday prayer, and afterwards the whole family has a big lunch together, which is the highlight of my week. I then like to meet friends or family, perhaps for a meal or a simple outing, since spending time with loved ones is genuinely **restorative**. Once or twice a month, we take the bus to my grandparents' village home, where I sit with my grandfather and listen to his stories. I also try to fit in some of my hobbies, like reading or ~~hiking~~, walking along the Jamuna, which I never have time for during the week. On Saturday evenings, I often meet a couple of old friends at a tea stall near the river. What I enjoy most is the freedom and lack of a rigid schedule; I can be **spontaneous** and do whatever I feel like. Honestly, I think weekends are essential for maintaining a healthy work-life balance. Without that break, the weeks would blur into one exhausting stretch. I make a conscious effort not to let work spill into them. A good weekend leaves me feeling refreshed and genuinely **reinvigorated**, ready to face the week ahead with renewed energy and a clear **sense of perspective**.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Do you ever work at the weekend? Occasionally, when application deadlines are close and students need urgent help. I don't mind now and then, but I try hard not to let it become a habit.

Were your weekends different when you were a child? Completely. As a child, I spent weekends playing cricket in the street from morning till evening. Now I value rest and conversation far more, which I suppose is a sign of growing up.

Part 3 link: Work-Life Balance · Hobbies & Leisure

198. Describe an important lesson you have learned in life

Activities & Ideas · your card 38 · sp2_activities_38 · 255 words (yours: 169)

- what the lesson is
- how you learned it
- why it is important
- and how it has affected you

An important lesson I have learned in life is that failure is not something to be feared, but a valuable teacher. I learned this the hard way, after failing at something I had worked hard for and initially feeling completely **demoralised**. After school, I prepared for months for the admission test of a well-known public university, but I missed out on a place by a small margin. For weeks, I barely wanted to leave the house, and I felt I had let my parents down. In time, however, I came to see that the setback taught me far more than easy success ever could. I went on to study business administration at another university, worked hard and discovered a field I truly enjoy. This lesson is important because the fear of failure holds so many people back from even trying. Once I embraced the idea that mistakes are simply part of growth, I became far more **resilient** and willing to take risks. Honestly, this shift in mindset has been genuinely **transformative**. I now approach challenges with curiosity rather than dread. It has affected every area of my life, from my career to my personal relationships. At work, I now share this story with students who receive rejection letters, and it seems to **reassure** them. I think it is one of the most **liberating** realisations a person can have. Understanding that failing is part of succeeding has given me the courage to pursue things I once would have avoided entirely, including my plan to study abroad.

Rounding-off questions (new)

How did your parents react when you failed that test? Much better than I expected. My father told me he had faced many losses in business and still recovered, and my mother simply

cooked my favourite food. Their calm reaction really helped me move on.

Do you think schools should teach this lesson? Yes, definitely. Schools here focus so heavily on results that children see failure as shameful. Teachers could normalise mistakes by showing how every expert once struggled as a beginner.

Part 3 link: Parenting & Childhood · Education Systems

199. Describe a hobby that is popular in your country

Activities & Ideas · your card 39 · sp2_activities_39 · 251 words (yours: 168)

- what it is
- who does it
- why it is popular
- and how you feel about it

A hobby that is enormously popular in my country is playing and watching cricket. It is genuinely a national passion, cutting across all ages and social backgrounds. You will find children playing it in narrow alleys and open fields all over the country, using whatever equipment they can find. Boys have always dominated, but more and more girls are joining in too, partly inspired by the success of our women's team. Even older men, like my father, follow every ball on television and discuss matches at the tea stall for days afterwards. It is popular partly because it requires very little to get started, making it wonderfully accessible to everyone. A tennis ball, some tape and a plank of wood are really all you need. I think its popularity also stems from the sense of unity and pride it brings, especially when the national team performs well. During major matches, the whole country seems to come to a standstill, which is quite remarkable. Honestly, I think it is a wonderful thing for a nation to share such a common passion. It brings people together in a way few other things can. I am very fond of it myself, ~~both~~ mostly as a ~~player~~ spectator these days, though I played constantly as a boy. My only slight concern is that cricket overshadows other sports, like football, which receive far less attention and ~~a-spectator-~~ investment. Still, I believe this shared enthusiasm is a genuinely unifying force, and it is a lovely part of our national identity.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Is cricket more popular than football in your country? Nowadays, yes, although football was once hugely popular too. During the World Cup, people still fly Argentina and Brazil flags from their rooftops, so football hasn't disappeared, it just comes in waves.

Do you think this hobby will stay popular in the future? I am fairly sure it will. It is so deeply rooted in our culture, and every new generation grows up playing it in the street. It is hard to imagine Bangladesh without cricket.

Part 3 link: Hobbies & Leisure · Fame & Celebrity

200. Describe a way people can lead a healthier lifestyle

Activities & Ideas · your card 40 · sp2_activities_40 · 246 words (yours: 173)

- what the way is
- why it works
- who could benefit from it
- and how you feel about it

A simple but effective way people can lead a healthier lifestyle is by incorporating more physical activity into their daily routine, without needing a gym. In my view, small changes like walking instead of driving for short trips, or taking the stairs, can be genuinely transformative over time. In Bangladesh, for example, many people take a rickshaw even for a five-minute journey, when walking would be just as quick and far healthier. This works because it does not require a

huge, intimidating commitment; it simply builds movement into everyday life. You don't need special clothes, money or even extra time, which removes most of the usual excuses. Almost anyone could benefit from this, particularly people with **sedentary**, desk-based jobs like mine. Older people could benefit too; since my father retired, he has started walking to the market every morning, and he says he feels years younger. I think the reason many people fail to get fit is that they set unrealistic goals and quickly become **discouraged**. A gentler, more **sustainable** approach is far more likely to stick. Honestly, I feel strongly that health is our most precious asset, yet we **neglect** **take it for granted** until something goes wrong. Combining a little more movement with a balanced diet is a genuinely practical path to better health. It is something I try to practise myself, with my evening walks by the river, and I would encourage everyone to do the same. Small, consistent steps really do add up.

Rounding-off questions (new)

Is it easy to walk in your town? In quieter areas, yes, but the main roads can be crowded and there aren't always proper footpaths. The river embankment is ideal, though, which is why it is always busy in the evenings.

Do you think your family lives a healthy lifestyle? Mostly, yes. We eat home-cooked food and rarely have takeaways. The weak point is probably our love of sweets and oily snacks, especially during festivals, which is hard to **resist**.

Part 3 link: Happiness & Wellbeing · Public Spaces

Part 3 · Discussion

Role Models

People & Relationships · sp3_people_01 · 1 of 8 answers edited

1. Do you think it is important for young people to have role models? (Opinion)

I believe it is absolutely vital for adolescents to have someone to look up to. Role models act as a kind of moral compass, offering guidance on how to navigate life. When a young person admires a professional, they are **internalising** the values of hard work and **perseverance** that led to that success. Without such figures, young people can feel a little **unmoored**, lacking any real sense of direction.

2. How have the types of role models changed since your grandparents' time?

(Comparison)

There has been a rather dramatic shift, I would say. In my grandparents' era, role models tended to be figures within the immediate community, such as teachers or elders. Today, influence is increasingly **dominated** by celebrities and social media personalities, many of whom are famous for very little of substance. I find this shift somewhat concerning, because fame has become almost entirely **disconnected** from genuine **merit**.

3. How do role models affect the way people behave in a society? (Social Impact)

They have a profound ripple effect, in my opinion. When influential figures behave ethically, they set a positive standard that others tend to **emulate**. Conversely, when role models behave badly, it can **normalise** that behaviour, particularly among impressionable young people. So I would argue they play a significant part in shaping a society's **collective** values.

4. Why do some public figures fail to remain positive role models over time? (Cause & Effect)

I think the main reason is the immense pressure and **scrutiny** that come with public life. Constant attention can distort a person's judgement, and some become **complacent** once they achieve fame. There is also the temptation of wealth and power, which can gradually **erode** the very values that made them admirable in the first place. Sadly, staying grounded under that spotlight is genuinely difficult.

5. In the future, do you think AI or fictional characters could become role models?

(Future)

It is quite possible, and to some extent it is already happening. Virtual influencers are becoming increasingly **prevalent**, and young people do form attachments to fictional heroes. However, I would be somewhat **wary** of this trend, because a fabricated character lacks the real struggles that make human role models relatable. I think something genuinely **authentic** would be lost in that shift.

6. What can be done to encourage young people to choose positive role models?

(Problem & Solution)

Education is key, I believe. Parents and schools should actively help children think **critically** about who they admire and why. Rather than simply banning certain influences, which rarely works, we should **cultivate** media literacy so young people can distinguish substance from mere celebrity. Highlighting inspiring local figures would also provide more **attainable** and grounded examples to follow.

7. Do you think people are more influenced by role models in real life or in the media? (Comparison)

That is an interesting question. I would argue that media figures have a wider reach, but real-life role models, like a parent or mentor, have a far deeper and more **lasting impact**. The influence of a media personality is often **superficial** and **fleeting**, whereas someone you interact with

daily shapes your character in a much more meaningful way.

8. Some people say governments should promote positive role models. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I partly agree. Governments can certainly **showcase** admirable citizens, such as scientists or humanitarians, to counterbalance shallow celebrity culture. However, I am slightly cautious, because state-endorsed role models can easily become **propaganda** if handled poorly. So while the intention is commendable, it needs to be done **transparently** and without any political agenda.

Family & Relationships

People & Relationships · sp3_people_02 · 2 of 8 answers edited

1. Do you think family is as important today as it was in the past? (Opinion)

I would say family remains just as important, though its form has changed. The emotional support and sense of **belonging** a family provides are timeless human needs. That said, modern life has certainly **strained** family bonds, with people moving away for work and spending less time together. So while its importance is **undiminished**, sustaining it now requires more conscious effort.

2. How are family relationships different now compared to a generation ago? (Comparison)

The biggest difference is probably the shift from large, extended families to smaller, more **nuclear** ones. In the past, several generations often lived under one roof, which fostered close bonds. Today, families are more **dispersed**, and technology has, ironically, both connected and **distanced** us. Relationships are more equal now, but arguably less tightly knit.

3. Why do you think many families spend less time together nowadays? (Cause & Effect)

Several factors are at play. The demands of modern careers are **relentless**, leaving parents exhausted and **time-poor**. On top of that, digital devices have become a real distraction, with family members often absorbed in their own screens even when in the same room. This gradual erosion of shared time is genuinely **detrimental** to close relationships.

4. What role does the extended family play in your culture? (Social Impact)

In my culture, the extended family remains absolutely central. Grandparents, uncles and cousins are deeply involved in one another's lives, providing a strong support network. This **interdependence** means that responsibilities, from childcare to financial help, are often shared. I think this **collective** approach offers a real sense of security, though it can occasionally feel a little **intrusive**.

5. How do you think family structures will change in the future? (Future)

I anticipate that families will continue to become smaller and more diverse in form. We will likely see more single-parent households and **blended families** becoming **commonplace** and widely accepted. Technology may also allow **far-flung** relatives to stay connected more easily. Overall, I think the definition of family will grow more flexible and inclusive.

6. What can families do to stay close despite busy modern lives? (Problem & Solution)

I think the key is being **intentional** about spending time together. Simple rituals, like sharing at least one meal a day without phones, can make a real difference. Families could also **prioritise** occasional trips or activities that create shared memories. Ultimately, closeness does not happen by accident; it has to be actively **nurtured** amid the busyness.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of living with extended family? (Adv & Disadv)

The main advantage is the constant support; there is always someone to help with childcare or during a crisis, which is **invaluable**. It also passes down traditions and keeps bonds strong. On the downside, it can mean a lack of privacy and occasional **friction** between generations with differing views. So it is really a trade-off between **solidarity** and personal independence.

8. Some believe children should care for their parents in old age. Do you agree?

(Agree / Disagree)

I strongly agree, at least in principle. In my culture, caring for elderly parents is seen as a moral **obligation**, a way of repaying the sacrifices they made. That said, I recognise this is not always practical in modern life, so it need not mean living together. What matters is that the elderly are not **neglected** and retain their **dignity**.

Friendship

People & Relationships · sp3_people_03 · 6 of 8 answers edited

1. Do you think it is better to have a few close friends or many acquaintances?

(Opinion)

I firmly believe that quality trumps quantity when it comes to friendship. A few close friends who genuinely understand you provide far deeper support than a large circle of **superficial** acquaintances. While it is useful to have a wide network for professional reasons, the emotional **intimacy** of a true friendship is something that simply cannot be **replicated** at scale.

2. How has technology changed the way people make friends? (Comparison)

Technology has transformed it enormously. People now form friendships online with others across the globe, which was **unimaginable** a generation ago. This has made connection more **accessible**, but I would argue these digital friendships can be more **fragile**. Meeting through a screen sometimes lacks the depth that comes from sharing real experiences face-to-face.

3. Why do some childhood friendships fade over time? (Cause & Effect)

I think it is largely a natural consequence of people growing and changing. As we mature, our interests, values and circumstances **diverge**, and friends who once had everything in common may drift apart. Physical distance, when people move for work or study, only **accelerates** this. It is sad, but I see it as an almost **inevitable** part of life.

4. How important are friends compared to family in a person's life? (Social Impact)

Both are essential, though they serve different roles. Family offers **unconditional** support and a sense of roots, whereas friends are people we actively choose, which makes those bonds uniquely **affirming**. Friends often understand aspects of our lives that family cannot. I would say a fulfilling life requires a healthy balance of both, as each provides a distinct kind of **companionship**.

5. Do you think online friendships will replace face-to-face ones in the future? (Future)

I doubt they will replace them entirely, but they will certainly become more significant. Online friendships are convenient and can be genuinely meaningful. However, humans are **inherently** social creatures who crave physical presence, so I believe in-person connection is **irreplaceable**. The most likely outcome is a **hybrid**, where the two forms coexist and complement each other.

6. What can people do to maintain long-distance friendships? (Problem & Solution)

Consistent effort is really the crucial ingredient. Regular video calls and messages can **keep a friendship alive** despite the distance. I think it also helps to be **deliberate** about planning occasional visits, as nothing quite replaces meeting in person. Ultimately, both parties have to be committed, because a friendship that only one person **sustains** rarely lasts.

7. What are the benefits and drawbacks of having friends from different cultures?

(Adv & Disadv)

The benefits are considerable. Friends from other cultures **broaden your perspective** and challenge your assumptions, which is deeply **enriching**. You learn to be more **tolerant** and open-minded. The only real drawback might be occasional misunderstandings arising from different customs or communication styles. But in my view, these minor obstacles are easily outweighed by the rewards.

8. Some say social media has made friendships shallower. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I largely agree with that sentiment. Social media encourages us to **accumulate** hundreds of contacts while investing little in any of them. The constant highlight reels can also breed comparison rather than genuine connection. That said, it depends how you use it; for maintaining existing bonds it is useful. Used as a **substitute** for real intimacy, though, it does **trivialise** friendship.

Parenting & Childhood

People & Relationships · sp3_people_04 · 7 of 8 answers edited

1. What do you think are the most important qualities of a good parent? (Opinion)

In my view, the most important qualities are patience and **consistency**. Children thrive on stability, so a parent who sets clear, fair boundaries helps them feel secure. Equally vital is unconditional love balanced with the willingness to discipline when necessary. A good parent also **leads by example**, since children tend to **absorb** behaviour far more than instructions.

2. How is childhood today different from childhood in the past? (Comparison)

Childhood has changed dramatically. In the past, children spent most of their free time playing outdoors and socialising in person. Today, much of that has been ~~replaced~~ **supplanted** by screens, which I find rather ~~concerning~~ **disconcerting**. Children are also under far more academic pressure now. So while modern children have more opportunities, they arguably have a less **carefree** upbringing.

3. What effect does strict parenting have on children? (Cause & Effect)

It can have mixed effects. On one hand, strict parenting can instil discipline and a strong work ethic. On the other, if it is excessively **authoritarian**, it may **stifle** a child's creativity and confidence, or even breed rebellion. In my opinion, the ideal lies in a balanced approach that is firm but also **nurturing** and understanding.

4. How does a person's childhood affect them as an adult? (Social Impact)

I think childhood is profoundly **formative**. The experiences and relationships we have in those early years shape our personality, our self-esteem and how we relate to others. A secure, loving childhood tends to produce confident, well-adjusted adults, whereas a troubled one can leave lasting **scars**. In many ways, our childhood **lays the foundation** for everything that follows.

5. How do you think parenting will change in the coming decades? (Future)

I expect parenting will become increasingly ~~shaped by~~ **intertwined with** technology. Parents will likely rely more on apps and online resources for guidance, and managing children's screen time will become an even ~~bigger~~ **more daunting** challenge. I also anticipate a move towards more **egalitarian** parenting, with responsibilities shared more equally. Hopefully there will also be greater awareness of children's emotional wellbeing.

6. How can parents help children develop good values? (Problem & Solution)

The most effective way is by **modelling** those values themselves, since children imitate what they see. Beyond that, parents can use everyday situations as **teaching moments**, discussing honesty or kindness openly. Encouraging empathy, perhaps through community involvement, also helps. Ultimately, values are **instilled** gradually through consistent example rather than through occasional lectures.

7. What are the pros and cons of both parents working full time? (Adv & Disadv)

The clear advantage is financial; a **dual income** provides a higher **standard of living** and more opportunities for the children. It can also make both parents positive role models of independence. The downside is that it may leave less time for the children, potentially affecting the parent-child bond. It really **comes down to** the quality of the time spent, not just the quantity, and whether adequate childcare is in place.

8. Some people think children are given too much freedom today. Do you agree?

(Agree / Disagree)

I partly agree. Modern parenting rightly encourages children's independence, but in some cases **the pendulum has swung** too far, and children lack clear boundaries. A total absence of limits can leave children feeling **insecure** rather than free. That said, the opposite extreme is equally harmful, so the goal should be freedom within a **framework** of sensible, loving guidance.

Generational Differences

People & Relationships · sp3_people_05 · 7 of 8 answers edited

1. Do you think there is a big generation gap in your country? (Opinion)

Yes, I think the generation gap in my country is quite **pronounced**, largely because of the rapid pace of change. Older generations grew up in a very different, more traditional society, while the young have been shaped by technology and global culture. This creates differing values and expectations, which can sometimes lead to **tension**, though it also brings a healthy **diversity** of perspectives.

2. What are the main differences between the older and younger generations?

(Comparison)

The differences are quite **stark**. The older generation generally values stability, tradition and hard-earned security, whereas young people tend to prioritise flexibility, self-expression and work-life balance. There is also a huge gap in digital fluency. However, I think these differences are often **exaggerated**; at their core, both generations share many of the same fundamental **aspirations**.

3. Why do older and younger generations sometimes struggle to understand each other? (Cause & Effect)

The root cause is that they have lived through fundamentally different eras. Their formative experiences, technologies and social norms were worlds apart, which shapes how they see everything. This can lead to a failure to **empathise**, with each side viewing the other's values as **alien**. A lack of open, patient communication only **widens that gulf**.

4. How can different generations learn from one another? (Social Impact)

There is enormous potential here. Younger people can help older generations navigate technology, while the elderly offer **invaluable** wisdom and life experience that no textbook can provide. This kind of exchange, sometimes called reverse mentoring, is **mutually beneficial**. When generations genuinely listen to each other, both are **enriched**, and society as a whole becomes more cohesive.

5. Do you think the generation gap will grow larger in the future? (Future)

It is a real possibility, given how quickly technology now **evolves**. Each new generation is being shaped by tools the previous one barely understands, which could **amplify** the divide. On the other hand, constant connectivity might actually help **bridge** it. So the outcome is uncertain, and it may depend on whether we make a deliberate effort to stay connected across ages.

6. What can be done to reduce conflict between generations? (Problem & Solution)

Fostering genuine dialogue is essential. Creating opportunities for generations to interact meaningfully, whether in families or communities, builds mutual understanding. Both sides need

to approach differences with **humility** rather than judgement. I also think education plays a role in teaching young people to respect their elders while encouraging older people to remain **receptive** to new ideas.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of a workplace with mixed age groups? (Adv & Disadv)

The advantages are significant. A mix of ages brings together the fresh ideas and **tech-savviness** of the young with the experience and **prudence** of older staff, which is a powerful combination. The potential disadvantage is friction arising from clashing work styles or communication preferences. But with good management, this diversity of thought is far more of an asset than a **liability**.

8. Some say younger generations have life easier than older ones. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I think it is more **nuanced** than that. In material terms, young people today certainly enjoy comforts and technology their grandparents lacked. However, they face their own distinct pressures, such as intense competition, **job insecurity** and a constant online spotlight. So I would not say life is simply easier; rather, the **hardships** have shifted in nature.

Leadership

People & Relationships · sp3_people_06 · 3 of 8 answers edited

1. What qualities make someone a good leader? (Opinion)

In my opinion, a good leader combines vision with genuine **integrity**. They need the ability to inspire and motivate others towards a common goal, but also the humility to listen. Crucially, effective leaders lead by example and take responsibility for failures rather than shifting blame. I think this **accountability**, paired with genuine **empathy**, is what earns lasting respect.

2. Is it better for a leader to be respected or feared? (Comparison)

I firmly believe respect is far more effective than fear. A leader who rules through fear may achieve short-term **compliance**, but this breeds resentment and stifles honest communication. A respected leader, by contrast, inspires genuine loyalty and willing effort. People follow such a leader out of **conviction** rather than intimidation, which produces far better and more **sustainable** results.

3. What happens to an organisation when it has poor leadership? (Cause & Effect)

The consequences can be severe. Poor leadership often results in low morale, as employees feel **directionless** and undervalued. This typically leads to reduced productivity and high staff turnover. Without a clear vision, an organisation can quickly **stagnate** or lose its way entirely. In short, weak leadership tends to **permeate** every level and undermine the whole enterprise.

4. How important is leadership in bringing about social change? (Social Impact)

Leadership is often the decisive factor. Throughout history, major social movements have been galvanised by charismatic leaders who could **articulate** a shared vision and mobilise people. A strong leader gives a movement focus and **momentum**. That said, I think the best leaders empower others rather than dominate, ensuring the change is **collective** rather than dependent on one individual.

5. How do you think leadership styles will change in the future? (Future)

I believe we are moving away from the traditional top-down, authoritarian model towards something more **collaborative**. Future leaders will likely need to be more emotionally intelligent and adaptable, given how quickly the world changes. There will also be greater emphasis on **transparency** and inclusivity. In short, leadership is becoming less about command and more about **facilitation**.

6. How can society develop better leaders? (Problem & Solution)

I think it starts with education that nurtures not just intelligence but character and empathy. Providing young people with genuine opportunities to take responsibility, through mentorship or community projects, helps cultivate leadership skills early. We should also reward ethical leadership rather than mere ambition. Essentially, good leaders are developed over time, not simply born.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of a young person becoming a leader? (Adv & Disadv)

The advantages include fresh energy, innovative ideas and a willingness to challenge outdated conventions. Young leaders can be genuinely dynamic. The main disadvantage is a lack of experience, which may lead to impulsive decisions or difficulty commanding respect from older colleagues. Ideally, a young leader would be paired with experienced mentors to balance their enthusiasm with wisdom.

8. Some say great leaders are born, not made. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I largely disagree with that idea. While some people may have a natural charisma or confidence, I firmly believe leadership is a set of skills that can be learned and refined through experience. History is full of leaders who grew into the role. To claim leaders are simply born undermines the value of hard work and personal development.

Fame & Celebrity

People & Relationships · sp3_people_07 · 4 of 8 answers edited

1. Why do you think so many young people want to be famous? (Opinion)

I think it is largely driven by social media, which has made fame appear both glamorous and easily attainable. Young people see influencers achieving wealth and adoration seemingly overnight, which is highly seductive. There is also a deeper human desire for validation and significance. Unfortunately, this often means chasing fame as an end in itself rather than as a by-product of genuine achievement.

2. How is fame today different from fame in the past? (Comparison)

The nature of fame has changed completely. In the past, fame was usually earned through exceptional talent or accomplishment, and famous people were relatively few. Today, anyone can become famous overnight through a viral video, and fame is often fleeting and detached from any real skill. Modern celebrity is also far more invasive, with stars under constant surveillance.

3. What effect does celebrity culture have on young people? (Cause & Effect)

The effects are often detrimental, in my view. Constant exposure to celebrities' curated, idealised lives can create unrealistic expectations and fuel insecurity, especially about appearance. It can also promote materialism and a distorted sense of what matters. That said, positive celebrities who champion good causes can be a genuinely inspiring influence, so it is not entirely negative.

4. Do celebrities have a responsibility to be good role models? (Social Impact)

I would argue they do, whether they like it or not. Given the enormous influence they wield over millions of impressionable fans, celebrities have a certain moral obligation to behave responsibly. Their actions can genuinely shape public attitudes. However, it is also unfair to expect them to be flawless, since they are human. The key is a basic level of accountability and awareness.

5. Do you think celebrity culture will become more or less influential in the future? (Future)

I suspect it will become even more influential, but also more **fragmented**. Rather than a few global superstars, we are likely to see countless niche influencers, each commanding devoted audiences. Technology like virtual influencers may further blur the line between real and fabricated fame. Whether this influence is healthy will depend on whether audiences become more **discerning** and **sceptical**.

6. How can society reduce the negative effects of celebrity obsession? (Problem & Solution)

Media literacy education is crucial here. Teaching young people to critically **evaluate** the polished images they see online can lessen the harmful comparisons. Promoting a broader range of admirable figures, such as scientists or activists, would also help **rebalance** what we celebrate. Ultimately, encouraging people to derive self-worth from their own lives rather than **idolising** others is the real solution.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of being famous? (Adv & Disadv)

The obvious advantages are wealth, influence and opportunities that most people can only dream of. Fame also provides a platform to promote worthy causes. However, the disadvantages are considerable: a total loss of privacy, relentless **scrutiny**, and immense pressure that can take a serious toll on mental health. Many celebrities find the constant spotlight genuinely **suffocating**, so it is far from the **idyllic** life it appears.

8. Some people say celebrities are paid too much. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I **have some sympathy with** that view. It does seem **disproportionate** that an entertainer can earn more in a day than a nurse earns in a year, when the latter arguably contributes more to society. On the other hand, their pay simply reflects the market and the vast revenue they generate. So while it feels **morally questionable**, it is economically logical.

Trust & Honesty

People & Relationships · sp3_people_08 · 4 of 8 answers edited

1. Why is honesty important in relationships? (Opinion)

Honesty is really the **bedrock** of any healthy relationship. Without it, trust cannot exist, and trust is what allows people to feel safe and secure with one another. Even small lies, once discovered, can **erode** that foundation and breed suspicion. In my view, being truthful, even when it is difficult, is what gives a relationship genuine depth and **resilience**.

2. Do you think people are more or less honest than they were in the past?

(Comparison)

That is a difficult question. I do not think human nature has fundamentally changed, but the opportunities for **deception** have multiplied with technology, from online scams to fake identities. At the same time, the internet has made it much harder to hide dishonesty, since **misdeeds** are quickly exposed. So perhaps we are no less honest, just more **transparent**.

3. What happens to a society when trust in institutions breaks down? (Cause & Effect)

The consequences are deeply damaging. When people lose faith in institutions like government or the media, it breeds **cynicism** and division. Cooperation becomes difficult, conspiracy theories can **flourish**, and social cohesion begins to unravel. Trust is essentially the glue that holds a society together, so its breakdown can lead to genuine **instability** and dysfunction.

4. Is it ever acceptable to tell a lie? (Social Impact)

I think there are rare cases where a so-called white lie is justifiable, particularly when the truth would cause needless harm and the lie is genuinely **benevolent**. Sparing someone's feelings is a common example. However, this is a **slippery slope**, because habitual lying, even with good intentions, can **undermine** trust. So while not absolute, honesty should be the strong default.

5. Do you think it will be harder to trust information in the future? (Future)

Unfortunately, I think it will. With the rise of sophisticated technology like deepfakes and AI-generated content, distinguishing genuine information from **fabricated** material will become increasingly difficult. This could make people either dangerously **gullible** or excessively cynical. Developing strong critical-thinking skills and reliable verification tools will be absolutely essential to **navigate** this new landscape.

6. How can trust be rebuilt once it has been broken? (Problem & Solution)

Rebuilding trust is a slow and difficult process. It requires the person who broke it to take full responsibility and offer a sincere apology, without excuses. More importantly, they must demonstrate changed behaviour **consistently** over time, since words alone are not enough. **The wronged party**, meanwhile, needs to be willing to gradually **reconcile**. Essentially, trust is rebuilt through actions, not promises.

7. What are the benefits and risks of being completely honest all the time? (Adv & Disadv)

The great benefit of total honesty is that it builds a reputation for **integrity**, and people know exactly where they stand with you. It fosters deep trust. The risk, however, is that unfiltered honesty can sometimes be hurtful or **tactless** if not delivered with care. So I think the ideal is honesty tempered with **diplomacy**, being truthful but also kind.

8. Some say honesty is always the best policy. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I largely agree, though I would add a small **caveat**. As a general principle, honesty builds trust and spares us the burden of maintaining lies, so it is almost always wise. However, I think it must be balanced with **compassion**; brutal honesty that needlessly wounds someone is not virtuous. So honesty is the best policy, provided it is delivered **sensitively**.

Peer Pressure

People & Relationships · sp3_people_09 · 7 of 8 answers edited

1. Do you think peer pressure is always a bad thing? (Opinion)

Not at all, and this is a common misconception. While peer pressure is usually associated with negative behaviour, it can be a powerful positive force too. If your peers are ambitious and disciplined, their influence can motivate you to raise your own standards. So peer pressure is really a **double-edged sword**; its effect depends entirely on **the company you keep** and how **discerning** you are.

2. Who has more influence on teenagers, their friends or their parents? (Comparison)

During the teenage years specifically, I would argue friends often have the greater immediate influence. Adolescents are forming their own identity and naturally seek acceptance from their peers, sometimes **at the expense of** parental advice. However, parents provide the deeper, **underlying** values that tend to **resurface** later in life. So peers shape day-to-day behaviour, while parents shape long-term character.

3. Why are young people especially vulnerable to peer pressure? (Cause & Effect)

It largely comes down to their **developmental stage**. Adolescents have a deep psychological need to belong and fear social rejection intensely. Their sense of identity is still forming, which makes them more **susceptible** to conforming with the group. Additionally, the part of the brain governing **impulse control** is not yet fully developed, so they are more likely to act on that pressure.

4. How does the desire to fit in affect people's behaviour? (Social Impact)

The desire to fit in is an extraordinarily powerful driver of behaviour. It can lead people to **conform** to group norms even when they privately disagree, a phenomenon that affects everything from fashion to opinions. While this social **cohesion** has its benefits, it can also

suppress individuality and lead to poor decisions. Learning to resist this pull and think independently is a mark of real maturity.

5. Do you think social media has made peer pressure stronger? (Future)

Absolutely, I think it has intensified it dramatically. In the past, peer pressure was confined to your immediate social circle, but now it is constant and global. People compare themselves to countless others online, and the pressure to project a perfect image is **relentless**. This **amplified**, round-the-clock pressure is, I believe, **taking a serious toll** on young people's wellbeing.

6. How can young people be helped to resist negative peer pressure? (Problem & Solution)

Building self-confidence is the most effective safeguard. A young person with a strong sense of self is far less likely to **succumb** to pressure. Parents and teachers can help by fostering open communication, so children feel able to discuss difficult situations. Teaching practical strategies, like how to say no gracefully, also **empowers** them to **stand firm**.

7. What are the positive and negative sides of wanting to be like others? (Adv & Disadv)

On the positive side, wanting to **emulate** others can inspire self-improvement; admiring successful people can push us to work harder. It also helps social **integration**. The negative side is that it can lead to a loss of individuality and constant, unhealthy comparison. It may cause people to suppress their true selves to fit in. The healthiest approach is to draw inspiration from others while **staying true to** who you are.

8. Some say peer pressure decreases as people get older. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I broadly agree, though it never disappears entirely. As people mature, they generally develop a firmer sense of identity and care less about others' approval, making them more **resilient** to pressure. However, the pressure simply takes on a more **subtle** form in adulthood, such as keeping up with colleagues' lifestyles. So it lessens, but it certainly does not **vanish**.

Conflict & Mediation

People & Relationships · sp3_people_10 · 6 of 8 answers edited

1. Do you think conflict between people is always negative? (Opinion)

Not necessarily. While conflict is uncomfortable, it can actually be **constructive** if handled well. Disagreements often bring underlying problems to the surface, which allows them to be addressed rather than festering. Healthy conflict can also **spark** better ideas and deeper understanding. The key is whether it is managed respectfully; it is unresolved or **hostile** conflict that is truly damaging.

2. Is it better to confront a problem directly or avoid it? (Comparison)

In most cases, I believe confronting a problem directly is far healthier. Avoidance may keep the peace temporarily, but the underlying issue tends to **fester** and grow worse over time. Addressing it calmly and early usually leads to genuine resolution. That said, direct confrontation should be done **tactfully**, choosing the right moment, so it does not **escalate** into a bigger dispute.

3. What are the main causes of conflict between people? (Cause & Effect)

In my experience, most conflict **stems from** poor communication and misunderstanding rather than genuine **malice**. When people fail to express themselves clearly or make assumptions about others' intentions, friction inevitably arises. Differences in values, competition over resources and simple **miscommunication** are also common triggers. Interestingly, many disputes could be avoided entirely with a little more patience and clarity.

4. How important is emotional intelligence in resolving conflicts? (Social Impact)

It is absolutely crucial. Emotional intelligence allows a person to understand not only their own feelings but also the perspective of the other party, which is the foundation of any resolution. Someone with high emotional intelligence can stay calm, **empathise**, and communicate without **inflaming** the situation. Without this ability, people tend to react **defensively**, which almost always makes the conflict worse.

5. Do you think people will become better at resolving conflicts in the future? (Future)

I am cautiously optimistic. There is growing awareness of the importance of emotional intelligence and communication skills, which are increasingly taught in schools and workplaces. If this trend continues, future generations may be better **equipped** to handle disagreements. On the other hand, online communication can sometimes make people more **polarised** and less willing to **compromise**, so it is not guaranteed.

6. What is the best way to resolve a serious disagreement? (Problem & Solution)

The most effective approach usually involves calm, honest dialogue where both sides genuinely listen to one another. It helps to focus on the specific issue rather than attacking the person, and to seek a compromise where possible. In some cases, involving a **neutral third party** as a **mediator** can be **invaluable**. Ultimately, a willingness to see the other's perspective is what unlocks resolution.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of using a mediator in disputes? (Adv & Disadv)

The main advantage is that a neutral mediator can **defuse tension** and help both parties communicate objectively, often reaching a solution they could not manage alone. It is also usually cheaper and quicker than legal action. The disadvantage is that mediation relies on both parties' goodwill; if one side is **uncooperative**, it can fail. It also lacks the **binding** authority of a court ruling.

8. Some say avoiding conflict keeps relationships healthier. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I largely disagree with that. While constant conflict is obviously harmful, consistently avoiding it is not healthy either, as it allows **resentment** to build silently. Relationships that never address problems often **suppress** genuine feelings, which eventually surface in a much larger explosion. In my view, healthy relationships are not conflict-free; they simply handle disagreement **maturely** and constructively.

Emotional Intelligence

People & Relationships · sp3_people_11 · 7 of 8 answers edited

1. Do you think emotional intelligence is more important than academic intelligence? (Opinion)

I would argue they are both important but serve different purposes. Academic intelligence may get you a qualification, but emotional intelligence is often what determines success in life and work, since it **governs** how you deal with people. The ability to manage emotions, empathise and communicate is genuinely **indispensable**. So while I would not rank one above the other, emotional intelligence is arguably more **underrated**.

2. Are emotional skills valued more in some professions than others? (Comparison)

Definitely. In **people-facing** roles such as teaching, healthcare or management, emotional intelligence is arguably the most important skill of all, as success depends on connecting with others. In more technical or **solitary** fields, like programming, it may seem less critical, though even there teamwork requires it. So while its importance varies, I think emotional skills are becoming increasingly valued **across virtually every sector**.

3. What happens when a person lacks emotional intelligence? (Cause & Effect)

A lack of emotional intelligence can cause real difficulties, both personally and professionally. Such a person may struggle to **read social cues**, handle criticism, or manage their own reactions, which can damage relationships. They might come across as **insensitive** or provoke unnecessary conflict without even realising it. Over time, this can lead to isolation and repeated interpersonal **friction**.

4. How does emotional intelligence affect a person's relationships? (Social Impact)

It has a profound effect. People with high emotional intelligence tend to have healthier, more fulfilling relationships because they can understand and respond to others' feelings **sensitively**. They handle disagreements calmly and communicate their own needs clearly. This creates an atmosphere of trust and **mutual understanding**. In essence, emotional intelligence is the quiet skill that makes relationships genuinely **harmonious**.

5. Will emotional intelligence become more important as technology advances? (Future)

I strongly believe it will. As machines and AI take over more analytical and routine tasks, the uniquely human skills, like empathy, creativity and emotional connection, will become more valuable, not less. These are precisely the abilities that technology cannot easily **replicate**. So **paradoxically**, in an increasingly automated world, emotional intelligence may become one of our most **sought-after** qualities.

6. Can emotional intelligence be taught, and if so, how? (Problem & Solution)

Yes, I firmly believe it can be developed, even if some people are naturally more gifted. Self-awareness can be **cultivated** through reflection and honest feedback. Skills like active listening and empathy can be practised deliberately. Schools could help by **incorporating** emotional learning into the curriculum from an early age. Like any skill, it improves with **conscious effort** and practice, so it is far from fixed.

7. Are there any downsides to being highly emotionally sensitive? (Adv & Disadv)

There can be, yes. Being highly attuned to emotions is generally a strength, but it can occasionally become a burden. Very sensitive people may absorb others' stress and feel **overwhelmed**, or take criticism too personally. They can also find it hard to make tough, unpopular decisions. So the ideal is emotional sensitivity balanced with healthy **boundaries** and enough **resilience** to protect oneself.

8. Some say schools focus too much on academics and not enough on emotional skills. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I strongly agree with this criticism. Traditional education has long **prioritised** exam results above all else, often neglecting the emotional and social skills that are equally vital for a fulfilling life. Skills like managing stress, empathising and collaborating are rarely taught explicitly. I think a more **holistic** education, one that develops the whole person, would produce far more **well-rounded** and capable adults.

Social Isolation & Loneliness

People & Relationships · sp3_people_12 · 4 of 8 answers edited

1. Why do you think loneliness is becoming more common today? (Opinion)

I think it is a paradox of modern life. Despite being more digitally connected than ever, many people feel increasingly isolated. Urbanisation has weakened traditional community bonds, and busy, individualistic lifestyles leave little time for genuine connection. Ironically, social media can **exacerbate** the problem by replacing deep relationships with **superficial** online interaction, leaving a real emotional **void**.

2. Is loneliness worse in cities or in the countryside? (Comparison)

This is quite counterintuitive. You might assume the countryside, being less populated, would be lonelier, but often the opposite is true. Rural communities tend to be tight-knit, where everyone knows each other. Cities, by contrast, can be profoundly **alienating**; you can be surrounded by millions yet feel completely **anonymous**. So urban loneliness, born of that anonymity, is arguably the more **acute** problem.

3. What effects can long-term loneliness have on a person? (Cause & Effect)

The effects can be genuinely serious. Prolonged loneliness is strongly linked to mental health problems such as depression and anxiety. It can also have physical consequences, as chronic isolation is thought to weaken the immune system and even affect **longevity**. Beyond that, it can trap people in a negative cycle, where low mood makes them **withdraw** further, deepening the isolation and their sense of **despair**.

4. Which groups of people are most at risk of social isolation? (Social Impact)

Several groups are particularly **vulnerable**. The elderly are perhaps most at risk, especially those who have lost a spouse or whose family lives far away. Newcomers to a city, who lack an established network, are also susceptible, as are those with disabilities or health issues that limit their mobility. Essentially, anyone facing barriers to regular social contact is **prone** to becoming isolated and **marginalised**.

5. Do you think loneliness will become a bigger problem in the future? (Future)

I fear it might, if current trends continue. As societies become more individualistic and people increasingly work and socialise remotely, opportunities for spontaneous human contact may **diminish**. An ageing population in many countries could also worsen the situation. However, I remain hopeful that growing awareness of the issue will **prompt** communities and governments to take **preventive** action.

6. What can communities do to reduce loneliness? (Problem & Solution)

Communities can play a powerful role. Creating accessible public spaces and organising local events, from community gardens to social clubs, gives people natural opportunities to connect. Initiatives that specifically reach out to isolated individuals, like **befriending schemes** for the elderly, are especially valuable. Ultimately, **fostering** a culture where people look out for their neighbours can rebuild the **social fabric** that has frayed.

7. Is spending time alone always a bad thing? (Adv & Disadv)

Certainly not; there is an important distinction between loneliness and healthy **solitude**. Chosen time alone can be genuinely **restorative**, allowing for reflection, creativity and rest. Many people find solitude essential for recharging. The problem arises only when isolation is **involuntary** and prolonged. So spending time alone is perfectly healthy, as long as it is balanced with meaningful connection.

8. Some say technology is the main cause of modern loneliness. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I partly agree, but I think it is too simplistic to blame technology alone. It is true that excessive screen time can replace real interaction and **foster** unhealthy comparison. However, technology can also connect isolated people, such as those far from family. So the technology itself is **neutral**; the real issue is how we use it. The deeper causes lie in broader **societal** changes.

Education Systems

Education & Work · sp3_education_01 · 6 of 8 answers edited

1. What do you think is the main purpose of education? (Opinion)

In my view, education serves a dual purpose. On a practical level, it equips people with the knowledge and skills needed for employment. But more importantly, I believe its deeper purpose is to **cultivate** critical thinking and produce well-rounded, responsible citizens. Education should

teach people how to think, not merely what to think. Sadly, many systems overemphasise **rote learning** at the expense of this broader **enrichment**.

2. How is education today different from education in the past? (Comparison)

The differences are considerable. In the past, education was largely teacher-centred, based on memorisation and strict discipline. Today, there is a much greater emphasis on interactive, student-centred learning, and technology has **revolutionised** access to information. Learning is now more **collaborative** and creative. However, I would argue that academic pressure and competition have also intensified, which is a rather **double-edged** development.

3. How does the quality of education affect a country's development? (Social Impact)

The link is absolutely fundamental. A well-educated population drives economic growth through innovation and a **skilled workforce**. Beyond economics, quality education tends to reduce poverty, improve public health and strengthen democratic institutions. It is, in essence, the **bedrock** of national progress. Conversely, a country that **neglects** education severely limits its own potential and risks falling behind its competitors.

4. Why do you think exam results are given so much importance? (Cause & Effect)

I think it stems from the need for a seemingly objective way to measure ability and allocate opportunities. Exams provide a convenient, **quantifiable** benchmark for universities and employers. However, this **overreliance** on results can be **counterproductive**, as it encourages students to memorise for tests rather than truly understand. It also fails to capture vital qualities like creativity, which are far harder to quantify.

5. How could education systems be improved? (Problem & Solution)

There are several improvements I would suggest. Firstly, systems should place less emphasis on high-stakes exams and more on continuous, practical assessment. Secondly, curricula should be **modernised** to include life skills such as financial literacy and emotional intelligence. Finally, investing in teacher training and reducing class sizes would allow for more **personalised** learning. The goal should be a more **holistic** and flexible model.

6. How do you think education will change in the next 20 years? (Future)

I anticipate dramatic changes, largely driven by technology. Personalised, AI-assisted learning could **tailor** lessons to each student's pace, and online education will make quality teaching far more accessible globally. The traditional classroom may become less central. There will likely also be a stronger focus on **adaptable** skills, given that people will need to **reskill** repeatedly throughout their careers.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of a highly competitive education system? (Adv & Disadv)

A competitive system can certainly drive high achievement and prepare students for a demanding world, pushing them to **excel**. However, the disadvantages are significant. Excessive competition can cause immense stress and anxiety, and it may **stifle** creativity and collaboration. It can also **disadvantage** those who learn differently. In my view, a healthy system needs to balance ambition with student wellbeing.

8. Some say education should be free for everyone. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I strongly agree, at least regarding basic and secondary education. I see education as a fundamental right and a **public good**, not a privilege for those who can afford it. Free access promotes **social mobility** and reduces inequality. For higher education, the picture is more complex due to cost, but I believe it should at least be heavily **subsidised** so that talent, not wealth, determines opportunity.

Learning Methods

Education & Work · sp3_education_02 · 6 of 8 answers edited

1. What do you think is the best way to learn something new? (Opinion)

In my experience, the most effective way to learn is through active, hands-on practice rather than passive listening. We tend to **retain** information far better when we actually apply it. I am a firm believer in **learning by doing**, and in making mistakes, since they are often the most **instructive** experiences. Combining this practical approach with genuine curiosity makes learning both effective and thoroughly engaging.

2. Is it better to learn alone or in a group? (Comparison)

Both have their merits, and the ideal depends on the task. Learning alone allows for focus and lets you progress at your own pace, which suits deep, concentrated study. Group learning, on the other hand, is more **dynamic**; you benefit from different perspectives and can clarify doubts through discussion. Personally, I favour a **blend** of the two, as they **complement** each other nicely.

3. Why do some people find learning easier than others? (Cause & Effect)

There are many contributing factors. Some of it comes down to natural **aptitude**, but I think motivation and **mindset** matter far more. People who are genuinely curious and believe they can improve tend to learn faster. Environment also plays a huge role; a supportive home and good teachers make an enormous difference. So learning ability is really a mix of **innate** talent and nurtured habits.

4. How has technology changed the way people learn? (Social Impact)

Technology has transformed learning almost beyond recognition. Information that once required a library is now instantly accessible, and online platforms allow anyone to learn almost anything for free. This has **democratised** education enormously. That said, it has downsides; the sheer abundance of information can be **overwhelming**, and constant digital distraction can actually **hinder** deep, focused learning.

5. Do you think traditional classrooms will disappear in the future? (Future)

I doubt they will disappear entirely, but their role will certainly change. Online learning will keep growing, offering flexibility that classrooms cannot match. However, physical classrooms provide something valuable: social interaction, mentorship and a structured environment that many learners need. So rather than **vanishing**, I expect classrooms to **evolve** into more interactive spaces, **complementing** rather than being replaced by digital tools.

6. How can people stay motivated when learning independently? (Problem & Solution)

Self-motivation is the biggest challenge in independent learning. I think the key is setting clear, **achievable** goals and breaking a large subject into smaller **milestones**, which gives a regular sense of progress. Establishing a routine helps make studying a habit rather than a struggle. Finding a community of fellow learners online can also provide **accountability** and encouragement, which is often what people lack.

7. What are the pros and cons of online learning? (Adv & Disadv)

Online learning offers tremendous flexibility and access; you can learn from world-class instructors anywhere, often at low cost. It is ideal for **self-directed**, motivated learners. The drawbacks, however, include a lack of face-to-face interaction, which can feel **isolating**, and it requires considerable self-discipline. Some practical subjects are also hard to teach remotely. So it is excellent for some, but not a complete **substitute** for every kind of learning.

8. Some say the internet has made memorisation unnecessary. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I only partly agree. It is true that we no longer need to memorise facts that we can look up instantly, so pure memorisation is less critical than before. However, I would argue that a solid base of knowledge in your own memory is still essential for **reasoning** and creativity, because you cannot connect ideas you do not **possess**. So the internet has shifted, rather than

eliminated, the value of memory.

Career Choices

Education & Work · sp3_education_03 · 4 of 8 answers edited

1. What factors do you think are most important when choosing a career? (Opinion)

I think the most important factor is genuine interest, because you will spend a huge portion of your life working. A job you are passionate about is far more sustainable than a purely lucrative one. That said, practical considerations like financial security, job stability and growth opportunities cannot be ignored. Ideally, people should seek a career that strikes a healthy balance between passion and pragmatism.

2. Is it better to choose a job you love or a job that pays well? (Comparison)

This is the classic dilemma. In an ideal world, you would have both. If forced to choose, I lean towards a job you love, because passion tends to lead to better performance and long-term fulfilment, and money alone rarely brings lasting contentment. However, this is somewhat a privilege; those with financial pressures may reasonably prioritise a stable income first.

3. Why do many people change careers during their lives now? (Cause & Effect)

Several factors drive this. The job market is far more volatile than in the past, so lifelong employment in one company is increasingly rare. People also have higher expectations of finding meaningful work, and are more willing to pursue fulfilment. Additionally, rapid technological change means some jobs disappear while new ones emerge, which compels people to adapt and retrain.

4. How much do parents influence their children's career choices? (Social Impact)

In many cultures, including mine, the influence is quite significant. Parents naturally want security for their children and often steer them towards prestigious or stable professions like medicine or engineering. This guidance can be helpful, but it can also become overbearing, pushing young people into careers that do not suit them. I think the ideal is for parents to advise while ultimately respecting their child's own autonomy.

5. What kinds of jobs do you think will be most important in the future? (Future)

I believe jobs involving skills that machines cannot easily replicate will be most valuable. This includes creative fields, healthcare, and roles requiring emotional intelligence and complex problem-solving. Careers related to technology, such as AI and data science, will obviously be in high demand, as will jobs focused on sustainability and renewable energy. Essentially, roles that are adaptable and distinctly human will thrive.

6. How can young people be helped to make better career decisions? (Problem & Solution)

Better career guidance in schools would make an enormous difference. Too often, students choose paths with little real understanding of what the jobs actually involve. Providing internships and work experience gives them valuable exposure to different fields. Mentorship from professionals can also offer honest, realistic first-hand insight. Essentially, we need to help young people make informed choices rather than blind ones.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of staying in one job for a long time? (Adv & Disadv)

The advantages include deep expertise, job security, and the trust and seniority that come with loyalty. It offers a comforting stability. The disadvantages, however, are that it can lead to stagnation and complacency, and one may miss out on the higher pay and fresh challenges that come from changing roles. So long-term employment offers security at the potential cost of growth and variety.

8. Some say job security is more important than job satisfaction. Do you agree?

(Agree / Disagree)

I think it depends heavily on a person's circumstances. For someone supporting a family, security is understandably the priority, as it provides essential peace of mind. However, I personally lean towards satisfaction, because a secure but miserable job can take a serious toll on one's mental health over time. Ideally, one should not have to sacrifice one for the other, though reality often forces a compromise.

Job Satisfaction

Education & Work · sp3_education_04 · 8 of 8 answers edited

1. What do you think makes people happy at work? (Opinion)

In my opinion, job satisfaction ~~comes~~ stems from more than just a good salary. Feeling that your work is meaningful and appreciated is ~~enormously important~~ paramount. A positive relationship with colleagues, opportunities to grow, and a sense of autonomy all contribute significantly. Ultimately, people are happiest when they feel valued and can see the genuine purpose behind what they do.

2. Is money or a sense of purpose more important for job satisfaction? (Comparison)

While money is obviously necessary, ~~research and my own belief suggest~~ I believe that beyond a certain point, a sense of purpose matters more. A high salary provides comfort, but it does not compensate for feeling that your work is pointless. People who find meaning in their jobs tend to be far more engaged and resilient. So money is important up to a threshold, but purpose provides the deeper, more lasting fulfilment.

3. What effect does job dissatisfaction have on people? (Cause & Effect)

The effects can be quite serious and far-reaching. Chronic dissatisfaction often leads to stress, low morale and even burnout, which can spill over and harm a person's personal life and health. At work, it results in reduced productivity and higher staff turnover. Essentially, an unhappy workforce is detrimental to both the individuals involved and the organisation's overall performance.

4. How does a person's job affect the rest of their life? (Social Impact)

A job has a profound influence on overall wellbeing. Since we spend so many hours working, a fulfilling job can boost confidence and happiness that permeate our whole life. Conversely, a stressful or unfulfilling job can cause anxiety that affects our relationships and health. Work also shapes our identity and social status, so it is deeply intertwined with our sense of self.

5. Do you think people will be more or less satisfied with their jobs in the future?

(Future)

I am cautiously optimistic. As automation takes over tedious, repetitive tasks, workers may be freed to focus on more creative and meaningful work, which could boost satisfaction. There is also growing awareness of employee wellbeing. On the other hand, increased job insecurity and the pressure of constant connectivity could undermine satisfaction. So the outcome will likely depend on how wisely we manage these changes.

6. What can employers do to make their staff happier? (Problem & Solution)

Employers can do a great deal. Offering fair pay and genuine recognition for good work is fundamental. Beyond that, providing opportunities for growth, some flexibility, and a supportive, respectful culture makes an enormous difference. Simply listening to employees and giving them a degree of autonomy over their work is powerful. Investing in staff wellbeing is not just ethical; it is genuinely profitable in the long run.

7. Are there advantages to doing a job you find challenging? (Adv & Disadv)

Absolutely. A challenging job keeps you engaged and constantly learning, which prevents boredom and fuels personal growth. Overcoming difficulties also builds confidence and a real sense of accomplishment. The potential disadvantage is that if the challenge becomes overwhelming or **unrelenting**, it can **tip into** stress and burnout. So the ideal is a job that **stretches** you without exhausting you.

8. Some say people today change jobs too often. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I do not entirely agree that it is a problem. Changing jobs frequently is often a sensible way to gain diverse experience, increase pay and find a better fit, especially in a fast-changing economy. The old model of **lifelong loyalty** is somewhat **outdated**. That said, changing too often can look unstable to employers and prevent one from developing deep **expertise**, so a degree of balance is wise.

The Future of Work

Education & Work · sp3_education_05 · 6 of 8 answers edited

1. How do you think work will change in the next few decades? (Opinion)

I believe work will become far more flexible and technology-driven. Remote and hybrid working, already common, will likely become the norm for many roles. Automation and AI will take over routine tasks, meaning humans will focus more on creative and interpersonal work. People will also need to **reskill** continuously, as the concept of a single lifelong career becomes increasingly **obsolete** and **fluid**.

2. Is working from home better or worse than working in an office? (Comparison)

It really depends on the person and the job. Working from home offers wonderful flexibility and eliminates the commute, which many find **liberating** and more productive. However, the office provides valuable social interaction, easier collaboration and a clearer boundary between work and home life. Personally, I think a **hybrid** model captures the best of both, though it requires real **self-discipline** to work remotely well.

3. What effects will automation have on employment? (Cause & Effect)

Automation is a genuine **double-edged sword**. On one hand, it will **inevitably displace** many workers in routine and manual jobs, which is a serious concern. On the other hand, history shows that technology also creates entirely new industries and roles. The key effect is a shift in the types of jobs available, which means workforces will need to adapt and acquire new skills.

4. How might the changing nature of work affect society? (Social Impact)

The societal impact could be substantial. If automation **concentrates wealth**, it may **widen inequality**, which is a real danger. The rise of the gig economy also brings flexibility but often **at the cost of** job security and benefits. On a positive note, more flexible work could improve work-life balance. Managing these changes fairly will be one of the great challenges of our era, requiring thoughtful policy.

5. Do you think people will work fewer hours in the future? (Future)

I think it is a real possibility, and one I would welcome. As automation boosts productivity, there is a strong argument that the gains could be shared through shorter working weeks. Trials of the four-day week **seem to** have shown **promising** results, with productivity maintained. However, this will not happen automatically; it will require **deliberate choices** by businesses and governments to **prioritise** wellbeing over pure output.

6. How can workers prepare for a rapidly changing job market? (Problem & Solution)

The single most important thing is to embrace lifelong learning. Workers should continually update their skills and remain **adaptable**, rather than assuming their current expertise will last forever. Developing **transferable skills**, like communication and problem-solving, is wise, since

these remain valuable across industries. Staying curious and open to change is really the best **safeguard** against being left behind.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of the gig economy? (Adv & Disadv)

The gig economy offers genuine advantages: flexibility, independence and the ability to work for multiple clients, which suits many people. However, the disadvantages are considerable, **chiefly** the lack of job security, steady income and benefits like sick pay or pensions. This **precariousness** can be very stressful. So while it offers freedom, it often shifts significant risk onto the individual worker, which needs better **regulation**.

8. Some say machines will eventually do most human jobs. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I think that is something of an exaggeration, at least for the foreseeable future. Machines will certainly automate many tasks, but jobs requiring creativity, empathy, complex judgement and manual **dexterity** in unpredictable settings are far harder to replace. Rather than making humans **redundant**, I believe technology will mostly **augment** human work, changing jobs rather than eliminating the need for people entirely.

Higher Education

Education & Work · sp3_education_06 · 6 of 8 answers edited

1. Do you think a university degree is necessary for success? (Opinion)

I do not think it is strictly necessary, though it certainly helps in many fields. A degree provides knowledge, **credentials** and valuable connections, and for professions like medicine it is essential. However, success can absolutely be achieved through other routes, such as vocational training or **entrepreneurship**. In my view, a degree is a powerful tool, but it is not the only path, and it is no **guarantee** of success.

2. Is academic education or vocational training more valuable? (Comparison)

I believe both are equally valuable, just for different purposes, and society needs both. Academic education develops theoretical knowledge and critical thinking, suited to research and the professions. Vocational training provides practical, **job-ready** skills that are in high demand and often lead directly to employment. Unfortunately, vocational paths are often unfairly **stigmatised**, when in reality **skilled trades** are absolutely essential and highly rewarding.

3. Why do so many young people want to attend university nowadays? (Cause & Effect)

There are several reasons. Firstly, a degree is often seen as a minimum requirement for many good jobs, so there is **real mounting pressure** to obtain one. There is also considerable social **prestige** attached to a university education in many cultures. Additionally, university offers young people independence and a chance to grow. However, this rush has led to some **devaluation** of degrees, as they become more common.

4. How does higher education benefit society as a whole? (Social Impact)

The societal benefits are considerable. Universities drive research and innovation, which fuel economic and medical progress. They also produce the skilled professionals a modern society depends on, from doctors to engineers. Beyond that, higher education promotes critical thinking and informed **citizenship**, which strengthens democracy. In essence, universities are **engines** of both economic and intellectual **advancement**.

5. How do you think universities will change in the future? (Future)

I expect universities to become more flexible and accessible. Online and hybrid degrees will likely become **mainstream**, allowing people to study while working. There may be a shift towards shorter, more **modular** courses focused on specific skills rather than lengthy traditional degrees. Universities will also need to work more closely with industry to ensure their qualifications remain relevant in a **fast-changing** economy.

6. University is becoming very expensive. What could be done about this? (Problem & Solution)

This is a **pressing issue** in many countries. Governments could increase funding and **subsidies** to keep public universities affordable, treating education as an investment rather than a cost. Expanding scholarships and income-based repayment schemes would help ensure that talent, not wealth, determines access. Promoting quality alternatives, like online courses and apprenticeships, would also **relieve pressure** on the traditional, expensive model.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of studying a subject purely out of interest? (Adv & Disadv)

The great advantage is genuine engagement; studying something you love leads to deeper learning and personal fulfilment, and passion often breeds **excellence**. The potential disadvantage is practical: a subject with poor job prospects may leave you struggling financially after graduation. So ideally, one would find a field that **ignites** genuine interest while also offering reasonable **employability**, marrying passion with pragmatism.

8. Some say there are too many university graduates today. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

There is some truth to this in certain fields. The rapid expansion of higher education has, in some cases, led to a **surplus** of graduates in particular subjects, resulting in **underemployment** and a **mismatch** with the job market. However, I would not say education itself is the problem. The real issue is the lack of alignment between what people study and what the economy actually demands.

Skills & Qualifications

Education & Work · sp3_education_07 · 7 of 8 answers edited

1. Which is more important for a job, skills or qualifications? (Opinion)

While qualifications open doors, I believe practical skills ultimately matter more in the actual workplace. A degree may get you an interview, but it is your ability to actually do the job well that determines your success and **progression**. Employers increasingly value demonstrable **competence** over paper credentials. That said, in regulated professions, formal qualifications are **non-negotiable**, so the ideal is really a combination of both.

2. Are so-called soft skills or technical skills more valuable? (Comparison)

Both are important, but I would argue soft skills are becoming increasingly decisive. Technical skills are essential to perform specific tasks, but they can often be taught relatively quickly. Soft skills, like communication, teamwork and adaptability, are harder to acquire yet crucial for career advancement. As technology automates technical work, these uniquely human, **transferable** skills are likely to become even more **prized** and **sought-after**.

3. Why do some qualified people struggle to find jobs? (Cause & Effect)

There are several reasons. Often there is a **mismatch** between their qualifications and the skills employers actually need, especially if their degree is too theoretical. A lack of practical experience is another common barrier, as employers value hands-on ability. In some cases, an **oversupply** of graduates in a particular field simply means competition is fierce. Poor soft skills can also **hinder** otherwise qualified candidates.

4. How important is work experience compared to formal education? (Social Impact)

I think work experience is enormously valuable and, in many fields, **indispensable**. It teaches practical skills, professional behaviour and real-world problem-solving that no classroom can fully replicate. This is why internships and apprenticeships are so valued. That said, formal education provides the foundational knowledge upon which experience builds. The ideal candidate usually has a solid **blend** of both theoretical grounding and practical **exposure**.

5. Will qualifications become less important in the future? (Future)

I think their nature will change rather than their importance disappearing. Traditional degrees may become less of a strict requirement as employers increasingly focus on **demonstrable** skills and portfolios. We are already seeing a rise in **micro-credentials** and **skills-based hiring**. So the emphasis may shift from what certificate you hold to what you can actually demonstrate, making qualifications more practical and specific.

6. How can education better prepare students with practical skills? (Problem & Solution)

The most effective step is to integrate more practical, real-world experience into the curriculum. This means expanding internships, project-based learning and industry partnerships so students apply what they learn. Teaching should also explicitly develop soft skills, which are often **neglected**. **Bridging the gap** between academia and industry would ensure graduates are genuinely **job-ready** rather than merely knowledgeable.

7. What are the pros and cons of learning a skill through self-teaching? (Adv & Disadv)

Self-teaching offers great flexibility and is often free or cheap, and it **cultivates** valuable discipline and independence. Many successful people are largely **self-taught**. The drawbacks are the lack of structured guidance and formal recognition; without a certificate, it can be harder to prove your ability to employers. You also miss out on expert feedback. So it demands real motivation and can lack **external validation**.

8. Some say too much emphasis is placed on paper qualifications. Do you agree?

(Agree / Disagree)

I largely agree. Society has long **placed excessive weight on** formal certificates, sometimes **overlooking** genuinely talented individuals who lack them. This can create a **rigid** system where a piece of paper matters more than actual ability. Thankfully, this is slowly changing as employers recognise the value of skills and experience. A shift towards judging people on real competence would be a genuinely positive development.

Work-Life Balance

Education & Work · sp3_education_08 · 6 of 8 answers edited

1. How important is work-life balance? (Opinion)

I believe it is absolutely essential for long-term wellbeing. Without a healthy balance, people risk burnout, which harms both their health and, ironically, their productivity. Time for family, rest and hobbies is not a luxury; it is what makes us **resilient** and effective. In my view, a culture that glorifies overwork is ultimately **unsustainable** and **counterproductive**.

2. Do you think people had a better work-life balance in the past? (Comparison)

In some respects, yes. In the past, work was more clearly confined to the workplace, and once you went home, you were genuinely off duty. Today, smartphones mean we are perpetually **reachable**, and the boundary between work and personal life has become dangerously **blurred**. That said, past generations often worked longer physical hours, so it is not entirely one-sided; the nature of the **imbalance** has changed.

3. What are the consequences of a poor work-life balance? (Cause & Effect)

The consequences can be severe. Chronic overwork frequently leads to stress, burnout and serious health problems, both physical and mental. It also strains personal relationships, as work encroaches on time with family and friends. Ironically, it often reduces long-term productivity too. Essentially, neglecting your personal life for work is **self-defeating**, **taking a heavy toll** that eventually **undermines** everything.

4. How does work-life balance affect society? (Social Impact)

A society where people are **chronically** overworked tends to suffer from higher rates of stress-related illness and weaker family and community bonds. When people have no time or

energy left, civic and social life **deteriorates**. Conversely, a society that values balance tends to be healthier, happier and arguably more productive in the long run. So it is genuinely a matter of **collective** wellbeing.

5. Do you think work-life balance will improve in the future? (Future)

I am hopeful, though not entirely certain. There is a growing cultural awareness of the importance of wellbeing, and flexible and remote working could, if managed well, improve balance considerably. Concepts like the four-day week are **gaining traction**. However, there is a risk that **constant connectivity** could make things worse. So improvement is possible, but it will require a **deliberate cultural shift** rather than happening automatically.

6. What can people do to achieve a better work-life balance? (Problem & Solution)

On a personal level, setting firm boundaries is crucial, such as not checking work emails after hours. Learning to prioritise and, importantly, to say no to excessive demands helps enormously. Making dedicated time for rest and relationships should be treated as **non-negotiable**. However, individuals can **only do so much**; employers must also foster a culture that genuinely respects personal time and does not reward **overwork**.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of flexible working hours? (Adv & Disadv)

The advantages are considerable: flexibility allows people to work when they are most productive and to fit work around personal commitments, which greatly improves balance. The disadvantage is that without a clear structure, work can **bleed into** all hours, and it requires strong **self-discipline**. It can also complicate team coordination. So flexibility is a wonderful benefit, provided it comes with sensible **boundaries** and mutual trust.

8. Some say working hard is more important than having free time. Do you agree?

(Agree / Disagree)

I respectfully disagree with framing it as either-or. Hard work is certainly important for achievement, and I value **diligence**. However, free time is not the opposite of hard work; it is what makes sustained hard work possible by preventing burnout. The two are **complementary**. In my view, someone who works intensely but never rests is not admirable but heading towards **exhaustion**, so balance is wiser.

Remote Work

Education & Work · sp3_education_09 · 8 of 8 answers edited

1. Do you think remote working is a positive development? (Opinion)

On balance, I think it is largely positive. Remote work offers people tremendous flexibility, eliminates stressful commutes and can improve work-life balance significantly. It also allows companies to hire talent regardless of location. However, it is not without drawbacks, such as isolation and blurred boundaries. So while I view it **favourably**, its success depends on being managed thoughtfully rather than **imposed** without support.

2. Is remote work better suited to some jobs than others? (Comparison)

Absolutely, the suitability varies enormously. Knowledge-based, **computer-centric** jobs like writing, programming or design **translate very well** to remote work. However, roles requiring physical presence, such as healthcare, manufacturing or hospitality, simply cannot be done remotely. Even within office jobs, tasks needing intense collaboration or mentoring may suffer. So remote work is a wonderful option for some, but it is far from **universally applicable**.

3. How has remote work affected cities and communities? (Cause & Effect)

The effects have been quite significant. As fewer people commute, some city centres have seen businesses that relied on office workers struggle. Conversely, remote work has allowed people to move away from expensive cities to smaller towns, potentially **revitalising** those areas. This

redistribution of population could reshape **urban planning**. So it is causing a genuine, ongoing transformation of where and how people live.

4. How does remote work affect relationships between colleagues? (Social Impact)

It has a notable impact. On the positive side, it can reduce office politics and let people focus on their work. However, the spontaneous, informal interactions that build genuine **camaraderie** are much harder to replicate remotely. Relationships can become purely **transactional**, and new employees in particular may struggle to feel connected. Maintaining a real sense of **belonging** requires deliberate effort in a distributed team.

5. Do you think most people will work remotely in the future? (Future)

I think hybrid working will become the **dominant model** rather than fully remote work. Most companies seem to be **settling on** a mix, valuing both the flexibility of home and the collaboration of the office. Fully remote roles will grow but remain a minority. So the future of work is likely to be flexible and varied, with people **splitting their time** according to what each task demands.

6. How can companies keep remote workers engaged and productive? (Problem & Solution)

Clear communication is absolutely key. Companies should set clear expectations while trusting employees rather than **micromanaging** them. Regular virtual check-ins and occasional in-person meetups help maintain connection and **morale**. Providing the right technology and supporting mental wellbeing are also crucial. Ultimately, engagement comes from a culture of trust and inclusion, ensuring remote staff never feel **overlooked** or forgotten.

7. What are the main advantages and disadvantages of working from home? (Adv & Disadv)

The advantages are clear: no commute, greater flexibility, fewer office distractions and often improved work-life balance. Many people are genuinely more productive. The disadvantages include social isolation, difficulty separating work from home life, and potential distractions at home. **Career progression** can also suffer from being **out of sight**. So it offers real freedom, but demands strong **self-discipline** to manage well.

8. Some say working from home makes people lazy. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I largely disagree with that **stereotype**. While a lack of supervision might tempt a few, **the evidence generally suggests** it seems that most remote workers are just as productive, if not more so, than their office counterparts. In fact, many overwork because the boundaries blur. Laziness is really a matter of individual discipline and motivation, not location. So I think this criticism is largely **unfounded** and rather **outdated**.

Studying Abroad

Education & Work · sp3_education_10 · 7 of 8 answers edited

1. Why do you think so many students want to study abroad? (Opinion)

There are several compelling reasons. Studying abroad often provides access to higher-quality education and internationally recognised qualifications, which boost career prospects. Beyond academics, it offers an invaluable chance to experience a new culture, gain independence and **broaden one's horizons**. For many, it is a genuinely **transformative** personal journey as much as an academic one, offering **exposure** that home study cannot match.

2. Is studying abroad better than studying in one's own country? (Comparison)

It depends entirely on the individual and their goals. Studying abroad offers **cultural immersion** and independence that home study cannot, and sometimes access to better facilities. However, it is expensive, and studying at home is cheaper, closer to family, and free of the challenge of adapting to a foreign culture. So neither is universally better; it is a matter of **weighing** the

enrichment against the cost and difficulty.

3. What challenges do students face when studying in another country? (Cause & Effect)

They face numerous challenges. Culture shock and homesickness are extremely common, especially at first. A language barrier can make both study and daily life difficult and **isolating**. There are also practical hurdles, like managing finances and navigating an unfamiliar system alone. Adapting to different academic expectations can be **daunting** too. However, overcoming these difficulties is precisely what makes the experience so rewarding and **character-building**.

4. How does studying abroad benefit a student's home country? (Social Impact)

The benefits can be substantial. Students who return bring back advanced knowledge, new skills and valuable international perspectives that can drive innovation and development at home. They also form global networks that can **foster** trade and collaboration. However, there is a risk of a brain drain if graduates choose to stay abroad. So the benefit to the home country depends heavily on **repatriating** that talent and **expertise**.

5. Do you think studying abroad will become more common in the future? (Future)

I think physical study abroad will remain popular but may face competition from online alternatives. Increasingly, students can access foreign universities' courses remotely, offering the academic benefits without the cost of **relocating**. However, the cultural and personal growth of actually living abroad is **irreplaceable**, so demand will **persist**. The future may see a mix of physical and virtual international education, making it more accessible and diverse.

6. How can universities better support international students? (Problem & Solution)

Universities can do a great deal. Providing strong orientation programmes and language support eases the initial transition. Pairing international students with local mentors or buddy schemes helps combat isolation and homesickness. Practical guidance on visas, housing and finances is also invaluable. Essentially, creating a genuinely **inclusive** and welcoming environment helps international students **integrate** and **flourish** rather than feeling like outsiders.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of studying abroad? (Adv & Disadv)

The advantages are significant: exposure to a new culture, greater independence, improved language skills, and often a superior education, all of which boost **employability**. The disadvantages, however, include the high financial cost, the **emotional strain** of homesickness, and the difficulty of adjusting to an unfamiliar environment. So it offers immense personal and academic growth, but **at a considerable price** in both money and comfort.

8. Some say governments should fund students to study abroad. Do you agree?

(Agree / Disagree)

I broadly agree, provided there are sensible conditions. Funding talented students to gain world-class education and skills abroad can be a smart investment in a country's future development. However, to avoid a **brain drain**, such funding could reasonably require graduates to return and contribute for a period. So I support it as a **strategic investment**, as long as the country actually **reaps** the eventual benefits of that investment.

Professional & Soft Skills

Education & Work · sp3_education_11 · 5 of 8 answers edited

1. Which soft skills do you think are most valuable in the workplace? (Opinion)

In my view, communication is the single most valuable soft skill, since almost everything at work depends on it. Closely behind it, I would place teamwork and adaptability, as modern workplaces are collaborative and constantly changing. Problem-solving and emotional intelligence are also hugely important. These **interpersonal** abilities often distinguish a merely competent employee from a truly **exceptional** and **promotable** one.

2. Are soft skills or hard skills harder to learn? (Comparison)

I would argue soft skills are generally harder to acquire. Hard skills, like using a software program, can be learned through structured courses relatively quickly. Soft skills, however, involve deeply ingrained habits and personality traits, so improving your communication or empathy requires sustained self-awareness and practice over years. They are more **nuanced** and **subtle**, which is precisely why they are so **prized** by employers.

3. Why are communication skills so important at work? (Cause & Effect)

Communication is fundamental because it **underpins** almost every workplace activity. Clear communication prevents misunderstandings, which can otherwise cause costly errors and conflict. It enables effective teamwork, allows ideas to be shared persuasively, and builds strong relationships with clients and colleagues. Someone who communicates well can influence, lead and collaborate far more effectively. In essence, poor communication can **derail** even the most technically **gifted** team.

4. How do soft skills affect a person's career progression? (Social Impact)

They have an enormous impact, often more than technical ability. As people **advance into leadership** and management, success depends less on doing the work themselves and more on inspiring, coordinating and communicating with others. Those with strong soft skills tend to be promoted faster because they can lead teams effectively. So while hard skills may get you hired, soft skills are frequently what determine how far you ultimately **ascend** and **excel**.

5. Will soft skills become more important as technology advances? (Future)

I firmly believe they will. As artificial intelligence automates more technical and analytical tasks, the distinctly human skills, creativity, empathy, leadership and complex communication, will become increasingly valuable. These are precisely the abilities machines struggle to **replicate**. So paradoxically, the more technological the world becomes, the more **premium** employers are likely to place on these **irreplaceable** human qualities.

6. How can people develop their soft skills? (Problem & Solution)

Soft skills are developed mainly through practice and self-reflection. Seeking out situations that stretch you, like leading a project or public speaking, builds confidence and competence. Actively seeking honest feedback and observing people who excel at these skills is invaluable. Reading and formal training can help too. The key is to treat them as **learnable** skills that improve with **deliberate** effort, not fixed **traits**.

7. Are there any downsides to focusing too much on soft skills? (Adv & Disadv)

There can be. While soft skills are vital, an **overemphasis** on charm and communication at the expense of actual competence can be problematic. Someone might **talk a good game** but lack the substance to deliver. In technical fields especially, genuine expertise remains **indispensable**. So the ideal is a solid foundation of hard skills combined with strong soft skills; one without the other leaves a person incomplete.

8. Some say soft skills should be taught in schools. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I strongly agree. Given how crucial these skills are for both work and life, it seems a serious oversight that they are rarely taught explicitly. Skills like communication, teamwork and emotional regulation could be **woven into** the curriculum from an early age. Equipping young people with these **competencies** would make them far more employable and better prepared for life, so it would be a genuinely **worthwhile** reform.

Lifelong Learning

Education & Work · sp3_education_12 · 7 of 8 answers edited

1. Do you think learning should continue throughout a person's life? (Opinion)

Absolutely, I am a firm believer in lifelong learning. The idea that education ends when you leave school is completely **outdated**, especially in today's fast-changing world. Continuing to learn **keeps the mind sharp**, opens new opportunities and helps people adapt to change. Beyond practical benefits, I think curiosity and growth are essential to a fulfilling life. Learning should be a **lifelong pursuit**, not a phase.

2. Is it easier to learn when you are young or when you are older? (Comparison)

There are **trade-offs** at each stage. Young people generally absorb new information, especially languages, more easily, and have fewer competing responsibilities. However, adult learners bring focus, motivation and real-world experience that can make their learning more **purposeful** and efficient. So while children may have a biological advantage, adults **compensate** with discipline and context. Neither is simply easier; it depends on what is being learned.

3. Why is continuous learning becoming more necessary today? (Cause & Effect)

It is primarily because of the **breakneck pace** of technological change. Skills that were valuable a decade ago can quickly become **obsolete**, and entirely new fields emerge constantly. To remain employable, workers must continually update their knowledge and **reskill**. The old model of one qualification lasting a whole career is no longer viable. In short, adaptability through learning has become a genuine necessity, not a luxury.

4. How does lifelong learning benefit society? (Social Impact)

A society that embraces lifelong learning tends to be more adaptable, innovative and **economically resilient**, as its workforce can respond to change. It also promotes **social mobility**, giving people second chances to improve their prospects. On a personal level, continued learning keeps older people mentally active and engaged, which benefits public health. So it strengthens both the economy and the overall **vitality** of a community.

5. Do you think lifelong learning will become the norm in the future? (Future)

I am confident it will, **out of sheer necessity**. As careers become less linear and technology evolves ever faster, continuous learning and periodic reskilling will simply be part of working life. I anticipate more flexible, **bite-sized** courses and employer-sponsored training becoming **commonplace**. Society's whole conception of education will likely shift from a one-off event to an ongoing, lifelong process.

6. What prevents adults from continuing to learn, and how can this be solved?

(Problem & Solution)

The main barriers are usually time, cost and lack of confidence. Busy working adults with family commitments struggle to find the time and money for further study. To address this, flexible online and part-time courses are invaluable, as is employer support through funded training. Governments could also offer **subsidies** or learning accounts. **Removing Dismantling** these obstacles would make lifelong learning genuinely **attainable** for everyone.

7. Are there any drawbacks to constantly having to learn new skills? (Adv & Disadv)

There can be. While staying current is beneficial, the constant pressure to reskill can be exhausting and stressful, creating a feeling that you can never **rest on your achievements**. It may also breed anxiety about becoming obsolete. For some, particularly older workers, this **relentless** demand can feel genuinely overwhelming. So although the principle is sound, the pace of change can make it feel like a **burden** rather than a joy.

8. Some say you are never too old to learn. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I wholeheartedly agree. While learning styles may change with age, the human brain remains capable of acquiring new knowledge and skills throughout life. There are countless inspiring examples of people learning languages, instruments or even new careers late in life. I think the biggest barrier is usually psychological, a **self-imposed** belief that it is too late. In reality, curiosity and effort **transcend** age entirely, keeping us **youthful** in spirit.

Social Media

Technology & Media · sp3_technology_01 · 6 of 8 answers edited

1. Do you think social media has a positive or negative effect on society? (Opinion)

I think it is genuinely a **mixed blessing**. On the positive side, social media connects people across distances, gives a voice to the marginalised and spreads information rapidly. However, its negative effects are equally significant, from spreading misinformation to fuelling anxiety and comparison. In my view, the platforms themselves are **neutral**; the real issue is how we use them. Used **mindfully**, the benefits can outweigh the drawbacks.

2. How has social media changed the way people communicate? (Comparison)

It has transformed communication dramatically. In the past, staying in touch required letters or calls, whereas now we can share our lives instantly with hundreds of people at once. Communication has become faster and more visual, but arguably more **superficial**. We interact more frequently yet often less **meaningfully**, replacing deep conversations with quick likes and comments. So it has **widened our reach** while sometimes shallowing our connections.

3. How does social media affect young people's mental health? (Social Impact)

The impact can be quite concerning. Constant exposure to carefully curated, idealised images can **fuel feelings of inadequacy** and low self-esteem, particularly regarding appearance. The pressure to gain likes and the **fear of missing out** can also cause real anxiety. That said, it can also provide community and support. On balance, though, I believe excessive use is genuinely **detrimental** to young people's wellbeing.

4. Why do you think people share so much of their lives online? (Cause & Effect)

I think it stems largely from a deep human desire for validation and connection. Receiving likes and comments triggers a sense of approval that can be quite **addictive**. Many people also enjoy documenting their lives and keeping in touch. However, this **compulsion** to share can tip into oversharing, where people **curate** an idealised image, sometimes at the expense of actually living in the moment.

5. How do you think social media will develop in the future? (Future)

I anticipate it will become even more immersive, possibly through virtual and augmented reality, blurring the line between online and offline life further. Artificial intelligence will make content ever more **personalised**, which raises concerns about **echo chambers**. Hopefully, there will also be a growing backlash leading to more regulation and healthier usage habits. So it will likely become more **sophisticated**, but not necessarily more beneficial.

6. What can be done to reduce the harmful effects of social media? (Problem & Solution)

A **multi-pronged** approach is needed. On an individual level, promoting digital literacy and encouraging conscious limits on usage helps enormously. Platforms themselves should be **held accountable** for their algorithms and do more to combat misinformation and protect young users. Governments may also need to introduce sensible regulation. Ultimately, teaching people to engage **critically** rather than passively is the most sustainable solution.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of social media for businesses? (Adv & Disadv)

For businesses, the advantages are substantial: it offers a cheap, powerful way to reach a huge audience, build a brand and engage directly with customers. Small businesses in particular can **thrive**. The disadvantages include the risk of negative publicity spreading rapidly, the pressure to constantly produce content, and vulnerability to online **backlash**. So it is a powerful tool, but one that requires careful, **strategic** management.

8. Some say social media does more harm than good. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I am somewhat **torn** on this. There **is** **seems to be** compelling evidence of harm, from mental health issues to the spread of misinformation, which I take seriously. However, I cannot ignore the genuine benefits, such as connecting isolated people and enabling social movements. So rather than declaring it simply harmful, I would say its impact is highly dependent on usage. The technology is not inherently **malign**; our habits determine its **net effect**.

Artificial Intelligence

Technology & Media · sp3_technology_02 · 5 of 8 answers edited

1. Do you think artificial intelligence will benefit or harm humanity? (Opinion)

I believe AI has the potential to do both, and the outcome depends entirely on how we manage it. On the positive side, it could **revolutionise** medicine, science and productivity, solving problems beyond human capacity. On the other hand, it raises serious concerns about **job displacement**, privacy and even safety. So I am cautiously optimistic, but I firmly believe it requires careful **ethical oversight** to remain beneficial rather than harmful.

2. Are there things humans can do that AI never will? (Comparison)

I firmly believe so, at least for the foreseeable future. While AI excels at processing data and pattern recognition, it lacks genuine consciousness, emotional depth and lived experience. True creativity, empathy, moral judgement and the ability to understand context in a human way remain uniquely ours. AI can **mimic** these, but I do not think it can authentically **replicate** the human **essence** behind them.

3. What effect will AI have on employment? (Cause & Effect)

The effect will be profound and disruptive. AI will inevitably **automate** many jobs, particularly routine and repetitive ones, which will **displace** some workers. However, history suggests it will also create new roles and industries we cannot yet imagine. The key challenge is managing the **transition**, ensuring that displaced workers can retrain. Without such support, there is a genuine risk of increased inequality and social disruption.

4. How is AI already changing everyday life? (Social Impact)

AI is already deeply **embedded** in our daily routines, often **invisibly**. It powers the recommendations on our streaming services, the navigation on our phones, and the virtual assistants we speak to. It filters our emails and even helps diagnose illnesses. Most of this makes life more convenient and efficient. However, this quiet **integration** also raises important questions about how much of our lives we are handing over to algorithms.

5. Should there be limits on the development of AI? (Future)

Yes, I strongly believe sensible limits and regulation are essential. The technology is advancing so rapidly that it risks outpacing our ability to understand its consequences. Without ethical guidelines and oversight, there are real dangers regarding privacy, bias and even autonomous weapons. This does not mean **stifling** innovation, but rather guiding it responsibly. I think proactive **governance** is far wiser than trying to **contain** the risks after they emerge.

6. How can societies prepare for the widespread use of AI? (Problem & Solution)

Preparation must happen on several fronts. Education systems need to adapt, focusing on the creative and interpersonal skills that AI cannot replicate, while also teaching digital literacy. Governments should invest in retraining programmes for workers whose jobs are at risk. Crucially, robust ethical frameworks and regulations must be developed proactively. A **social safety net** may also be needed to **cushion** those affected by the **disruption**.

7. What are the main benefits and risks of using AI in healthcare? (Adv & Disadv)

The benefits are enormous. AI can analyse medical images with incredible accuracy, help diagnose diseases early, and accelerate drug discovery, potentially saving countless lives.

However, the risks include the danger of **algorithmic bias** leading to unequal care, concerns over patient data privacy, and the potential for errors if AI is trusted **blindly**. So while it is a genuinely powerful tool, human oversight remains absolutely **indispensable**.

8. Some fear AI will one day become smarter than humans. Do you share this concern? (Agree / Disagree)

I have measured concern rather than alarm. AI already surpasses us in narrow tasks like calculation, and it will keep improving. The idea of a general intelligence exceeding humans is more **speculative**, but not impossible in the long term. My concern is less about a science-fiction takeover and more about the immediate risks of misuse and lack of control. So I think a degree of **vigilance** is wise, but **hysteria** is unhelpful.

Digital Communication

Technology & Media · sp3_technology_03 · 7 of 8 answers edited

1. Do you think digital communication is better than face-to-face communication? (Opinion)

I would say it is not better, but rather different, with its own strengths. Digital communication offers **unmatched** convenience and lets us stay connected across any distance instantly. However, it lacks the richness of face-to-face interaction, where tone, body language and physical presence convey so much. For deep, emotional conversations, nothing beats being together in person. So digital tools are a wonderful **supplement**, but not a full **substitute** for genuine human contact.

2. How is the way young people communicate different from older generations? (Comparison)

The difference is quite marked. Young people have grown up as **digital natives**, so they favour instant messaging, voice notes and social media over phone calls, which many find **intrusive**. Older generations often prefer calls or in-person conversation. Young people also communicate more through images, emojis and memes, a kind of **visual shorthand**. This can lead to occasional misunderstanding between the generations, though both are simply adapting to their era.

3. What effect has instant messaging had on our language? (Cause & Effect)

It has had a noticeable influence. Instant messaging has spawned a whole new informal language of abbreviations, emojis and slang, which allows for quick, expressive communication. Some worry this is **eroding** traditional writing skills and grammar, especially among the young. However, I take a more relaxed view; language has always **evolved**, and people generally understand when to switch between casual and formal **registers**. So it is evolution, not decay.

4. Has technology made us more or less connected to each other? (Social Impact)

This is a fascinating **paradox**. On the surface, technology has made us more connected than ever, allowing instant contact with anyone worldwide. Yet many argue we are actually more isolated, replacing deep, present relationships with shallow digital interactions. We may have hundreds of online contacts but few genuine **confidants**. So I would say we are more connected in quantity but perhaps less connected in quality and true **intimacy**.

5. How do you think we will communicate in the future? (Future)

I imagine communication will become even more immersive and instantaneous. Technologies like virtual reality could allow us to feel genuinely present with distant people, and real-time translation may **dissolve** language barriers entirely. We may increasingly communicate through augmented reality overlays too. While exciting, I hope these advances **enhance** rather than replace human warmth, and that we do not lose the value of simple, **unmediated** face-to-face connection.

6. How can people avoid becoming too dependent on digital communication? (Problem & Solution)

Being intentional is key. Setting aside device-free time, particularly during meals or when with loved ones, helps enormously. Consciously choosing to call or meet someone rather than always texting preserves deeper connection. Turning off unnecessary notifications reduces the **constant pull** of our devices. Essentially, we need to treat technology as a tool that serves us, rather than allowing it to **dominate** our attention and **displace** real interaction.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of communicating mainly through text? (Adv & Disadv)

Text communication is convenient, allowing you to reply at your own pace and keep a **written record**, which is useful. It is also less intrusive than a call. However, the major disadvantage is the absence of tone and body language, which makes messages easy to **misinterpret**. It can also feel **impersonal** and lead to misunderstandings that a quick conversation would avoid. So it is efficient, but emotionally limited.

8. Some say technology is making face-to-face conversation a dying skill. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I think there is a **kernel of truth** to this, though I would not go so far as to call it dying. It is certainly true that some young people, accustomed to texting, can feel awkward in direct conversation and may struggle to read social cues. However, humans are inherently social, and the need for real connection persists. So the skill may be underused and in need of **nurturing**, but I do not believe it will ever become **obsolete**.

Online Privacy

Technology & Media · sp3_technology_04 · 5 of 8 answers edited

1. How important is online privacy to you? (Opinion)

I consider online privacy extremely important, though I admit I do not always protect it as well as I should. In an age where our data is constantly collected, I believe people have a fundamental right to control their personal information. The **erosion** of privacy can lead to manipulation and surveillance, which is genuinely worrying. So while convenience often tempts us to be careless, I think **safeguarding** our privacy is a vital and **overlooked** responsibility.

2. Do people care about privacy more or less than they used to? (Comparison)

This is quite paradoxical. On one hand, awareness of privacy issues has grown enormously following major data scandals, so people claim to care more. On the other hand, our actual behaviour suggests otherwise; we **readily** hand over data for the sake of convenience and free services. This gap between concern and action is often called the **privacy paradox**. So people are more aware, yet often equally willing to **compromise** their privacy.

3. What are the consequences of companies collecting so much personal data? (Cause & Effect)

The consequences are significant and often hidden. Companies use our data to target advertising with **uncanny** precision, which can feel manipulative. More seriously, large data collections are vulnerable to breaches, potentially exposing people to fraud and identity theft. There is also the broader concern of this information being used to influence our behaviour and opinions. Essentially, it creates a huge **imbalance** of power that can **undermine** individual autonomy.

4. How does the loss of privacy affect society? (Social Impact)

A society without privacy can become one of pervasive surveillance, which can have a **chilling effect** on free expression. If people feel constantly watched, they may **self-censor** and conform, which is unhealthy for democracy. The concentration of personal data in a few powerful hands also creates opportunities for manipulation on a mass scale. So the erosion of privacy is not

merely a personal issue; it has profound **implications** for freedom itself.

5. Do you think privacy will exist in the future? (Future)

I am somewhat pessimistic, though not entirely without hope. As technology becomes ever more **pervasive**, with smart devices and surveillance everywhere, maintaining privacy will become increasingly difficult. However, I am hopeful that growing public awareness and stronger regulations, like data protection laws, could push back against this trend. So while privacy as we once knew it may diminish, I believe the fight to **preserve** a meaningful degree of it will **intensify**.

6. What can be done to better protect people's online privacy? (Problem & Solution)

Solutions must operate at multiple levels. Governments should enforce robust data protection laws that give people genuine control over their information, like Europe's regulations. Companies must be more **transparent** about how they use data. On an individual level, education about privacy settings, strong passwords and cautious sharing is vital. Ultimately, shifting the default towards protecting the user, rather than **exploiting** them, is the most important **safeguard**.

7. Are there any benefits to sharing personal data with companies? (Adv & Disadv)

Yes, there are genuine trade-offs. Sharing data allows companies to offer highly personalised and convenient services, from tailored recommendations to smoother experiences. Many valuable free services are funded this way. In healthcare, shared data can even advance medical research. The problem is the lack of **transparency** and consent. So the benefits are real, but they should come from an informed, **voluntary** exchange rather than covert **exploitation**.

8. Some say if you have nothing to hide, privacy does not matter. Do you agree?

(Agree / Disagree)

I strongly disagree with that argument. Privacy is not about hiding wrongdoing; it is a fundamental right that protects our autonomy and dignity. We all have private thoughts and information that are simply **nobody else's business**, regardless of innocence. This argument also dangerously assumes those in power will always act benevolently. In my view, defending privacy is about protecting freedom itself, not **concealing** anything **sinister**.

Media & News

Technology & Media · sp3_technology_05 · 5 of 8 answers edited

1. How important is it for people to follow the news? (Opinion)

I believe it is quite important for people to stay reasonably informed, as it is part of being an engaged citizen. Understanding current events helps us make sense of the world and participate in democracy. However, I would add a **caveat**; consuming too much news, especially negative or sensational content, can be **overwhelming** and **anxiety-inducing**. So the ideal is to stay informed through reliable sources without becoming obsessed.

2. How has the way people get news changed over the years? (Comparison)

The change has been revolutionary. In the past, people relied on scheduled TV bulletins and printed newspapers, receiving curated news once or twice a day. Now, news is constant, instant and consumed largely through social media and online sources. This has made news more accessible, but also more **fragmented** and harder to verify. The rise of citizen journalism is a benefit, but so too is the spread of **unverified**, **sensational** content.

3. Why do you think fake news spreads so easily? (Cause & Effect)

Several factors are at play. Social media algorithms tend to prioritise engaging content, and false or sensational stories are often more **provocative** than the truth. People also share things impulsively without verifying them, especially if they confirm existing beliefs. The lack of traditional editorial gatekeepers online means misinformation can spread **unchecked**. Combined

with a general decline in media literacy, this creates the perfect conditions for falsehoods to **proliferate**.

4. How does the media influence public opinion? (Social Impact)

The media **wields** enormous influence over public opinion. By choosing which stories to cover and how to frame them, it shapes what people think is important and how they interpret events. This **agenda-setting** power is significant. Repeated exposure to particular viewpoints can gradually shape attitudes, sometimes reinforcing bias. So while a free media is vital for democracy, its power to **sway** opinion also carries real responsibility.

5. Do you think traditional newspapers will survive in the future? (Future)

In their printed form, I think they will largely decline, as younger generations consume news almost entirely online. However, I do not believe quality journalism itself will disappear; rather, it will continue its shift to digital platforms and subscription models. The **reputable** news organisations behind the papers may well **endure**, just in a different format. So the printed page may fade, but the institution of journalism should **persist**.

6. What can be done to combat the spread of misinformation? (Problem & Solution)

Tackling this requires a combined effort. Improving media literacy so people can critically **evaluate** sources is perhaps the most important long-term solution. Social media platforms must also take greater responsibility, using fact-checking and adjusting algorithms that reward sensationalism. Supporting quality, independent journalism is equally vital. Ultimately, an informed, **sceptical** public is the best defence against the **tide of misinformation**.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of having 24-hour news? (Adv & Disadv)

The advantage is that we are kept constantly informed of breaking events as they unfold, which can be valuable in a crisis. However, the disadvantages are considerable. The pressure to fill airtime often leads to speculation, repetition and **sensationalism** over substance. It can also foster a state of perpetual anxiety and **desensitise** us to serious events. So constant news offers **immediacy** at the cost of depth and perspective.

8. Some say the media focuses too much on negative news. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I largely agree with this. There is a well-known principle in journalism that bad news sells, so outlets tend to prioritise disasters, conflict and scandal, which are more attention-grabbing. This can give people a distorted, overly **pessimistic** view of the world, ignoring genuine progress. While reporting problems is important, this relentless **negativity** can be **demoralising**. A more balanced approach, including constructive news, would be healthier.

Smartphones & Devices

Technology & Media · sp3_technology_06 · 7 of 8 answers edited

1. Do you think smartphones have improved people's lives? (Opinion)

On the whole, I think they have, though not without significant drawbacks. Smartphones have put a world of information, communication and services in our pockets, which is genuinely empowering and convenient. However, they have also introduced constant distraction and a degree of **dependence** that can harm our focus and relationships. So I see them as a remarkable tool that has improved life, provided we use them **consciously** rather than **compulsively**.

2. How was life different before smartphones? (Comparison)

Life was noticeably slower and, in some ways, more present. People were less **contactable** and more likely to be fully engaged in their **immediate surroundings** rather than staring at a screen. Getting lost, being bored or having to memorise information were normal. While we have gained incredible convenience, I think we have lost a certain patience and the ability to simply be **idle**, which had its own value.

3. What effects does excessive smartphone use have on people? (Cause & Effect)

The effects can be quite detrimental. Excessive use is seems to be linked to reduced attention spans, disrupted sleep and increased anxiety, partly due to the constant stream of notifications. It can also erode face-to-face social skills and lead to a sedentary lifestyle. There is even a recognised phenomenon of phone addiction. So while occasional use is harmless, overuse can genuinely impair both our mental and physical wellbeing.

4. How have smartphones changed social interactions? (Social Impact)

They have transformed them in mixed ways. On one hand, they let us maintain connections effortlessly across distances. On the other, they often intrude on our real-world interactions; it is common to see people together physically but absorbed in their phones. This phenomenon, sometimes called phubbing, can make people feel ignored. So smartphones have expanded our virtual social lives while sometimes diminishing the quality of our present ones.

5. How do you think mobile technology will develop in the future? (Future)

I anticipate devices will become even more integrated into our lives, perhaps evolving beyond the handheld phone into wearables or augmented reality glasses. Artificial intelligence will make them ever more anticipatory and personalised. The line between the digital and physical worlds is likely to blur further. While this promises even greater convenience, I hope it comes with a stronger awareness of the need to remain present and in control.

6. How can people reduce their dependence on their phones? (Problem & Solution)

There are several practical strategies. Turning off non-essential notifications immediately reduces the constant pull to check the phone. Designating device-free times and zones, such as during meals or in the bedroom, helps re-establish boundaries. Using apps that track and limit screen time can raise awareness of usage. Ultimately, consciously replacing mindless scrolling with more rewarding activities is the most sustainable way to loosen the phone's grip.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of children owning smartphones?

(Adv & Disadv)

The advantages include safety, as parents can stay in contact, and access to educational resources. It also helps children develop digital literacy. However, the disadvantages are considerable: exposure to inappropriate content, cyberbullying, addiction and reduced physical activity. It can also hinder the development of face-to-face social skills. So while there are benefits, I believe children's phone use needs careful supervision and sensible limits.

8. Some say people cannot live without their phones now. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I think that is an exaggeration, but it contains an uncomfortable truth. Obviously, people survived perfectly well before phones, so it is not a literal dependency. However, phones have become so integral to how we work, navigate and communicate that living without one would be genuinely inconvenient and isolating in modern society. So while we could live without them, our society has become so reliant on them that it would be a difficult adjustment.

The Internet & Information

Technology & Media · sp3_technology_07 · 7 of 8 answers edited

1. Do you think the internet has been a good thing for society? (Opinion)

Overwhelmingly, yes, though it is not without serious problems. The internet has democratised access to information and education, connected the world, and driven economic innovation in extraordinary ways. It has empowered individuals and given voice to the voiceless. However, it has also enabled misinformation, cybercrime and privacy violations. On balance, I consider it one of humanity's most transformative and beneficial inventions, provided we manage its downsides responsibly.

2. How did people find information before the internet? (Comparison)

It was a far more **laborious** process. People relied on libraries, encyclopaedias, newspapers and asking knowledgeable individuals. Finding a specific fact could take hours or even days of research. While this was slow, some argue it encouraged deeper engagement and better retention. Today, information is instant, but arguably we process it more **superficially**. So the internet has traded depth and effort for **unprecedented** speed and convenience.

3. What are the effects of having so much information available online? (Cause & Effect)

The effects are double-edged. On the positive side, unprecedented access to information empowers learning and informed decision-making. However, this sheer abundance can lead to **information overload**, making it hard to focus or discern what is reliable. It can also create echo chambers, where algorithms feed us only what we already believe. So while access is empowering, navigating it wisely requires strong **discernment** to avoid being overwhelmed or **misled**.

4. How has the internet affected inequality between people? (Social Impact)

It has had a complex effect. In some ways it has reduced inequality by giving people everywhere access to free education and economic opportunities. However, it has also created a new form of inequality, the so-called **digital divide**, between those with reliable access and skills and those without. Those lacking connectivity or literacy risk being left further behind. So the internet is a **double-edged** force that can either narrow or widen **disparities**.

5. Do you think everyone will have internet access in the future? (Future)

I am hopeful that access will become nearly universal, though significant gaps will likely **persist** for some time. Technology like satellite internet is rapidly extending connectivity to remote regions, and access is increasingly seen as a **basic necessity**. However, cost and **infrastructure** remain real barriers in poorer areas. So while I believe the digital divide will narrow considerably, achieving truly universal access will require sustained global investment.

6. How can people learn to tell reliable information from unreliable information online? (Problem & Solution)

Developing critical thinking is essential. People should learn to check the credibility of a source, look for corroboration from multiple reputable outlets, and be wary of sensational headlines designed to provoke. Being aware of one's own biases is also important. Ideally, these media literacy skills should be taught in schools from a young age, **equipping** people to **scrutinise** information rather than accepting it **uncritically**.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of children using the internet for learning? (Adv & Disadv)

The advantages are substantial: the internet offers a vast library of educational content, interactive tools and access to knowledge that **enriches** learning enormously. It **caters to** different learning styles too. The disadvantages include exposure to unreliable or inappropriate content, distraction, and the risk of reduced deep reading. So it is a **phenomenal** educational resource, but children need guidance and supervision to use it safely and effectively.

8. Some say the internet makes people less intelligent. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I disagree with that as a **blanket statement**, though it raises a fair concern. The internet does not make us less intelligent; rather, it changes how we use our intelligence. We may memorise less, relying on it as an external memory, but we have unparalleled access to knowledge. The risk is that passive consumption and short attention spans can weaken deep thinking. So it is a tool that can either **enrich** or **diminish** the mind, depending on use.

Online Entertainment

Technology & Media · sp3_technology_08 · 5 of 8 answers edited

1. Do you think online entertainment is better than traditional forms? (Opinion)

I would say it is not necessarily better, but far more convenient and personalised. Streaming and online platforms offer endless choice on demand, which is hard to beat. However, traditional forms like cinema, live theatre or reading a physical book offer a certain quality and communal experience that online consumption can lack. So I appreciate the convenience, but I do not think it fully replaces the richness of certain traditional experiences.

2. How is the way people are entertained today different from the past? (Comparison)

The difference is stark. In the past, entertainment was largely communal and scheduled; families gathered to watch a programme at a set time, or went out to the cinema. Today, entertainment is highly individualised and on-demand, consumed alone on personal devices whenever we wish. This offers wonderful freedom, but I think we have lost some of the shared, communal aspect. Entertainment has become more personalised yet arguably more solitary.

3. Why has streaming become so popular? (Cause & Effect)

Its popularity comes down to convenience and choice. Streaming offers instant, on-demand access to an enormous library of content that you can watch anywhere, anytime, without adverts. It is also relatively affordable compared to traditional cable. The personalised recommendations keep people engaged, and binge-watching entire series has become a cultural phenomenon. Essentially, it perfectly suits the modern desire for flexibility and instant gratification.

4. What impact do video games have on young people? (Social Impact)

The impact is genuinely mixed and often exaggerated. On the positive side, many games improve problem-solving, coordination and even teamwork when played socially, and they are a legitimate form of relaxation. However, excessive gaming can lead to addiction, a sedentary lifestyle and, in some cases, exposure to toxic online behaviour. So like most things, video games are beneficial in moderation but harmful to excess.

5. How do you think entertainment will change in the future? (Future)

I expect entertainment to become far more immersive and interactive. Virtual and augmented reality could allow us to step inside stories and games rather than merely watching them. Artificial intelligence may create personalised content tailored precisely to individual tastes. The line between passive viewing and active participation will likely blur. While thrilling, I hope this does not come at the expense of the shared, communal joys that entertainment can foster and preserve.

6. How can people avoid spending too much time on online entertainment? (Problem & Solution)

Self-discipline and awareness are key. Setting clear time limits and using apps that track usage can prevent hours from slipping away unnoticed. Consciously scheduling other activities, like exercise, hobbies or socialising, ensures entertainment does not crowd out everything else. It also helps to remove the constant temptation, perhaps by keeping devices out of reach. Essentially, treating entertainment as a reward rather than a default keeps it in balance.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of on-demand entertainment? (Adv & Disadv)

The advantages are obvious: unprecedented convenience, choice and control over what and when we watch. It is tailored to our tastes and available instantly. The disadvantages, however, include the temptation to binge excessively, which can waste time and disrupt sleep. The sheer abundance of choice can also be paralysing, and it can isolate us. So it offers wonderful freedom, but demands self-control to enjoy without overindulging.

8. Some say people are becoming too passive in how they spend their free time. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I have some sympathy with this view. There is a real tendency to default to passive consumption, like endless scrolling or binge-watching, which requires little effort and can be **mindless**. This may come at the expense of more active, **enriching** pursuits like exercise, hobbies or socialising. However, I would not generalise too broadly, as many people remain active. It is more a temptation to **guard against** than an inevitable decline.

Technology & Children

Technology & Media · sp3_technology_09 · 6 of 8 answers edited

1. At what age do you think children should be allowed to use technology? (Opinion)

This is a difficult question with no perfect answer. I believe very young children should have extremely limited screen time, as their development depends on **real-world play** and interaction. As they grow, technology can be gradually introduced, ideally in an educational and supervised way. So rather than a strict age, I favour a **gradual, age-appropriate** approach, always emphasising quality of content over quantity of time.

2. How is childhood today different because of technology? (Comparison)

Technology has fundamentally reshaped childhood. Today's children are digital natives, growing up with screens and instant access to information their parents never had. Much of their play, learning and socialising now happens online. While this offers incredible opportunities, it also means less unstructured outdoor play and more **sedentary** time. So childhood is arguably more **stimulating** but also more **screen-bound** than it was a generation ago.

3. What effects can too much screen time have on children? (Cause & Effect)

The potential effects are concerning. Excessive screen time **is** **seems to be** linked to problems with sleep, attention and physical health due to **inactivity**. It may also **hinder** the development of social skills and language if it replaces real interaction. There are concerns about exposure to unsuitable content too. So while technology has benefits, an excess can genuinely **impair** a child's healthy development, both physically and socially.

4. How can technology be used positively in children's education? (Social Impact)

Used well, technology can be a wonderful educational tool. Interactive apps and games can make learning engaging and cater to different learning styles. It gives children access to a vast world of knowledge and can help those with special needs. Educational videos can explain complex ideas vividly. The key is that it should be used **purposefully** as a **supplement** to good teaching, not as a **substitute** for it.

5. Do you think future generations will be even more dependent on technology?

(Future)

Almost certainly, yes. As technology becomes ever more woven into every aspect of life, future generations will grow up with it as an **inseparable** part of their existence. This dependence will likely deepen, which brings both opportunities and risks. My hope is that alongside this, we will develop a stronger culture of digital wellbeing, teaching children to use technology **intentionally** and to maintain a healthy balance rather than being **consumed** by it.

6. How can parents keep their children safe online? (Problem & Solution)

Parents can take several practical steps. Using **parental controls** and age-appropriate settings helps filter unsuitable content. Keeping devices in shared family spaces rather than bedrooms allows for supervision. Most importantly, maintaining open, honest communication so children feel able to report anything **troubling** is vital. Educating children about online risks, like strangers and scams, **empowers** them. Ultimately, a combination of supervision and education is the best protection.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of children learning to code at a young age? (Adv & Disadv)

The advantages are significant. Coding teaches **logical thinking**, problem-solving and creativity, and it **equips** children with a highly valuable skill for the future job market. It can also be genuinely fun and empowering. The potential disadvantages are that it adds to screen time and academic pressure, and it should not **crowd out** other essential activities like play and physical exercise. So it is a valuable skill, provided it is kept in balance and not forced.

8. Some say technology is robbing children of a real childhood. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I partly agree, though I think it is a little **overstated**. There is a legitimate concern that excessive screen time is replacing the outdoor play, imagination and face-to-face friendships that define a healthy childhood. However, technology also offers genuine benefits and is simply the reality of the modern world. So rather than **demonising** it, I believe the answer lies in **moderation**, ensuring children still enjoy a rich, balanced upbringing.

Traditions & Customs

Culture & Lifestyle · sp3_culture_01 · 4 of 8 answers edited

1. Do you think traditions are still important in modern society? (Opinion)

I believe they are more important than ever. In a rapidly changing, globalised world, traditions provide a vital sense of identity, continuity and belonging. They connect us to our history and to one another. While some outdated customs deserve to fade, I think the core traditions that **bind** a community together are worth **preserving**. They give life a certain meaning and rhythm that **modernity** alone cannot provide.

2. Are young people less interested in traditions than older generations? (Comparison)

To some extent, yes, though it varies. Young people, being more exposed to global culture and modern lifestyles, sometimes view certain traditions as **outdated** or irrelevant. However, I would not say they have abandoned tradition entirely; many still take great pride in their **cultural roots**, just alongside a more modern outlook. So there is a shift in emphasis, but I think the connection to heritage remains, merely **reinterpreted** in a contemporary context.

3. Why do you think some traditions are disappearing? (Cause & Effect)

Several forces are at work. Globalisation and the dominance of Western culture have **homogenised** lifestyles, making some local customs seem less relevant. Urbanisation and modern, busy lives also leave less time for elaborate traditional practices. Additionally, as older generations pass away, knowledge and skills are sometimes not passed on. So it is really a combination of cultural **dilution** and the practical pressures of modern life **eroding** them.

4. How do traditions help bring communities together? (Social Impact)

Traditions play a powerful unifying role. Shared festivals, rituals and customs create a sense of collective identity and belonging, reminding people that they are part of something larger than themselves. They bring people together to celebrate or mourn collectively, strengthening social bonds. This shared heritage fosters mutual understanding and **solidarity**. In essence, traditions act as a kind of **social glue** that reinforces community **cohesion**.

5. Do you think traditions will survive in the future? (Future)

I am cautiously optimistic. While some traditions will inevitably fade, I believe the most meaningful ones will **endure**, perhaps in modified forms. There is actually a growing appreciation for heritage as a counterbalance to globalisation, with many people actively seeking to **revive** old customs. Technology can also help document and share them. So rather than vanishing, I think traditions will **evolve**, adapting to remain relevant in a changing world.

6. What can be done to preserve traditional culture? (Problem & Solution)

A **concerted effort** is needed. Education is crucial; teaching young people about their heritage in schools fosters pride and understanding. Documenting traditions and supporting the **artisans**

and elders who hold this knowledge is also vital. Governments and communities can organise festivals and cultural events to keep customs alive and visible. Essentially, making tradition feel relevant and engaging to the young is the key to its **continuity**.

7. Are there any disadvantages to holding on to old traditions? (Adv & Disadv)

Yes, tradition can have a darker side. Some customs are rooted in outdated beliefs and can **perpetuate** inequality or harmful practices, such as those that discriminate against certain groups. Blindly following tradition can also **stifle** progress and individual freedom. So while I value heritage, I think it is important to be discerning, preserving what enriches us while being willing to **discard** customs that are genuinely harmful or unjust.

8. Some say globalisation is destroying local cultures. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I partly agree, as it is a genuine threat. The spread of a dominant global culture can certainly **overshadow** and dilute local traditions, languages and customs, leading to a worrying uniformity. However, I would not say it is entirely destructive. Globalisation also allows cultures to share and celebrate their uniqueness on a world stage. So while the risk of **homogenisation** is real, cultures can also prove remarkably **resilient** and adaptive.

Festivals & Celebrations

Culture & Lifestyle · sp3_culture_02 · 6 of 8 answers edited

1. Why do you think festivals are important? (Opinion)

Festivals serve several important purposes. They provide a much-needed break from routine and an occasion for joy and celebration. More deeply, they reinforce cultural identity and bring communities and families together in shared rituals. They also pass traditions from one generation to the next. In my view, this sense of **collective** celebration and **belonging** is something people fundamentally need, which is why festivals remain so **cherished** across cultures.

2. How are festivals celebrated differently now compared to the past? (Comparison)

The essence remains, but the style has changed. In the past, celebrations were often simpler and more community-focused, with everyone participating directly. Today, festivals have become more **commercialised**, with an emphasis on spending and consumption. Technology has also changed things; people now share their celebrations on social media. So while festivals are still meaningful, some argue they have lost a degree of **authenticity**, becoming more about **consumerism** than genuine tradition.

3. What effect does commercialisation have on traditional festivals? (Cause & Effect)

The effect is **double-edged**. On one hand, commercialisation can boost the economy and **raise a festival's profile**, making it more widely known. On the other, it can **dilute** the festival's original spiritual or cultural meaning, reducing it to a shopping opportunity. The genuine sentiment behind the celebration can get lost amid the advertising and pressure to spend. So it brings visibility, but often at the cost of authenticity and true significance.

4. How do festivals contribute to a country's economy? (Social Impact)

Festivals can be a significant economic driver. They boost spending on food, gifts, clothing and travel, benefiting countless businesses. Major festivals also attract tourists, generating substantial revenue for the hospitality and transport sectors. They create **seasonal employment** too. So beyond their cultural value, festivals are a genuine economic **stimulus**, injecting money into local economies and showcasing a country's culture to a global audience, which is a real **asset**.

5. Do you think traditional festivals will remain popular in the future? (Future)

I believe they will, though they will continue to evolve. While the way we celebrate may change, the fundamental human need for community, joy and shared meaning will ensure festivals **endure**. There may even be a **resurgence** of interest as people seek authenticity in an increasingly digital world. So while some may become more modernised or commercial, I think the core appeal of festivals will **persist** and remain relevant for generations.

6. How can the true spirit of festivals be preserved? (Problem & Solution)

Preserving the spirit requires conscious effort. Emphasising the values behind the festival, such as togetherness, gratitude or reflection, rather than just the material aspects, is important. Involving young people in traditional practices and explaining their meaning helps too. Communities can prioritise participation over consumption. Essentially, if we consciously focus on the **essence** of a festival rather than its **commercial trappings**, its true spirit can **thrive**.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of large public celebrations? (Adv & Disadv)

Large public celebrations create a wonderful, **vibrant** atmosphere and a powerful sense of collective joy and unity. They boost tourism and local pride. However, the disadvantages include practical issues like **overcrowding**, noise, litter and strain on public services. There can also be safety concerns. So while they are culturally and economically valuable, they require careful management to minimise the **disruption** and ensure everyone can enjoy them safely.

8. Some say festivals have become too commercial. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I largely agree with this observation. Many festivals now seem dominated by advertising, sales and pressure to spend, which can **overshadow** their original cultural or spiritual meaning. The focus has shifted, in some cases, from **togetherness** to consumerism. That said, this is not universal, and the deeper meaning often survives beneath the commercial surface for those who seek it. So it is a real trend to resist, but not an **irreversible** one.

Food & Cuisine

Culture & Lifestyle · sp3_culture_03 · 8 of 8 answers edited

1. How important is food to a country's culture? (Opinion)

Food is absolutely central to culture, in my view. It is far more than mere **sustenance**; it reflects a nation's history, geography, values and social customs. Sharing a meal is a universal expression of hospitality and community. Traditional dishes carry deep **sentimental** and cultural significance, passed down through generations. So I would say cuisine is one of the most **tangible** and beloved expressions of a country's identity.

2. How have people's eating habits changed over the years? (Comparison)

Eating habits have changed considerably. In the past, people mostly ate home-cooked, seasonal and local food, often together as a family. Today, busy lifestyles have led to more processed food, takeaways and eating **on the go**, often alone. **Portion sizes** have grown, and international cuisine is now widely available. While this offers more variety and convenience, I think it has come at some cost to health and the **communal** nature of dining.

3. Why do you think fast food has become so popular? (Cause & Effect)

Its popularity comes down to a few key factors. Firstly, it is convenient and quick, which suits our increasingly busy, time-poor lifestyles. Secondly, it is relatively cheap and consistently tasty, engineered to appeal to our **cravings**. Aggressive marketing has also made it **ubiquitous** and aspirational. Unfortunately, this convenience comes at a cost, as **many argue** its popularity has contributed to rising rates of **obesity** and related health problems.

4. How does the availability of international food affect local cuisine? (Social Impact)

It has a mixed effect. On the positive side, it enriches our **culinary** options and promotes **cultural exchange**, allowing people to enjoy dishes from around the world. This is broadening

and enjoyable. However, there is a concern that the popularity of international chains could **overshadow** and threaten traditional local cuisine. So while it adds welcome diversity, it is important that local food traditions are also valued and preserved alongside it.

5. How do you think the way we eat will change in the future? (Future)

I anticipate significant changes driven by health and sustainability concerns. Plant-based diets and **alternative proteins**, like lab-grown meat, are likely to become far more **mainstream** as we address the environmental impact of food. Technology may also personalise nutrition. Hopefully, there will be a renewed appreciation for healthy, **sustainable** eating. So our diets may become more conscious and innovative, balancing convenience with health and the planet.

6. What can be done to encourage people to eat more healthily? (Problem & Solution)

A range of measures could help. Education about nutrition from a young age is fundamental, so people can make informed choices. Making healthy food more affordable and accessible, while perhaps **taxing unhealthy options**, can shift behaviour. Clear **food labelling** and restrictions on junk food advertising, especially to children, would also help. Ultimately, creating an environment where the healthy choice is the easy, **appealing** choice is the most effective approach.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of eating out often? (Adv & Disadv)

Eating out offers convenience, saves time on cooking and cleaning, and provides a pleasant social experience and variety. It can be **a real treat**. The disadvantages, however, are that it is expensive and often less healthy, as restaurant food tends to be higher in salt, sugar and fat, with larger portions. Doing it too often can **strain** both your finances and your health. So it is best enjoyed in **moderation**.

8. Some say home-cooked food is always better than restaurant food. Do you agree?

(Agree / Disagree)

I largely agree, particularly regarding health and value. Home cooking allows you to control the ingredients, ensuring meals are fresher, healthier and cheaper, and it can be a rewarding activity. There is also something uniquely **comforting** about a home-cooked meal. However, I would not say it is always better; skilled chefs create **exquisite** dishes that are hard to **replicate** at home. So home cooking is generally healthier, but restaurants offer expertise and occasion.

Travel & Tourism

Culture & Lifestyle · sp3_culture_04 · 8 of 8 answers edited

1. Why do you think people enjoy travelling? (Opinion)

People travel for a wonderful variety of reasons. Fundamentally, I think it satisfies a deep human curiosity and desire to escape routine. Experiencing new cultures, landscapes and cuisines is genuinely **enriching** and broadens one's perspective. Travel also offers relaxation, adventure and the chance to create lasting memories. For me, the greatest value is how it makes you more **open-minded** and **appreciative** of the world's incredible diversity.

2. How has travel changed compared to the past? (Comparison)

Travel has been transformed almost beyond recognition. In the past, it was expensive, slow and largely a privilege of the wealthy. Today, **budget airlines** and the internet have made it far more accessible and easy to organise, leading to mass tourism. We can now reach distant corners of the globe in hours. While this democratisation is positive, it has also led to **overcrowding** at popular sites and a more **superficial**, hurried style of travel.

3. What effects does tourism have on local communities? (Cause & Effect)

Tourism has profound and mixed effects. Economically, it can bring vital income and jobs, boosting the local economy significantly. However, it can also cause problems: it may **inflate** local prices, strain infrastructure, and sometimes lead to the **commodification** of culture, where

traditions are performed purely for tourists. Environmental damage is another concern. So while tourism offers real economic benefits, it must be managed **sustainably** to avoid harming the very communities it supports.

4. How does travel affect a person's understanding of the world? (Social Impact)

Travel is genuinely one of the best forms of education. By experiencing different cultures firsthand, people develop empathy and challenge their own assumptions and prejudices. It reveals both the vast diversity and the fundamental similarities of humanity. This tends to make people more **tolerant**, worldly and appreciative of what they have at home. In essence, travel **broadens the mind** in a way that no book or documentary can fully **replicate**.

5. How do you think tourism will change in the future? (Future)

I foresee several shifts. Growing environmental awareness will likely make sustainable and **eco-tourism** far more popular, as people seek to **minimise their impact**. Technology, such as virtual reality, might offer new ways to experience places remotely. There may also be a move towards more meaningful, **immersive** travel over mass tourism. So I expect the future of travel to be more conscious, more personalised, and hopefully more responsible.

6. How can the negative impacts of tourism be reduced? (Problem & Solution)

Sustainable tourism practices are the answer. Governments can manage visitor numbers at fragile sites through limits or timed entry to prevent overcrowding. Promoting **lesser-known** destinations helps spread the benefits and reduce pressure on **hotspots**. Encouraging tourists to respect local cultures and environments, and to support local businesses, is also key. Essentially, prioritising sustainability over sheer volume can **mitigate** the harm while preserving the benefits.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of tourism for a country? (Adv & Disadv)

The advantages are considerable: tourism generates significant income and employment, funds infrastructure, and promotes cultural exchange and international understanding. It can be a real economic **lifeline**. The disadvantages include **environmental degradation**, overcrowding, the erosion of local culture and over-reliance on a volatile industry. So tourism is a powerful economic tool, but a country must balance the pursuit of revenue against protecting its environment and cultural **integrity**.

8. Some say tourism does more harm than good to destinations. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I think it depends entirely on how it is managed. In some over-touristed places, the harm, from environmental damage to cultural erosion and inflated living costs, is undeniable and can indeed outweigh the benefits. However, when managed responsibly and sustainably, tourism can be a tremendous **force for good**, funding conservation and lifting communities out of poverty. So I would not agree it is inherently harmful; the outcome **hinges on** responsible **stewardship** and planning.

Fashion & Trends

Culture & Lifestyle · sp3_culture_05 · 8 of 8 answers edited

1. Why do you think fashion is important to some people? (Opinion)

For many people, fashion is a genuine form of **self-expression**, allowing them to communicate their personality, mood and identity without words. It can boost confidence and create a sense of belonging to a particular group. For some, it is also an art form and a source of creativity. While I personally value comfort over trends, I completely understand why fashion **holds such significance**; it is a powerful, **visual language** of identity.

2. Do you think people care more about fashion now than in the past? (Comparison)

In some ways, yes. The rise of social media has made appearance more visible and, arguably, more important, with influencers constantly showcasing new trends. **Fast fashion** has also made trendy clothing cheap and accessible, **fuelling** constant consumption. However, past eras had their own strong fashion cultures too. So perhaps it is not that people care more, but that fashion has become more fast-paced, **disposable** and publicly displayed than ever before.

3. What effect does the fashion industry have on the environment? (Cause & Effect)

The environmental impact is unfortunately severe, particularly from fast fashion. The industry is a major consumer of water and a significant source of pollution and carbon emissions. The culture of buying cheap, disposable clothing generates enormous **textile waste**, much of which ends up in landfill. So while fashion brings joy and self-expression, its current **unsustainable** model **exact**s a **heavy toll** on the planet that urgently needs addressing.

4. How does fashion influence young people? (Social Impact)

Fashion has a **powerful hold** on young people. It is closely tied to identity and social acceptance, so what they wear can strongly affect their confidence and sense of belonging. Trends spread rapidly through social media, creating pressure to keep up, which can be expensive and stressful. While fashion can be a positive outlet for creativity, this **relentless** pressure to conform can also **breed insecurity** and unhealthy comparison.

5. How do you think fashion will change in the future? (Future)

I anticipate sustainability will become a **driving force**. As awareness of fast fashion's harm grows, I expect a shift towards more durable, ethical and recycled clothing, and a move away from **throwaway culture**. Technology may also personalise fashion, and digital or virtual clothing could even emerge. So I am hopeful the future of fashion will be more sustainable, more conscious, and perhaps less **wasteful** than the current model.

6. What can be done to make fashion more sustainable? (Problem & Solution)

Several changes are needed. On the industry side, brands should adopt ethical, eco-friendly production and be more transparent. Consumers can play a huge role by buying less, choosing quality over quantity, and embracing **second-hand** or recycled clothing. Repairing and reusing garments rather than discarding them also helps. Ultimately, moving away from a throwaway mindset towards more **durable**, **considered consumption** is the most impactful solution.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of following fashion trends? (Adv & Disadv)

Following trends can be fun and allows people to feel current, confident and part of a community. It is a **creative outlet** and can help people fit in socially. The disadvantages, though, are that constantly chasing trends is expensive, contributes to environmental waste, and can suppress genuine individuality. It can also foster insecurity. So while there is joy in it, an **obsessive** pursuit of trends can become both costly and **superficial**.

8. Some say fashion is a waste of money. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I only partly agree. Excessive spending on constantly changing trends, particularly disposable fast fashion, can certainly be wasteful and financially **imprudent**. However, I would not dismiss fashion entirely, as it is a **legitimate** form of self-expression and creativity that brings people genuine joy and confidence. Investing in quality, lasting pieces is also sensible. So it is not inherently a waste; it becomes one only when pursued excessively and **impulsively**.

Hobbies & Leisure

Culture & Lifestyle · sp3_culture_06 · 7 of 8 answers edited

1. Why are hobbies important in people's lives? (Opinion)

Hobbies are far more valuable than people often realise. They provide a **vital outlet** for relaxation and stress relief, offering a welcome escape from the pressures of work. They also

allow for personal growth, creativity and a sense of accomplishment outside our professional identity. Additionally, many hobbies foster social connections. In my view, hobbies are essential for a balanced, fulfilling life, **nourishing** parts of ourselves that work often **neglects**.

2. How do people's leisure activities differ between generations? (Comparison)

There are noticeable differences. Older generations often favour traditional **pastimes** like gardening, reading physical books, or socialising in person. Younger people, by contrast, spend much of their leisure time on digital activities, such as gaming, streaming and social media. That said, there is considerable overlap, and interest in older hobbies is **reviving** among the young. So the core need for leisure is universal, but the **medium** has shifted towards the digital.

3. What are the benefits of having a creative hobby? (Cause & Effect)

Creative hobbies offer numerous benefits. They provide a productive outlet for self-expression and can be deeply **therapeutic**, reducing stress and improving mental wellbeing. The sense of accomplishment from creating something is genuinely rewarding and boosts confidence. They also keep the mind active and can spark skills that **enrich** other areas of life. Essentially, creative pursuits **nourish the soul** and offer a fulfilment that passive entertainment simply cannot match.

4. How does having free time affect people's quality of life? (Social Impact)

Free time is essential for a good quality of life. It provides the space to rest, **recharge** and pursue the activities and relationships that bring us joy and meaning. Without adequate leisure, people risk burnout, stress and a **diminished** sense of wellbeing. Free time allows us to be more than just workers. So I would argue that leisure is not a luxury but a fundamental necessity for a healthy, **rounded** existence.

5. Do you think people will have more free time in the future? (Future)

This is uncertain. **Optimistically**, if automation boosts productivity and society chooses to share the gains, people could work less and enjoy more leisure, as concepts like the four-day week suggest. However, there is an opposing risk that **constant connectivity** and economic pressure could actually **erode** our free time further. So the amount of leisure we have may depend less on technology and more on the choices society makes about priorities.

6. Many people say they have no time for hobbies. What can they do? (Problem & Solution)

It often comes down to priorities rather than an absolute lack of time. People can start by consciously **carving out** even small **pockets of time**, perhaps by reducing passive activities like scrolling on their phones. Scheduling hobby time like any other commitment helps make it happen. Choosing hobbies that fit their lifestyle is also wise. Essentially, treating leisure as essential rather than optional helps people **reclaim** time they did not realise they had.

7. Are there any downsides to spending too much time on hobbies? (Adv & Disadv)

There can be, if taken to an extreme. While hobbies are healthy, an obsessive devotion to one could lead to neglecting responsibilities, relationships or work. Some hobbies can also become expensive. If a hobby turns into an escape from dealing with real problems, that is unhealthy too. So like most things, hobbies are wonderful in **moderation**, but they should **complement** a balanced life rather than **consume** it entirely.

8. Some say hobbies should be useful, not just for fun. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I respectfully disagree with that as a rule. While hobbies that build skills are certainly valuable, I firmly believe a hobby does not need to be productive to be **worthwhile**. The primary purpose of leisure is enjoyment, relaxation and wellbeing, and something that brings pure joy is valuable in itself. Insisting that all free time be useful reflects an overly **utilitarian** mindset. Sometimes, doing something simply for pleasure is **exactly the point**.

Consumer Behaviour & Shopping

Culture & Lifestyle · sp3_culture_07 · 8 of 8 answers edited

1. Do you think people buy more things than they actually need? (Opinion)

Yes, I think overconsumption is a defining feature of modern society. We are constantly **bombarded** with advertising designed to create desires for things we do not truly need. Cheap goods and easy credit make impulsive buying effortless. Many people also shop for emotional reasons, as a form of therapy. So I would say that a great deal of our consumption is driven by **manufactured** wants rather than genuine necessity, which is quite **wasteful**.

2. How has shopping changed with the rise of the internet? (Comparison)

Online shopping has **revolutionised** the experience. It offers **unparalleled** convenience, allowing people to buy almost anything from home at any hour, with easy price comparison. This has, however, put pressure on traditional physical shops, many of which have struggled. The experience has become more efficient but arguably less social. So while the internet has made shopping far more convenient and accessible, it has also transformed our **high streets**, not always for the better.

3. Why do you think advertising is so influential? (Cause & Effect)

Advertising is influential because it is sophisticated and **pervasive**. It cleverly taps into our emotions, insecurities and aspirations, associating products with happiness, status or belonging rather than mere function. Its sheer ubiquity means we are exposed to it constantly, which **reinforces** its messages. Modern targeted advertising is especially potent, as it is tailored precisely to our interests. So it shapes our desires far more than we consciously realise, subtly **steering** our behaviour.

4. What impact does consumerism have on society? (Social Impact)

Consumerism has a profound and mixed impact. It drives economic growth and provides jobs, which is beneficial. However, it also fuels **materialism**, encouraging people to equate happiness with possessions, which **studies suggest** many would argue is **illusory**. It contributes significantly to environmental degradation through waste and **resource depletion**. It can also foster debt and dissatisfaction. So while it powers the economy, unchecked consumerism carries serious social and environmental costs.

5. Do you think people will become more conscious consumers in the future? (Future)

I am cautiously hopeful. There is a growing awareness of the environmental and ethical impact of our purchases, and movements towards **minimalism**, sustainability and ethical consumption are **gaining momentum**. Younger generations in particular seem more **values-driven** in their spending. However, the powerful forces of marketing and convenience remain strong. So while I believe conscious consumption will increase, whether it becomes the norm depends on a genuine cultural shift.

6. How can people be encouraged to consume more responsibly? (Problem & Solution)

Education and awareness are key. Helping people understand the true environmental and social cost of their purchases can shift attitudes. Encouraging habits like buying quality over quantity, repairing rather than replacing, and choosing ethical brands makes a difference. Governments can also play a role through regulation and **incentives**. Ultimately, **fostering** a cultural value of **sufficiency** over excess, where we question whether we truly need something, is the most sustainable path.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of online shopping? (Adv & Disadv)

The advantages are clear: convenience, a vast selection, easy price comparison and often lower prices, all from home. It is a great **time-saver**. The disadvantages include the inability to physically examine products before buying, delivery delays, the environmental cost of packaging and transport, and the temptation to **overspend**. It also lacks the social experience of physical

shopping. So it offers wonderful convenience, but with some real **trade-offs** in experience and impact.

8. Some say buying things makes people happy. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I only partly agree. There is undeniably a short-term thrill in acquiring something new, so buying can bring a **fleeting** sense of pleasure. However, ~~extensive research suggests~~ many people feel this happiness is temporary and superficial, quickly fading in a cycle sometimes called the **hedonic treadmill**. Lasting happiness tends to come from experiences and relationships, not possessions. So while shopping offers momentary joy, relying on it for happiness is ultimately **hollow** and unfulfilling.

Globalisation of Culture

Culture & Lifestyle · sp3_culture_08 · 6 of 8 answers edited

1. Do you think cultural globalisation is a positive development? (Opinion)

I see it as a genuinely **double-edged** phenomenon. On the positive side, it fosters greater understanding, tolerance and exchange between cultures, and lets us enjoy the best of what the world offers, from food to film. However, there is a real risk that it leads to cultural **homogenisation**, where dominant cultures **overwhelm** local ones. So while I appreciate the connection it brings, I believe we must actively work to preserve cultural diversity alongside it.

2. How has globalisation changed local cultures? (Comparison)

The changes are significant. Local cultures have been enriched by exposure to global ideas, technologies and cuisines. However, they have also been challenged, as global brands, media and the English language spread, sometimes **eclipsing** local traditions and languages. The result is often a hybrid culture, blending the local and the global. So globalisation has made cultures more **interconnected** and diverse in some ways, yet more **uniform** in others.

3. What effect does the spread of English have on other languages? (Cause & Effect)

The spread of English as a global **lingua franca** has clear benefits, facilitating international communication, business and science. However, it also poses a threat to **linguistic diversity**. As English dominates, some smaller languages are being **marginalised** and, in extreme cases, are dying out, taking unique cultural knowledge with them. So while a common language is enormously useful, its dominance risks a loss of the rich linguistic heritage that makes humanity so diverse.

4. How does exposure to other cultures affect people? (Social Impact)

Exposure to other cultures is generally very positive for people. It tends to make individuals more open-minded, tolerant and **empathetic**, as they realise there are many valid ways of living. It challenges stereotypes and prejudices. It can also be creatively inspiring, blending ideas in new ways. So while it can occasionally cause a sense of confusion about one's own identity, overall I believe cultural exposure **broadens horizons** and **enriches** people enormously.

5. Do you think all cultures will eventually become the same? (Future)

I do not think so, though they will certainly grow more similar in some respects. While globalisation is a powerful homogenising force, human beings have a deep-seated need for distinct identity and belonging, which tends to make cultures **resilient**. We are also seeing movements to actively preserve and revive local traditions. So rather than becoming identical, I expect cultures to blend and influence one another while retaining their **distinctiveness**.

6. How can countries protect their cultural identity in a globalised world? (Problem & Solution)

There are several strategies. Governments can support and fund local arts, languages, film and traditions to ensure they thrive. Education that **instils** pride in one's heritage is fundamental. Protecting local media and industries from being entirely overwhelmed by **global giants** also

helps. Crucially, this should be done not by rejecting outside influence, but by celebrating and promoting one's own culture so that it remains **vibrant** and valued.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of a globalised world? (Adv & Disadv)

The advantages are substantial: greater economic opportunity, the **free flow of ideas** and technology, cultural exchange, and international cooperation on shared problems. It has lifted many out of poverty. The disadvantages include cultural homogenisation, growing inequality, the exploitation of cheaper labour, and increased vulnerability to global crises, as the pandemic showed. So globalisation is a powerful force for connection and progress, but one with significant **inequalities** and **vulnerabilities**.

8. Some say globalisation mainly benefits wealthy countries. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

There is considerable truth to this, though it is not the whole picture. It is often argued that wealthy nations and large corporations reap the greatest rewards, while poorer countries may suffer exploitation and cultural erosion. The benefits are undeniably **unevenly** distributed. However, globalisation has **arguably** also lifted hundreds of millions out of poverty in developing nations. So while the **playing field** is far from level, I would not say the benefits are exclusively for the **privileged**.

Music & the Arts

Culture & Lifestyle · sp3_culture_09 · 7 of 8 answers edited

1. Why do you think music is important to people? (Opinion)

Music holds a unique and powerful place in human life. It has an extraordinary ability to **evoke** emotion, from joy to sorrow, and to comfort us in a way few other things can. It is also deeply tied to memory and identity, and it brings people together, whether at concerts or festivals. In my view, music is a universal language that **transcends** barriers and speaks directly to our emotions, which is why it is so **cherished**.

2. How has the way people listen to music changed? (Comparison)

It has changed dramatically. In the past, people bought physical records or CDs and often listened to a whole album deliberately. Now, streaming gives us instant access to virtually all recorded music, and we tend to consume it in playlists and individual tracks. This is wonderfully convenient, but some argue it has made listening more **passive** and **fragmented**. So access has expanded enormously, but our engagement with music may have become more **casual** **cursor**.

3. What effect does learning a musical instrument have on children? (Cause & Effect)

Learning an instrument has remarkably positive effects. **Studies suggest** Many believe it enhances cognitive development, improving skills like memory, concentration and mathematical ability. It also teaches discipline, patience and perseverance, since **mastery** requires consistent practice. Furthermore, it provides a creative outlet and a real sense of accomplishment that boosts confidence. So beyond the joy of making music, it offers profound **developmental** and **character-building** benefits.

4. How important are the arts to society? (Social Impact)

I believe the arts are absolutely vital, though often **undervalued**. They enrich our lives, **provoke thought**, and allow us to explore and express the full range of human experience. The arts preserve culture and history, foster empathy by exposing us to different perspectives, and can even drive social change. Economically, the creative industries are significant too. So far from being a luxury, the arts are, in my view, essential to a civilised and **reflective** society.

5. Do you think technology will change the arts in the future? (Future)

Undoubtedly, and it already is. Technology is providing artists with powerful new tools and mediums, from digital art to AI-generated music, expanding creative possibilities. It has also

democratised the arts, allowing anyone to create and share their work globally. However, this raises questions about **authenticity** and the role of human creativity. So while technology will transform and **democratise** the arts, I hope it will **augment** human expression rather than replace it.

6. Arts funding is often cut. How can the arts be better supported? (Problem & Solution)

Supporting the arts requires a **multi-pronged** approach. Governments should recognise their cultural and economic value and provide stable funding rather than treating them as **expendable**. Encouraging private sponsorship and **philanthropy** can supplement this. Integrating arts education properly into schools ensures future generations value them. Making the arts more accessible and affordable to ordinary people also builds public support. Essentially, we must treat the arts as an investment, not a luxury.

7. Are there advantages to studying an arts subject rather than a science? (Adv & Disadv)

Certainly. Arts subjects develop invaluable skills like critical thinking, creativity, communication and empathy, which are highly transferable and increasingly prized by employers. They encourage us to **grapple with** complex human questions. The perceived disadvantage is that arts degrees are sometimes seen as less directly employable than sciences. However, I think this is often overstated, as the skills they cultivate are genuinely **versatile**. So both paths have distinct and equal **merit**.

8. Some say art is not as important as science. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I firmly disagree with ranking them this way, as they serve different but equally vital purposes. Science advances our material understanding and improves our lives technologically, which is crucial. But art nourishes our emotional and spiritual lives, fosters empathy, and gives meaning to human existence. A world with science but no art would be efficient yet **soulless**. So rather than one being more important, I see them as **complementary** pillars of a **flourishing** civilisation.

Environmental Protection

Environment & Cities · sp3_environment_01 · 7 of 8 answers edited

1. Whose responsibility is it to protect the environment? (Opinion)

I believe it is a shared responsibility, though the **burden falls unevenly**. Individuals certainly have a role through their daily choices, but honestly, their impact is limited compared to that of governments and large corporations. Governments must implement effective policy and regulation, while industries must change their practices. So while everyone should do their part, I think the greatest responsibility lies with those who hold the power to **enact systemic change**.

2. Are individuals or governments more effective at protecting the environment? (Comparison)

While individual actions are valuable and add up, I would argue governments are far more effective due to their **scale of influence**. A single person recycling makes a small difference, but a government can regulate entire industries, invest in renewable energy and shape behaviour through law. That said, individual pressure and voting ultimately influence what governments do. So the two are **interconnected**, but the **leverage** of government is undeniably greater.

3. Why do you think some people do not care about the environment? (Cause & Effect)

There are several reasons. For some, environmental problems feel distant and abstract, so they do not feel a sense of urgency. Others prioritise immediate economic concerns, like putting food on the table, over long-term issues. There is also a feeling of **helplessness**, that individual action is **futile**. Additionally, some are simply unaware or misinformed. So it is usually a mix of **apathy**, immediate priorities and a sense of powerlessness.

4. How does environmental damage affect people's lives? (Social Impact)

The effects are increasingly tangible and severe. Pollution directly harms public health, causing respiratory and other illnesses. Climate change brings extreme weather, threatening homes, food security and **livelihoods**, especially for the poor. The degradation of natural resources also affects economies and can even fuel conflict over scarce resources. So environmental damage is not an abstract issue; it has profound and growing **repercussions** for human health, **prosperity** and stability.

5. Are you optimistic about the future of the environment? (Future)

I am cautiously optimistic, though the challenges are **daunting**. On one hand, the scale of problems like climate change is alarming, and progress often feels too slow. On the other hand, awareness has never been higher, technology in renewable energy is advancing rapidly, and younger generations are deeply committed to the cause. So while I have real concerns, I believe human **ingenuity** and growing collective will give us genuine **grounds for hope**.

6. What can ordinary people do to help the environment? (Problem & Solution)

There is a surprising amount individuals can do. Reducing consumption and waste, recycling, and being **mindful** of energy and water use all help. Choosing sustainable transport, like walking or public transit, and eating less meat can significantly cut one's **carbon footprint**. Beyond personal habits, supporting green businesses and, crucially, voting for environmentally responsible policies **amplifies** our impact. Collectively, these individual choices can drive genuine change.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of strict environmental laws? (Adv & Disadv)

The advantages are clear: strict laws can effectively **curb** pollution, protect natural resources and drive innovation in clean technology, safeguarding public health and the planet. The potential disadvantages are economic; such regulations can increase costs for businesses and consumers and may, in the short term, affect certain industries and jobs. However, I believe the long-term benefits far **outweigh** these costs, though a balanced, **well-planned transition** is essential.

8. Some say economic growth is more important than protecting the environment.

Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I strongly disagree with framing them as opposites. This is a **short-sighted** view, because a healthy environment is actually the foundation of long-term economic prosperity; you cannot have a thriving economy on a ruined planet. Furthermore, the green economy itself is a huge source of growth and jobs. So rather than a trade-off, I believe sustainable development, where growth and protection go hand in hand, is not only possible but **imperative** and **mutually reinforcing**.

Climate Change

Environment & Cities · sp3_environment_02 · 7 of 8 answers edited

1. How serious a problem do you think climate change is? (Opinion)

I consider it one of the most serious challenges facing humanity, if not the most serious. The scientific consensus is overwhelming, and we are already witnessing its effects through more frequent extreme weather, rising sea levels and disrupted ecosystems. Its potential to cause widespread displacement, food insecurity and conflict is genuinely alarming. So while some still **downplay** it, I believe it is an **existential** threat that demands urgent, **decisive** action.

2. Do you think richer or poorer countries should do more to fight climate change? (Comparison)

This is a matter of both responsibility and capability. I believe richer, industrialised nations bear a greater responsibility, as they have contributed the most historical emissions and have the

financial resources to lead. It seems only fair for them to do more, including helping poorer nations. However, developing countries, some of which are now major emitters, must also participate. So the burden should be shared **equitably**, with the wealthy **shouldering** a **proportionate** load.

3. What are the main effects of climate change on people? (Cause & Effect)

The effects on people are wide-ranging and increasingly severe. More intense heatwaves, floods and storms directly threaten lives and homes. Changing weather patterns disrupt agriculture, **jeopardising** food security and livelihoods. Rising seas endanger coastal communities, potentially creating **millions** large numbers of **climate refugees**. There are also serious health impacts. So climate change is not merely an environmental issue; it is a profound **humanitarian** one that threatens the stability of entire societies.

4. Why is it difficult for countries to agree on climate action? (Social Impact)

The difficulty lies in competing national interests. Countries worry that ambitious climate action will harm their own economies and competitiveness, so many are reluctant to act unless others do too. There are also disputes over who is most responsible and who should bear the costs. Powerful industries **lobby against** change as well. So despite the shared threat, short-term **self-interest** and a lack of trust often **hinder** the global cooperation required.

5. Do you think we can still prevent the worst effects of climate change? (Future)

I believe we still can, but the window is closing rapidly and it will require unprecedented effort. The technology and knowledge to transition to a clean economy largely exist; what is often lacking is the **political will** and global cooperation. If we act decisively now, we can still limit the damage, though some impacts are already **inevitable**. So I remain hopeful, but only if we treat it with the urgency it truly **warrants**.

6. What are the most effective ways to tackle climate change? (Problem & Solution)

The most effective solutions involve rapidly **transitioning away from** fossil fuels towards renewable energy like solar and wind. Improving energy efficiency and protecting and restoring forests, which absorb carbon, are also crucial. Government policy is key, from **carbon pricing** to investment in green technology. Individual lifestyle changes help too. Essentially, it requires a coordinated **overhaul** of our energy, transport and consumption systems on a global scale.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of switching to renewable energy?

(Adv & Disadv)

The advantages are compelling: renewables are clean, produce no carbon emissions, and are increasingly cheap and inexhaustible, enhancing energy security. They also create new jobs. The disadvantages include the high initial cost of infrastructure, and the fact that sources like solar and wind are **intermittent**, requiring storage solutions. Transitioning also affects existing fossil fuel industries. So while there are real **hurdles**, the long-term benefits make it a clearly **worthwhile** shift.

8. Some say individuals can do little about climate change. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I partly agree but find the statement **disempowering**. It is true that systemic change by governments and industry is far more impactful than individual action alone, so no one should feel the entire burden rests on them. However, I disagree that individuals are powerless. Collectively, our consumer choices, our voices and, above all, our votes exert real pressure that drives the bigger changes. So individual action is not **futile**; it is part of a larger **momentum**.

Urban Development

Environment & Cities · sp3_environment_03 · 8 of 8 answers edited

1. Do you think living in a city is better than living in the countryside? (Opinion)

It really depends on one's priorities and stage of life. Cities offer better job opportunities, **amenities**, healthcare and a vibrant social life, which many find appealing. The countryside, by contrast, offers peace, clean air, space and a stronger sense of community. Personally, I appreciate the convenience of the city for now, but I can see the **profound appeal** of a quieter rural life later. So neither is objectively better; each suits different needs and **temperaments**.

2. How have cities changed over the past few decades? (Comparison)

Cities have transformed dramatically. They have grown enormously in size and population due to rapid urbanisation, becoming denser and often more **congested**. Skylines have risen with skyscrapers, and technology has made them smarter. However, this growth has often **outpaced** infrastructure, worsening problems like traffic, pollution and housing shortages. So while cities have become more developed and connected, this expansion has brought significant **growing pains**.

3. Why do so many people move to cities? (Cause & Effect)

The primary driver is economic opportunity. Cities are hubs of employment, offering far more and better-paid jobs than rural areas, which is the biggest **pull factor**. They also provide superior access to education, healthcare and services. For many, the appeal of a more exciting, diverse lifestyle is also a draw. So this migration is largely driven by the search for a better standard of living, though it can place enormous **strain** on urban **infrastructure** and resources.

4. What are the main problems facing large cities today? (Social Impact)

Large cities **grapple with** numerous interconnected challenges. Traffic congestion and air pollution are among the most visible, harming both quality of life and health. A shortage of affordable housing is another major issue, pushing up costs and inequality. Overcrowded public services, waste management and, in some cases, rising crime add to the burden. So while cities are **engines of prosperity**, managing this rapid growth sustainably is a **formidable** challenge.

5. What do you think cities will be like in the future? (Future)

I envision cities becoming smarter and, hopefully, greener. Technology will likely manage traffic, energy and services more efficiently through data. There is a strong push towards more sustainable, **walkable** cities with more green spaces and cleaner transport. However, they may also become even more crowded. So I am hopeful the cities of the future will be more **liveable** and sustainable, provided planning **prioritises** people and the environment over pure expansion.

6. How can cities be made better places to live? (Problem & Solution)

Thoughtful **urban planning** is the key. Investing in efficient, affordable public transport reduces congestion and pollution. Creating more green spaces and **pedestrian areas** improves wellbeing. Ensuring an adequate supply of affordable housing tackles inequality. Designing **mixed-use**, walkable neighbourhoods fosters community. Essentially, cities become better when they are planned around the needs of people and the environment, rather than simply cars and commerce.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of urbanisation? (Adv & Disadv)

Urbanisation drives economic growth and innovation, and provides better access to jobs, services and opportunities, lifting many out of poverty. Cities are also cultural and intellectual **hubs**. However, the disadvantages include **overcrowding**, pollution, pressure on housing and infrastructure, and the loss of green space and community ties. It can also **deepen inequality**. So urbanisation is a powerful engine of progress, but one that must be managed to avoid serious social and environmental costs.

8. Some say governments should stop cities from growing too big. Do you agree?

(Agree / Disagree)

I do not think halting growth is realistic or desirable, but managing it is essential. Trying to stop urban growth **outright** would be difficult and could stifle economic opportunity. However, I

strongly agree that governments should guide this growth intelligently, perhaps by developing smaller **satellite cities** and improving rural areas to **ease the pressure**. So rather than restricting cities, the focus should be on making growth sustainable and balanced.

Transportation

Environment & Cities · sp3_environment_04 · 8 of 8 answers edited

1. Do you think public transport should be free? (Opinion)

I find the idea appealing, though it is complex. Making public transport free could reduce traffic, cut pollution and help **lower-income** people enormously, which are **compelling** social benefits. However, it would be extremely expensive to fund and might lead to overcrowding or reduced service quality without careful management. So while I support **heavily subsidising** it to keep it affordable, whether it should be entirely free depends on a country's priorities and budget.

2. Is it better to travel by public transport or private car? (Comparison)

Each has its merits, but from a societal viewpoint, public transport is clearly **preferable**. It is far more environmentally friendly, reduces congestion, and is cheaper for the user. Private cars, however, offer **unmatched** convenience, comfort and flexibility, especially where public transport is poor. So while I personally value the freedom of a car, I believe well-developed public transport is the more sustainable and **equitable** option for society as a whole.

3. What are the effects of traffic congestion on cities? (Cause & Effect)

Traffic congestion has serious and costly effects. It wastes an enormous amount of people's time, reducing productivity and quality of life. It significantly worsens air pollution, harming public health and the environment. It also causes frustration and stress for commuters and can **hamper** emergency services. Economically, the lost hours and fuel represent a huge **drain**. So congestion is far more than an inconvenience; it **undermines** a city's efficiency and wellbeing.

4. How does good transport benefit a society? (Social Impact)

An efficient transport system is the **backbone** of a thriving society. It connects people to jobs, education and services, enhancing opportunity and social mobility. It enables the smooth flow of goods, boosting the economy. Good public transport, in particular, reduces pollution and congestion while providing affordable mobility for all, including those without cars. So investing in transport is not just about convenience; it is fundamental to economic **prosperity** and social **inclusion**.

5. How do you think transport will change in the future? (Future)

I anticipate significant transformation. Electric vehicles will likely become the norm, drastically cutting emissions, and **autonomous**, self-driving cars may reshape how we travel. Cities will probably invest more in cycling, walking and clean public transport. Concepts like **shared mobility** could reduce car ownership. So the future of transport is likely to be cleaner, smarter and more **integrated**, hopefully making our cities less polluted and more liveable.

6. How can traffic problems in cities be solved? (Problem & Solution)

A combination of measures is most effective. Investing heavily in reliable, affordable public transport gives people a genuine alternative to driving. Encouraging cycling and walking through better **infrastructure** helps too. Some cities use **congestion charging** to **discourage** car use in busy areas. Better urban planning that reduces the need to travel far is also valuable. Essentially, the solution lies in making sustainable options more attractive than driving, rather than simply widening roads.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of owning a car? (Adv & Disadv)

Owning a car offers tremendous freedom, convenience and comfort, allowing you to travel **on your own schedule**, which is especially valuable where public transport is limited. The

disadvantages, however, are significant: the high costs of purchase, fuel, insurance and maintenance, plus the stress of traffic and parking. There is also the considerable environmental impact. So a car provides genuine **autonomy**, but at a substantial financial and **ecological** cost.

8. Some say cars should be banned from city centres. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I broadly agree with this, at least for private cars in the busiest central areas. Many cities that have **pedestrianised** their centres **seem to** have seen reduced pollution, safer streets and more vibrant public life, which is very appealing. However, it must be done carefully, ensuring excellent public transport alternatives and access for deliveries and those with disabilities. So rather than a **blanket ban**, I support significantly restricting cars to create more **liveable**, people-friendly centres.

Pollution

Environment & Cities · sp3_environment_05 · 7 of 8 answers edited

1. How serious is the problem of pollution in your country? (Opinion)

Unfortunately, pollution is a very serious problem in my country, particularly in the major cities. Air quality often reaches **hazardous** levels due to traffic, industry and construction, which **poses a real threat** to public health. Water pollution from industrial and domestic waste is also a significant concern. So while there is growing awareness, I would say pollution remains one of our most **pressing** environmental and public-health challenges.

2. Which do you think is worse, air pollution or water pollution? (Comparison)

Both are extremely damaging, and it is hard to rank them. Air pollution is perhaps more immediate and **inescapable**, as we breathe constantly, and it causes widespread respiratory illness. Water pollution, however, is arguably more **insidious**, contaminating our drinking water and food chain and devastating **aquatic ecosystems**. So rather than one being definitively worse, I would say they are both severe problems with different but equally devastating consequences.

3. What are the main causes of pollution in cities? (Cause & Effect)

Urban pollution stems from several sources. Vehicle emissions are a **primary culprit**, given the sheer density of traffic. Industrial activity and factories release pollutants into the air and water. Construction generates dust, and the burning of fossil fuels for energy contributes heavily. Poor waste management adds to the problem. So it is largely a **by-product** of dense population, industry and **reliance on fossil fuels** concentrated in a small area.

4. How does pollution affect people's health? (Social Impact)

The health impacts of pollution are profound and well-documented. Air pollution causes and worsens respiratory conditions like asthma, as well as heart disease and even cancer, **reportedly** contributing to millions of **premature deaths** globally. Water pollution can cause serious diseases through contaminated drinking water. Vulnerable groups, like children and the elderly, are especially at risk. So pollution is a genuine **silent killer**, imposing an enormous **burden** on public health.

5. Do you think pollution will get better or worse in the future? (Future)

I am cautiously hopeful it will improve, though it depends on our actions. On one hand, rapid **industrialisation** in developing nations could worsen it in the short term. On the other, growing awareness, stricter regulations, and cleaner technologies like electric vehicles and renewable energy offer real solutions. Many developed cities have already reduced pollution significantly. So with sufficient **political will** and innovation, I believe we can **reverse the trend**, but it is not guaranteed.

6. What can be done to reduce pollution? (Problem & Solution)

Tackling pollution requires action **on multiple fronts**. Transitioning to renewable energy and electric transport would **drastically** cut emissions. **Enforcing** strict regulations on industrial waste and improving public transport are vital. Better waste management and recycling reduce landfill and litter. On an individual level, reducing consumption and waste helps. Ultimately, a combination of regulation, clean technology and changed behaviour offers the most effective path forward.

7. Some solutions to pollution are expensive. Are they worth the cost? (Adv & Disadv)

I firmly believe they are worth it, viewed correctly. While measures like transitioning to clean energy carry a high upfront cost, this must be weighed against the enormous, often hidden, costs of pollution itself, from healthcare bills to environmental damage and lost productivity. In truth, the cost of **inaction** is far greater. So although the investment is substantial, it is far more **prudent** than allowing pollution to **escalate** unchecked.

8. Some say factories should be moved away from residential areas. Do you agree?

(Agree / Disagree)

I largely agree with this as a sensible measure. Locating polluting factories away from where people live can significantly reduce residents' **direct exposure** to harmful air and water pollution, protecting public health. However, it is not a complete solution, as pollution still spreads, and it may simply **shift the burden** to another community. So while separating industry from homes is beneficial, it must be combined with actually reducing the pollution **at its source**.

Sustainability

Environment & Cities · sp3_environment_06 · 8 of 8 answers edited

1. What does it mean to live sustainably? (Opinion)

To me, living sustainably means meeting our own needs without compromising the ability of future generations to meet theirs. In practice, it involves being mindful of our consumption, reducing waste, and using resources efficiently and responsibly. It is about living within the planet's ecological limits rather than **depleting** them. Essentially, it is a shift from a throwaway, **exploitative** mindset to one of **stewardship** and long-term responsibility.

2. Are people more environmentally conscious now than in the past? (Comparison)

Yes, considerably so. Environmental awareness has grown enormously over recent decades, driven by scientific evidence, media coverage and visible impacts like extreme weather. Concepts like recycling, carbon footprints and sustainability are now part of everyday conversation, which was not the case a generation ago. However, I would add that awareness does not always **translate into action**. So people are certainly more **conscious**, even if their behaviour has not fully **caught up**.

3. Why is it hard for people to change to a more sustainable lifestyle? (Cause & Effect)

Several barriers make it difficult. Sustainable options are sometimes more expensive or less convenient than the alternatives, so cost and habit get in the way. Many people also feel their individual actions are **insignificant** against such a vast problem. Additionally, our entire economic system is built around consumption, making unsustainable choices the default. So it is a combination of practical obstacles, **ingrained habits** and a sense of **powerlessness**.

4. How can businesses become more sustainable? (Social Impact)

Businesses have a huge role to play. They can reduce their carbon footprint by using renewable energy and improving efficiency. Adopting **circular economy** principles, where products are designed to be reused and recycled, cuts waste dramatically. **Sourcing** materials ethically and being transparent about their impact matters too. Crucially, they should see sustainability not as a cost but as an investment that can drive innovation and win loyalty from increasingly

conscious consumers.

5. Do you think future generations will live more sustainably? (Future)

I am hopeful they will, partly **out of necessity**. As the impacts of unsustainable living become more severe, future generations will likely be forced to adapt. **Encouragingly**, young people today already show strong environmental values and are pushing for change. Advances in green technology should also make sustainable living easier and cheaper. So I believe sustainability will increasingly become the norm rather than the exception, driven by both necessity and **shifting values**.

6. How can governments encourage sustainable behaviour? (Problem & Solution)

Governments have powerful tools **at their disposal**. They can use financial incentives, like subsidies for renewable energy or electric cars, and taxes on pollution and waste to **steer behaviour**. Investing in sustainable infrastructure, such as public transport and recycling, makes green choices easier. Regulation and clear information, like **carbon labelling**, also help. Essentially, by making the sustainable choice the easy, affordable and default option, governments can drive widespread change.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of recycling? (Adv & Disadv)

Recycling has clear advantages: it **conserves** natural resources, reduces landfill waste, saves energy compared to making new products, and cuts pollution. It also raises environmental awareness. The disadvantages are that the process itself consumes energy and water, some materials are difficult or costly to recycle, and **contamination** can **render efforts ineffective**. So while recycling is genuinely beneficial, it is not a complete solution and works best alongside reducing and reusing.

8. Some say sustainable products are too expensive for ordinary people. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

There is some truth to this currently, though it is changing. It is true that some sustainable products, like organic food or electric cars, carry a higher **price tag**, which can put them **out of reach** for those on tight budgets. This is a real barrier to **widespread adoption**. However, as demand grows and technology improves, prices are steadily falling. So while cost is a genuine obstacle today, I believe sustainability is becoming increasingly affordable and accessible.

Housing

Environment & Cities · sp3_environment_07 · 8 of 8 answers edited

1. Do you think everyone has the right to affordable housing? (Opinion)

I strongly believe that access to decent, affordable housing is a **fundamental human right**, not a privilege. Shelter is a basic need, and stable housing is the foundation upon which people build healthy, productive lives. When housing becomes unaffordable, it drives inequality, homelessness and **hardship**. So I think governments have a clear responsibility to ensure that housing is available and affordable to all, treating it as an essential rather than a mere **commodity**.

2. Is it better to rent or to own a home? (Comparison)

Both have their advantages, depending on circumstances. Owning a home offers stability, security and the chance to build wealth over time, which is why many **aspire to** it. Renting, however, offers greater flexibility and freedom from the burdens of maintenance and large **mortgages**, which suits those who value mobility. So there is no universal answer; it depends on one's financial situation, life stage and how much stability versus flexibility one **prioritises**.

3. Why is housing so expensive in many cities? (Cause & Effect)

The high cost is driven by a fundamental imbalance between supply and demand. As people **flock to** cities for work, demand for housing soars, while the supply of new homes often fails to

keep pace due to limited land and slow construction. Property speculation and foreign investment can also inflate prices. So it is largely a matter of high demand meeting **constrained** supply, made worse by **speculation**, pushing prices beyond ordinary people's reach.

4. How does a housing shortage affect society? (Social Impact)

A housing shortage has **far-reaching** social consequences. It drives up rents and prices, forcing people to spend a huge portion of their income on housing, which deepens financial stress and inequality. It can lead to overcrowding, longer commutes, and in severe cases, homelessness. It may also prevent young people from becoming independent. So a lack of affordable housing genuinely **undermines social mobility** and the overall wellbeing of a community.

5. How do you think housing will change in the future? (Future)

I anticipate several developments. To address shortages and sustainability, we may see more compact, **high-density** and eco-friendly housing, along with innovative solutions like modular or **prefabricated** homes. Smart-home technology will likely become standard. There may also be a shift towards **co-living** arrangements, especially in expensive cities. So future housing may become smaller and denser, but hopefully smarter, greener and more affordable, adapting to modern needs.

6. What can be done to make housing more affordable? (Problem & Solution)

Increasing the supply of housing is fundamental, particularly affordable and social housing built by governments. Reforming planning regulations to allow more construction can help. Measures to **curb** speculation, such as taxes on empty properties, may also **cool prices**. Rent controls and support for first-time buyers are other options. Essentially, treating housing as a basic need rather than a pure **investment vehicle** is key to keeping it accessible and fair.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of living in an apartment versus a house? (Adv & Disadv)

Apartments are generally more affordable, **low-maintenance**, and often centrally located with good security, which is convenient. The disadvantages are less space and privacy, no garden, and potential noise from neighbours. Houses, by contrast, offer more space, privacy and outdoor areas, ideal for families, but they are more expensive and require more **upkeep**. So it is really a **trade-off** between convenience and affordability on one hand, and space and privacy on the other.

8. Some say owning a home is no longer a realistic goal for young people. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I partly agree, especially in expensive cities, where it has become genuinely difficult. **Soaring** property prices relative to wages, combined with the challenge of saving for a large deposit, have put homeownership **out of reach** for many young people, which is a real and worrying shift. However, I would not say it is impossible everywhere. So while it has certainly become far more challenging and requires greater sacrifice, I would not call it entirely **unattainable**.

Public Spaces

Environment & Cities · sp3_environment_08 · 8 of 8 answers edited

1. How important are public spaces like parks in a city? (Opinion)

I consider them absolutely essential to a healthy city. Public spaces like parks provide vital areas for recreation, exercise and relaxation, which is crucial for physical and mental wellbeing amid the stress of urban life. They also act as the **lungs of a city**, improving air quality, and serve as places where the community comes together. So far from being a luxury, well-designed public spaces are fundamental to a **liveable** and **cohesive** city.

2. Do you think there are enough public spaces in modern cities? (Comparison)

In many rapidly growing cities, unfortunately not. As urban land becomes increasingly valuable, green and public spaces are often sacrificed for commercial or residential development, which I find **short-sighted**. Older, well-planned cities tend to have generous parks, whereas newer, denser developments frequently lack them. So while the importance of public space is increasingly recognised, in practice many cities are **falling short**, prioritising profit over **liveability**.

3. What effect do green spaces have on people living in cities? (Cause & Effect)

The effects are overwhelmingly positive, ~~and well-researched~~ in my view. Access to green spaces reduces stress, improves mood and encourages physical activity, benefiting both mental and physical health. They provide a **peaceful escape** from the noise and concrete of the city. Socially, they **foster** community interaction. Environmentally, they cool cities and clean the air. So green spaces have a genuinely **restorative** and beneficial effect on urban wellbeing.

4. How do public spaces bring communities together? (Social Impact)

Public spaces act as vital social hubs. Parks, squares and community centres provide neutral, accessible places where people from **all walks of life** can meet, interact and **mingle**, whether at a market, a festival or simply while relaxing. This casual contact builds a sense of community and belonging, and helps break down social barriers. In an increasingly isolated world, these shared spaces are crucial for fostering **social cohesion** and mutual understanding among diverse people.

5. Do you think cities will have more or fewer public spaces in the future? (Future)

I am hopeful there will be more, though it faces real pressure. On one hand, **intense competition** for urban land threatens existing spaces. On the other, there is a growing recognition of their importance for wellbeing and sustainability, and many **forward-thinking** cities are now actively creating parks, green roofs and pedestrian zones. So the outcome depends on planning priorities, but I am optimistic that the value of public space will increasingly be recognised and **prioritised**.

6. How can cities create more public spaces despite limited land? (Problem & Solution)

Creativity is key when land is scarce. Cities can **repurposedisused** areas, such as old railway lines turned into elevated parks, or convert rooftops into green spaces and gardens. Pedestrianising streets reclaims space from cars for people. Even small pocket parks on vacant plots make a difference. So even in dense cities, with imaginative planning, it is possible to integrate valuable public and green space into the existing **urban fabric**.

7. Are there any drawbacks to having large public spaces in cities? (Adv & Disadv)

While the benefits are enormous, there are a few considerations. Large public spaces are expensive to create and maintain, requiring **ongoing public funds**. If poorly designed or managed, they can sometimes attract **antisocial behaviour** or feel unsafe. They also take up valuable land that could be used for housing. However, in my view, these drawbacks are minor and **manageable** compared to the immense social, health and environmental value such spaces provide.

8. Some say building more housing is more important than preserving parks. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I understand the argument given the housing crisis, but I largely disagree with sacrificing parks. While housing is undeniably crucial, green spaces are equally vital for residents' health and wellbeing, and destroying them creates a poorer quality of life. It should not be an either-or choice. With clever planning, cities can build housing on **brownfield sites** and increase density elsewhere while preserving parks. So both are essential, and **pitting them against** each other is a **false dilemma**.

Wildlife & Conservation

Environment & Cities · sp3_environment_09 · 7 of 8 answers edited

1. Why is it important to protect wildlife? (Opinion)

Protecting wildlife is important for several profound reasons. Ecologically, every species plays a role in maintaining the **delicate balance** of ecosystems that humans ultimately depend on for clean air, water and food. There is also a strong ethical argument that we have a duty to protect other living creatures. Furthermore, **biodiversity** has immense scientific and economic value. So conservation is not merely sentimental; it is essential for **ecological stability** and our own survival.

2. Should we prioritise protecting animals or supporting human development?

(Comparison)

I reject the idea that these are truly in opposition, though tensions certainly arise. In the short term, development sometimes conflicts with conservation, and people's immediate needs are understandably a priority. However, in the long run, human development depends entirely on a healthy natural world. Destroying nature for short-term gain is ultimately **self-defeating**. So rather than choosing one over the other, I believe we must pursue sustainable development that **reconciles** both **imperatives**.

3. What are the main reasons some animal species are becoming extinct? (Cause & Effect)

The primary driver is human activity. Habitat destruction, as forests and wild areas are cleared for agriculture and development, is the biggest threat, leaving animals nowhere to live. Poaching and overfishing directly deplete populations, while pollution and, increasingly, climate change disrupt ecosystems. So extinction is largely a tragic consequence of human **encroachment**, **exploitation** and environmental **degradation**, rather than natural causes.

4. How does the loss of biodiversity affect humans? (Social Impact)

The loss of biodiversity has serious, often underestimated, consequences for humanity. Healthy ecosystems provide us with essential services: **pollination** for crops, clean water, fertile soil and disease regulation. As species disappear, these systems can collapse, threatening food security and health. We also lose potential sources of medicine and scientific knowledge. So biodiversity loss is not just an environmental tragedy; it directly threatens human **livelihoods** and **resilience**.

5. Are you hopeful about the future of wildlife conservation? (Future)

I hold a cautious hope. The threats are severe, and we are losing species at an **alarming rate**, which is deeply concerning. However, there are genuine success stories where dedicated conservation efforts have brought species **back from the brink**. Growing public awareness, international cooperation and new technologies for monitoring wildlife are encouraging. So while the challenge is immense, I believe that with sufficient commitment, we can still preserve much of our **natural heritage**.

6. What can be done to protect endangered species? (Problem & Solution)

A range of measures is required. Establishing and properly funding protected areas and national parks safeguards vital **habitats**. Enforcing strict anti-poaching laws and **cracking down on** illegal wildlife trade is crucial. International cooperation and treaties help protect **migratory** species. Supporting local communities so they benefit from conservation rather than exploitation is also key. Ultimately, addressing the root causes, like habitat loss and climate change, is essential for lasting protection and recovery.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of zoos? (Adv & Disadv)

Zoos have genuine advantages: they play a role in conservation through **breeding programmes** for endangered species, they educate the public and foster appreciation for

wildlife, and they support scientific research. However, the disadvantages are significant ethical concerns about keeping animals in **captivity**, which can cause them distress and deny them natural behaviour. So while modern, well-run zoos can serve valuable conservation and educational purposes, the **welfare** of the animals remains a legitimate concern.

8. Some say humans have no right to interfere with nature. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

This is a nuanced issue. I agree we should minimise harmful interference, such as destroying habitats or exploiting species, as we have caused enormous damage. However, I would argue we now have a responsibility to **intervene** positively, through conservation, to repair the damage we have already done. Given our impact, complete non-interference is neither possible nor helpful. So rather than not interfering at all, we should act as responsible **stewards**, protecting rather than **plundering**.

Success & Ambition

Society & Values · sp3_society_01 · 7 of 8 answers edited

1. How do you define success? (Opinion)

I think success is deeply personal and far broader than wealth or status. To me, genuine success means finding **fulfilment** in what you do, maintaining good relationships, and feeling that you are growing and contributing something meaningful. While financial security matters, defining success purely by money seems rather **hollow**. So I would say true success is a sense of **contentment** and purpose, which looks different for every individual.

2. Is success more about hard work or luck? (Comparison)

I believe it is a combination of both, though hard work is the factor within our control. Undeniably, luck plays a role, such as being born into favourable circumstances or being in the right place at the right time. However, hard work, persistence and seizing opportunities are what allow people to **capitalise on** that luck. So while luck can open doors, it is usually **diligence** and determination that **sustain** lasting success.

3. Why do some people become more ambitious than others? (Cause & Effect)

Ambition is shaped by a mix of factors. Upbringing plays a big role; children encouraged to aim high often **internalise** that drive. Personal experiences, including hardship, can also fuel a determination to succeed. Individual personality and the influence of role models matter too. Additionally, some are motivated by a fear of failure or a desire for recognition. So ambition usually stems from a blend of **nurture**, personal circumstance and innate **temperament**.

4. Is ambition always a good thing? (Social Impact)

Ambition is largely positive, as it drives progress, innovation and personal achievement. However, it has a darker side when taken to extremes. Unchecked ambition can lead people to become ruthless, neglecting ethics, relationships and their own wellbeing in the relentless pursuit of their goals. It can breed dissatisfaction too. So while healthy ambition is a wonderful motivator, it becomes harmful when it turns into an **obsessive** or **ruthless** drive that **overrides** everything else.

5. Do you think the definition of success is changing? (Future)

Yes, I believe it is evolving, particularly among younger generations. The traditional **markers of success**, like a high salary and status, are increasingly being questioned. Many now place greater value on work-life balance, wellbeing, purpose and experiences over pure material wealth. There is a growing recognition that a fulfilling life matters more than a merely impressive one. So the definition of success seems to be shifting towards something more **holistic** and meaningful than **materialistic**.

6. How can society support people to achieve their goals? (Problem & Solution)

Society can do much to help. Ensuring equal access to quality education and opportunities gives everyone a fairer chance, regardless of background. Providing mentorship, resources and support for entrepreneurs and innovators helps too. Creating a culture that values effort and does not **stigmatise** failure encourages people to take risks. Essentially, by removing barriers and fostering an **enabling** environment, society can help far more people **fulfil their potential**.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of being highly ambitious? (Adv & Disadv)

High ambition drives people to achieve great things, fuels motivation and resilience, and can lead to considerable success and personal growth. It gives life direction and purpose. The disadvantages, however, include the risk of chronic stress, burnout and neglecting personal relationships and health in the **single-minded** pursuit of goals. It can also breed **perpetual** dissatisfaction. So ambition is a powerful asset, provided it is balanced and does not become ~~all-consuming~~ **all-consuming**.

8. Some say money is the best measure of success. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I strongly disagree with this narrow view. While money is a tangible and convenient measure, and financial security certainly matters, equating it with success ignores far more important dimensions of a good life. Many wealthy people are deeply unhappy, while many people of **modest means** live rich, fulfilling lives. Reducing success to a bank balance seems **reductive** and **misguided**. True success, in my view, is measured by fulfilment, relationships and character, not currency.

Happiness & Wellbeing

Society & Values · sp3_society_02 · 8 of 8 answers edited

1. What do you think makes people truly happy? (Opinion)

In my view, lasting happiness comes primarily **from within** and from our connections, rather than from external possessions. Strong, loving relationships ~~are consistently shown~~ **seem** to be the greatest source of happiness. Beyond that, having a sense of purpose, good health, and the freedom to pursue what we find meaningful all contribute enormously. So I believe true happiness is **rooted in** connection, purpose and **gratitude**, not in material wealth.

2. Are people happier now than in the past? (Comparison)

This is a fascinating and debated question. In material terms, we are far better off than previous generations, with more comfort, health and opportunity. Yet, **curiously**, rates of anxiety and depression seem to be rising, especially among the young. It appears that material progress has not straightforwardly translated into greater happiness. So while we have gained much, I am not convinced we are **fundamentally** happier, which suggests happiness depends on more than mere **prosperity** and comfort.

3. Why do you think some wealthy people are unhappy? (Cause & Effect)

This reflects the fact that money, beyond meeting basic needs, has **diminishing returns** on happiness. Wealthy people may still suffer from poor relationships, a lack of purpose, or the isolation and pressure that wealth can bring. There is also the phenomenon where people constantly adapt and want more, never feeling satisfied. So it demonstrates that happiness is not something money can simply buy; it depends on deeper, ~~non-material~~ **non-material fulfilment**.

4. How does a person's environment affect their happiness? (Social Impact)

Our environment has a **profound influence** on our wellbeing. A supportive community, safe and pleasant surroundings, and access to nature and green space all contribute significantly to happiness. Conversely, a stressful, **isolating** or polluted environment can seriously **undermine** it. The people around us, our relationships and social connections, are perhaps the most important environmental factor of all. So happiness is not purely internal; it is profoundly shaped

by our surroundings and relationships.

5. Do you think people will be happier in the future? (Future)

I am genuinely uncertain. On one hand, advances in medicine, technology and **living standards** could improve wellbeing. There is also growing awareness of mental health and the importance of a balanced life. On the other hand, rising pressures, social media comparison and uncertainty could work against happiness. So I think future happiness will depend less on material progress and more on whether we learn to **prioritise** the things that genuinely **nourish** human wellbeing.

6. What can societies do to improve people's wellbeing? (Problem & Solution)

Societies can take meaningful steps. Prioritising mental health services and reducing the **stigma** around them is crucial. Fostering community, reducing inequality, and ensuring people have access to nature, leisure and a healthy work-life balance all help. Some argue governments should measure national wellbeing, not just economic output. Essentially, by valuing human **flourishing** alongside economic growth, societies can create conditions in which more people can genuinely **thrive** and feel content.

7. Is the constant pursuit of happiness a good thing? (Adv & Disadv)

This is quite paradoxical. Striving for a good, meaningful life is clearly positive. However, obsessively pursuing happiness as a goal in itself can be **counterproductive**; it can create pressure and dissatisfaction when we inevitably experience negative emotions, which are a normal part of life. Chasing constant positivity is unrealistic. So I would argue that accepting the full range of human emotions and finding meaning is healthier than a relentless, anxious **pursuit** of **fleeting** pleasure.

8. Some say happiness is a choice. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I partly agree, but with important reservations. There is real truth that our attitude, gratitude and how we respond to circumstances significantly influence our happiness, so mindset matters. However, saying happiness is simply a choice can be **dismissive** of those facing genuine hardship, mental illness or difficult circumstances beyond their control. So while we have some agency over our happiness, I think it is **oversimplified** to call it purely a choice, ignoring the **structural** and biological factors involved.

Money & Wealth

Society & Values · sp3_society_03 · 8 of 8 answers edited

1. How important is money in life? (Opinion)

Money is **undeniably** important, but its importance has limits. It is essential for meeting our basic needs, providing security, and giving us freedom and opportunities, so I would never dismiss it. However, beyond a certain point of comfort, its ability to improve our happiness **diminishes sharply**. Health, relationships and purpose matter far more. So I see money as a vital tool and **enabler**, but a poor ultimate goal in itself.

2. Is it better to save money or spend it? (Comparison)

A healthy balance between the two is ideal. Saving is **prudent**, providing security, peace of mind and the means to achieve future goals or weather emergencies. However, being excessively frugal can mean missing out on valuable experiences and enjoyment in the present. Spending wisely, particularly on experiences and things that genuinely enrich life, is worthwhile. So I favour disciplined saving combined with mindful spending, avoiding both reckless **extravagance** and joyless **hoarding**.

3. What effect does the pursuit of wealth have on people? (Cause & Effect)

The pursuit of wealth has mixed effects. Positively, it can motivate hard work, innovation and achievement, driving both personal and economic progress. However, an excessive obsession

with wealth can be corrosive, leading people to become greedy, materialistic, and to neglect relationships, ethics and their own wellbeing. It can foster perpetual dissatisfaction too. So while a healthy desire to prosper is fine, an **all-consuming fixation** on money can genuinely **distort** a person's values.

4. How does the gap between rich and poor affect society? (Social Impact)

A large wealth gap has damaging effects on society. Extreme inequality tends to **breed social tension**, resentment and instability, and can undermine social mobility, trapping people in poverty. It is often associated with higher crime and poorer public health. It can also erode social cohesion and trust in institutions. So while some inequality is perhaps inevitable, a vast and growing gap is genuinely **corrosive**, weakening the **social fabric** and threatening stability.

5. Do you think the gap between rich and poor will grow in the future? (Future)

I am concerned that it might, without deliberate intervention. Trends like automation, which may concentrate wealth among those who own the technology, and globalisation could widen the gap further. However, there is also growing awareness of inequality and political pressure to address it through **progressive taxation** and social policy. So the outcome is not **predetermined**; whether the gap widens or narrows will depend on the political choices societies make to **redistribute** opportunity.

6. What can be done to reduce poverty? (Problem & Solution)

Reducing poverty requires a comprehensive approach. Access to quality education and healthcare is fundamental, as it enables social mobility. Creating decent, well-paid jobs and ensuring fair wages tackles the **root causes**. Social **safety nets**, like unemployment support, protect the most vulnerable. Progressive taxation can fund these efforts. Ultimately, empowering people with opportunities and skills, rather than mere **handouts**, offers the most sustainable path out of poverty.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of a cashless society? (Adv & Disadv)

A cashless society offers convenience, speed and enhanced security against theft, and it makes transactions easier to track, which can reduce crime and **tax evasion**. However, the disadvantages are significant: it excludes those without bank access or digital skills, particularly the elderly and poor, raising concerns about **exclusion**. It also enables greater **surveillance** of our spending and leaves us vulnerable to system failures. So it offers efficiency but at some cost to privacy and inclusion.

8. Some say money cannot buy happiness. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I largely agree, though with a **nuance**. It is certainly true that beyond meeting our basic needs, more money does not reliably increase happiness, and the richest people are not necessarily the happiest. Lasting happiness comes from relationships and purpose. However, I would add that a lack of money, and the poverty and stress it brings, can definitely cause unhappiness. So money cannot buy happiness, but **financial security** can certainly remove a major source of **misery** and anxiety.

Equality & Social Justice

Society & Values · sp3_society_04 · 8 of 8 answers edited

1. Do you think society treats everyone equally? (Opinion)

Unfortunately, I do not think any society treats everyone truly equally, though many have made real progress. Despite laws promoting equality, discrimination based on factors like gender, ethnicity, class or background still persists, often subtly. People's opportunities are still heavily influenced by the **circumstances of their birth**. So while the ideal of equality is widely embraced, in practice significant **disparities** and **injustices** remain that we must continue to address.

2. Has society become more or less equal over time? (Comparison)

In many respects, society has become considerably more equal. Enormous progress has been made in areas like women's rights, racial equality and the rights of minorities compared to the past. Legal discrimination has been **dismantled** in many places. However, economic inequality has actually widened in some countries. So the picture is mixed; we have **made great strides** in social and legal equality, while economic disparities remain a **persistent** challenge.

3. What are the main causes of inequality in society? (Cause & Effect)

Inequality stems from a **complex web** of factors. Unequal access to quality education and healthcare is a major driver, as it limits opportunity from birth. Discrimination based on gender, race or class also plays a role. Economic systems that concentrate wealth, along with the circumstances one is born into, **perpetuate** the cycle. So inequality is rarely due to a single cause; it results from **structural**, historical and social factors that reinforce one another.

4. Why is equal opportunity important? (Social Impact)

Equal opportunity is fundamental to a just and thriving society. It ensures that people can succeed based on their talent and effort, rather than being **held back** by circumstances of birth they cannot control. This is not only fair but also benefits society by allowing everyone's potential to be realised. Without it, talent is wasted and resentment grows. So equal opportunity is essential for both social justice and a society's overall **prosperity** and **cohesion**.

5. Do you think full equality is achievable? (Future)

I think complete **equality of outcome** is probably unrealistic, given natural differences in talent, effort and luck. However, equality of opportunity, where everyone has a genuinely fair chance to succeed, is a **worthy** and achievable goal to strive towards. We may never reach a perfectly equal society, but we can continually reduce unfair barriers. So while perfect equality may be an ideal rather than a destination, meaningful progress towards fairness is absolutely **attainable**.

6. How can governments promote greater equality? (Problem & Solution)

Governments have powerful tools. Ensuring universal access to quality education and healthcare is perhaps the most important, as it **levels the playing field**. Progressive taxation and social welfare programmes can reduce economic disparities. Strong anti-discrimination laws protect marginalised groups. Investing in disadvantaged communities helps break cycles of poverty. Essentially, by actively removing barriers and **redistributing** opportunity, governments can foster a more **equitable** and inclusive society.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of policies that favour disadvantaged groups? (Adv & Disadv)

Such policies, like **affirmative action**, can help **redress** historical injustices and give disadvantaged groups a genuine chance, promoting diversity and breaking cycles of exclusion. The disadvantages are that they can be seen as unfair to others and may sometimes prioritise group identity over individual merit, occasionally breeding resentment. So while I believe such measures can be a necessary **corrective** for deep inequality, they must be carefully designed to be fair and temporary.

8. Some say a completely equal society is neither possible nor desirable. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I partly agree. A society with perfectly equal outcomes is probably neither achievable nor, arguably, desirable, since some inequality reflecting effort and talent can incentivise productivity and reward hard work. However, I strongly believe that **gross inequality** is both unjust and harmful. So while I agree that absolute equality is unrealistic, this should not be used as an excuse for **complacency**; striving for genuine fairness and opportunity remains an essential **imperative**.

Freedom & Individual Rights

Society & Values · sp3_society_05 · 5 of 8 answers edited

1. How important is personal freedom? (Opinion)

I regard personal freedom as one of the most precious human values. The ability to make our own choices, express ourselves and live according to our own beliefs is fundamental to human dignity and fulfilment. Without freedom, people cannot truly **flourish**. However, I also believe freedom is not absolute; it must be balanced with responsibility to others. So while freedom is **indispensable**, it works best within a framework that also respects the **collective good**.

2. Which is more important, individual freedom or the safety of society? (Comparison)

This is a classic tension, and I believe the two must be carefully balanced rather than one always **trumping** the other. Individual freedom is precious, but a society cannot function if that freedom endangers others, so some limits are necessary for collective safety. The danger is when safety is used to justify excessive restrictions on liberty. So neither is absolutely **paramount**; the challenge is finding a **proportionate** balance that preserves both liberty and security.

3. What happens when a society has too little freedom? (Cause & Effect)

A society with too little freedom tends to suffer greatly. Suppressing free expression and choice stifles creativity, innovation and progress, as people cannot challenge ideas or think independently. It breeds fear, conformity and resentment, and often enables abuses of power to go unchecked. Human potential is squandered. So excessive restriction of freedom typically leads to **stagnation**, **oppression** and a profound loss of human **dignity** and vitality.

4. Should there be limits on freedom of speech? (Social Impact)

This is a delicate balance. I am a strong advocate of free speech as essential to a healthy democracy, allowing ideas to be debated openly. However, I believe some reasonable limits are justified, such as prohibiting **incitement** to violence or hatred that directly harms others. The difficulty lies in where to **draw the line** without enabling **censorship**. So while free speech should be robustly protected, I accept there is a legitimate case for narrow, carefully defined restrictions.

5. Do you think people will have more or less freedom in the future? (Future)

I have mixed feelings about this. In some ways, technology empowers people and gives them a greater voice. However, the same technology enables unprecedented surveillance by governments and corporations, which could erode privacy and freedom. The tension between security, technology and liberty will be a defining issue. So the future of freedom is genuinely uncertain, and I believe it will require constant **vigilance** to **safeguard** our liberties against creeping **encroachment**.

6. How can a balance be struck between freedom and security? (Problem & Solution)

Striking this balance requires careful, transparent judgement. Any restriction on freedom in the name of security should be proportionate, necessary, and subject to independent oversight and accountability, rather than granted unchecked. Robust legal frameworks and an independent judiciary are essential safeguards. Public debate about these trade-offs is also healthy. Essentially, the key is ensuring that security measures are **accountable** and do not quietly **erode** the very **liberties** they claim to protect.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of a society with very few rules? (Adv & Disadv)

A society with few rules offers maximum individual freedom, autonomy and space for creativity and self-expression, which can be **liberating** and dynamic. However, the disadvantages are considerable: without sufficient rules, there is a risk of chaos, exploitation of the weak by the strong, and a breakdown of order and safety. Rules protect people and enable cooperation. So while excessive rules are **stifling**, too few can lead to **disorder**; the ideal is a balanced,

reasonable framework.

8. Some say people should be free to do whatever they want. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I disagree with this as an absolute principle. While I deeply value personal freedom, unlimited freedom is **unworkable**, because one person's unrestrained actions can easily harm others. My freedom to act ends where it **infringes on** someone else's rights or safety. A functioning society requires that we balance our own liberty with responsibility towards others. So freedom must operate within reasonable limits; it is about liberty with accountability, not **unchecked licence**.

Crime & Punishment

Society & Values · sp3_society_06 · 8 of 8 answers edited

1. What do you think are the main causes of crime? (Opinion)

I believe crime usually stems from a combination of social and personal factors rather than pure **wickedness**. Poverty, inequality, lack of education and unemployment often create conditions in which crime **flourishes**, as people feel they have few legitimate options. Poor upbringing, addiction and social exclusion also play a role. So while individuals bear responsibility, I think addressing the **underlying social roots** of crime is essential to genuinely reducing it.

2. Is it better to prevent crime or to punish it? (Comparison)

I firmly believe prevention is far better than punishment. Addressing the root causes of crime, through education, opportunity and social support, stops it before it happens, sparing potential victims and saving society enormous costs. Punishment, while necessary, is essentially **reactive**; it deals with the damage after it is done. So while a justice system is essential, I would argue that investing in **prevention** is a more **humane** and effective long-term strategy.

3. What effect does prison have on criminals? (Cause & Effect)

The effects vary and are much debated. Ideally, prison should deter crime, protect society and rehabilitate offenders. However, in reality, prisons often fail to rehabilitate; they can even become schools for crime, where offenders learn worse behaviour, and the stigma makes **reintegration** difficult. High reoffending rates suggest this. So while prison serves important functions, I think an overreliance on **incarceration** without genuine rehabilitation can be **counterproductive**, perpetuating a cycle of crime.

4. Should the purpose of prison be punishment or rehabilitation? (Social Impact)

I believe the primary purpose should be rehabilitation, alongside protecting the public. While there is an understandable desire for punishment and justice for victims, focusing purely on punishment does little to reduce future crime. Rehabilitation, through education, therapy and job training, addresses the causes and helps offenders become **productive citizens**, which benefits everyone. So although punishment has its place, I think a system oriented towards **rehabilitation** is ultimately more **constructive** and beneficial for society.

5. Do you think technology will help reduce crime in the future? (Future)

I think it will play a significant, double-edged role. On one hand, technologies like surveillance, data analysis and improved **forensics** can help prevent and solve crimes more effectively. On the other hand, technology also enables new forms of crime, such as cybercrime and fraud, which are growing rapidly. There are also privacy concerns with heavy surveillance. So technology will be a powerful tool against crime, but it will also create new **vulnerabilities** and **dilemmas**.

6. How can societies reduce crime rates? (Problem & Solution)

A **comprehensive** approach works best. Tackling the root causes, by reducing poverty and inequality and improving education and employment, addresses why crime occurs. Effective, fair policing and a justice system that rehabilitates rather than merely punishes are important. Strong communities and support for **at-risk** young people also help. Essentially, combining prevention,

opportunity and rehabilitation, rather than relying solely on punishment, offers the most sustainable way to reduce crime.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of harsher punishments for crime?

(Adv & Disadv)

Proponents argue harsher punishments **deter** crime and satisfy the public's sense of justice, while keeping dangerous offenders off the streets. However, the evidence that severe punishment actually deters crime **is seems** surprisingly weak; **many argue** the certainty of being caught matters more than the severity. Harsh sentences can also be costly and hinder rehabilitation. So while there is **emotional appeal**, I am sceptical that simply being harsher is effective; addressing root causes is more productive.

8. Some say poverty is the main cause of crime. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I partly agree, as there is a clear correlation, but it is not the whole story. Poverty and the desperation, lack of opportunity and inequality it brings undoubtedly create **fertile ground** for crime. However, most poor people are law-abiding, and crime also occurs among the wealthy, such as fraud. So while poverty is a significant contributing factor, crime is a complex phenomenon with multiple causes, and attributing it solely to poverty is an **oversimplification** of a **multifaceted** issue.

Government & Public Policy

Society & Values · sp3_society_07 · 6 of 8 answers edited

1. What do you think is the most important role of a government? (Opinion)

In my view, the most fundamental role of a government is to protect its citizens and ensure their basic wellbeing. This includes maintaining security and the **rule of law**, but also providing essential public services like healthcare, education and infrastructure. Beyond that, a good government should create the conditions for people to thrive and prosper fairly. So I see the core role as **safeguarding** both the security and the **welfare** of its people.

2. Should governments focus more on the economy or on social welfare? (Comparison)

I believe these two are deeply **interconnected** rather than opposed. A strong economy generates the wealth needed to fund social welfare, while investing in people's health, education and wellbeing actually strengthens the economy by creating a productive workforce. Neglecting either ultimately harms the other. So rather than choosing one over the other, I think a wise government pursues both **in tandem**, recognising that economic prosperity and social welfare are **mutually reinforcing**.

3. What are the effects of good governance on a country? (Cause & Effect)

Good governance has profoundly positive effects. **Transparent**, accountable and effective government fosters economic growth, attracts investment and reduces corruption. It ensures public services function well and that resources are used fairly, which improves citizens' quality of life. It also builds public trust and social stability. Conversely, poor governance **breeds corruption** and **stagnation**. So good governance is genuinely the foundation of a country's prosperity, stability and overall development.

4. How much should governments intervene in people's lives? (Social Impact)

This is a matter of constant debate, and I believe in a balanced approach. Governments should intervene to protect citizens, provide essential services and correct market failures, as some intervention is clearly necessary for a functioning society. However, excessive intervention can stifle freedom, innovation and personal responsibility. So the ideal lies somewhere in between; the government should provide a strong safety net and framework while respecting individual **autonomy** and avoiding becoming **overbearing** or **paternalistic**.

5. How do you think the role of government will change in the future? (Future)

I anticipate governments will face new and complex challenges that reshape their role. Issues like climate change, artificial intelligence, and global pandemics require unprecedented coordination and regulation. Technology may enable more direct citizen participation but also greater surveillance. Governments will likely need to become more **agile** and collaborative internationally. So while the fundamental role of serving citizens remains, the tools and challenges will **evolve**, demanding greater **adaptability** from those who govern.

6. How can governments earn the trust of their citizens? (Problem & Solution)

Trust is earned through transparency, accountability and competence. Governments that are open about their decisions, **deliver on** their promises, and **tackle corruption** tend to be trusted. Actually improving people's lives through effective policy is crucial. Listening to citizens and involving them in decisions fosters a **sense of ownership**. So by being transparent, honest and genuinely responsive to people's needs, governments can rebuild and maintain the public trust that is so vital to good governance.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of a strong central government? (Adv & Disadv)

A strong central government can act **decisively**, implement coherent national policy, and coordinate effectively during crises, which is valuable. It can also ensure consistency and tackle large-scale problems. The disadvantages are that too much centralised power can become **authoritarian**, ignore local needs, and stifle regional autonomy and diversity. It may also be less responsive. So while strong central authority has clear benefits, it must be balanced with checks and local representation to avoid **overreach**.

8. Some say governments should provide free healthcare for everyone. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I strongly agree with this principle. I believe access to healthcare is a fundamental human right, not a privilege dependent on wealth. Universal healthcare ensures that no one is denied treatment or **bankrupted** by illness, which is both humane and promotes a healthier, more productive society. While it is expensive and requires efficient management, the alternative, where people suffer for lack of money, seems deeply **unjust**. So I consider free, universal healthcare a worthwhile and **civilised** investment.

Ethics & Moral Values

Society & Values · sp3_society_08 · 8 of 8 answers edited

1. Where do you think people get their moral values from? (Opinion)

I believe our moral values come from a combination of sources. Our upbringing and family are hugely influential, **instilling** early notions of right and wrong. Culture, religion and society also shape our ethics, as do our own experiences and reflection as we mature. Some argue there is even an innate, universal sense of fairness. So our values are essentially **absorbed** from those around us and then **refined** through personal reflection over time.

2. Are moral values the same across all cultures? (Comparison)

I think there is a fascinating mix of universal and culturally specific values. Certain core principles, like **prohibitions** against murder or valuing honesty and care for others, appear across virtually all cultures, suggesting a shared moral foundation. However, many values, such as attitudes to family, **individualism** or specific customs, vary considerably between cultures. So while there are some universal **moral constants**, ethics are also significantly shaped by cultural context.

3. What happens to a society when it loses its moral values? (Cause & Effect)

A society that loses its shared **moral compass** tends to suffer serious consequences. Trust between people erodes, corruption and dishonesty can flourish, and social cohesion breaks down.

Without agreed ethical standards, laws alone struggle to maintain order, and self-interest can dominate at the expense of the common good. So a strong shared morality acts as invisible **social glue**; its erosion can lead to division, **distrust** and dysfunction.

4. Do you think moral values are declining in modern society? (Social Impact)

This is a common concern, but I am somewhat sceptical. Every generation seems to believe that values are declining, yet by many measures, such as the reduction of violence and expansion of rights, society has **arguably** become more ethical over time. What is really happening, I think, is that values are shifting rather than declining; some traditional values fade while new ones, like tolerance and environmental awareness, emerge. So I would say values are **evolving**, not simply **deteriorating** or **vanishing**.

5. How might moral values change in the future? (Future)

I expect our moral frameworks to be tested and expanded by new challenges. Advances in technology, such as artificial intelligence and genetic engineering, will raise entirely new **ethical dilemmas** we have never faced before. Growing awareness may also extend our moral concern further, perhaps towards animals, the environment and future generations. So I anticipate that ethics will continue to **evolve**, becoming broader in scope as we **grapple with** unprecedented moral questions.

6. How can strong moral values be encouraged in young people? (Problem & Solution)

The most powerful way is through example, since children learn ethics primarily by observing the adults around them. Parents and teachers who **model integrity**, kindness and honesty have a profound influence. Open discussion of ethical issues, encouraging empathy, and involving young people in helping others also help. Rather than simply lecturing, allowing them to **reason through** moral situations builds genuine understanding. So values are best **instilled** through consistent example and guided reflection.

7. Is it always right to follow the rules, or are there times to break them? (Adv & Disadv)

While rules are generally important for order and fairness, I do not believe following them is always morally right. History shows that some laws have been deeply unjust, and challenging them, through **civil disobedience**, has been essential to progress. There are times when a **higher moral principle** justifies breaking an unjust rule. However, this is a serious matter, not an excuse for convenience. So rules should generally be respected, but **blind obedience** can sometimes conflict with genuine morality.

8. Some say people are becoming more selfish. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I am not entirely convinced. It is a common perception, and certain trends, like consumerism and individualism, can appear to encourage selfishness. However, I see abundant evidence of generosity, volunteering and collective action, particularly among young people concerned with social and environmental causes. Human nature contains both selfish and **altruistic** tendencies. So rather than people simply becoming more selfish, I think it is a **mischaracterisation**; both generosity and self-interest **coexist** as they always have.

Global Challenges

Society & Values · sp3_society_09 · 8 of 8 answers edited

1. What do you think is the biggest challenge facing the world today? (Opinion)

While there are many pressing issues, I believe climate change is arguably the most significant, because it threatens the very **habitability** of our planet and amplifies other problems like poverty and conflict. Its effects are global and potentially irreversible. That said, inequality and the risks of new technology are also profound. So although I would single out climate change as the most urgent and **far-reaching**, these challenges are deeply **interconnected**.

2. Should countries solve their own problems or work together on global issues?

(Comparison)

For many modern challenges, international cooperation is not just preferable but essential. Problems like climate change, pandemics and terrorism **do not respect borders**, so no single country can solve them alone. While nations should certainly address their domestic issues, the great **transnational** challenges require collective, coordinated action. So I would argue that in an interconnected world, a spirit of cooperation and shared responsibility is **indispensable** for tackling our common threats.

3. Why is it so difficult to solve global problems? (Cause & Effect)

The difficulty largely stems from competing national interests and a lack of trust. Countries are often reluctant to bear costs or make sacrifices, especially if they fear others will not do the same. Differing priorities between rich and poor nations complicate matters, and there is no single global authority to enforce agreements. Short-term political thinking also gets in the way. So global problems persist because collective action requires overcoming **deep-seated self-interest** and **coordination failures**.

4. How do global problems affect ordinary people? (Social Impact)

Global problems have very real and personal impacts, even when they seem distant. Climate change brings extreme weather that destroys homes and livelihoods. A global pandemic, as we have seen, can **upend** everyone's daily life and health. Economic crises that originate elsewhere can cause job losses locally. So although these issues are global in scale, their consequences are felt **intimately** in ordinary people's **livelihoods**, health and security, which is why they matter to us all.

5. Are you optimistic that the world can solve its biggest problems? (Future)

I try to remain cautiously optimistic, despite the **daunting** challenges. History shows that humanity is remarkably capable of innovation and cooperation when truly pressed, and we have overcome major threats before. Growing global awareness and technological progress offer real hope. However, success is far from guaranteed and will require unprecedented political will. So while I acknowledge the risks are serious, I choose to believe in human **ingenuity** and our capacity to **rise to the occasion**.

6. How can international cooperation on global issues be improved? (Problem & Solution)

Strengthening international institutions and agreements is essential, giving them more authority to coordinate and, where necessary, enforce collective action. Building trust between nations through dialogue and fair **burden-sharing** is crucial, ensuring poorer countries are supported. Aligning short-term incentives with long-term goals would help too. Ultimately, fostering a genuine sense of **shared humanity** and common purpose, over **narrow nationalism**, is the foundation of effective cooperation.

7. What are the advantages and disadvantages of an interconnected world? (Adv & Disadv)

The advantages of our interconnected world are immense: the **free flow of ideas**, trade and technology, cultural exchange, and the ability to cooperate on shared problems. It has driven progress and **lifted many from poverty**. The disadvantages are that problems, whether financial crises, pandemics or misinformation, also spread rapidly across borders, making us more **vulnerable**. So interconnection brings both tremendous opportunity and shared vulnerability, which we must learn to manage wisely.

8. Some say ordinary individuals cannot influence global issues. Do you agree? (Agree / Disagree)

I respectfully disagree, as I find this view **unduly disempowering**. While it is true that individuals cannot **single-handedly** solve global problems, collective individual action is

precisely what drives change. Our consumer choices, our activism, and above all our votes shape the policies of governments and the behaviour of corporations. Great social movements have always begun with ordinary people. So while one person's impact is small, collectively individuals **wield** genuine influence and should not underestimate it.